

CHAPTER 1: “THE WEIGHT OF BLOOD AND SPECTACLE”

THE COUNCIL OF FLESH AND SCORE

The chamber was carved from bone.

Not sculpted—*grown*. The ceiling curved like a spinal shell, ribs arching downward into obsidian thrones placed in a perfect circle. Beneath each throne, blood dripped from a hollowed skull-basin, soaking the groove-runes inscribed across the floor. Each rune pulsed faintly—responding to voice, mood, and appetite.

The Demon Council had convened.

Thirty-one seats.

Only twenty-four were filled tonight.

The rest—slain in past judgments or devoured in off-council duels—remained unclaimed, their thrones whispering ancient names.

A curved screen of flesh-glass hovered at the center of the chamber, displaying slowed, replayed, and rotated images from the final hours of *The Devouring Path*. Each frame was a battlefield—bloodstreaked illusions, broken contestants, screaming hybrids, and the survivors.

A voice like dripping silver broke the silence.

“She melted a vat-born with her foot,” purred Lady Vurnessa, the Seductress of the Hollow Bloom. Her throne writhed underneath her, grown from stitched-together torsos. Her hand toyed with a vein-pipe, fingers stained with nectar-sap and something darker. “I could watch *Shyvana* fight all week. She’s like sex with teeth.”

A slow grunt answered her.

“Shyvana is a weapon,” rumbled Arch-Duke Mur’Rok, the Skulldrinker of the Eastern Maw. His skin was made of stone-scales and throat tusks. “And *Abhishaap* commands her like breath. No waste. No arrogance. Just execution. That team... that’s not a team. That’s a massacre on leash.”

The screen flicked.

Team Abhishaap—mid-motion. Abhishaap flickering forward in his *Thunderstep Core*, a blur of stormlight and silence. Krurog, the frost-hound, tore through three contestants with a single slam. Shyvana laughed as the ground split under her ashfield, faces melting.

Lady Vurnessa exhaled, eyelids heavy.

“Two hundred Blood Points,” said a neutral voice.

The announcement came from one of the central scorers—his head was a flaming bowl of green fire, face hidden in smoke.

“Highest rating of Phase 1 in the past five centuries.”

A long whistle echoed from behind.

“Deserved,” said Judge Maltiq the Laughing Maw. His lips never moved—stitched shut—but his voice oozed from the belly-mouth on his abdomen. “Their only mistake is being predictable. Always straight lines. No elegance.”

“And yet,” another judge murmured, “no one stopped them.”

The room stirred.

Then a demoness from the Obsidian Hive shifted in her jagged throne.

“What about Kaal’s team?” she asked. “Rachit, Scar, Kaal himself? They fought *through* the illusions. They walked the Path like it was design, not challenge. That *collapse sphere* Kaal used to fold eight vat-borns—textbook pressure discipline.”

“They only got 170,” the fire-bowl scorer confirmed. “Ruthless. Calculated. Unrelenting. But...”

“But Rachit is a problem,” hissed another voice.

A spindly demon with layered horn-crowns and twelve blinking eyes leaned forward. Judge Erix’thel of the Blood Scholar Circle.

“I watched him,” he said, tapping his long claw on the bone armrest. “Rachit that, human is... mocking us. He doesn’t even *fight* half the time. He calculates, disrespects, than walks away.”

The screen showed Rachit—back to the corridor, one hand raised to his temple. That same signal.

“Think.”

A silent challenge.

A judge with a jawless face growled, “He doesn’t respect the Games.”

“He doesn’t *need* them,” Erix’thel said. “That’s what bothers you. He plays at being weaker than he is.”

“Disqualify him,” barked one of the elders. “I hate his face.”

“No,” Vurnessa said, licking blood from her wrist. “Keep him. He tastes like mystery.”

Another judge—wrapped in bandages that leaked whispers—sighed.

“Scar we tolerate because he bleeds beautifully. Kaal we respect. But Rachit? He walks like he’s above being watched. Dangerous.”

“And yet they got the second-highest,” the flame-score keeper noted.

Silence fell.

Then a slow clap.

Judge Karthorin, ancient and skeletal, laughed. “You argue over arrogance when half of you chew slaves during judgment.”

He leaned forward. “What about *Team Athereon*?”

The screen shimmered.

Athereon’s team—efficient, clean, victorious. But... too perfect.

One demon scoffed. “That’s a nobleman’s team. Groomed, branded, polished. They win because they’re expected to. No fun. No danger.”

“Still got 160 Blood Points,” came the reply. “They cleared with grace.”

A judge with molten wings chuckled. “Grace is for temples. Not arenas.”

The screen changed again.

A darker image.

Krotha.

Dragging two teammates through the spiral collapse. Face hidden under the frost-leather mask. Lightning crawling through broken arms. No elegance. Just will.

He didn’t scream.

He didn’t fall.

He bled.

And kept walking.

50 Blood Points.

Low.

Too low.

But still...

“I know him,” said a voice from the far end.

Heads turned.

It was a silent demon. Tall. Antlered. Eyes pale blue. He rarely spoke.

“I met *Krotha* once,” he said slowly. “He sat upon the Frozen Throne at the edge of the north shrines. The *entire Fire Forest* was turned to ice. Flamebeasts begging for death. He’d done it... because one of them had touched his slave.”

No one laughed.

Not even Vurnessa.

The screen paused on Krotha's mask—half-frozen, stitched with pain.

"Then why is he weak now?" a judge demanded.

"Maybe he's playing," the antlered one whispered. "Or maybe he's waiting."

The room felt colder.

Then the scorer chimed again.

"Team Nyss—30 points."

Groans.

A horned demoness flicked a bone-nail. "They crawled through like dying pigs."

"But they crawled through," the flame-face noted.

"They had *Gaurav*," said a demon with snake-flesh arms. "I like him. Angry boy. Punches like he wants to break history."

Another sneered. "Still human. Just a tool."

A judge with cracked teeth spoke up, lips bleeding:

"Humans are *only* good for slavery, breeding, and flavor."

"Pleasure," added Vurnessa lazily. "Don't forget pleasure."

The scorer ignored them. "Team Syris, Team Slade, Team Reeve—awarded between 70 and 120. Performance good, not legendary. Moving on."

One demon raised a talon. "Back to Kaal's team. You're underestimating them. Abhishaap may be fast, but gravity doesn't care about speed. That 'collapse sphere' nearly broke the Path structure."

"And Scar's seals?" murmured another. "He turned a screaming hybrid into a chain reaction of blood explosions."

"He *clapped* a tank-class demon to death," said one judge with a dry laugh. "And Rachit..."

"He didn't even try," finished another. "That's the scary part."

"But none of them can stop Abhishaap's spear," came a growl from a silver-armored demon. "Raijin's Spear splits *terrain*. No tricks, no counters."

Someone coughed.

"What about Krotha?"

The screen shifted back to him—falling, bleeding, but walking.

“Only 50,” someone scoffed.

“And yet,” the antlered one said again, “he walked through a beast that erased *nine* contestants. *Alone*. While dragging two half-dead warriors.”

“Did he even use a real attack?” another questioned.

“He didn’t,” Vurnessa said. “That’s the fun part.”

“And that thread boy,” someone added. “Yugetsu. Woke up, stitched a mask, and blew half the corridor apart. For what?”

A pause.

“To protect him,” the antlered one said. “To protect Krotha.”

Another moment of silence.

Then the scorer declared:

“All major team judgments complete.”

“Blood Points locked.”

Team Abhishaap – 200

Team Kaal – 170

Team Atheron – 160

Team Krotha – 50

Team Nyss – 30

Other teams followed with lower scores.

Then the judge with the cracked teeth barked, “Let’s see how long the humans last in the Arena.”

“They won’t,” someone muttered.

“I hope they scream.”

The screen shimmered one last time.

Rachit.

Still.

Not injured. Not exhausted. Just *present*.

Standing in the shadows of the post-trial haze, body turned slightly, eyes unreadable—but aware.

He raised his left hand—

Index and middle fingers extended. Thumb up.

A two-finger mock gun.

He pointed it at the *screen itself*—at *them*.

Then—

Bang.

His thumb flicked down.

The moment snapped—

The screen **cracked** down the middle, a jagged web of hairline fractures splintering across the flesh-glass.

Gasps. Growls.

A low, grinding growl came from one judge. “He *knows* we’re watching?”

Several judges leaned back instinctively.

A few hissed. One grinned with sharp teeth.

Vurnessa licked her lower lip.

Erix’thel growled, “He dares?”

“Was that a threat?” snapped one of the war-born.

“No,” said the antlered judge softly. “That was a message.”

“I see you.

And I don’t care”.

The flame-faced scorekeeper stared at the cracked screen for a long moment before turning away.

“Judgment concluded,” he said flatly. “Let the Arena begin.”

And so the blood moved forward.

Somewhere far from that...

The air in the dome-tent had gone still.

Not silent—*still*.

The kind of stillness that settled when life was still breathing, but no one wanted to disturb it. Like standing near a frozen lake that still held corpses beneath the ice.

Day five.

Five days since the Devouring Path closed its flesh doors forever. Five days since Krotha collapsed at the edge of the exit glyph, dragging Yugetsu and Aviral behind him with a broken spine and bleeding ribs.

He hadn't moved since.

Swayam—disguised still as *Krotha*—lay on the cot near the back, half-covered by frost-thread sheets and a loose net of monitoring glyphs pulsing blue and silver. His body twitched occasionally, like his nerves were fighting with the memory of motion.

Each time he did, Gaurav looked up.

Gaurav sat close—close enough that one arm always rested on his bent knee, and the other hand half-curved near the cot's edge, never touching, but never leaving either.

His knuckles were cracked. His nails had lines of dry blood under them.

He hadn't fought since Trial One, but he hadn't slept either.

Not really.

Across from him, Yugetsu sat cross-legged, spine unusually straight, his face less like a boy and more like someone who had *woken up too fast*. His eyes didn't blink often. And when they did, they scanned Krotha. Then Gaurav. Then back again.

The silence between them was easy.

But heavy.

Near the far wall, Aviral paced—his limp gone now, but his right leg still wrapped in dull-red glyph tape. His left arm held a thick scroll and a small demon-forged data tablet that blinked every few seconds with glowing text.

He read without speaking.

Then stopped.

“Trial Two is a bastard.”

Gaurav didn't respond.

Yugetsu blinked. “That bad?”

Aviral tapped the scroll against his thigh, frustrated.

“It's not a trial. It's a blood circus with point calculations.”

Gaurav finally glanced up, one brow raised.

Aviral walked over, tossed the scroll onto a nearby table where the demon-broth pot had long gone cold. “Listen.”

He began listing off the rules, but not like a reader—like a soldier studying death warrants.

TRIAL 2 – ARENA OF JUDGMENT

“Strength alone means little in a world where demons cheer your ruin.”

Purpose: To entertain. To manipulate. To expose.

Tests:

- Tactical coordination.
- Audience manipulation.
- Team synergy.
- Survivor resilience.

Advancement Conditions:

- Reach *semifinals* or *finals*
OR
 - Total **1000+ merit points** across 3 matches.
-

Aviral raised the tablet so they could see the rest.

“The merit system’s rigged.”

Gaurav looked up fully now.

“Rigged how?”

“Your win gets you 30 points. That’s it. *Base.*”

Yugetsu leaned forward. “Only 30 for winning?”

“Yep. Then comes the trap.” Aviral jabbed the air. “Every *individual* gets a score from the audience—between *–100 and +100*. It’s averaged. That means even if we win, if they don’t like us, we *bleed points*.”

Gaurav scoffed. “So popularity over power.”

“Exactly. Then there’s the nobles’ betting pool—another 40 possible points. And the ‘Thrill Bonus’—10 points per highlight.”

Yugetsu grimaced. “So it’s not a fight. It’s a...”

“*Performance*,” Aviral said. “A weaponized talent show.”

Gaurav stood.

He stepped away from the cot for the first time in an hour.

“Doesn’t matter.”

He turned toward the center of the tent where a dim glyph-lamp flickered above a low stone ring. The moment he stepped into its circle of light, his silhouette cut sharp and tired across the wall.

“We don’t have time to whine.”

Yugetsu raised a brow. “So we just... what? Dance like clowns?”

Gaurav turned his head just enough to let them see his expression.

He didn’t blink.

“If that’s what it takes to keep *him* alive until the finals—then yeah.”

Aviral didn’t argue.

But he did say, “There’s more.”

He walked over to the wall, tapped a section of cloth. A rune flared, and a long glyph-panel slid open—revealing an etched tournament bracket and a pulsing tally board for teams.

“Each team fights *three* random matches. That’s it. Then scores are ranked. Top 4 go to semis.”

Yugetsu crossed his arms. “What happens to the bottom ones?”

Aviral didn’t look back.

“Lowest scores? Publicly executed. Or worse—auctioned.”

Yugetsu went silent.

Then said softly, “And if we win the final?”

Gaurav answered before Aviral could.

“The captain gets to choose two people from *any* team. To make them slaves.”

Yugetsu frowned. “...Even semifinalists?”

“Yes.”

Aviral’s jaw clenched. “Even top scorers. Doesn’t matter.”

Yugetsu looked over at Swayam’s sleeping form.

“And if *he* wins... who would he take?”

No one answered that.

In the cot, Swayam’s hand twitched.

But he didn’t wake.

On the opposite side of the tent, two other cots lay unmoving.

Anshika and Nyss.

Nyss was still. Breath low, limbs slack, no twitch of eye or lip. She had been hit harder than they thought—her mind caught in some lingering spiral of illusion. Every time a medic checked her glyph signature, it flickered like a dream trying to erase itself.

Anshika was different.

Her face moved.

Barely. Subtly.

A flicker of eyebrows.

A tightening of the jaw.

Once every hour, she whispered something incoherent.

Her lips formed half-words, too fast to catch. Once she said, “No—I can’t—need to wak—” before the illusion reset, and she stilled again.

Gaurav watched her longer than the others.

Not just because she mattered.

But because he *hated* the way the illusion stopped her every time she got close to waking.

Like something inside her didn’t want her to come back.

“I don’t get it,” Aviral said suddenly. “Where’s Rachit?”

A long silence followed.

Yugetsu looked up, confused. “What?”

“He helped us.” Aviral voice wasn’t angry. Just lost. “Back in the Path. Gave us a signal. A route. We survived because of him. But... he hasn’t come.”

Gaurav exhaled.

“You think I haven’t noticed?”

His voice was sharper than usual. Not yelling. But sharp.

“He didn’t even *check* if we made it out.”

Yugetsu winced. “Maybe he’s... waiting?”

Gaurav turned slowly. His face was tight, but his eyes—darker than usual.

“He’s my *brother*, Yugetsu. Not by blood. But by fire. We bled in the same fights. Survived Kanpur together. I *buried people* with him.”

He pointed toward the flap of the tent.

“And he’s out there right now. Pretending none of this exists.”

Aviral rubbed his eyes.

“Maybe he’s processing.”

“Maybe he’s being a coward,” Gaurav said.

Yugetsu said nothing.

But he looked down at his hands.

The same ones that had dragged Swayam and Aviral out of death.

The same hands that had stitched a frost mask onto a bleeding man.

He whispered, “Or maybe we just all break differently.”

A gust of wind howled outside the tent, carrying the sound of demon horns and cheering from the upper platforms.

Day Five.

The Arena of Judgment would open in twenty-four hours.

The first matches were being announced tonight.

The nobles were already placing bets.

And inside a sealed corner of the tent, where no light reached—

Swayam’s eyes moved under his lids.

A flick.

A tremble.

Then stillness.

The frost mask remained.

But his chest rose—just slightly deeper than before.

The glyph-lamps in the dome tent dimmed suddenly.

Not from exhaustion.

From instinct.

Something outside was approaching, and even the enchanted lights preferred not to be seen when she walked past.

A flutter of fabric.

A scent—iron, wine, jasmine smoke.

Then the flap of the tent parted like breath drawn too slowly, and she entered.

Barefoot.

Beautiful.

And wrong in all the ways that made men forget caution.

She stepped in with the poise of someone who didn't need permission—one foot crossing behind the other like she was walking through a garden, not the base camp of half-dead gladiators.

In her left hand, she held a slender black vial of translucent blood.

In her right: nothing. Just delicate fingers, perfectly still.

She sipped.

Not like a drink.

Like it was a love letter.

The moment the blood touched her tongue, her lips parted in a subtle moan—not loud, not vulgar. Just enough to make silence blush.

“Divine,” she whispered to no one. “Like nectar... soaked in a dying man's last kiss.”

All three of them—Gaurav, Aviral, Yugetsu—turned at once.

Even Swayam's unconscious body seemed to flinch slightly, as if sensing something outside reason had entered the space.

She raised her eyes slowly, blood still trickling down her lower lip.

“Is this the frost one's tent?” she asked casually.

Aviral stepped forward, instincts flickering behind his eyes. “It is. And you are...?”

She tilted her head, smiling faintly.

Her voice was low. Sweet. Laced with something... venomous.

“Lilith. Healer. Noble-blooded. Still too bored.”

Another sip.

Then a breathy sigh.

“Though today’s been better than most.”

She gestured lazily with her wrist—at the vial. “I’ve been drinking this *all* day. Human blood, if you’re wondering. *Perfectly textured filled with jeev shakti*, too. Whoever it was—*mmhh*—what a complex flavor.”

Gaurav’s brow tightened. Yugetsu just stared.

Lilith didn’t care.

She walked deeper into the room, her steps too soft for the floor to creak, her presence too thick for anyone to relax.

She passed the cots of Nyss and Anshika—paused briefly.

“No illusion-breaker in my arsenal can untangle *these two*.” She tapped a painted nail against Anshika’s head gently. “This one’s trying, though. Her face twitches like a girl fighting to breathe above water. But the current’s still stronger.”

She moved on without a second glance.

“I *can* fix the rest of you,” she said, eyes sweeping over Aviral, then Gaurav, and then to the sleeping form of Swayam in his frost-masked Krotha attire. “Bones, muscle, mind... even the ugly old pain you don’t talk about.”

Yugetsu, voice cautious but steady, asked, “Who sent you?”

Lilith paused mid-sip.

She blinked once. Then smiled again.

“Not sure. Handsome little thing, though. Didn’t give a name. Walked into the southern healer’s court like he owned it. Said, ‘Heal Team Krotha. Thoroughly.’ And before walking out left this divine treat.”

Another sip.

Eyes half-lidded now.

“Red-brown eyes. Crimson underlight when the sun hit. *Mmm*. He bled recently. I could smell it under his nails.”

She trailed off, pupils dilating slightly.

“I did wonder... if he were mine—would I devour him slowly, or keep him in silk chains and call it devotion?”

A long pause.

Then her lips curled.

“Maybe both.”

Gaurav straightened abruptly.

“Was he wearing grey harem pants?”

Lilith turned her gaze to him, genuinely curious.

She looked him up and down, as if replaying the image in her head.

“Yes and a tanktop too. Even his scars were deliberate.”

Aviral and Yugetsu shared a glance.

Gaurav closed his eyes.

Damn it, Rachit.

He felt it land in his gut like a hammer of guilt.

3 hours ago, he’d called Rachit a coward.

Said he abandoned them.

But Rachit hadn’t come because he was busy dragging divine-class healers into action—without asking for credit, without checking in.

Just like always.

Just like *him*.

Gaurav exhaled slowly. “He never changes...”

Yugetsu offered nothing but a quiet nod.

Aviral’s mouth twitched. “Guess the strategist still listens.”

Lilith had already crossed the floor.

“Shall I begin?” she asked, but it was rhetorical.

She knelt beside Aviral first, her body never bending awkwardly—*only* elegantly. Her fingers hovered just an inch above his chest.

A hum.

Then heat.

Then a pulse of green-silver light.

Aviral’s eyes widened. Every cell in his body screamed relief.

His bones didn't knit—they *rewrote*. The lingering scar in his thigh vanished. The pressure behind his left eye (an old concussion) evaporated like steam.

He sucked in air. Sat up like a man drowning on land.

"Stars above—"

Lilith winked. "Don't thank me. Thank the red-eyed boy."

She moved to Gaurav.

Sat beside him without asking. Pressed two fingers against his forehead.

"You're already whole," she said, half-compliment, half-lament. "But your *heart* is a spoiled little thing. So tight. So twisted."

He didn't answer.

But when she pushed psychic calm into his mind, he felt it crack through the chains of self-blame, of fury, of survivor's guilt.

For the first time in days, he *breathed*.

Truly breathed.

And didn't taste blood in his throat.

Yugetsu she barely touched—just a brush of her nail across his cheek.

"Yours is fresh," she said. "But quiet."

And then—finally—she approached Swayam.

She paused beside his cot, examining his frost-thread mask, the crusted blood at his ribs, the twitch of his left hand.

Her voice lowered—not out of reverence, but curiosity.

"You don't look like a demon," she said softly.

"But something in you doesn't belong to the weak."

She reached out, fingertips brushing the center of his chest.

The reaction was instant.

His body *arched* upward.

A wave of steam exploded from under the sheet—flesh reknitting, bones setting, old internal ruptures flaring *then vanishing*. Even his skin lightened by half a shade, layers of trauma melting like dried wax from his nervous system.

The frost mask glowed.

Then settled.

Lilith's lips parted in fascination.

"Fascinating," she whispered. "No wonder he hid you in frost."

Behind her, the others watched in stunned silence as even *their own* old scars vanished—resonance rebounding across shared combat zones, as if the healing was echoing.

She stood.

Stretched.

Took one last sip from her blood-vial.

Closed her eyes like she was savoring a final note of music.

"He'll wake soon," she murmured. "Hour, maybe two. Depending on how stubborn his spirit is."

She turned to go, pausing at the tent flap.

"Next time," she said with a playful smirk, "tell your handsome friend to leave a name. I like knowing what I'm fantasizing about."

And just like that—she slipped through the flap and vanished into the settling night, hips swaying like an unfinished sentence.

Inside the tent, it was quiet again.

But this time...

Different.

Hope had a pulse again.

And soon—

Swayam would open his eyes.

The sky above Malakour was no longer blue.

It had turned spectacle-gold—the shade that came only when thousands of watching demons filled the upper balconies of the Trial Spire and screamed so loud that the heavens themselves tried to match the roar.

A floating arena crystal hovered high in the air, projecting blood-lit glyphs visible across the Sector.

One by one, names appeared—burning, rotating, locking into pairings.

A guttural, echo-warped announcer boomed:

ARENA OF JUDGMENT – MATCHES ANNOUNCED

“Let all filth, fury, and fortune gather. The games begin now.”

ROUND 1

Match 1: *Team Kaal vs Team Maledictus*

(Gravity will meet speed. Blood will meet steel.)

Match 2: *Team Abhishaap vs Team Reeve*

(Fastest blades vs coldest tacticians. May the slow die blind.)

Match 3: *Team Nyss vs Team Mavik*

(Gaurav, Aviral, and the sleeping songbird... against the Snake and twin-skins of the Eastern Rift.)

Match 4: *Team Krotha vs Team Glazen*

(Frost mask versus molten bones. A clash between illusions and instinct.)

More names followed, scrolling like execution orders being signed by fate:

Match 5: *Team Slade vs Team Viren*

Match 6: *Team Juro vs Team Vyra*

Match 7: *Team Irik vs Team Syris*

Match 8: *Team Drexil vs Team Maav*

Match 9: *Team Ashed vs Team Nakaros*

Match 10: *Team Athereon vs Team Krask*

Ten matchups.

Twenty teams.

And then—

Silence.

The air waited.

So did Aviral, seated near the long-range transmitter hub near the supply crate inside their dome tent, watching the projections update in real time. His eyes narrowed as the final slot refused to fill.

“Wait,” he said quietly. “That’s only twenty.”

Yugetsu looked up from where he was cleaning his gloves. “There are twenty-one qualified teams.”

Gaurav’s brows furrowed.

Before Aviral could speak again, the crystal changed.

And the announcer’s voice darkened—less showman, more sentence.

Notice: One team has been removed.

TEAM 21: ELIMINATED

REASON: Awarded **0** points in Trial 1.

Status: Disqualified. Disavowed. Executed.

Then the screen cut.

And the scene shifted.

Elsewhere – Trial Grounds Periphery

A battlefield long cooled.

A half-circle of corpses—bloodless, eyes still open, glyphs burned into their foreheads.

Team Draxx.

Dead.

Their bodies weren't mangled. No signs of war.

Just... *ended*.

And standing between them—alone—a no-horned demon with purple hair, sword in hand.

He wore no banner, no insignia, no rank cloth.

But power hung around him like mist off a volcano.

He raised his sword.

Flicked it once—barely a breath of motion.

The corpses turned to **dust**.

No flames. No screams.

Just ash.

The wind obeyed. Took the remains and scattered them to nothing.

He sheathed his sword in silence.

Then walked away.

Back at the Tent – Team Krotha

Steam curled from the leftover broth pot.

And Swayam exhaled.

Not deeply.

Just enough for Yugetsu to flinch.

Gaurav looked over, posture already half-lifting.

Aviral stopped mid-swipe on his scroll.

Another breath.

Then Swayam's fingers moved.

The frost-thread mask shifted slightly as his lips parted.

A weak rasp escaped.

"...Did we win?"

Gaurav burst into a laugh that choked halfway into a cough. "Idiot."

Yugetsu nearly dropped the gloves he'd been holding. "He's awake."

Aviral didn't smile.

But he did say, "Well. Took your sweet time."

Swayam blinked slowly.

His vision refocused.

His throat worked hard before he muttered, "I had this *great line* planned. Thought I'd wake up, say something cool..."

He coughed, winced.

"Totally blew it."

Gaurav stepped in, smacked him lightly on the leg. "Yeah. That was trash."

Still, they all laughed.

Even Swayam, despite the pain.

Then his gaze shifted across the tent—

And landed on **Anshika**.

She hadn't moved.

Still trapped in the illusion.

Her brow furrowed every now and then—like she was fighting herself to reach the surface, but couldn't.

"...She's still under?"

A silent nod from Gaurav.

Then Swayam's eyes flicked toward the other cot.

Nyss.

Motionless.

The leader of Team Nyss—his co-survivor, Gaurav's newest burden—still didn't stir.

He sighed. "Great. One member from each of ours teams down. Trial starts tomorrow?"

Yugetsu nodded. "Matchups just got announced."

Swayam tried to sit up.

Then actually sat up.

His body moved too smoothly.

He noticed it.

Frowned.

"Wait. What the hell did you guys do while I was asleep?" He rolled his shoulder, flexed his neck. "Even *old* aches are gone. I feel like I skipped three years of physical trauma."

Yugetsu stepped forward. "We didn't do anything."

He gestured at the now-empty corner of the tent.

"She did."

"Who?"

"Lilith."

Gaurav nodded. "Healer. Demon noble. Gorgeous. Terrifying. Drinks blood like it's poetry."

Aviral added, "Also obsessed with whoever sent her."

Swayam blinked. "Wait. Who *did* send her?"

Yugetsu spoke softly, "We didn't know. Asked her. She said some red-eyed pretty boy came in, handed her a vial of blood, and told her to heal us."

Swayam's body stilled.

"Red-brown eyes?" he asked.

Gaurav looked at him.

Then nodded.

"Grey harem pants."

Swayam stared at the floor.

Didn't move.

Didn't breathe.

Then he muttered:

"...Of course he did."

Yugetsu tilted his head. "It was Rachit, wasn't it?"

Gaurav didn't answer immediately.

Then said, voice quieter than usual:

"Yeah. That's what I think."

Aviral raised a brow. "Wait—demon healers take *payment*. Why would a guy like *her* agree to heal us for just a vial of blood?"

"Human blood's not rare," Yugetsu added. "There's cages of it being harvested in Slava."

Swayam didn't look up.

He just spoke.

Calm.

Plain.

"...We never told you guys, did we?"

Yugetsu and Aviral exchanged glances.

"Told us what?" Aviral asked.

Swayam's voice dropped.

"When we were slaves..."

"Rachit wasn't with us."

"They kept him in the *high-tier pens*. Special storage."

A pause.

Then: "Because of his blood."

Gaurav picked it up.

"Type Zeta Prime. One in ten million. High magical retention."

He glanced at Yugetsu.

“Even after death, his blood keeps most of its power. Some say it enhances stats. Others used it in rituals.”

Aviral’s face twisted. “So they... what? Farm him?”

“Almost,” Swayam said. “We heard a buyer once. Said Rachit would sell for a *mountain of coin* once he turned sixteen.”

Yugetsu went pale. “And now he’s—”

“Sixteen,” Gaurav said. “Retention rate would be near ninety-six percent. Maybe higher.”

Silence.

Real silence.

Then Aviral muttered:

“...No wonder she came. That vial wasn’t payment. It was a *gift box made of gold*.”

Yugetsu frowned, troubled. “Why didn’t he ever say anything?”

Swayam’s jaw clenched.

“Because he *hates* being worth something for the wrong reason.”

He looked up.

Eyes sharp.

Focused.

“He’s been like this from the start; he bleeds for others. But never talks about it.”

The silence stretched again.

This time, it wasn’t peaceful.

It pulsed with the absence of someone who *should* have been there.

Yugetsu’s voice cut through it, low and quiet.

“But... why?” he asked. “If Rachit was willing to help... then *why not meet us*? Why disappear since the reshuffle?”

His words weren’t angry.

They were hollow.

Disbelief draped in hurt.

“He hasn’t even *looked* at us since the reshuffle,” he added. “Not a glance. Not even when you collapsed. Not when the healers dragged your body back here like a bundle of frost-bitten cloth.”

He didn't mean to make it sting.

But it did.

Swayam didn't answer at first.

He sat forward slightly, arms resting on his knees, the frost-thread mask in his lap.

His expression didn't change.

But something in his jaw flexed.

Quietly.

Calculating.

Thinking in layers, not lines.

Then he spoke—calmly, but with precision, each word placed like a tile on the floor of truth.

“You're looking at it wrong.”

Gaurav turned to him. “What do you mean?”

Swayam kept his eyes lowered, tone even.

“Rachit didn't choose not to contact us. He *can't*.”

That made them pause.

Yugetsu blinked. “Can't?”

“Think,” Swayam continued, voice growing firmer. “Before the Trial began, they reshuffled everyone. I ended up with You and Anshika. Gaurav, you were thrown in with Aviral and Nyss—a hybrid who you'd never even spoken to before.”

He finally looked up.

“*But Rachit...?*”

A beat of silence.

“He got no one.”

Aviral narrowed his eyes. “You think he's isolated?”

“No,” Swayam said, shaking his head. “Worse.”

He leaned back slightly, shoulders tense.

“He was reshuffled into a team *completely unknown* to him. And when we last saw him—during the Path—remember what he did?”

Gaurav squinted. “The signal?”

Swayam raised his hand.

One finger aiming at his temple.

“THINK”.

Aviral nodded slowly. “He was telling us to think.”

Swayam nodded.

“He gave us direction, not reassurance. He wanted us to survive. But around him—”

He paused, recalling the image clearly.

“—there were two others. Bigger than him. Stronger. Shadows like towers behind him. I don’t think he’s just with strangers. I think he’s with *elite demons*. Maybe nobles. Maybe something worse.”

Aviral looked toward Nyss’s cot, expression troubled.

“So you’re saying he’s hiding us from them?”

Swayam’s eyes didn’t blink.

“I’m saying he’s keeping his distance to protect us.”

Yugetsu muttered, “But... that means he’s playing a role too.”

Swayam almost smiled.

“Seems I’m not the only one with masks.”

They didn’t speak for a moment after that.

Because suddenly it made sense.

The silence.

The distance.

The healer’s blood vial.

He hadn’t walked away.

He was *standing guard* from the other side.

Aviral finally exhaled.

“Well. Twenty-one hours to go.”

Yugetsu nodded. “Yeah. No more guesses now. Just prep.”

Gaurav pulled out the arena schematic he’d folded earlier.

“Team Mavik and Team Glazen. Our Round One.”

Swayam stood up.

The frost-mask clicked into his hand like it had always belonged there.

“I’ll be outside,” he said. “Need air.”

They let him go without question.

Outside the Tent

The wind hit his face the moment he stepped out—cold, biting, familiar.

Like a childhood memory you hate, but miss.

He pulled the frost-mask up onto his face, letting it settle, letting it *own* him.

Krotha.

That name wasn’t his.

But he wore it now.

Owned it.

If only to protect the ones who still called him brother.

He sat down on the edge of a low stone bench beside the outer glyph-fire, legs spread, elbows resting on his knees. His breath misted in the air.

The sky had turned golden with veins of purple magic crackling across the clouds.

Thunder rolled far above the arena towers.

Swayam closed his eyes.

Breathed in.

And then—

He heard it.

Not from outside.

Not from memory.

From within.

A voice.

Like glacier teeth grinding against broken metal.

The same voice from **five and a half years ago**.

The same voice that *woke* inside him as he screamed in that frozen prison—bloodied and broken, kneeling beside Rachit and Gaurav, standing against the *(demon who he’s been faking to trick other demons)* with nothing but instinct.

The voice whispered again.

“Don’t disappoint me.”

It faded like lightning before the thunder.

Swayam opened his eyes, slow and sharp.

His jaw clenched.

His mind spiraled.

That *thing* inside him—whatever it was—hadn’t spoken in five years.

Not once.

Not even when he bled.

Not even when he killed.

But now...

Now it returned.

And it was *watching*.

He looked out toward the outer sectors of Malakour, toward the place where the arena shadows danced under the torches of demon nobles.

The city groaned with cheers.

With teeth.

With hunger.

And he knew something:

If *Krotha* failed—if even one lie slipped—then they weren’t just dead.

They’d be *eaten, starting a chain events of several deaths*.

He reached up, adjusting the frost mask.

It slid into place, smooth and confident.

Then he muttered—quietly, not for anyone else.

“Need to think smarter. Not harder. If they smell even a hint of human under this mask...”

He exhaled again.

Cold mist left his mouth.

“Everything burns.”

He thought of the children of Sector 3A.

The ones with cracked cheeks and paper-thin bones.

The ones who called them heroes.

Who whispered stories about the trio that robbed a Scourge Lord’s convoy and lived.

They had *nothing*.

But they believed.

And belief... was weight.

He clenched his fists.

“Can’t let them down.”

The words weren’t loud.

But they echoed.

Deep.

The dome tent was dim.

The light-glyphs had softened into a sleep-pulse hue—blue fading into muted lavender.

Nyss hadn’t moved.

Anshika murmured something in her sleep—just once—barely audible, her fingers twitching like they were trying to claw out of drowning soil.

Yugetsu was curled like a threadless cocoon, one arm shielding his face from the lamplight, the other hand resting on the hilt of a stitched kunai.

Aviral lay on his back, breathing deep, the trial tablet still gripped in one hand as if he’d tried to study between blinks and lost.

Only Gaurav was still awake.

His eyes locked on the cot where Swayam had rested just hours earlier.

He didn’t blink much.

Didn’t move.

Like his body was afraid that if he fell asleep, he'd open his eyes to find this was all another Devouring Path illusion.

Swayam stood near the flap of the tent, frost mask resting on his face once again, arms folded, back straight.

"You should sleep," he said quietly.

Gaurav scoffed under his breath. "Can't."

"You need to," Swayam insisted. "You haven't truly slept in five days. Trial Two isn't a back-alley brawl. You'll need all of you to fight."

Gaurav looked away.

Then muttered, "What if I sleep and one of them—"

"They'll be here," Swayam said, firmly.

It was *not* a suggestion.

Gaurav didn't argue.

He looked at the sleeping forms again.

Then at Swayam.

Then finally laid back slowly, exhaling in defeat.

"Wake me before our match."

"I will."

The tent fell silent.

Swayam waited until Gaurav's breathing leveled out—steady, rhythmic, real.

Then he turned.

And stepped out into the night.

Midnight – Trial Sector Grounds

The camp was eerie at night.

The celebration drums had stopped.

The wine-fires were dying.

The laughter of the noble demon audience was long replaced with a cold wind and the distant groans of enchantment engines under the city's core.

The arena tower loomed in the distance, a jagged behemoth of black stone and lava-glyphs, like it had erupted straight from hell's spine. Its central eye—an open stadium sphere—glowed dim, as if slumbering between blood feasts.

Swayam didn't look at it long.

Instead, he moved between the dome tents.

Some were quiet like his.

Others were *too* quiet—empty, or perhaps filled with teams already lost.

He noticed one tent flutter slightly from movement. A silhouette within it was standing—arms extended in meditation or madness. He couldn't tell.

He walked on.

Eventually, he reached the plaza where the *Trial Grounds Armory* stood—silent and empty, save for a dimly pulsing sigil above the door that read: *Participants only. Access: Always.*

Swayam stepped inside.

Weapon Quarter – Armory

The air inside smelled of ash-oil, old metal, and something like sparking ozone.

Weapons lined the walls—swords, axes, chain-spears, mono-rods, enchanted darts, thunder claws, and relic firearms. All etched with glyphs. All waiting.

But the place was *empty*.

Except for one demon asleep behind a bone-glass counter, snoring with his boots propped on a pile of registration scrolls.

Swayam walked up.

Paused.

Then said flatly, “I need weapons.”

The demon didn't stir.

Swayam leaned forward, voice colder this time—*Krotha's voice*.

“Wake up, forge-rat. I said I need weapons that discharge.”

The demon jolted, fell off his chair, cursed in three tongues, then stood, wiping his eyes.

“Right, right—Let's see...”

He stumbled over to a side rack.

Opened a sealed case.

“Got thunderblades. Feed on ambient charge. Discharge through friction or focused snap.”

He pulled two out.

Each blade was slightly curved, obsidian at the core with filament veins of white-blue electricity slithering under the surface. They hummed faintly—like wolves dreaming of thunder.

Swayam took them both.

Spun one.

Let it hum in his hand.

Then sheathed them in a cross-back configuration—like he’d done it a hundred times before.

“Free?” he asked.

The demon yawned. “All standard arsenal’s free. Just return 'em if you survive.”

Swayam turned to go.

“Anything else?” the demon called half-heartedly.

Swayam paused.

Eyes flicked to a locked case in the far corner.

“...Yes,” he said.

And he took something else.

Elsewhere – Inside the Illusion

Anshika

The village was fire.

Not metaphor.

Not fear.

Just *fire*.

Ash clung to her face like warpaint. Her hands were blistered from grabbing things that weren’t real—burning children, melting bridges, walls that turned to bone.

Dead bodies collapsed around her, screaming as they fell:

“*Save us,—save us!*”

But she *couldn’t*.

No matter how fast she ran, no matter how loud she cried out—it was like her voice evaporated in the heat.

She dropped to her knees beside a charred boy whose face was her *old friend*

But he had no eyes.

He just whispered, “You’re too late again.”

Then exploded into flame.

Anshika screamed—

But in the real world, her mouth didn’t move.

Only her fingers clenched.

The illusion's grip was weakening.

But not gone.

Nyss

Nothing was shown.

Only a heartbeat.

Slow.

Then slower.

The illusion wasn’t fire.

It was drowning in *ice*.

And Nyss was sinking deeper.

Before Dawn – Returning

The sky was beginning to blush.

Not light.

But potential.

Swayam—Krotha now in full form—walked back to the dome tent, two thunder swords strapped to his back, his gait balanced, prepared, *ready*.

The glyphs on the tent fluttered as he passed through the barrier.

He looked at them.

One by one.

Yugetsu—still curled in his instinctive guard position.

Aviral—scroll in hand, a foot twitching every now and then like he was fighting monsters in sleep.

Gaurav—finally relaxed, but one arm still halfway across his body like he might rise and punch reality if it changed again.

Nyss—still lost.

Anshika—still trapped.

He looked at them all.

Then smiled—small. Crooked. Quiet.

“Don’t worry,” he whispered.

“We’re not here to win the round.”

He took a slow breath.

“We’re here to win the *war*.”

And the light behind the horizon began to stir.

Despite the chaos curled inside his chest, despite the blade weight of decisions to come, he actually napped.

Only for an hour.

Maybe less.

But when he opened his eyes again, the dome tent was already lit with a soft violet-pink glow—*dawn, quiet and careful*. The kind of dawn that didn’t want to wake anyone too harshly because it *knew* today was going to be war.

The time glyph blinked faintly from the far wall: **06:41 AM**.

Swayam sat up slowly, bones loose, muscles unusually fresh. A side effect of Lilith’s healing, sure—but also a quiet reminder that for once in his life, he wasn’t waking up in a cell or a slaughter pit.

He scanned the tent.

Aviral was seated cross-legged near the portable fire plate, shirt off, one half of his torso already armored. He was polishing a metallic *staff* that shimmered faintly every time the cloth moved. Thin glyph lines etched with molten-gold runes pulsed along its length like blood through a vein.

Each stroke of the cloth made the air *pop*—just a little. Like it was warning the morning to behave.

Swayam stretched. “Where’d you get that?”

Aviral didn’t look up. “Armory. Picked it two days ago while you were doing your best dead-frost-ghost impression.”

Swayam let out a breath through his nose. “Looks lethal.”

“Feels even better.”

Outside the tent flap, a wet gargling noise followed by an unnecessarily violent **hurrrGGHHH–PWAH!** echoed in.

They didn’t flinch.

They just looked at each other.

“Gaurav,” they said in unison.

Swayam snorted.

It felt good.

Normal.

He pulled the mask halfway off his face, letting the morning air cool his cheeks, then stood and wandered toward the center of the tent.

Yugetsu stood by the corner cots—Anshika and Nyss still unconscious.

He wasn’t speaking.

Just... looking.

His arms were folded, but not in annoyance. His brows were low, thoughtful, his fingers twitching lightly like he wanted to *do* something but couldn’t figure out what.

Then, as Swayam walked closer, Yugetsu turned—

—and immediately flushed red.

Swayam blinked. “...What?”

Yugetsu looked like a kid who’d been caught watching something he wasn’t supposed to.

“N-Nothing,” he said quickly.

Swayam narrowed his eyes. “That was *definitely* something.”

Yugetsu scratched the back of his head, ears pink now. “I-I was just thinking... we’re lucky their bodies are in partial stasis because of the illusion fields.”

Swayam raised a brow. “Okay?”

Yugetsu gestured nervously between Anshika and Nyss. “It means... no excess sweat. No digestion. No—uh—excretory function. Mostly dormant. Just the vital organs being kept alive by the medical glyphs. It’s clean.”

He smiled, almost proud of his observation.

Swayam blinked again. "...And?"

Yugetsu looked around awkwardly. Then leaned in and *whispered*:

"But we... can't take them into Trial Two in *those* clothes. Look at them. Armor's ripped. Sleeves are bloodstained. One of Nyss's boots is melted. They *need* to be changed. And washed."

A beat.

Swayam paused.

Aviral paused.

They both turned their heads slowly toward Yugetsu, realization dawning like a comet crashing into a temple.

Then, in perfect sync, they laughed.

Not loud, not obnoxious.

But a short, sharp, "Pfft—"

Followed by: "Oh, that's easy. We'll just—"

And then it hit them.

They were boys.

Both of them.

Yugetsu included.

All three stared at each other for a full two seconds before the awkward silence *slammed* into the dome like a thunder god's hammer.

Aviral's hand froze mid-stroke on his staff.

Swayam scratched his neck without looking at anyone.

Yugetsu, still red, mumbled, "I mean... maybe if we close our eyes?"

Swayam answered without thinking. "What are we, blindfolded laundry demons?"

Aviral muttered, "I'm not touching."

Yugetsu's ears were now *glowing*.

"Do we... I dunno... rotate them like a log and slide the clothes out?"

Swayam deadpanned, "That's not how clothes work, genius."

The silence returned.

Heavier.

More dangerous.

The only sound was the subtle buzz of the time glyph reminding them Trial Two was **less than ten hours away**.

And they had no plan.

Just three idiot brothers and two unconscious warriors in badly damaged armor.

Gaurav walked in.

Towel slung over one shoulder, water flask in hand, teeth freshly brushed and shining like a warlord about to punch fate.

He stopped.

He stared.

All three of them were seated in a triangle on the floor, red-faced, fidgeting, and avoiding eye contact like they'd summoned a ghost and kissed it.

He squinted. "You guys got fevers?"

Swayam muttered, "Worse."

Aviral said, "Way worse."

Yugetsu whispered, "So much worse."

Gaurav looked from one to the other.

Then at Anshika and Nyss.

Then back at them.

His jaw dropped.

"Oh no."

Yugetsu nodded solemnly. "Yep."

Gaurav walked two steps, sat beside them, and leaned forward, head in hands.

A moment later—

His neck turned red too.

Then his face.

Then his ears.

Swayam exhaled.

"We are *doomed*."

Aviral grumbled, “Trial of tactical synergy and emotional resilience, and we’re being undone by laundry.”

Yugetsu deadpanned, “Maybe Lilith comes back and we just bribe her with, like, a toe.”

Gaurav didn’t look up. “If you suggest toe bribery again, I’m sending you out in *Anshika’s skirt*.”

That *almost* broke the silence.

Almost.

But not quite.

Then Swayam stood, clapping his hands once.

“Okay. We find cloaks. Wrap them. Pray they don’t wake up while we change them. Then give them proper armor post-trial.”

Yugetsu raised a shaky hand. “Uh... and *who* is going to do the changing?”

Everyone turned to look at each other.

Then turned away.

Then sat in silence again.

And the time glyph blinked:

06:54 AM.

For another minute, no one spoke. Just the low crackle of a dying rune-flame and the occasional stretch-groan from Aviral’s shoulder joints as he shifted his armor.

Finally, Swayam stood.

“I’ll handle it,” he said simply.

Yugetsu blinked. “You sure?”

“No,” Swayam muttered, grabbing his frost-mask from the cot’s edge. “But we’re not exactly overflowing with options.”

Medical Court – Outer Grounds

The Medical Court sat like a low fortress of polished bone, half-buried in the inner arena’s substructure. It was too quiet this morning—no buzzing glyph-drones, no nurse packs darting between wards. Just a single demoness seated behind a crescent-stone counter, polishing her nails with a blade shard.

Swayam—fully in *Krotha* persona now—strode in with the kind of presence that expected silence to follow it.

She didn’t even look up.

“Emergency?” she asked flatly.

“Not exactly,” Krotha replied coolly. “I require a female medic to accompany me. Two unconscious combatants at my tent. Illusion-locked. Need cleaning. Clothing. Preparation for Trial Two.”

“Denied,” the demoness said without hesitation.

Swayam’s eyes narrowed behind the frost mask. “You do know who I am, yes?”

She finally glanced up.

“Doesn’t matter if you’re the Fire King’s cousin—every medic’s been dispatched to their assigned arena ward. We’re down to zero.”

Krotha leaned forward slightly, voice dropping. “Try again.”

The demoness gave a mock bow. “I would, but even miracles have quotas.”

Swayam exhaled sharply through his nose and turned to leave. This was supposed to be *easy*.

He was halfway to the exit when—

“—That voice sounds familiar.”

It came from behind him.

Silken. Dangerous. Pleased.

Lilith.

She had just stepped through the archway, the bone doorway parting like it *recognized* her.

The demoness behind the counter snapped to attention, eyes wide, mouth sealed shut.

“Lady Lilith,” she said, bowing so low her forehead tapped the desk. “Apologies—I didn’t realize you had entered.”

Lilith ignored her entirely.

Her golden-red gaze locked onto Swayam’s back.

She took three slow steps forward, her hair catching faint light like molten wine.

“Got any idea,” she said aloud, “where that friend of yours might be?”

Swayam turned slowly—controlled, deliberate.

Lilith was already walking closer, her gaze dancing over his posture, the mask, the aura. She looked intrigued, maybe even mildly amused.

“That blood,” she said, almost purring. “I’ve tasted potent humans before. But *his*? Oh, darling... it was like lightning bottled in vintage silk. I’ve been trying to find him for two days.”

She tilted her head. “Surely you know something?”

Swayam paused.

Then leaned into the persona.

Cool. Calculated. Half amused.

“You can meet him after Phase One,” he said casually. “He’s... shy. Doesn’t show it, but he is.”

Lilith squinted at him. “Shy?”

He gave a faint shrug. “Type who doesn’t handle compliments well.

She studied him for a second.

Then grinned.

“But in exchange,” Krotha continued, “I’ll need a favor.”

Lilith raised a brow. “From me?”

“I need a female medic,” he said bluntly. “To clean and redress two illusion-locked warriors in my camp. Both female. Trial’s in less than ten hours.”

Lilith blinked.

Then broke into a low laugh.

“Oh, *Krotha*, of all the favors you could ask of me after such blood and storm—you come here for *laundry and grooming*?” She wiped a mock tear. “Why not command your slaves?”

Swayam’s voice dropped.

Cold. Flat.

“Because how my warriors are treated reflects directly on me.”

That hit.

Lilith’s grin faded—just for a moment.

Then returned—more sly now.

“Mmm. Where was that towering authority,” she said sweetly, “when your handsome friend had to come and offer his blood just to save you?”

Krotha tilted his head.

And gave her a small, dark smirk.

“I was busy,” he said. “Dying. Painfully. But I do that sometimes. Keeps things interesting.”

Lilith let out an actual laugh—light and bright and somehow lethal.

“Fine,” she said. “But my favor’s still owed, frost prince.”

She turned to the demoness behind the counter.

“Send someone with him.”

The demoness flinched. “All medics are stationed—”

“You’re here, aren’t you?” Lilith cut in.

“But I—I’m not field certified—”

“You have hands. You can clean. Go.”

The demoness paled. “Yes, Lady Lilith.”

She vanished into the back chamber, emerging a minute later with a sealed satchel of garments—neutral armor, flexible underlayers, reinforced boots, standard glyph-strip for combat support. Fresh, basic—but solid.

Swayam nodded once.

Lilith waved a lazy goodbye.

“And *tell* your friend,” she called, “if he ever wants to be tasted properly—next time, bring his name with the blood.”

Back at the Tent

The medic walked stiffly behind Swayam like she’d rather be anywhere else. When they reached the dome tent, she paused, eyeing the structure.

“They’re... inside?”

“Yes,” Swayam said. “We’ll stay out.”

She entered.

The flap sealed shut.

The boys didn’t say a word.

Not for several minutes.

Gaurav crossed his arms. Yugetsu tried not to pace. Aviral was adjusting the tension straps on his armor with more force than necessary.

Inside, they heard faint movements—clothes being removed, water activated through glyph-bags, the muted snap of fabric, the occasional low grunt of exertion from the medic.

Then silence.

Then the flap opened.

She stepped out.

“It’s done,” she said. “They’re cleaned, clothed, combat-ready. Still unconscious.”

Gaurav nodded respectfully. “Thank you.”

She didn’t reply.

Just left.

Maybe she didn’t want to be seen as kind.

The boys reentered the tent.

And stopped.

The light from the morning glyphs shimmered faintly across Anshika’s new armor—slim, black-on-maroon leather plating, cleaned and restructured to allow mobility even in unconsciousness. Nyss wore a similar set—her limbs placed precisely, boots lined, hair fixed in a low braid.

No blood. No soot. No trace of Trial One.

Just readiness.

The illusion still held.

But at least now, it held *cleanly*.

Aviral exhaled. “One problem solved.”

Swayam stared a moment longer.

Then, almost to himself, he said:

“Now we deal with the bigger one.”

Outside, the arena gates were opening.

The hours slipped past like sharpening blades. Team Krotha and Team Nyss rested in shifts, mentally rehearsing everything they’d learned since the reshuffle: movement sync, tactical breaks, glyph alignment, healing protocol, knockout windows.

It wasn’t sleep. It was coiled waiting.

When the time glyph blinked **02:11 PM**, they moved.

Swayam walked in full *Krotha* attire—frost mask on, thunder swords sheathed in an X-formation across his back, cold silence wrapped around him like a skin.

Behind him walked Yugetsu, who carried Anshika’s unconscious form with a reverence that made the weight invisible.

Beside him, Gaurav bore Nyss on his back—taller, heavier, but it didn't matter. He carried her like a shield he wouldn't drop.

Aviral walked in the middle—staff in hand, fire-rune flickering every few steps as if to warn the air not to breathe too loud.

They said nothing as they approached the Trial 2 gates.

Only when the heavy vaults hissed open and the arena compound bloomed before them in full bloodlit majesty did Swayam speak.

“Here,” he said, voice quiet but firm.

They reached the registration pillars.

Demonic clerks with inked horns gestured them into separate wings.

Team Nyss: Gaurav, Aviral, Nyss.

Team Krotha: Swayam, Yugetsu, Anshika.

For a heartbeat, all five stood still at the crossroads between entry halls.

Yugetsu glanced at Aviral.

Aviral gave a single nod.

Gaurav stepped forward, raised his fist. “To the end.”

They all bumped fists, tight, focused.

Swayam looked at all of them, voice low:

“All seven of us walk out of this alive.”

And then they split.

The arena was alive.

Not just with demons—but with **hunger**.

Glyph-screens hovered high above, projecting multi-angle feeds. Lava braziers burned like suns around the edges. The coliseum seating was overflowing—thousands of nobles dressed in ceremonial cloths, draped in luxury, sipping bloodwine and ready to bet on death.

In the center circle stood the **host**—
draped in a gold-thread cloak, smile wider than his face, teeth impossibly white.

He raised his arms theatrically.

“Lords, ladies, nobles, fiends—**welcome back** to the roaring bloodstage of Kaali Bhoomi!”

The crowd screamed.

The host turned slowly, his voice booming from a dozen glyph-towers.

“Today... is not just a *trial*.”

He paused. Grinned.

“It’s an offering. A spectacle. A soul-deep *temptation*.”

One hand rose.

“And to begin this grand slaughter—we open with the finest seasoning...”

He vanished.

Smoke erupted.

The glyph-ring around the central platform exploded into the sky, sending firework trails in spirals above the arena.

A horn blared like a war beast being gutted.

The Announcers Take Over

The broadcast glyph flared.

Three voices cut in:

IGNIS – The Shapeshifting Dragon of Commentary

“Well, well, well! It seems the Trial Gods are merciful today, because we’re kicking off with a matchup that *smells* like volcanic carnage wrapped in sweet betrayal!”

ELSA – Mistress of Pleasure and Pain

“Ooooh, Ignis, I can *already* taste the agony! These teams aren’t here to entertain—they’re here to devour each other *cell by screaming cell*.”

RAKTABĪJA – The Eviscerator Poet, voice like spilt wine over razors

“In this crucible, only pain makes music. And today’s opera begins... with *grief made flesh*.”

Ignis roared, “So light your glyphs, sharpen your claws, and hold your lover’s head tight—because Trial 2’s **first match is upon us!**”

HOLOGRAPHIC PROJECTION: MATCH 1

TEAM KAAL

- Kaal (Captain)
- Scar
- Rachit

VS

TEAM MALEDICTUS

- Maledictus Dreadborne (Captain)
- Kraise, the Stormborn
- Ashborn, the Blackened Pit

The arena floor groaned and rearranged—stone panels splitting, rearranging into a massive jagged circle bordered by containment glyphs and amplification seals.

Above them, new text burned into the sky in molten red:

MATCH RULES:

1. 1v1 rotation format
2. Victory only by **knockout or kill**
3. A team loses when all three members fall
4. Audience rule-vote active after every round

RAKTABĪJA, hushed and hungry:
“Only one team will walk out whole.”

ELSA, purring:
“The other will crawl... if they still have knees.”

Arena Prep – Team Maledictus Appears

The left gate groaned open.

Black fire spilled out.

And they walked through:

—**Maledictus**, calm and terrible, draped in shadowed bone-armor, crown of molten spike rising like a devil’s throne.

His **eyes**—gray voids that pulled color from the light.

His presence silenced half the crowd.

—**Kraise**, skin bioluminescent, hair floating like water possessed. He cracked his knuckles, and arcs of steam-lightning danced between his fingertips.

He *grinned* at the crowd, unstable.

—**Ashborn**, silent, charred. Smoke curled off his skin. His mechanical arm hissed with soul-forged pressure, veins pulsing with dormant flame.

They said nothing.

Just *stood there*.

Ready to be devoured or do the devouring.

ELSA: “Maledictus—one of the few that even the noble families refused to adopt. Too much null in that blood. Too much hunger.”

IGNIS: “And Kraise? The lovechild of two disasters.

RAKTABĪJA: “Ashborn... speaks not. But when he hits you, your *children* flinch.”

The other gate hissed.

But the announcers fell silent.

Waiting.

Because everyone knew:

Team Kaal was not just another team.

They were **expectation manifest**.

And the crowd leaned forward.

Eyes wide.

Breath held.

Waiting for the **executioners** to enter.

The air trembled.

The arena floor buzzed with pre-match hunger.

Three names had already burned themselves into the glyph-sky like prophecies:

TEAM KAAL

Kaal – The Steel Pulse of Ruin

Scar – The Bleeding Rule

Rachit – The Silent One

From across the arena, nobles leaned forward, tongues flicking, eyes pulsing, bets locking in like chains.

Then—

The gate creaked.

No, not creaked.

It *groaned*—as if it knew what was coming.

ELSA, her voice smooth as skin under a dagger:

“Mmmm... and here they come. The team that walked the Devouring Path like it owed them rent.”

IGNIS, with crackling mirth:

“I can already smell the tension, Elsa. Do you smell it? That steel-and-blood kind of silence?”

RAKTABĪJA, low and reverent:

“No pageantry. No posing. Just walking sin.”

And then they stepped out.

First: **KAAL**.

A wall.

A system.

A creature of law forged in muscle and gravity.

7’9”, frame cut from siege geometry, burnt-bronze skin gleaming under glyphlight. Horns curled like chains over his temple—one fractured, like a permanent scar from the first war that ever mattered.

His eyes—

Unblinking.

Smoldering like embers that forgot how to go cold.

He didn’t look at the crowd. He didn’t acknowledge the noise.

He just walked.

Straight line. No breaks. The arena bent to him.

Next: **SCAR.**

Chaos wrapped in ritual.

6'6", dust-white skin streaked in pulsing crimson blood seals. Four arms. A permanent carved grin. His black vest still soaked from earlier blood he shed of someone, scripture-cloth wrapped tight along his forearms like a prayer he planned to defile.

He didn't walk.

He danced.

Hopped.

Twirled on one foot, eyes scanning the bloodthirsty stands like he was shopping for the juiciest fruit.

One tongue-flick. One crack of his knuckles.

"OH I'M GONNA MAKE YOU SING," he shrieked toward the air. "ONE BY ONE!"

Then—

Last:

Rachit.

No horns.

No fire.

Just a tall, lean figure in a blue tank top, grey harem pants, twin spiked rods strapped across his back like restrained thunder.

He didn't smile.

Didn't speak.

He just walked.

Quiet.

Calculating.

His reddish-brown eyes scanned the arena with disinterest—until they found the match glyphs hovering overhead.

His gaze locked onto the rules:

ROUND 1, Match 1: Kaal vs Maledictus

Format: 1v1 until entire team falls

Victory only by **kill** or **complete incapacitation**

He sat.

At the edge of the staging platform.

Watching.

Waiting.

Only his fingers moved—tapping slow rhythms against his thigh, like listening to a frequency no one else could hear.

RAKTABĪJA, voice sharpened:

“A human. In Kaal’s team. How curious...”

IGNIS:

“Not just curious. *Unprecedented*. The reshuffle algorithm chose him—because it saw something. Brains? Brawn? Brokenness?”

ELSA, with a slow purr:

“Oh, don’t underestimate broken things. Sometimes they cut deeper than blades.”

In the **waiting chamber** of Team Nyss, Gaurav leaned forward.

His knuckles were pale.

Aviral stood by the side panel, silent.

All two stared at the live holo-glyph feed projected above their bench.

There was no sound. Just image.

Rachit. Sitting alone. Eyes forward. Breathing calm.

Aviral exhaled. “Hope he knows what he’s doing.”

Gaurav didn’t blink.

“He always does.”

Team Krotha’s room.

Swayam stood beside the wall.

Frost mask in hand. Arms crossed.

Yugetsu glanced between him and the screen. “You okay?”

Swayam didn’t reply.

He watched as Rachit sat—silent, alone, calculating.

Then, under his breath, he said:

“Let them see what a ghost can do.”

In the noble viewing towers...

Lilith tilted her head, lounging on her blood-silk recliner.

The screen adjusted.

Rachit came into view.

She sat up.

Licked her lower lip slowly.

“Ooooh. So *that’s* your name...”

She chuckled to herself.

“Rachit. Mmm.”

Her fingers traced the rim of her blood-vial idly.

“Guess I’ll fantasize with better context now.”

In the Arena

On the opposite side of rest area

TEAM MALEDICTUS.

But only one walked out.

Ashborn.

No need for speech. No introduction.

The air hissed around him—skin charcoal gray, joints steaming, one arm glowing with pulsing red sigils and reinforced lava-metal.

He stepped onto the field like gravity hated him.

He didn’t look at the crowd.

Just cracked his neck.

And *waited*.

Scar squealed.

“Oh **YESSSSSSS!**”

He skipped toward Kaal, bouncing on his toes.

“I am going carve him up, okay Kaalie? Let me go first! Let me *break* him!”

Kaal didn’t turn.

Just gave a single nod.

Scar burst forward, arms splayed, laughter ripping from his throat like choir-screams stitched together with nails.

The crowd roared.

IGNIS, ecstatic:

“Scar is UP first! And that means the fun begins IMMEDIATELY.”

RAKTABĪJA:

“Ashborn... forged in pain. Scar... born to multiply it.”

ELSA:

“Do you feel that? That taste in the air? That’s not fear. That’s foreplay.”

Scar landed mid-ring.

Arms wide.

Head tilted.

Tongue licking the air.

Ashborn just stood there.

Still.

Scar whispered:

“You’re already bleeding, aren’t you?”

Ashborn said nothing.

But the ground beneath him cracked.

Heat shimmered around his feet.

Scar grinned wider.

“I’ll find the blood soon enough.”

He raised two arms—

Flexed.

And the match glyph lit.

MATCH BEGIN

CHAPTER:2 SHOW,S OVER

The arena groaned as its inner plates shifted, gears grinding beneath miles of stone and bone. Hologlyphs lit the sky—scorching brands of crimson, cobalt, and molten gold. Names roared above the air like a battlefield sermon:

Team Kaal vs. Team Maledictus

—Round 1 Begins Now—

The center plate rose.

A battlefield of cracked obsidian veins, ember-lit craters, and hovering fragments of blackened debris. The match space changed its terrain each battle, and this one seemed forged from ash and forgotten war.

From the east gate—

Ashborn stepped into the light.

His body smoked.

Not metaphorically—his skin was literally steaming from the joints. Charcoal-black, cratered with ember pulses, one arm fused with a brutal alloy that looked stolen from a god’s forge. The crowd hushed at first, then erupted into feral cheer.

In the distance, seated nobles leaned in.

A molten knight. A walking furnace.

And—

From the west gate, laughter.

Not joyous.

Not mocking.

A *hungry* kind of laughter.

Scar walked in, slow, barefoot, blood-cloth straps flapping around his carved arms like war-banners. His smile didn’t twitch—it was already set, ritual-carved. Four arms flexed. His torso pulsed with faint red seals.

He stopped just past the midline and flicked one of the blades from his wrist.

The crowd tensed.

Raktabīja’s voice bled into the air with a snarl of joy.

“Now, now, now. What do we *have* here? One burning mountain of hate... and one dancing bloodletter with a taste for breakdowns. Elsa, Ignis—how long do you think before the first bone pops?”

Elsa purred through her glowing teeth:

“Less than thirty seconds. I *like* Ashborn’s quiet. It means his screams will be louder.”

Ignis, draped along his shifting seat of bones, chuckled in his serpentine voice:

“Scar doesn’t even want to win. He just wants someone to bleed *better* than the last. This’ll be art.”

Above it all, the dome of noble viewing platforms glimmered—and from one balcony, **Lilith’s lips curled** around a whisper.

“That’s the human’s teammate? And *you* wanted me to heal him?”

She laughed, slow. Then licked the rim of her glass.

In the rooms of krotha and nyss—

Team Krotha stared at the hologlyph projection.

Anshika, still asleep. Yugetsu’s fingers twitched at his side. At, the same time Gaurav stood at the edge of the table, fists tight.

Said nothing.

But when Rachit’s silent image showed on the hologlyph—sitting back, legs folded, eyes locked forward with zero emotion—

He felt something was coming.

Back in the arena—

The match started not with a bell, but a pulse of raw gravity. **Kaal**, unmoved from his seat, had triggered it from outside the ring—a silent nod of permission.

Scar cracked his knuckles.

Ashborn said nothing.

Then—

Scar vanished.

Four blurs of motion. A knife snapped through the air—and **Ashborn caught it mid-flight** with his mechanical arm. It sizzled on contact, metal softening under sheer heat. But Scar was already there.

First cut: missed.

Second: blocked.

Third—**landed**.

A shallow scrape on Ashborn's thigh.

Scar whispered, delighted.

"Got it."

He twisted in place, slammed both feet into the ground—and **the arena lit red**.

Blood had touched stone.

Seal One: Vein Lock.

Ashborn staggered as his leg muscles tightened. Not pain—something worse. Paralysis. *Inside* his bloodstream.

He grunted, flexed—and molten heat burst from under his skin. The blood seal sizzled and broke.

Scar's grin widened. "Ohoho... you're going to be *so fun*."

Ashborn roared. Not a scream—more like a volcano cracking open. The ground beneath him *exploded*. Lava burst upward in a spike—but Scar jumped, flipping above it, laughing midair.

The two clashed again.

Blow for blow.

Scar's blades scraped against Ashborn's molten body, steam bursting between strikes. Ashborn's haymaker missed, but when he hit ground—**half the arena cratered**.

Seal Two activated on Scar's wrist.

Spinal Pulse.

Scar slashed his own arm and sent blood flying at Ashborn. It *pulsed* with sound and slammed into Ashborn's skull. For 3 seconds—he was blind.

But Ashborn moved by heat.

And Scar had *a heartbeat*.

The mechanical arm caught Scar's waist and flung him across the arena like a broken puppet.

The crowd screamed.

Elsa moaned theatrically.

"I felt that in places I don't legally have!"

Ignis, now fully coiled into a fiery sphere, hissed with pleasure:

“But he bleeds *still*, dear Scar. You only need one more...”

Back at the benches—Rachit watched.

Didn’t blink.

Didn’t speak.

The other teams stared at his face.

Gaurav leaned closer to the screen.

“He’s... not watching the fight.”

Yugetsu turned. “Huh?”

“He’s watching Ashborn’s footwork. Scar’s breathing.”

Aviral added, “...he’s watching how long it takes for a seal to go active.”

Rachit’s eyes flicked left.

Another fight had already begun—in his mind.

Ashborn’s skin was cracking now. His body glowing from within.

Scar’s seals had layered five deep. Each wound was a *death trap*.

Then Scar jumped again. Landed a cut across Ashborn’s collar.

Seal Six.

Reverse Torrent.

Ashborn froze—blood surged backward in his chest.

His heart stuttered.

Scar whispered:

“Boom.”

He touched his tongue to the blood trail mid-air.

Seal Seven: Detonation.

And the entire left side of the arena *exploded*.

Ashborn’s body vanished in the blast.

The crowd erupted in hysteria.

Ignis roared. Elsa stood.

But in the smoke—

Ashborn walked out.

Still burning.

His skin flaking like paper.

But alive.

And smiling.

One word left his mouth:

“My turn.”

Ashborn stepped forward.

The blast scars on his body hissed. One eye-socket smoked. His right arm had fully overheated—runes flashing, metal groaning.

But he was grinning.

That *terrified* the crowd.

Raktabija whispered like death beneath silk.

“He’s smiling. That means something *vile* is coming.”

Elsa, low and excited:

“Look at that skin. Cracked like dry clay. He’s going to burn this arena just to end one man.”

Scar wiped blood off his lip with the back of his hand. “You done creaking?”

Ashborn didn’t answer.

He slammed his mechanical arm into the ground.

Ash Rift Core: Activated.

The air howled.

From the point of impact, molten spires exploded upward in a ring—dark fire stitched with bone-light. Ashborn’s body ignited—flames crawling up his neck, torso, even the hollow of his eye sockets.

The arena turned into a hell-maw.

Scar just laughed.

“Now *we’re talking!*”

Ashborn charged. His entire body radiated *impact*. Scar dashed—four arms whirling with blades. Flame met blood.

The floor melted.

Spikes jutted up like teeth—Scar ducked, spun, sliced through the ribs of a spire and redirected himself toward Ashborn’s flank.

The crowd gasped.

Scar screamed joy.

“Die tired, you smoky bastard!”

Ashborn’s molten punch met Scar’s torso mid-air.

Boom.

Scar *bent*—but not far.

He rotated with it. Let his bones flow with the heat.

Then his blade cut deep into Ashborn’s other shoulder—*blood* hissed through steam.

Seal Eight: Nerve Sliver.

A precision seal designed to send a searing current of pain through one muscle group on loop.

Ashborn staggered—but didn’t fall.

He roared again, this time catching Scar by the leg and slamming him against the wall.

Once.

Twice.

Three times.

The arena’s edge cracked.

Dust rose.

Scar disappeared in the smoke.

The crowd *stopped breathing*.

Then:

A low laugh.

And Scar *walked out*.

Not limping.

Not hurt.

Walking.

Ashborn's flame dimmed slightly.

Scar twirled a small dagger in his fourth hand and sighed.

"You almost got me."

Ashborn opened his mouth—
and Scar's blade sliced across his jaw.

Seal Nine: Lockjaw.

Ashborn froze.

Scar moved with clinical grace now.

One hand gripped Ashborn's shoulder.

Another carved across his chest.

Two more drew sigils mid-air—blood magic looping into geometric death.

Scar whispered:

"Show's over."

And with a final press of his palm to Ashborn's back—

All nine seals pulsed.

Ash Rift Core ruptured.

Ashborn exploded from the *inside*.

Flame surged in reverse—imploding with a wet crunch.

His body fell.

Still smoking.

Still burning.

But no longer standing.

WINNER: SCAR

The glyph above the ring flashed red.

The crowd? **Unhinged.**

Scar stood in the center of the cracked arena floor, arms raised like a choir conductor finishing a massacre symphony.

ANNOUNCERS—

Ignis burst out laughing, shapeshifting into a storm of wings and flame.

“HE DID IT! The bloodsinger outlasted the inferno! One hell of an opening round!”

Elsa, nearly breathless:

“He didn’t just win. He *savored* every second.”

Raktabija, voice soft and sharp:

“He played pain like an instrument. Ashborn burned. But Scar *bled him dry*.”

Cut to Hologlyph Feeds—

In Team Krotha’s room and nyss room, Yugetsu looked visibly pale.

Aviral just muttered, “That... was one guy?”

Gaurav leaned back.

Silent.

Watching.

Processing.

“This isn’t just a strong team,” he said finally.

“I take it back. Calling him a coward? That was blind.”

Back in the arena—

Scar twirled.

Bowed.

Then turned to the arena edge.

The next name was already lit: Kraise.

The stormchild.

The hybrid disaster.

He stepped in slowly—lightning cracking at his ankles, water vapor hissing off his back like steam from a dying god.

He cracked his neck.

Looked at Scar.

Scar stared back.

Then...

Dropped to his knees.

Tongue out.

And **faceplanted**.

Hard.

The crowd froze.

Then **screamed**.

IGNIS: “DID HE—WHAT—?”

ELSA: *gasping laughter* “He faked it! He’s out! He faked a KO to skip the fight!”

RAKTABĪJA: *hollow delight* “Genius. That’s not fear. That’s performance.”

In the noble stands—murmurs.

Some shocked.

Some amused.

Others enraged.

In Team Krotha’s room—Yugetsu burst out laughing.

“He just—!”

In Team Nyss’s room .

Aviral shook his head. “I don’t even know what that was.”

Gaurav stared at the hologlyph.

“...He’s crazy. But tactical.”

Back in the arena—

Kaal didn't move from his bench.

Just raised one hand.

The *gravity shifted*.

Scar's body lifted gently—almost like it was dignified.

He floated backward toward the benches and landed with a smooth thump.

Sat up.

Grinned at Kaal.

“Tag, big guy.”

Kaal didn't reply.

Just turned his head toward the only one left sitting.

Rachit.

Kaal's voice was quiet.

But the entire arena *felt* it.

“Your turn.”

The battlefield still smoked from Ashborn's defeat.

Charred stone. Broken glyphs. Blood cooled in shattered craters.

Then—

Rachit stood.

No trumpets. No aura burst.

Just a quiet human in loose fabric and tired wrists.

His **blue tank top** clung slightly from sweat. His **grey harem pants** shifted softly in the scorched breeze. Two slim **black metal rods** hung crossed on his back—one spike-tipped, one flat-ended—held by a strap so worn it looked stitched by desperation.

His **feet**, wrapped in black khappar sandals, scraped the cracked obsidian floor as he walked forward.

But the detail that unsettled the crowd?

The bands.

He was wrapping two black wristbands slowly, methodically. A gesture not of flair, but of **ritual**. The kind a man does when he knows something is about to break.

His **reddish-brown eyes** scanned the path ahead like a hunter memorizing escape routes—half-shadowed, half-shining. Too soft to be a demon’s. Too focused to be afraid.

The audience?

Laughed.

Mocking. Louder now that the battlefield had reset.

“What is this, a peasant in cosplay?”

“Is he *seriously* wearing sandals?”

“Scar’s little pet project finally got loose.”

In the Team Krotha chamber, Swayam stood near the projection, arms crossed. Yugetsu, seated near Anshika’s slumbering form, muttered:

“They don’t get it.”

Team Nyss, same moment—Aviral leaned forward. Gaurav stared.

Gaurav whispered, “Wait.”

Because **Rachit stopped**.

Dead center.

Kraise, already in the ring, flicked one spark-lit finger toward him.

“Already lost your brain, monkey?”

Rachit didn’t blink.

Didn’t reply.

Instead—

He stepped forward.

Opened both arms wide.

Faced the crowd.

And *spoke*.

Loud. Clear. Unshaken.

“To all the noble demons, hybrids, and bloodline freaks watching this... don’t you think it’s boring?”

That got attention.

Gasps. Hushed murmurs.

Rachit continued.

“I mean, let’s be honest. You all already know how this ends, right? I lose. Kraise gets mildly injured. Then Kaal—”

he motioned to the seated bronze juggernaut behind him

“—kills the rest of them one by one.”

“Because if you’ve read any performance logs, from trial 1 you know—no one beats Scar. No one beats Kaal. Not in a 1v1.”

He turned slightly toward Kraise, whose grin had faded into an uncertain twitch.

“Your captain? Maledictus? Maybe, *maybe* he has a chance. In *darkness*. In *silence*. But here? With lights and screams and eyes on you?”

He smiled.

The crowd was now... listening.

“So how about we make this fun?”

“Let’s turn this into a **2v2 death match**. Me and Kaal. Versus you and your captain.”

“Odds are fairer. Stakes are higher.”

He paused.

Then looked straight at Kraise.

“After all... I’m just a weak human, right?”

IGNIS, absolutely losing it:

“DID HE JUST—IS THIS ALLOWED—”

ELSA, laughing hard:

“OH it *is* allowed. Mid-match audience votes *can* change the rules. He’s using the system!”

RAKTABĪJA, in a reverent hiss:

“He weaponized boredom.”

Kraise stepped forward. Lightning curled behind his shoulders.

But he didn’t strike.

He *laughed*.

“Fine. I’ll wait.”

He folded his arms.

Turned to the sky-cam glyph.

“Let’s hear what the crowd wants.”

Above, the main hologlyph updated:

Mid-Match Rule Vote Active:

“Allow 2v2 Battle Substitution?”

Yes / No

The glyphs spun. The arena held its breath.

Back in the noble boxes, demons argued. Some laughed. Others protested. Bets recalculated. The vote timer ticked down from five minutes.

In those five minutes, Rachit didn’t move.

Didn’t twitch.

Just stood.

Kraise tried staring him down.

But it didn’t work.

Because Rachit—

He started smiling again.

Not wide. Not mocking.

Just enough to unsettle.

A small, unhinged grin that looked like it came from a place no one else had ever been.

IGNIS:

“Look at him. That is not a fighter. That is a *question*—one with no answer and too many teeth.”

RAKTABĪJA:

“He stands like someone who knows what’s gonna happen next.”

ELSA, delighted:

“I want to touch his soul. With a scalpel.”

Five minutes passed.

The glyph flashed:

☑ **Vote Passed.**

New Rule Applied: 2v2 DEATH MATCH — TEAM KAAL (Rachit & Kaal) vs TEAM MALEDICTUS (Kraise & Maledictus)

The ground *shook*.

The arena plates shifted again—adjusting for four combatants. Glyph barriers reset. Energy fields recalibrated. Kill-rules affirmed.

From the benches—

Maledictus stood.

His molten crown flared. His gray void eyes lit with anti-light.

He stepped into the ring like silence with bones.

Rachit exhaled—slow, quiet.

Behind him—

Kaal rose.

No words. No gesture.

Just power walking.

Footsteps that cracked stone.

He joined Rachit at the center.

Kraise and Maledictus faced them.

Elsa, voice rich with arousal:

“Four demons. Well... three demons and one very broken, *beautiful* boy.”

Ignis:

“Two teams. Zero mercy.”

Raktabīja:

“No more waiting. No more hiding. One will fall.”

And then—

The battlefield trembled.

Molten shards still steamed in the wake of Ashborn's defeat. Lightning halos spiraled above the glyph posts. The arena had reset its plates, now pulsing with crimson circuitry—an altar waiting for the next blood offering.

A voice slithered across the glyph-feed.

Raktabīja, low and amused:

“Two captains. One human. One breathing experiment. The field is set.”

Elsa, delighted:

“And Rachit's heartbeat is deliciously mortal.”

Ignis, fire crackling along his scales:

“Let's see if the human gets to finish even one breath.”

Then it began.

Not with a roar.

With a **snap**.

Kraise clapped his hands together—once—and the **entire battlefield blurred**.

A sphere of shimmering water shot from beneath Rachit's feet, **trapping him midair**.

No warning.

One second, he stood calmly beside Kaal—

The next, he was sealed inside a floating **blue orb**, suspended like prey in a predator's eye.

The crowd **howled** with laughter.

Inside the water sphere—

Sound died.

Rachit's eyes snapped open. Lips sealed tight. One long breath—held.

His fingers moved slowly, carefully. No vibration. No attack. Just patience.

But the water pressed in.

Heavy.

Cold.

His vision warped through the layers of distorted light.

Outside, shapes moved.

Maledictus spoke.

Low.

Measured.

A whisper that crackled like rotting parchment under flame.

“Told you,” he said to Kraise, “The human was bait.”

Kraise nodded, lightning dancing along his arms.

“Bait that forgot to drown first.”

Then they turned—

And leapt at Kaal together.

The behemoth moved only when the first strike landed.

Maledictus struck first, slashing his arm open mid-air and flinging **Null Blood** across Kaal’s chest.

The droplets *hissed*—nulling gravity fields in a three-foot radius.

But Kaal simply **shifted** his shoulder.

The blood slid off.

No reaction.

Then—

Kraise came down from above with a spinning Flashboil Surge—steam and lightning erupting around his fists. His body arced like a thunderbolt breaking into ocean rage.

He struck Kaal’s upper shoulder.

The ground cratered.

The glyphs screamed.

Kaal did not move.

From the projection in the Team Nyss room—

Gaurav stood, fists trembling.

“They’re double-teaming him.”

Aviral’s face was still. But his eyes locked on Rachit—**still sealed** in the floating sphere.

“He’s not struggling.”

Gaurav frowned. “He’s not fighting.”

“No. He’s *waiting*.”

Back on the field—

Kaal raised his head.

Slow. Mechanical.

His voice was cold iron dragged across silence.

“You. First.”

He stepped toward Kraise.

The air warped.

Gravity dropped to a crushing 10x normal in a blink—*only under Kraise’s feet*.

The hybrid’s eyes widened.

He buckled.

Spikes of obsidian cracked around his legs as pressure crushed downward.

But **Maledictus** was already moving.

From behind, he swept a hand and sent a line of blackened energy—**Curse Echoes**—straight into Kaal’s lower back.

Kaal **froze**.

The brand lit up—hex geometry across his back.

The Curse hit.

And Kaal... **saw something**.

Just for a second.

His hand trembled. Only once.

Raktabīja, voice hushed:

“Ahh... did the Steel Pulse just flinch?”

Back in the Krotha room, Yugetsu hissed. “What was that?”

Swayam stepped closer to the feed.

“That... wasn’t a hit. That was a *memory*.”

Kaal’s eyes narrowed.

His stance **recalculated**.

He spun, backhanded the hex flare off his body—gravity-concentrated, compact as a meteor, **launched it back**.

Maledictus barely evaded.

Meanwhile—

Inside the water sphere—

Rachit hadn’t moved.

But his skin had started to *tighten*.

Not from pain.

From **focus**.

He rotated gently, eyes still closed.

Every 27 seconds, a faint exhale through the nose.

His fingers tapped a pattern against his chest.

Timing.

Vibration.

Mapping pressure nodes.

Even here—

He was learning.

Back in the fight—

Kraise recovered.

Summoned three Tide-Wrath Orbs—glowing with shifting elemental charge.

One blue.

One green.

One crackling white.

He launched them all at once.

Kaal didn't flinch.

He raised one hand—

And gravity inverted.

The orbs stopped midair.

Wobbled.

Then collapsed inward into a tiny singularity—**snapped out of existence.**

Kraise cursed.

“Okay... that's cheating.”

Kaal took one step forward.

The arena groaned.

Maledictus, behind him, raised both hands.

Spikes of null-fire erupted, trying to wrap Kaal's limbs and suppress flow.

But Kaal simply **compressed** gravity under himself—

And exploded *upward*.

A shockwave tore across the arena.

Kraise got launched.

Maledictus stumbled.

Above it all—

Elsa, breathless:

“Gods below. That wasn't a strike. That was a *planetary response*.”

Ignis, whispering:

“And the human still hasn't drawn a weapon.”

Raktabīja:

“Not yet. But when he does... the tempo will die.”

Rachit floated.

Silent.

Still.

Just a boy inside a trap of water.

Holding his breath.

Counting beats.

Waiting for gravity to shift.

Waiting for someone to blink.

But five minutes is long.

Even for a strategist.

Even for a fighter.

And even for someone like Rachit—
with lungs like bellows and nerves like rope—

It's still five minutes.

Too long.

His fingers, which had been lightly tapping against his chest—
Stopped.

No air bubbles escaped.

No twitch.

No motion.

Elsa, voice a mock eulogy:

“And there it is, darlings. A human highlight reel ends in a quiet little bubble. I got excited for his battle for no reason”

Ignis, with a crackling exhale:

“Well, what else did they expect? A monkey can mimic war, but not survive it.”

Raktabīja, colder:

“He should have begged for mercy before the water filled his lungs.”

Kraise, mid-step, turned to glance at the floating sphere. Then smirked.

“One down.”

He flung a lightning-threaded orb to spin lazily around the bubble, as if adding insult.

“Shame. I was hoping he’d dance at least once.”

In the noble tiers, Lilith leaned forward—

Her smile faded slightly.

“...Was that really it?”

She tilted her glass.

Didn’t sip.

Just stared.

Back in the **Team Krotha chamber**, Yugetsu’s face had drained pale.

“He’s not breathing.”

Swayam stood still.

Mask down.

Voice unreadable.

“We watch. Until we can’t.”

Team Nyss chamber.

Aviral gritted his teeth.

Gaurav’s knuckles turned white.

He whispered like a confession:

“Rachit’s smarter than this.”

Aviral didn’t answer.

Didn't blink.

Just watched as the **crowd began to cheer Rachit's death**—

A boy drowned in silence.

On the field—

Kaal moved.

Not for Rachit.

Not for grief.

Not for anger.

Just because **Maledictus** was still standing.

The Steel Pulse of Ruin turned, cracked his neck once, and extended both hands.

A gravitational ring shimmered out.

Subtle.

Perfectly controlled.

The kind of shift that doesn't flatten—

It fragments.

Maledictus sensed it too late.

One step forward—

And suddenly his left shoulder **dropped** like it had been *erased from gravity*.

He twisted with perfect reflex, realigned his stance, but Kaal was already there.

One strike.

Just his forearm.

To the ribs.

The impact didn't send Maledictus flying—
it sent his **skeleton sideways**.

His body bent the wrong direction midair before correcting mid-fall.

Thud.

But Maledictus caught himself, skidding across stone. He landed in a crouch, coughing once.

His lips curled.

“That one had structure. I like structure.”

Kraise surged in.

Again from above.

No more testing strikes.

This time, **Flashboil Surge**.

He spun a high-pressure water ring into a blinding cyclone, his tattoos blazing neon-blue—

Then *collapsed* it into a spike of superheated steam and launched it downward.

Kaal didn't dodge.

He **redirected** gravity beneath him, slamming his own body downward with double-force—so fast the spike missed entirely.

And then—

He was below Kraise.

Mid-air.

A palm raised.

Collapse Sphere.

The entire arena dropped into a **black sphere of condensed weight** the size of a table.

Kraise was inside.

It hit.

No explosion.

No fire.

Just **crushing stillness**.

Like the world blinked.

Then the black faded.

And Kraise was on one knee, gasping, **blood dripping from his ears**.

Elsa, awed:

“Oh... oh that was *clean*. That wasn't a hit. That was a *reset button* on Kraise's bones.”

Ignis, serious now:

“That wasn't a counter. That was a punishment.”

Raktabīja, low:

“And yet the boy floats. Useless.”

Maledictus stood, brushing scorched bone ash off his armor.

“Let's stop playing.”

He sliced his palm open again, letting **Null Blood** flow down his fingers.

Not to attack.

To **draw**.

With his own blood, he carved six **hex rings** around Kaal—

Each one crackling, draining, suppressing flow.

Kaal looked up. Still silent.

“You're not like your teammates,” Maledictus said.

“You think this is a math problem.”

“It isn't.”

He closed his eyes.

And the hexes ignited.

Each ring peeled back a layer of **Kaal's pressure control**—like snapping strings from a violin, slowly detuning the world.

Back in the water sphere—

Nothing.

No flicker.

No breath.

No life.

Yugetsu turned away.

Couldn't look.

Swayam didn't move.

Just murmured, "Please don't die."

Aviral, from Team Nyss chamber:

"Kaal's going to lose momentum."

Gaurav, near a whisper:

"He's fighting alone."

And in the crowd, the nobles cheered louder.

The monkey had drowned.

Only Kaal remained.

The arena roared. Not with excitement.

But bloodlust.

The crowd had stopped laughing. Now they were leaning forward.

Because **Kaal**, unshaken till now, was starting to **bleed time**.

And **Maledictus** and **Kraise**?

They'd stopped holding back.

The **first strike** wasn't heard—it was felt.

A ripple of air pressure collapsed outward as **Kraise** disappeared mid-step, riding a current of compressed steam and lightning. He launched **downward**, fist-first, a spiral of water-plasma spinning like a drill around his arm.

Flashboil Surge: maximum output.

At the same time—

Maledictus sliced across both wrists and **slammed his palms into the floor**, releasing a sudden field of **null-fire glyphs** that spidered outward—an anti-energy minefield set to destabilize Prāṇ flow.

Kaal reacted too late.

He'd already shifted gravity under Kraise's feet—
but Kraise wasn't touching the ground.

His assault came from the sky.

Boom.

The strike hit Kaal's shoulder like thunder erupting under skin. Steam snapped sideways, and
Kaal buckled—his first full stumble in the match.

The crowd *howled*.

Elsa's voice cracked from glee:

"There! Right there! They broke formation! He *flinched!*"

Ignis hissed, coiling tighter:

"Two blades of chaos, perfectly synced."

Raktabija, colder:

"One blade resists. The others adapt."

Before Kaal could stabilize—

Maledictus moved.

Like smoke across broken light.

He emerged from the glyphs beneath Kaal's blindside and **slammed both hands into his spine**.

And whispered:

"Remember failure."

Curse Echoes. Direct insertion.

The hex seal bloomed across Kaal's entire back—hundreds of fractal regret patterns, crawling up
his vertebrae like guilt made flesh.

Kaal froze for a fraction.

Not pain.

Something else.

Doubt.

From above, **Kraise launched again.**

He summoned three Tide-Wrath orbs, this time with divergent elemental coding:

- One pure lightning.
- One mist-blind.
- One super-charged freezing burst.

He flung them not randomly—**but around Kaal’s body**, corralling his movement like a trap meant for a beast.

Kaal reacted—just in time.

He spun midair, gravity-walking across invisible anchors, and raised one palm.

Collapse Sphere.

The freezing orb blinked out.

The others missed by inches.

But his shoulder—already cracked—**dropped.**

He landed on one knee.

Maledictus adjusted the null-rings around his fingers.

“Let’s take the legs this time.”

Kraise grinned. “Or just snap the air around his neck.”

Together—**they lunged.**

The next ten seconds were chaos.

Steam and lightning **blinded the air.**

Null-fire glyphs cracked the floor like skeletal vines.

Kaal—**for the first time in the match**—didn’t counter.

He **absorbed.**

Let one strike **hit.**

Let another **stagger.**

Every block cost energy.

Every breath slowed.

But his eyes...

Never blinked.

Elsa whispered:

“He’s choosing not to fight back.”

Ignis snarled:

“Why? Why hold back now?”

Raktabija murmured:

“Perhaps the Steel Pulse... is waiting for something.”

Kraise landed a kick to Kaal’s ribs.

Maledictus drove a blade of null-energy into his side.

Kaal grunted. Once.

Then stood up.

Straight.

His eyes dimmed—not from pain.

From **judgment.**

He looked at both of them—

And simply said:

“You’re wasting time.”

But Kraise wasn’t mocking now.

And Maledictus wasn’t smiling.

They were sweating. Breathing heavier.

Their attacks—**synchronized**, vicious—still couldn’t bring him down.

Above them...

Rachit still floated.

Unmoving.

Eyes closed.

Forgotten.

Gaurav turned away from the projection.

Voice low.

“He's gone.”

Aviral didn't respond.

Just stared.

Swayam, in the Krotha chamber—eyes locked on the screen—muttered without blinking:

“Not yet.”

The Arena

Kaal's feet shifted over broken stone.

Blood ran from his side.

Down one leg.

His bronze skin glistened with sweat and faint cracks.

He was done playing.

No dramatic surge. No declaration.

Just momentum.

His next step left a crater.

Maledictus raised both hands—one of them **shaking**.

Null-glyphs spun like dying planets around him.

“Kraise,” he muttered.

“Now.”

Kraise understood instantly.

His arms opened wide.

The entire arena darkened as **steam began to swirl into a central storm**—

Lightning cracked overhead, dragged downward into the **heart of a superheated water sphere**—ten meters wide, pulsing, frothing, vibrating with unspeakable pressure.

It floated midair like a false sun.

Raktabīja, grim:

“That’s no spell. That’s a war crime.”

Elsa, flushed:

“If it lands, it *boils the soul* out of him.”

Ignis, quietly serious:

“He won’t dodge it. He *never* dodges.”

The sphere detonated downward.

A roar that swallowed the crowd.

The impact **vaporized a hundred feet of arena tiles**.

Mist exploded outward—screaming, scalding vapor that hit the crowd like an oven door swinging open. Lightning writhed within it like furious veins of a slain god.

Kaal was **gone in white**.

Then—

Gravity collapsed.

A pulse from within the mist.

And the boiling sphere—

Split.

Midair.

Into dozens of **blasted water arcs**, flung upward.

Steam.

Mist.

Obscured vision.

Everywhere.

But within the cloud—

Kraise smirked.

“Got you.”

The mist froze.

All of it.

Every scattered drop.

Every floating splash.

Transformed midair into glacial daggers, jagged and raw—each one laced with twitching threads of **blue lightning**.

Hundreds.

Each pointed at one place.

Each aimed at Kaal.

Then—**launched**.

The impact came fast.

Too fast.

Kaal crossed his arms, redirected gravity into a **repulsion dome**, but several spikes made it through.

One pierced his side. Another embedded deep in his thigh. A dozen glanced off boneplate and burned through skin.

He fell **to one knee**.

From above__

Maledictus descended from the smoke like an executioner.

No wings. No glyph-boost. Just control.

Gravity surrendered to him as he dropped straight at Kaal’s skull, arms locked, one fist glowing with layers upon layers of etched curses—hexes burned into flesh, veins streaking with **null-fire**

like molten ink. His fingers twitched mid-fall, forming seals that pulsed faster with every heartbeat.

He didn't scream.

He **fell** like a verdict.

And **struck** like an ending.

But Kaal...

Caught him.

One hand.

Clamped **midair** around Maledictus's throat.

Fingers sank in against fire-hardened skin. The force caused a ripple in the air around them, gravity folding slightly inward.

Maledictus grinned anyway—blood blooming between his teeth.

“Good.”

Then—he drove his hex-wrapped fist straight into Kaal's chest.

Impact.

A dull, monstrous *crack* echoed across the arena floor.

Kaal staggered.

Just a step.

But it was **the first**.

Blood slid from his mouth.

A thin thread ran from his ear.

He dropped Maledictus with a heavy *thud*.

But he **didn't fall**.

Didn't flinch.

Didn't wipe the blood.

He stood.

Unbending.

Eyes unreadable.

A storm unspoken.

The **mist** thickened.

Too fast.

Too quiet.

A sudden, swallowing stillness.

Not silence.

Something worse.

That unbearable hush **right before something dies.**

From the edge of vision, **Kraise charged.**

Steam flaring behind him.

Lightning arcing along his arms.

His voice sliced through the fog like a blade—

“We finish this—NOW!”

Feet pounding stone, lightning seeping from his heels, tattoos flashing as his blood surged with overcharged power. He raced through the fog like a bullet—

Until something behind him whispered.

A hiss.

Of steel.

Of air splitting.

Too fast.

Too clean.

Too late.

From behind Kraise—

A black rod.

Metal.

Spiked at one end.

Slick with silence.

Burst through his skull.

From behind.

The spike drove clean through bone, brain, forehead—flashing out the front like a lightning rod through wet clay.

His eyes—wide one second—dimmed mid-sprint.

The body kept running.

Two more steps.

Then collapsed forward.

The rod didn't stop.

It continued.

Still fast. Still humming with deadly vibration.

And pierced through Maledictus next.

The second impact cracked bone.

Blood **fountained** from the captain's mouth before thought could register.

Now both demons—

Two leaders.

Two monsters.

Pinned together through the skulls on one rod.

Like trophies on a spine.

Kaal blinked.

Only once.

The rod's spike had stopped **an inch** from his right eye.

It still **vibrated**.

Still **hot**.

From the mist—

A movement.

Not a step.

Not an approach.

A presence.

Black energy that had formed earlier from Maledictus punch curled in ribbons behind it. Dark mist parted—twisting like smoke around a silent storm.

A figure emerged.

Mid-air.

Rotating.

Twisting at the waist with zero wasted effort.

Then—a **kick**.

Fast.

Precise.

The blunt end of the rod—still lodged through the skulls—was **kicked**.

Hard.

The full force sent the whole impaled weapon **rocketing forward** like a railgun.

Kaal moved.

Barely.

Just a subtle twist of the neck.

Still—the spike **grazed his cheek**, slicing a line across bronze skin.

Then—

The rod slammed into the arena barrier.

The glyph barrier shrieked—rippled with impact.

The crowd behind it gasped—

One noble, holding a bucket of steamed eyes, dropped it mid-chew.

Another pissed himself.

No one spoke.

Not for a heartbeat.

In the commentator's tower—

Raktabīja, voice hushed, reverent:

“He aimed around Kaal.”

Elsa, breathless:

“That... wasn't rage.”

“That was *math*.”

Ignis, coldly whispering:

“...Rachit.”

The mist cleared just enough.

And there he stood.

Rachit.

Blue tank top torn at one shoulder.

Grey harem pants soaked.

Skin paler. Bruised.

Eyes—

Glowing red-brown under the mist.

Expression unreadable.

His arms loose.

Rod-less now.

But his silhouette—

Coiled.

Like a blade returned to sheath only by choice.

Kaal turned.

Just slightly.

Looked at the corpses.

At the rod.

Then back to the boy stepping through steam.

For a moment—

He thought the rod was meant for him.

For a split heartbeat, Kaal's stance **tensed**.

A memory flickered in his chest—a flare of caution.

But Rachit didn't step toward him.

He **walked past** him.

Not fast.

Not slow.

Not staggering.

Just...

Forward.

Across the resting zone—

Scar rose.

Clapped once.

Twice.

Slow.

Deliberate.

"I knew you wouldn't die."

"But I wished you would."

He grinned—forked tongue flicking out.

"I've been brainstorming all kinds of things to do with your bones."

"Your spine could make a wonderful quill. Or a flute."

Rachit said **nothing**.

Didn't glance at him.

He simply raised his **left palm**.

The rod—

Still embedded in the glyph barrier—

Snapped back like it had been **called by war**.

A sonic crack split the air.

It **slammed into his hand**.

He caught it like he'd never dropped it.

Slid it back onto his back, opposite the twin rod already strapped in.

Then—

Sat.

Arms folded.

Eyes forward.

Breathing soft.

Stillness complete.

No celebration.

No grin.

Not even relief.

Just—

Silence.

Krotha Room

Yugetsu's hands had been trembling for nearly a minute now.

He hadn't noticed.

His eyes were glued to the projection screen, lips parted, breath caught somewhere between panic and disbelief.

Then—**the rod struck**.

The kills were immediate. Instant. Final.

And from the mist—**Rachit stepped out**.

Alive.

Moving.

Breathing.

Yugetsu gasped so loud it startled the medical attendant crouched behind him.

“He’s... he’s alive—! Did you—did you see—?!”

His voice cracked like something inside had been wound too tight.

He nearly dropped Anshika’s sleeping body off his shoulder from the jolt, and instinctively tightened his grip, still watching, eyes damp now.

The screen flickered with smoke and blood.

Rachit just walked.

Calm. Whole. Back to the bench.

Swayam didn’t blink.

Didn’t shift.

But a **sound** came from him.

Small.

So quiet even Yugetsu almost missed it.

A half-sigh.

A breath that had been caught for hours... finally released.

“I told you,” he said quietly.

His tone was still neutral.

But his fingers curled into a slow fist behind his back.

The frost coating his Krotha disguise gauntlets had begun to **crack**—not from combat, but from the internal heat of emotion **barely restrained**.

“Not yet,” he said again.

This time softer.

Almost reverent.

Team Nyss Tent

Aviral stared.

He hadn’t blinked in half a minute.

His fire glyph staff **slipped from his fingers**, hit the ground with a flat *thunk*, and rolled into a corner.

He didn't move to pick it up.

His shoulders had stiffened like a bowstring about to snap.

But it was Gaurav who moved first.

He stood fast—so fast he kicked over the stool behind him.

He had stopped breathing entirely.

On the screen—

Rachit retrieved his rod.

Strapped it to his back.

Sat.

Alive.

Unbothered.

Whole.

Gaurav exhaled.

It wasn't steady.

It came out like a **half-sob**, half-laugh, something twisted and fragile and beautiful.

He didn't speak right away.

Just pressed both hands to his face.

Then—

"That son of a bitch," he whispered.

"He really pulled it off."

His voice cracked on the last word.

Aviral, quietly, stepped forward and placed a hand on his shoulder.

"He's okay," Aviral said, like he was reminding **himself**.

"Rachit's okay."

Gaurav didn't look away from the screen.

"I thought he was dead."

His hands dropped slowly.

His eyes were red now—but he was **smiling**.

“Just like always.”

In the Crowd

The demons didn’t react all at once.

At first—

There was **confusion**.

The two elite demons had just been killed. In one motion.

Then came **shock**.

A human. A **human**—one they laughed at, pitied, forgot—had just twisted the entire narrative into a chokehold.

And then—finally—**noise**.

A flood of roars.

Some from rage. Some from disbelief.

But most... from **excitement**.

A noble woman in the front row fanned herself, pupils wide.

“He’s not human,” she muttered, voice shaking.

“Not anymore.”

A glutton demon behind her punched the air with all four fists.

“That rod move! That—*that* was art!”

An elderly blue-skinned demon in full bone-plated regalia leaned forward and whispered to no one in particular:

“That precision... I haven’t seen it since the Ashen War.”

Announcers' Tower

Elsa, chest heaving, eyes glowing:

“I take my words back.”

“That was beautiful.”

“Three seconds. Two heads. No hesitation.”

“And he walked away like it was his morning walk.”

Ignis, still form wrapped in crackling dragonlight, stared quietly.

Then:

“All of the act from start to finish, it all happened..”

“In the palm of that human’s hand.”

Raktabīja, blood-flecked tongue flicking over his fangs:

“A death wish turned into a **death sentence**.”

“And the crowd just fell in love with a corpse.”

Lilith’s Viewing Balcony

Lilith had stood when Rachit fell unconscious.

Had watched the orb.

Had whispered, quietly, to her own glass:

“Please don’t let it waste.”

And when his breath stopped, her pupils had narrowed.

Her fingers clenched her wine goblet until it cracked.

But now—

As he stepped from the mist—

As two skulls dropped like discarded fruit—

As he called the rod back without a word—

Lilith’s smile returned.

But it wasn’t the same.

Not amusement.

Not curiosity.

Hunger.

And something **soft** behind it.

She licked a smear of blood from the corner of her lip—someone else’s blood, not his—and whispered:

“There you are...”

She leaned closer to the projection.

“My pretty little monster.”

“You really didn’t drown.”

The glyph matrix shifted.

Sparks trailed across the floating hologlyphs as numbers updated in real time.

+100 Crowd Bonus: **Legendary Kill Sequence**

+50 Audience Impact (Fear Spike)

+35 Kaal Team Sync Bonus

Trial 1 score 170

Total score = 355

In Resting Area

Kaal sat.

Still.

The scratch across his cheek already drying.

He hadn’t spoken a word since the corpses hit the floor.

Now he watched Rachit sit.

Just ten feet away.

Neither looked at the other.

But something—silent, unspoken—had passed between them in that near-miss.

Kaal knew it.

He’d felt it.

That rod could’ve struck him .

It didn’t.

Because **Rachit had made a choice.**

And the margin between friend and foe was now...
exactly one inch wide.

Scar finally laughed again, more sincerely this time.
He paced in a circle, tongue flicking the air.
“You absolute freak,” he muttered.
“Gods, I *like* you.”
“I wish you *had* died though.”
He flashed a grin at Rachit’s back.
“I was already designing your ribcage furniture.”
Rachit gave no reply.
His eyes were forward.
Still.
Glowing faintly.
He raised one hand—
Snapped his fingers.
The two rods on his back **clicked together** for a brief second, magnetized—
Then separated again, locked tight.
Ready.
Watching.

Back in Team Nyss Tent

Gaurav finally sat again—barely.
His hands were still shaking.
“I’m gonna punch him,” he muttered.
“When we meet again—I’m gonna punch that idiot so hard—”
Aviral gave a small laugh.
The first laugh in hours.

“You’ll have to reach him first.”

Gaurav huffed.

“I’ll climb gravity if I have to.”

Yugetsu, in Team Krotha’s dome, wiped his eyes quickly and turned to Swayam.

“What now?”

Swayam’s mask cracked with frost.

He looked down at Anshika’s sleeping face. Then back at the screen.

“Now?”

“Now we survive long enough to stand beside him again.”

And Rachit...

He just sat.

Still.

Breathing.

The blood mist still hadn’t cleared.

The scoreboard numbers hadn’t faded.

The audience hadn’t stopped talking about his trickery.

But he?

He didn’t move.

Because in that moment—

He wished his friends saw him and understood that we still can win.

There was no warning.

No glyph flash. No audible hum.

One moment Team Kaal was sitting—still soaked in blood and silence. The next—

Teleported.

A cold shift. A blink of space tearing.

They landed softly inside a new chamber.

Wide, circular, with floating beds set in rings around a transparent central holo-glyph pillar. Light from the pillar spun upward like liquid glass, displaying battle scores, audience reactions, and slowly rotating footage from the match just concluded.

Healers entered without speaking—high-ranking, gold-banded, demonic specialists who moved with silent urgency. None dared address Kaal. None even looked at Scar. A few paused when they noticed Rachit.

But none said a word.

Scar leaned back on the bed with all four arms stretched behind his head and sighed like a vacationing predator.

“You see that comeback?” he muttered to a random healer walking past. “That’s why I like the boy. That’s a corpse with style.”

Rachit, sitting alone near the wall, legs folded, eyes half-lidded, stared at the floating match feed as it looped through the final strike again.

Kaal was watching too.

He hadn't said a word since the teleport.

Just sat on the edge of his bed, arms resting on his knees, breathing through his nose like a war animal cooling down.

Commentators' Tower

Elsa’s heels clicked as she spun in place, face flushed, lips parted in a half-smile that hadn’t left since the last match.

“Those rods were delicious and fast,” she purred. “But now—shall we see the fastest blades in whole trial against master of tactics?”

Ignis chuckled, running clawed fingers along the edge of his draconic mic.

“Match 2: Team Abhishaap versus Team Reeva.”

“A fan favorite—versus a team known only for numbers and bad luck.”

Raktabīja, his voice as serrated as always:

“And I hear the storm’s already drunk.”

Arena – Match 2 Begins

Team Reeva stood in the ring—nervous, shoulder-to-shoulder, weapons drawn.

They didn’t look confident.

They looked like **statues awaiting execution**.

Then—

Thunder rolled.

The arena gates hissed apart.

Out stepped three demons—each radiating impossible energy.

Team Abhishaap.

Except—

They were... swaying.

Abhishaap himself strode forward, silver plasma hair trailing behind, body language regal—but every step came with the slightest delay. His eyes were **calm**, but glassy. A small bottle of something electric-blue clinked loosely in his hand before he tossed it into the stands.

Shyvana sauntered behind him, laughing at nothing. Steam rose from her skin. Her walk was exaggerated, hips swinging like a drunken flame dancer.

“Did you feel the floor move just now?” she whispered to no one, then laughed. “Or was that just my personality?”

They collapsed lazily onto the resting bench—Abhishaap with his arms crossed behind his head, eyes half-closed. Shyvana lay sideways, one leg kicked up, humming.

Only one remained standing.

Krurog.

The wolf-beast hybrid towered silently over the rest. Crystal fur shimmered with frost. Blue lines pulsed down his scars like breathing veins of ice.

He did not speak.

Did not sway.

Did not blink.

Only moved when the match glyph lit red.

Match Rule Displayed

□ **Rule: Elimination Round – 1 vs 1 KOs or Kill Only**

□ **Victory: When One Team Is Fully Eliminated**

Raktabija:

“Let’s be honest. This isn’t going to be fair.”

Elsa, purring:

“Oh, I *love* when it’s not fair.”

Ignis, dry:

“Match 2 begins. And... Reeve’s first contestant enters the ring.”

The Reeve fighter looked hesitant—brow furrowed, shoulders too tight.

Across the field, Krurog stepped forward.

No words.

Just a slow, deep exhale that fogged the air for fifteen feet in every direction.

Round 1: Reeve Fighter vs Krurog

They charged.

Tried to, at least.

The Reeve fighter dashed forward—speed glyphs lit on boots—

But then—

A growl.

Not loud.

Not long.

Just **targeted**.

Krurog opened his mouth—and sound ceased.

A cone of freezing pressure blasted outward.

The Reeve fighter stopped moving.

Mid-charge. Frozen solid.

Shards of frost raced up his arms, locking tendons, stiffening joints.

Krurog didn’t wait.

He was gone from the spot and **behind** the fighter before the breath ended.

One claw—

Straight through the back.

Shards of blood and spinal frost exploded from the chest.

Krurog stepped back.

Let the body fall.

Round 2.

Another Reeve fighter.

This one used flame—hoping to counter.

Krurog opened with a **Frozen Wall Slam**—summoning an icy ridge behind the target.

Then dashed forward.

Claws glowing.

He uppercut the demon **into** the wall.

Skull shattered.

The wall cracked. Then collapsed—taking the corpse with it.

Round 3.

Reeve's captain now.

Snarling. Desperate. Ready to die with dignity.

He cast five glyphs at once, forming a barrage of shadow javelins.

“You’re alone!” he screamed.

“The rest of your team’s too drunk to stand!”

Krurog’s head tilted.

Only once.

Then:

“That’s all I need.”

He opened both arms—

Let the javelins hit.

Two stuck into his chest.

Another pierced his shoulder.

He didn't blink.

Then—

Roared.

The arena shook.

The captain fell to one knee, bleeding from his nose instantly. Internal Prāṇ scrambled.

Krurog charged.

Fist to gut.

Claw to chest.

Then a breath—

Ice mist point-blank to face.

The captain froze over mid-scream.

Krurog stepped back.

Lifted one massive leg.

And **stomped.**

The body cracked.

Then shattered.

Team Reeve: Eliminated.

Elsa, delighted:

“I love efficiency.”

Ignis:

“Three enemies. One froststorm. No heat wasted.”

Raktabija:

“That wasn't a fight. That was an **audit.**”

Crowd Reaction

The arena erupted.

Some cheered.

Some stared.

One noble whispered:

“Why didn’t Abhishaap need to move?”

Another answered:

“Because his beast could do the job alone.”

Up in the nobility seats—

A deep-red demon prince sipped his drink, eyes narrowed.

“Krurog didn’t even howl fully.”

A merchant noble scribbled madly on a scroll, lips moving:

“Must study breath technique. Must enhance outer coat resonance—”

In Team Kaal’s Recovery Chamber

Scar laughed.

Clapped slowly.

“Oh, *I like that one*,” he muttered. “We’d get along.”

Rachit watched the match replays again.

But his eyes were sharper now.

Like he’d recognized **something** in Krurog’s rhythm.

Kaal?

Still silent.

But the side of his hand tapped the bed edge twice.

Once.

Twice.

Tactical thought.

Respect.

Team Nyss

Aviral raised a brow.

“That thing... that wolf?”

“That’s who we’ll face if they make semifinals.”

Gaurav leaned forward.

“Good.”

“We’ll need someone worthy when we reach it but for now it’s time for some action.”

Krurog walked.

That was all.

He didn’t acknowledge the crowd. Didn’t look toward the shattered glyphs or pulverized bones or the frost that hadn’t yet faded from the walls.

He just walked.

The moment his clawed feet passed the match boundary line, the **ring pulsed blue**, and all that remained of Team Reeve—scorch-black armor shards, frozen blood fans, fractured glyphs—vanished in a crystalline sweep.

The arena cleaned itself like a kid brushing crumbs from a plate.

Above the ring, new **holo-glyphs shimmered to life**.

MATCH RESULTS – TRIAL 2: MATCH 2

Team Abhishaap – Victory

Blood Points Earned:

- Base Win: +30
- Crowd Approval (Avg.): +90
- Noble Betting Spike: +50
- Kill Style Bonus: +30

Total Trial 2 Points: 200

+ Previous Trial 1 Score: 200

= Combined Blood Total: 400

Elsa gasped like someone had just kissed her spine.

“Four. Hundred. Points,” she murmured, eyes wide.

“We’re not halfway through Round One, and we already have a titan.”

Ignis, voice low and cool:

“Team Abhishaap has broken the silence with frost and laughter.”

Raktabija chuckled, lips curling in blood-wet satisfaction:

“And they didn’t even use their storm.”

Teleport Flash

White-gold light consumed them. When it faded, they were seated in a crescent of obsidian beds wrapped around a hovering crescent glyph.

Shyvana flopped onto her bench like a cat in the sun.

She stretched once—her red skin steaming softly—and groaned in bliss.

“I’m telling you... that drink?”

She rolled onto her side.

“It’s like flying inside a volcano. Gods, it’s still humming in my skull.”

Abhishaap, still standing, finished the last swig of his vial and looked at it quietly.

The liquid inside had tasted like lightning melted in glass.

And yet... it lingered.

“This isn’t the drink,” he murmured.

He flicked the bottle away.

“It’s the one from four days ago. Its hum hasn’t lessened. Not once.”

His fingers flexed once, then folded behind his back.

“That shouldn’t be possible.”

Only Krurog remained still, fur glistening with melted frost, eyes closed in meditation. The frostwolf said nothing. But he felt it too.

Something was wrong.

The roar hadn't yet faded from the last match when the arena lighting began to pulse again—this time softer, more ominous. From the walls, crimson glyphs flared to life, spiraling upward into the air like runes of warning.

The crowd stirred.

And then the announcers returned.

 **Ignis**, tail flicking like a cat about to pounce:

“Ooohh, and the blood hasn't even dried, but the next gates are already humming. Aren't we spoiled today?”

 **Elsa**, voice silken, fingers twirling her braid:

“Mmm... match two delivered slaughter. Match three, though?” She leaned closer to her mic-crystal. “This one might give us... emotion.”

 **Raktabīja**, low and dry, like teeth grinding glass:

“Emotion tastes best when served with dismemberment.”

Across the arena, massive stone gates creaked open.

On the **east end**, a glowing symbol appeared above the portal:

 **TEAM NYSS** 

On the **west**, another flared into being:

  **TEAM MAVIK**  

The tension snapped tight like a drawn bowstring.

Entry – East Gate

From behind a soft red haze, **Team Nyss** stepped into the arena.

Gaurav led the way, shirtless beneath his battle wrap, skin already shimmering faintly with threads of elemental power. His fists were clenched—not in anger, but purpose. Over one shoulder, he carried Nyss gently, wrapped in spell-cloth and bound with stabilizer glyphs. Her face, pale and serene, didn't stir. But a faint hum of mantra resonated from her chest crystal.

Beside him, **Aviral** walked slower, fire staff cradled with reverence. Its ember-tipped head flared slightly as he scanned the terrain.

They paused just past the threshold.

Healers from Kaali Bhoomi waited there.

One stepped forward.

Aviral nodded once and handed off Nyss.

“Don’t drop her,” Gaurav muttered to the healer—low, but not without threat.

“She might not wake. But if she does—” he looked down at Nyss’s still face, “—she deserves to open her eyes, not die with them closed.”

The healer nodded and vanished into the mist-staffed healer’s bay.

Entry – West Gate

On the opposite side—

Ash fell like snow.

The **Mavik Gate** didn’t creak. It groaned, like something ancient being unburied.

Out stepped **Arox** first—giant, shirtless, his scarred muscles like etched obsidian beneath the arena sun. He dragged the jawbone cleaver—**Blazetusk**—behind him. It left a groove in the stone.

Syra followed in silence, her daggers already out. Her body barely made a sound. Her wrap moved like air. Her eyes, rimmed with tired defiance, scanned Gaurav once. Then Aviral.

Then she was gone. Invisible again.

Last came **Nikhan**—his serpent-trident clicking softly as he glided forward on a coil of emerald scale. His mouth dripped ink-venom. His face was unreadable.

All three stopped just at the boundary.

None of them smiled.

 **Elsa**, licking her lips:

“Team Nyss enters as underdogs. Comatose member, low scores, two survivors and barely that.”

 **Ignis**, purring:

“But that Aviral... his glyph game is tight. And Gaurav? Five elements and a jawline built to throw punches through temples.”

 **Raktabīja**, rasping:

“Mavik, though. Not here for fame. They’re here to be remembered.”

Arena Mood

The crowd quieted—not out of boredom, but intrigue. The previous match had been loud, brutal, and bloody.

This one?

This one felt different.

Like a prayer before a storm.

The nobles shifted forward in their seats. The betting booths chimed with wagers. None favoured Nyss.

Match Rules Projection (Holo-Glyph Display)

TRIAL 2: ROUND 1 MATCH 3

Matchup: Team Nyss vs Team Mavik

Format: Traditional Elimination – 1 vs 1

Victory Condition: Eliminate all three opposing fighters by knockout or confirmed kill

Rotation Order: Chosen by team captains at time of match initiation

Mid-Match Rule Change: Enabled by Crowd Poll

Terrain Zone: Rift Stone & Ember Wards – limited earth manipulation, high mana conductivity

Pre-Fight Banter

As Gaurav rolled his shoulders, he turned to Aviral. “You take the lead.”

Aviral blinked. “You sure?”

“You think better when you’ve got the first blood.”

Aviral exhaled and traced his first glyph in the dirt with his finger—just enough to mark the field.

Across from them, **Arox** dragged Blazetusk up and over his shoulder and grunted.

“Do you always let your scholars bleed first?”

Gaurav laughed—sharp and bitter. “Nah. He just lights the match.”

Syra shimmered into partial view, one dagger resting on her finger like a coin.

“You think fire will save you here?” she said softly. “We were raised in ash.”

Aviral replied without looking up, glyph still forming under his hand.

“Then you’ll know exactly how long it takes to burn.”

Nikhan’s head tilted.

His tongue curled around a sound that shimmered in the air like a wet breath.

Aviral stiffened. That **voice venom**... it wasn’t words. It was pressure.

“Don’t talk to him too long,” Gaurav muttered. “He sings and you stop breathing.”

“Noted,” Aviral said, finishing the first seal.

Elsa, voice trembling with delight:

“Ooooh, and the foreplay is exquisite.”

Ignis, teeth bared:

“Mavik’s here for witness. Nyss? For survival.

Raktabija, drumming claws:

“One fights to survive. The other? To never be forgotten.”

Above the arena, the glyphs flared once more—marking the match active.

The ground shuddered slightly, mana veins igniting beneath the cracked black stone.

One by one, team members were called forward to the starting ring—

First: **Aviral vs Syra**

As they stepped into their positions, the crowd held its breath.

And above them—

The world watched.

Ready for the next prayer to bleed.

The arena cracked with tension.

Aviral stepped into the ring, fire glyph staff in hand. The carved sigils along its blacksteel length pulsed with faint warmth—like they too were holding their breath.

Across from him, Syra walked like mist.

She didn’t step—she appeared.

One blink, and she was already standing inside her starting ring.

Her markeel fangglass daggers shimmered in the arena lights, blades silent, her body draped in a glyph-stitched veil of black velvet. From a distance, she looked like shadow made flesh, breathless and cold.

Above them, the audience shifted forward as if pulled by gravity.

Then came the glyph flare—

MATCH START blazed across the sky.

The cracked obsidian battlefield glowed with under-veins of mana—blue and gold spirals lighting beneath the combatants' feet. From the sides, fiery embers hissed as wind glyphs activated around the edges—creating a storm-silencing ring, so the only sound inside would be the fight.

Even breathing felt sacrilegious.

From the eastern viewing place, Gaurav leaned forward, fingers white-knuckling the railing.

“He’s ready,” he muttered to himself.

Syra moved first.

She didn’t charge.

She vanished.

A shimmer flickered in the air—no sound, no warning—and she reappeared two meters from Aviral’s left.

He had already turned.

Two glyphs flared on his staff—one at the base, one at the tip.

“**Anchor logic. Predictive firepath.**” His voice was calm.

Syra struck—fangglass daggers curved toward his ribs.

Aviral spun his staff.

The glyph at the base exploded in a plume of redirected heat, not at her, but at the floor. The burst launched him backward—just barely dodging the slash.

Snap.

Syra vanished again.

Appeared behind.

He rolled left.

A dagger nicked his arm—thin, shallow. Still, blood.

“She’s toying,” Gaurav muttered. “That’s not a kill stroke.”

Elsa’s voice echoed through the arena, delighted.

“Ooooh, foreplay again. Syra’s *tracing* him. Mapping his boundaries. Oh, it’s getting warm in here.”

Raktabija’s claws tapped steadily, his grin wide.

“She moves like a death promised quietly. Can fire bargain with fog?”

Ignis chuckled.

“If it can’t see it coming—it burns too late.”

Aviral dropped a seal scroll mid-roll—his fingers moving in a twitch-perfect pattern.

The glyph unfurled, glowing red-orange: a timed **Fire Cage**.

A swirl of vertical lines erupted around him in a five-meter radius—like molten iron bars climbing from the earth. It was a temporary dome of flame. A wall of negotiation.

Syra shimmered in mid-vanish just outside.

She flickered back into view on top of the glyph cage—standing on the vertical bars like a dancer.

“Smart,” she said softly. “But flames whisper too slow.”

She dove.

Vertical.

Straight through.

Aviral’s eyes widened—

“Impossible—!”

She had pierced the delay of the glyph seal—twisting her body through the activation window.

Clash!

Her blades met the reinforced staff in a clang that shot embers skyward.

He kicked out—caught her mid-stomach.

She grunted—flipped backward midair—and landed like silk.

Syra now circled the fire cage—eyes flicking for rhythm.

Aviral rotated the staff once—three glyphs active.

He slammed it into the ground.

“Tri-glyph burn: Chain wall—snap twist—overload!”

The flames coiled in. Then *detonated* outward in a spiral of cracking, roaring heat.

The crowd howled in appreciation.

From above, mist formed—

But no Syra.

Aviral narrowed his eyes.

“Where—?”

A blur behind.

The dagger pressed at his neck.

Only a hair from blood.

She whispered near his ear.

“You burned too fast.”

In Team Nyss’s room, Nyss remained still—unmoving. But her crystal chest core glowed faintly, as if reacting to the pressure. Her mantra loops flickered slightly.

Gaurav’s hands were clenched.

“He can still flip this.”

Aviral, inside the ring, was panting.

One glyph scroll left.

Blood ran from a nick under his collarbone.

Syra’s breathing was smooth. Unbroken. She didn’t even sweat.

From the Krotha dome, Yugetsu whispered:

“She’s faster than he’s used to.”

Swayam nodded once.

“But not faster than he can think. He’s playing the long game.”

Syra disappeared again.

This time—longer.

Aviral stood motionless, eyes sweeping.

His staff tip began to glow white-hot.

One whisper escaped his lips.

“I’m done playing defense.”

The ground was cracked now—lines etched by ash and embers where Aviral’s glyph staff had swept. Opposite him, Syra barely left footprints.

She didn't need to.

She was already moving again.

Flash—gone.

A blur of black velvet shimmered out of sight as her body twisted mid-sprint, daggers crossing in an X-slash. Aviral twisted his shoulder—

CLANG—SKRAKT!

Her blades caught fire briefly—striking a glyph-lined air barrier Aviral had pre-laid two moves ago.

He didn't wait.

“Anchor Set,” he muttered—

His foot slammed down. A glyph beneath his heel sparked alive, detonating a vertical column of flame just as Syra reappeared on the far left, zigzagging through his trap line like fog through spears.

“She’s phasing again!” Ignis snapped from the tower, eyes narrowed. “That’s not pure invisibility. That’s—”

“Veil slicing,” Elsa purred. “She’s blinking through perception lines. He sees her—but only a moment *after* she’s moved.”

“And that,” Raktabīja grinned, “is how ghosts gut thinkers.”

In the Team Krotha chamber, Yugetsu leaned forward.

Swayam—still masked as Krotha—nodded slowly. “It’s Jeev Shakti,”]

Yugetsu blinked. “So how does she dodge fire?”

“She doesn’t.” Swayam pointed toward the arena. “She moves where the fire was *never meant* to go.”

Aviral's scroll fluttered on his belt, glyphs activating in layers.

Burn Count: 4 Seals Left

He muttered to himself, calm despite the pressure: “Think ahead, not fast.”

Then louder, mocking: “You know you’re not the only one who studied prayer-scripts, right?”

Syra’s reply came only in motion.

She vanished mid-run—no shimmer this time.

Just *gone*.

Aviral's brows twitched. He dropped low, dragging his palm across the stone, eyes calculating.

“Come on...”

His fingers brushed a second glyph—one he'd written *under* the arena floor in the prep zone.

It activated with a hiss—

BOOM!

The arena floor split in a diagonal wedge behind him.

Too late.

ZZIP—THUMP!

Blood flew.

His arm sliced—not deep, but fast enough to draw steam from the cut.

Syra stood behind him—no sound, no breath. Her blade dripped.

“I don’t miss the same spot twice,” she whispered.

Aviral spun back, staff flaring. “Then don’t aim for the same species.”

In the noble gallery—

Renzo whistled low. “She’s faster than I logged... Still—” he reached into his coin pouch, “Aviral hasn’t played his hand.”

He flipped a gold coin—then five—then the full pouch. “100,000 on Nyss.”

A demon beside him blinked. “You’re betting on the *human*?”

Renzo grinned, slick and dangerous. “Not my money, not my problem.”

In the Arena

Syra closed again—low to the ground, daggers slicing smoke. Aviral angled his staff and *pivoted*.

Not blocked.

Redirected.

Syra blinked.

Her blade passed exactly where his neck *would have been*. Instead, her own leg hit a glyph-pulse zone—

SNAP! A shock of flame ricocheted up her spine, staggering her.

Aviral turned.

“All that speed. No insulation?”

Syra didn’t answer.

She *vanished* again.

On the far wall—

Team Kaal sat silent.

Scar let out a slow whistle. “Heh. I like her. Cuts like she’s folding meat for breakfast.”

Kaal’s eyes stayed locked on the arena.

Rachit?

Didn’t blink.

Back in the ring—

Aviral’s breath was heavy now.

The burn in his wrist told him he’d overcast that last pulse. His spine itched—heat-crawling from inside out.

He pressed two fingers to a fresh glyph on his side rib.

“Anchor Logic: Rear-Flick Pattern.”

The glyph sank into his armor like a command string.

But Syra—

She reappeared in midair above him.

Dagger in reverse grip.

Eyes unreadable.

Time slowed.

Syra landed—

CLANG!

Not blade to flesh.

Blade to flame.

A wall of fire curved upward like a lotus unfolding—Aviral’s hidden trap had activated behind him, arcing over like a shell.

Syra was inside.

Locked in.

With him.

“Let’s *negotiate* now,” Aviral muttered—

The floor under them burned red.

Then—glyphs began *crawling* up the wall like fireflies writing scripture.

A glyph-seal chamber.

His domain.

“Your speed dies here.”

Syra stood still for the first time.

Then said, quiet:

“Good.”

In the crowd—

A noblewoman clutched her glass, heart hammering.

“What’s he doing?”

“Making a cage,” whispered an old man near her. “Of fire. And fate.”

Inside the glyph-seal—

Both combatants froze.

Then—

They moved.

Inside the flame chamber, light warped.

Glyphs crawled like molten veins, the curved dome reflecting not just fire—but *intent*. Aviral stood in the center, one palm pressed to his chest, sealing two glyphs into his ribs. Sweat clung to his jawline, blood already slick between his shoulder blades.

Across from him—Syra, smoke curling off her shoulders, knives still drawn. Her chest rose and fell once... then stilled.

No words.

She charged.

Outside the ring, the nobles surged forward in their seats.

Renzo was halfway out of his chair, eyes wild. “No—he shouldn’t have stayed inside with her. She’s *draining him in silence*. She’s baiting rhythm.”

In the Krotha dome, Yugetsu’s hand curled around Anshika’s wrist.

“She’s too fast now,” he whispered.

Swayam’s eyes narrowed. “She’s too fast because he’s trying to *out-think* her. He needs to stop thinking.”

Yugetsu blinked. “Then what?”

“Start trusting.”

In the glyph-seal—

Syra vanished again.

Her veil didn’t shimmer anymore. It *rippled*—as if her very outline was wind-bent glass.

FWUMP.

She reappeared *inside* Aviral’s guard, blades curved in X-form toward his neck.

He didn’t flinch.

He stepped *into* the slash.

Her blades passed behind his ears—missing by inches as his forward momentum threw her off balance.

And then—

BOOM!

One of his earlier floor glyphs ignited from under *her* left heel—flipping Syra back mid-air.

She twisted.

Too late.

His staff slammed into her midsection.

Not elegant.

Brutal.

CRACK—!

The sound echoed like a war drum as Syra was flung into the fire wall, smoke bursting on impact.

She didn't fall.

She rebounded—eyes narrowed, blades reversed again, her breathing now audible.

Aviral didn't speak.

He just pressed the final glyph—

On his wrist.

Burned it into his skin.

“Talk to me, fire,” he whispered. “I'll pay the price.”

The staff *detonated*.

Not an explosion.

A controlled burn—a ring of flame that launched from the base outward, funneled by precisely positioned seals, catching Syra mid-step.

She *sliced* through the ring—

But the **second** glyph layer triggered.

BANG!

Flame whip.

Direct across her waist.

Syra staggered.

Her daggers dropped.

In the Team Mavik side—

Arox's breath hitched.

Nikhan looked up.

“She got careless.”

“No,” Arox said, slow and heavy. “He... *tricked her tempo*. He let her teach him... and then flipped the rhythm.”

Syra’s body hit the arena floor with a soft thud.

Inside the flame dome, Aviral lowered his staff.

Then—

His knees *buckled*.

Across his chest, a deep gash leaked crimson—Syra’s final dagger had landed before the flame hit. It was precise, just below the collarbone to across the ribs.

Not fatal.

But *enough*.

He fell to one knee, pressing his palm to the wound.

“Gaurav... I’m... gonna need that ‘not dying’ speech now,” he muttered.

The audience was frozen—then burst into thunderous, divided noise.

Demons screamed both names.

Wagers were hurled in every direction.

And above the din—

Ignis roared, flames curling around his throat:

“AVIRAL WINS! FIRE HAS SPOKEN!”

Elsa, voice thick with sweat and thrill:

“That was *art*. That was *intelligence*. That was pain given geometry.”

Raktabija:

“Mark my words. This human’s brain burns hotter than most demons’ hearts.”

The dome flickered—glyphs faded.

Healers rushed in.

Gaurav was already standing—halfway to the screen, fists clenched.

“AVIRAL!!”

He punched the air, hard, once—then laughed.

A broken laugh. Relieved. Pained.

“He did it... He *did it!*”

Nyss remained still, but her glyph pulse quickened faintly. Just slightly.

As if her body heard something the mind hadn’t yet grasped.

In Team Krotha Chamber

Yugetsu wiped his eyes. “He won. He really—”

Swayam nodded, eyes fixed. “Yeah he did it.”

Back in the Arena

Aviral let the medics wrap his chest.

One of them whispered, “You’ll need six stitches minimum. You shouldn’t move—”

“I still have a team to guide,” he said, spitting blood.

His eyes scanned the crowd.

Saw Mavik’s chamber.

Syra was being carried out by her brother and Nikhan.

Arox looked up at Aviral once.

Then nodded.

One slow, respectful nod.

Aviral—bleeding, panting—nodded back.

Not as an equal.

But as one who had *earned the right* to be here.

In Team Kaal’s Room

He hadn’t moved for minutes.

But when the glyphs faded, and Aviral stood victorious, Rachit blinked.

His focused eyes relaxed a bit.

His lips moved.

No sound.

But one word:

“...Good.”

As Aviral sat down on the healer bench, breathing in stitched pain, he closed his eyes and smiled just once.

Not pride.

Not ego.

Just the knowledge:

They were still in this.

And the fire still answered him.

The glyph above the ring shimmered.

One word pulsed across the crimson sky in molten letters:

NEXT.

From the healer zone, Aviral stood slowly. His chest still wrapped, blood seeping faintly through the gauze. One hand clenched the railing as he leaned forward.

“Time,” he muttered.

Across from him, Gaurav rolled his shoulders—once. Twice. No nerves. Just ignition.

He didn’t wait for the announcement.

He stepped into the ring.

Bare-chested. Bare-fisted.

The five elements threaded beneath his skin like roots waiting to bloom. Steam danced from his forearms. His boots cracked the embers as he walked.

From the opposite gate—

Nikhan coiled forward.

He didn’t walk. He slithered. A single, fluid ripple of scale and muscle, tail carving lazy S-shapes across the ashstone. His trident was in hand, venom-black and humming low. Ink slid down his chin, caught sunlight, and hissed where it landed.

His eyes never left Gaurav.

And Gaurav?

Smiled. “You gonna sing me to sleep or stab me first?”

Nikhan didn’t answer.

But he *hummed*.

A low, wet vibration rolled across the air like a fevered whisper.

Gaurav’s grin faded instantly.

Aviral hissed under his breath. “Already?”

Mid-Match Rule Change – Activated by Noble Poll

The glyph-ring above flashed gold.

A new rule burned into place—

WIN CONDITION: RING OUT

Gasps echoed from the crowd.

Even the nobles stirred—eager.

Now it wasn’t about knockout.

It was about *control*.

The bell snapped—less a sound, more a command.

Nikhan launched.

Tail coiled tight, he exploded forward—trident first, voice bleeding venom in a staccato hiss that made the air *vibrate* unnaturally.

Gaurav twisted sideways, barely dodging the first jab—

—but his *left arm went numb*.

Ink had sprayed—mist-like—from Nikhan’s mouth mid-strike. It wasn’t visual. It was **felt**—a crawling **tingle**, like a thousand frozen bugs crawling under skin.

“Shit,” Gaurav spat, clenching his forearm, trying to spark heat through it. “You *don’t* miss.”

Nikhan exhaled.

Black droplets hit the floor, steaming.

Then he whispered:

“The venom doesn’t need to kill. Just... tilt the world beneath you.”

GUARD BREAK — GAURAV STRIKES BACK

Boom.

Gaurav's right leg lashed outward—not toward Nikhan, but toward the *ground* behind him. A burst of **pran** cracked the stone, sending shards upward like blades.

He followed it instantly with a **fire-punched uppercut**, dragging the flaming shards in a vertical wall between them.

Nikhan backflipped, tail looping up midair like a serpent kite, and landed—
—but Gaurav was already beneath him.

Fist to ribs.

Nikhan *grunted*, the first sound he'd made that wasn't controlled.

The trident spun down—
—and Gaurav caught it.

Bare-handed.

With a roar, he *snapped it sideways*, twisting the weapon to redirect the venom channel, and kneed Nikhan in the side.

Tail whipped out—

Whack.

Gaurav flew back.

Yugetsu leaned forward from the Krotha chamber, brows furrowed.

“He's losing his balance.”

Swayam, mask cold and tone flatter than usual, replied:

“No. He's learning spacing.”

Yugetsu blinked. “But he got hit.”

“And didn't fall,” Swayam replied. “Which means Gaurav is syncing.”

He gestured to the flickering glyphs on the arena walls.

“Ring-out isn't about pain. It's about angles.”

Nikhan exhaled ink again.

His thoughts moved like tides.

“He doesn’t stagger. That’s rare. Most do. When the venom hits the nerves... the spine *folds*. But this one—he *burns* it off.”

A memory flickered—
his sister’s eyes going glassy, lips still moving as her heartbeat stopped in his lap.

“You burn too hot, and the love dies first.”

He twitched his jaw, resetting his breath pattern.

“But this one... isn’t love. He’s just *loud*. Let’s see if loud can *swim*.”

Nikhan *hummed again*—but this time, not to Gaurav.

To the ground.

The arena beneath them cracked in a perfect **sound ripple**.

Like a sonar pulse had just detonated from the base of Nikhan’s throat.

Gaurav *stumbled*, one foot sinking into suddenly softened terrain.

He growled and twisted—channeling **wind** and **earth** together to lift himself back into balance—

Too late.

Nikhan *vanished* from vision for half a second.

Not by speed.

By silence.

When he reappeared—it was inches from Gaurav’s throat.

Trident raised—

Thrust.

“GAURAV!” Aviral shouted, halfway to the ring wall. “Ether! *NOW!*”

But Gaurav was already moving.

His entire **torso lit up in ether-fire**—the rarest of his five.

The trident pierced the flame.

And *melted*.

Not physically.

Spiritually.

Ether destabilized the venom's harmony.

The trident recoiled as if bitten, and Nikhan hissed, pulling back—

Gaurav used the opening.

Two punches.

One to Nikhan's lower jaw.

The other—a shoulder-check that blasted a full **air burst** behind it—

Launched Nikhan back toward the edge.

Back in the healer's bay, a faint sound broke the hum.

Nyss's fingers twitched.

Her head turned slightly.

And then—

A whisper. Barely audible.

“...loud flame... please don't fade.”

Arox, arms crossed, grunted. “He's pushing Nikhan already?”

Syra, bandaged, unconscious on a stretcher nearby, didn't move.

But Arox added, almost to himself:

“The loud ones usually die first. But this one... might just be worth bleeding.”

Nikhan slithered to a stop ten feet from the ring's edge, breath rasping, jaw darkened by impact bruising.

He didn't speak.

But he sang.

Just one note.

Like a *funeral hymn* cracked in half.

Gaurav felt it in his legs.

Blood slowed.

He bit down on the side of his mouth, drew blood—used the pain to **spark fire again** in his thighs.

And stepped forward.

“Sing again,” he growled. “Let’s see if you can still hiss when I crack your ribs.”

They charged.

Clash.

Black ink. Red flame. Cracked stone.

CHAPTER:2 END

CHAPTER 3: VICTORY

Ash dust spun in slow spirals across the cratered arena floor.

Nikhan's trident hissed.

Gaurav's bare fists cracked with ether-fire.

They slammed together like two philosophies made flesh.

Fist against fang. Fire against hum.

Nikhan's coil twisted mid-air, body launching at an unnatural side-angle, slithering not across the ground—but through it—his tail cleaving a shallow trench behind him. Gaurav followed with a three-step charge, feinting left, pivoting on heel, then hammering his right elbow into Nikhan's chest—
—but hit only the trident shaft.

CLANG!

The force shot a shockwave up Gaurav's spine. He bit down on a curse, slid backward, boots dragging sparks.

Nikhan didn't chase.

He hovered—coiled—balanced perfectly in mid-serpent curl, his trident raised, humming again. A deep, low pulse.

This time the frequency hit behind the ribs.

Gaurav staggered.

Not dizzy.

Disoriented.

His heartbeat out of sync. Like the inside of his body forgot how to agree with itself.

Nikhan blinked once.

His jaw unhinged.

Ink dripped.

Then came the second vibration—higher, thinner. The kind of sound that didn't make ears ring, but made teeth hurt.

Gaurav screamed—not from fear, but from something primal misfiring in his spine.

He dropped to one knee.

The crowd roared.

Aviral stood in the healer's stand, lips bloodied. "Get up, dammit."

In the Ring

Gaurav forced himself upright—face pale, arms trembling.

He didn't wait.

Didn't think.

He *punched the air*.

Not toward Nikhan—but behind him.

A wall of wind. Raw. Unforgiving.

It slammed across the battlefield like a hurricane's first breath. Ash flew. Glyph-dust scattered.

Nikhan vanished.

No retreat.

Just slithered into smoke like water escaping a crack in stone.

Gaurav's fist closed tighter.

He adjusted his stance—square, grounded.

Used *earth*.

Beneath his boots, the ground shifted. Rose. Thickened.

Then—he ran.

Straight line.

Through ash, through pain, through the fading sting of venom sound still ringing in his collarbone.

He *tackled* Nikhan mid-dash.

Shoulder to stomach.

Nikhan let out a sharp grunt.

Not a word.

Just... sound, the wrong kind.

They smashed into the far edge of the arena, inches from the glyph barrier. Sparks lit. Containment groaned.

Gaurav didn't let go.

One hand seized Nikhan's shoulder.

The other struck. Once. Twice.

Each punch melted against scaled skin, but the momentum built.

Nikhan's tail writhed—then coiled behind Gaurav's ankle, yanking.

Gaurav fell.

Nikhan struck.

Trident slammed down—

—but hit stone.

Gaurav rolled.

Barely.

He came up gasping.

Nikhan stood still.

Chest rising.

Eyes closed.

Voice—

Soft.

A hymn.

Broken. Shattered. Familiar.

Gaurav's knees buckled. Blood dripped from his nose.

The world spun.

Nikhan's lips didn't move much. He just *let the venom hum out of him* like a cracked flute note left in an old temple wind.

—

Memory: Dushaal, the Serpent Shrine

The song had been a lullaby once.

He remembered her small hand.

Not bleeding.

Just warm.

Just trembling.

His sister had been seizing again.

The healer was late.

Mother was gone.

His grandfather—the blind one—sat whispering in the corner, muttering prayers in a tongue only the snakes remembered.

Nikhan had panicked.

He'd leaned down beside her—cupped her face—
and *sang*.

A soft, trembling line.

Something their mother used to hum during the flood nights when the ocean gods came close enough to hear the dreams of children.

“Sleep, little coil, sleep soft in the light—
Let venom drift slow, let the tides be right...”

Her body went still.

He smiled. Thought it had worked.

Then he noticed—

The **blood leaking from her ears**.

—

She died smiling.

Like she forgave him for the lullaby.

But he never forgave himself.

—

Back in the Arena

Gaurav screamed.

Ether-fire exploded from his spine.

The venom rhythm shattered.

Nikhan's song cracked mid-pitch—enough for Gaurav to *slam a fire-infused headbutt* straight into his face.

CRACK.

Ink flew.

Nikhan reeled.

Gaurav didn't stop.

He was *roaring* now, fire climbing his arms like a warning. No elegance. Just violence honed into rhythm.

Right hook—jaw.

Left knee—gut.

Twist—shoulder slam.

Nikhan flew.

He hit the ground sliding.

The edge of the arena *blinked*. Containment glyphs glowed red.

In the noble towers, demons screamed. One noble stood, claws outstretched.

“Ringout! Ringout!”

Aviral stood too, arms trembling, whispering, “Come on...”

Nikhan hit the edge—

Almost.

His tail coiled at the last second, **hooking the rim of a boundary glyph**. His whole body flung around like a pendulum—and landed sideways, chest heaving, blood in his mouth.

But not out.

Not yet.

—

In his mind—Dushaal again

The elders had gathered after his sister’s death.

They did not scold him.

They knelt.

Wept.

Declared him the “Last Coil of Dushaal.”

A living relic.

A weapon sanctified by loss.

But weapons were not allowed to cry.

So they trained him in syllables.

Three words a day.

No more.

He was thirteen.

By fifteen, he could whisper paralysis into a goat from a mile away.

By sixteen, he could hum entire trees into root-lock.

By seventeen, he stopped speaking completely.

Because every word came with grief.

Because even when he loved something—

It stilled.

—

Now, in Kaali Bhoomi

Nikhan stood.

The ring beneath him cracked from his hum.

But his voice—faltering.

Gaurav was already back on him.

Elemental glyphs flared along Gaurav's spine: fire, wind, earth, *ether*.

His leg lashed outward in a spinning kick—

—but Nikhan dropped flat, tail slithering out, catching the leg, flipping him mid-air.

Snap!

Gaurav hit the stone hard—breath gone.

Nikhan launched his trident down again—this time not toward flesh.

But toward **the glyph under Gaurav's body**.

The arena tile *ruptured*.

Stone exploded upward.

Gaurav was tossed sideways—flung across the arena toward the east boundary.

Nikhan coiled tight.

Launched.

Mid-air.

He caught Gaurav's arm.

Pulled.

Redirected the momentum.

Spared him.

Didn't ring him out.

Didn't end it.

The crowd screamed in outrage.

Yugetsu blinked. "He just—why'd he save him?"

Swayam's jaw was set. "Because he's not here to win."

Yugetsu: "Then why fight?"

Swayam: "To *change*."

—

Back in the ring

Gaurav coughed, spit blood, and grinned.

"You hesitated."

Nikhan slithered back, silent.

Ink dripped from his chin.

But his eyes were shaking.

Not from fear.

From memory.

Gaurav stood.

Staggered.

But upright.

His fists clenched.

Then—his voice.

Quiet.

"You remind me of someone. Someone who lost something important and blamed himself too long."

Nikhan didn't reply.

He couldn't.

Not without hurting something.

But he *lowered his trident* slightly.

Gaurav raised his fists.

“Round two?”

Nikhan hissed.

A softer hum.

One that didn’t paralyze.

Just answered.

Yes.

The glyph above the arena began to flicker.

The crowd roared.

And the ring trembled—

as if it understood:

This was no longer just a fight.

It was two broken promises colliding.

Trying to rewrite themselves in fire and venom.

The ring trembled again—not from glyphs or force, but from *intention*.

Gaurav’s feet dragged twin scars across the ash-dusted stone as he circled left, eyes locked on Nikhan. Blood still ran from his nose. One eye was swelling. But his fists still pulsed with ether-heat, the flame folding in against his body like armor not yet finished forging.

Nikhan’s coils undulated slow. His trident scraped behind him in a lazy arc. The ink dripping from his mouth had thickened.

He tasted something unfamiliar.

Almost... respect.

But he masked it as venom.

He tilted his head, voice vibrating low and wet.

“Your body’s slowing, fire-man.

The poison’s inside now. It sings under your bones.”

Gaurav coughed—black-red. A tinge of his lips curled in defiance.

“And yet I’m still talkin’ back, aren’t I?”

Nikhan circled.

“Mixing ether with flame only delays the inevitable.
You're not resisting. *You're stalling.*”

“Yeah?” Gaurav stepped forward. Fire cracked underfoot. “If this were some other place, some other day... maybe I'd lie down and let you croon me to sleep.”

He raised his fists.
Blood beading at his knuckles.
Smile cracked but stubborn.

“But I got *reasons*, pal. Just like you.
I don't die quiet.”

Nikhan's hum stuttered for a heartbeat.
Then he laughed.

Actually laughed. A dry, brittle rasp.

“You really are loud.”

And then he charged.

—

CLASH!

Trident snapped toward Gaurav's throat—parried by a forearm flame-arc.

Counter-spin.

Gaurav dropped low, sweeping the tail—but Nikhan *sprung up*, spine folding unnaturally mid-air.
The trident reversed mid-flight and came down like a guillotine.

CLANG!

Gaurav caught it *barehanded*.

His palm sizzled—ether fought the venom—but the metal still scorched him.

He twisted the shaft and *headbutted* forward. Forehead to jaw.

Nikhan recoiled.

Gaurav spat blood—then smiled.

“C'mon. Sing louder.”

—

In the Announcer Booth

Elsa purred, her voice coiling around the crowd like silk dipped in blades.

“Oh... did your spine just crack? Delicious~”

 *Raktabīja* snorted.

“The mongrel bleeds and still babbles. Humanity’s only strength is its refusal to shut up before dying.”

 *Ignis* chuckled, shifting his form midair into a flaming mimicry of Gaurav’s last punch.

“But sometimes... that noise is defiance. And defiance has a rhythm.”

He paused, glowing eyes narrowing.

“Nikhan is humming more than usual. Trauma loosens tongues.”

In the resting seats, Arox frowned, arms crossed.

Syra lay unconscious behind him, but the vibration of the match shook the medic beds.

“He’s talking too much,” Arox muttered. “Nikhan. He never talks this much. Not even when he’s *winning*.”

Inside the Team Kaal chamber

Scar bounced on the balls of his feet, elbows crackling.

“kaal—kaal—are you seeing this!? That’s a *human*?! I’m fightin’ that firecracker someday. Right after I stab this medic guy into goo.”

Kaal lay half-asleep on the healer bed, one eye barely open.

“Mmh. Tell me if he dies. Or wins. Or both.”

Scar turned.

Rachit had stood up. Quiet. Calm. Walking to the door.

Scar raised an eyebrow.

“Where you going?”

Rachit didn’t look back.

“To take a leak.”

Door clicked.

Scar blinked.

Grinned.

“Cold bastard.”

Back in the Ring

Nikhan's coils lashed out again, sweeping in a tight arc. Gaurav dodged right—but *too late*. The edge of Nikhan's tail cracked across his ribs.

He spun.
Hit the ground.
Coughed blood.

But didn't stop.

With one broken breath, he smashed his fist into the stone—releasing a surge of wind and fire that *catapulted* him back to standing.

Nikhan was already mid-pitch.

A high hum tore the air—sharp enough to slice through thought.

Gaurav's knee gave out.

His body stuttered. Limbs out of sync.
Left arm slowed.
Right leg froze.

Nikhan stepped in.

"You're two notes from sleep. I could make this painless."

Gaurav laughed, mouth bloody.

"That's the thing about pain, brother—"

He lunged.

Grabbing Nikhan's collar with his left.

"—some of us already live there."

Right fist. Ether-lined.
Slams into Nikhan's cheek.

A flash of light.

The serpent dropped low, hissing.

Gaurav fell too—but caught himself on one knee.

Both panting.

Both bleeding.

—

The Crowd Lost It

The arena shook.

Demons screamed bets. Coins flung.

A noblewoman fainted in the balcony. A child clapped with manic glee.

The glyph-ring above flashed—

MOST EXCITING MATCH — VOTED LIVE

98% Audience Favorability

Ignis laughed mid-shift.

“This is what they came for. Not power. *Desperation.*”

Elsa sighed.

“Two broken things. Trying to out-scream fate.”

Raktabīja spat.

“They both die slow. I want new blood.”

—

Yugetsu stood now, hand to his chest.

“Swayam...”

“Yeah?”

“Who do you think wins?”

Swayam didn’t blink.

“The one who remembers why they fight louder.”

Yugetsu nodded.

Inside the ring

Nikhan’s breath was ragged.

He stared at Gaurav across the cracked earth.

Something... not venom... in his throat.

“We haven’t introduced ourself properly, Your name.”

Gaurav blinked.

“What?”

“Say it.”

“Gaurav.”

“Mine’s Nikhan.”

Gaurav smiled, eyes heavy.

“Cool. Now punch me again before I fall asleep standing.”

Nikhan obliged.

Their bodies collided once more—fire bursting, ink screaming, bones protesting.

The sky glyph flickered gold—

Mid-Match Rule Change Activated.

NEW CONDITION: FINISH THE MATCH IN 30 SECONDS OR DIE.

The air turned colder.

The flame sigils across the arena dimmed as a clock glyph appeared above them all—rotating like a sun made of swords.

30.

29.

28.

Nikhan and Gaurav froze.

Breaths visible.

Eyes locked.

The crowd didn’t cheer.

They *gasp*ed.

And then—

Gaurav broke the silence.

“Well. shit.”

Nikhan grunted, venom already pooling down his wrist.

“No time to talk now, loud one.”

Gaurav’s teeth bared in a grin.

“Then let’s speak in fists.”

—

They moved.

26.

Nikhan coiled and launched—tail whipping across the ground like a chain of knives.

Gaurav rushed forward—his aura flaring wild, fire and wind crisscrossing his arms like angry wings.

They collided in the center of the ring with a sound like *a mountain cracking in half*.

Nikhan struck high—trident angled for Gaurav's ribs.

Gaurav ducked, swept low, then *jumped*, flipping sideways and using **wind pressure** mid-air to launch himself behind Nikhan.

He landed—palm to earth.

FIRE GLYPH—triggered!

The tile under Nikhan detonated in a sharp *BOOM*—sending the serpent off-balance.

22.

Gaurav followed up—two punches to the gut, one knee to the hip.

Nikhan's tail wrapped around his waist mid-strike and *flung him*.

Gaurav slammed into the ground—but rolled with it, flames dragging like comet tails.

“Clock's ticking, snake!”

Nikhan hissed.

“Then let me squeeze harder.”

The **trident spun**—but this time it sang a different pitch.

The hum hit Gaurav's jaw mid-step. *Frozen* again—this time, a full half-second lock.

18.

Nikhan moved in. Fast. Intent to **stab** and **end it**.

But Gaurav—**broke his own shoulder** with a twist just to move again.

He *screamed* through the pain and **punched the glyph wall beside him**—

It rebounded him with force, launching him *like a missile*.

—

In the nyss team resting area

Aviral stood, eyes wide.

“No. No way. He *broke himself* to keep moving—”

13.

Back in the ring—Gaurav *grabbed* Nikhan mid-sprint.

Locked arms. Twisting grip.

Pulled.

Threw.

Nikhan adjusted in mid-air, tail lashing around a pillar.

He *swung back* like a pendulum—trident-first.

CLASH!

Gaurav caught the trident with both hands—**burned skin peeling**—and headbutted Nikhan *again*.

Blood. Ink. Steam.

—

10.

They both stumbled.

No stance. Just pain.

Then—Gaurav whispered:

“You’re strong.”

Nikhan exhaled black.

“So are you.”

Then—

“But only one of us is leaving.”

8.

6.

Nikhan surged again.

Gaurav didn’t dodge.

He *lowered* his stance.

Dug deep.

Then—

He *baited*.

Nikhan's trident struck forward—
But hit a glyph.

Ether-flame trap.

A decoy from earlier—Gaurav had carved it behind him during their last slam.

It *detonated*—an upward funnel.

Nikhan's body shot into the air—tail flailing.

3.

2.

Gaurav roared—

Willed fire into his feet.

Launched *with wind* combined.

Grabbed Nikhan mid-air.

And—

Spun.

A full-body throw.

Momentum.

Direction.

RINGOUT.

Nikhan *slammed* into the glyph wall—

And fell—**outside the ring.**

1.

—

The crowd erupted.

Some screamed.

Others threw chairs.

Coins hit the arena floor like rain.

Above it all—

Ignis bellowed in a voice like dragonfire:

“RINGOUT!

GAURAV OF TEAM NYSS WINS THE MATCH WITH 0.6 SECONDS LEFT!”

Elsa moaned.

“Ooohh, that finish was so close I almost *felt it*. The desperation. The bruises. The *sweat*. Mmm, give me ten more rounds like that~”

Raktabija spat from his chair.

“This is why mongrels are dangerous. They don’t know when to die. Kill the clock—what farce is this!?”

Ignis, still mid-shift, replayed the final move in slow motion to the crowd.

“That glyph... it was planted *mid-fall*. In pain. Under pressure. He didn’t just survive. He **won with intent.**”

—

In the Team Kaal chamber

Scar leapt into the air, nearly kicking over Kaal’s bed.

“HE DID IT! I TOLD YOU! THIS BASTARD CAN THROW!!”

He turned to Kaal—

Back in the arena

Nikhan lay still outside the ring.

Eyes half-lidded.

He breathed.

Then turned his head—saw Gaurav—collapsed inside the ring, burned, broken, but upright on one elbow.

Nikhan coughed ink, then chuckled.

“Still loud.”

Gaurav grinned, eyes closing.

“Still hissing.”

They both passed out.

The match was over.

But in the glyphs above, new words appeared—

MATCH 3: TEAM NYSS VS TEAM MAVIK — ? VS AROX.

Aviral limped into the ring, still breathing hard, but upright. His armor was cracked at the ribs, blood patching through the gauze. Yet his eyes locked onto Gaurav—collapsed at the edge, one hand clenched in victory.

He dropped to a crouch beside him.

“You...” Aviral muttered, voice shaking, “you actually did it.”

Gaurav didn’t respond right away.

But then—

A groan. A faint smirk. “Told you I’d win, didn’t I?”

“You were unconscious for half a second.”

“Doesn’t count if I still get the applause.”

Aviral laughed. Not loud. But real. He gripped Gaurav’s shoulder, steadying him as the medics rushed in.

From the other side of the arena, Arox stepped onto the platform. He didn’t roar. Didn’t posture.

He just slung Nikhan’s arm over his shoulder and began carrying him out.

The serpent-kin hybrid was still breathing. Barely. Blood and venom trailed behind him like regret.

Their eyes met across the field—Aviral and Arox.

No words.

Just a nod.

Acknowledgment between warriors.

One earned. One owed.

In the Announcer Tower

Elsa's voice was silk on stone. "That... was divine. I haven't felt this wet since the Siege of Cinderpeak."

Ignis, half-morphed into Gaurav's form, mimicked his final punch in slow motion for the audience. "Such torque... such symmetry... do you see it? His shoulder rotated just enough to make the blast directional. He didn't just punch Nikhan—he aimed him."

Raktabija snorted. "A lucky human. So what? Next match, he bleeds like the rest."

Ignis didn't look back. "Perhaps. But today... he danced on venom."

In Team Krotha's Room

Yugetsu's hands were white on the edge of the display table. "He won."

Swayam nodded once, slow. "Yeah."

"He actually won."

Swayam's voice was colder now. "Which means next up... is Arox."

Yugetsu glanced at him. “Can they handle him?”

Swayam didn’t answer.

In Team Kaal’s Rest Dome

Scar whooped. “I love that guy! Did you see the kick? The kick!”

He ran in a circle, bare feet stomping against the rune-inscribed stone. “Ooooh I want to punch him in the face!”

In the corridors

Rachit moved through the long corridors like a shadow looking for gravity. Past teams. Past noise.

He walked alone.

Toward something.

Above him, the glyph-sky shimmered again.

MATCH 3: TEAM NYSS VS TEAM MAVICK — COMMENCING.

And beside it:

NEXT: TEAM KROTHA VS TEAM GLAZEN.

He glanced up. Briefly.

Then looked away.

The air shifted.

Like the storm hadn't ended.

Just taken a new shape.

In the Arena

A hologlyph surged upward—burning like a scream given shape.

Arox.

Ash-scarred. Silver-locked. Steel-plated.

He stepped into the light, dragging his cleaver-sword behind him like it weighed nothing.

Gaurav, still groggy on the healer's bench, looked up and muttered, "Shit."

Aviral followed his gaze. "Yeah. That's our next mountain."

And above them all—

The arena thundered.

As if Kaali Bhoomi itself had decided:

The fire may have burned.

But now... it was time for stone.

Ash flickered across the healer zone like falling embers.

Nyss lay motionless on the cot, her face calm—but too calm.

The glyph-threaded illusion that had trapped her since Trial One still coiled around her mind, pulsing faintly like a dream refusing to end feeding on her pran.

Gaurav sat beside her. Bloodied. Stitched. Breathing like a furnace with half a chimney.

Aviral stood nearby—back straight, eyes focused on the ring.

“You’re not ready,” Gaurav muttered, watching him pick up the charred remains of his armor straps.

Aviral didn’t answer at first.

He just looked at Nyss—her hand twitching once in her sleep—and then turned to Gaurav.

“I’m gonna buy us time.”

Gaurav frowned. “You’ll get killed.”

Aviral smirked. “That’s not the plan.”

“Then what is?”

“To lose with intention.”

Gaurav sat forward, eyes narrowing. “I can still fight. You’ve seen me. I’m—”

“I know,” Aviral cut in, quietly. “I know you can. That’s why I’m going first.”

He picked up his staff—half-scorched, a third of the core glyphs already dead.

“Rest till it’s your turn.”

He didn’t wait for a response.

As Aviral walked toward the gate, he glanced once over his shoulder.

Saw the stitched Gaurav.

And said nothing.

Because there was nothing left to say.

He stepped into the light.

From the opposite gate—

Arox entered.

A beast carved from remembrance.

Every step cracked stone.

Volcanic ash drifted from his shoulders as if his very presence disturbed the air’s memory of heat.

Blazetusk—his cleaver—dragged behind him, leaving a scorched line in the ring like a scar that wouldn’t close.

He looked at Aviral and nodded.

“I respect your fire, glyph-weaver.”

Aviral raised his chin, not flinching.

“But we both know,” Arox continued, “we’re here for the same thing. To win. For ours. For reasons that don’t wait.”

Aviral exhaled once. “Then let’s skip the speeches.”

Above them, the sky glyph twisted—

NEW MATCH CONDITION: WIN BY KNOCKOUT OR KILL

The crowd gasped.

Ignis whispered from above:

“This is not a duel. It’s a sentence being carried out.”

Elsa leaned forward, her voice velvet-soaked razors.

“Oh, I love when they add a kill clause. It tastes like finality.”

Raktabija scoffed.

“It’s not a fight. It’s a mercy. That human’s already broken.”

The bell rang.

Aviral moved first—staff glowing, eyes locked, shoulders tense.

But—

Arox didn't move like a juggernaut.

He vanished.

One step.

Then blur.

BOOM.

The impact didn't echo. It collapsed.

Aviral's glyph cast didn't even finish before Blazetusk smashed down into his guard.

His staff shattered.

His shoulder folded inward.

He dropped.

Not unconscious.

Just done.

Arox caught him before he hit the ground.

Held him up by the collar with one arm.

"Your body's strong," Arox muttered. "But your reasons need more time."

Then he dropped him gently to the floor.

Healers rushed in.

In the Team Kaal Room

Scar stopped mid-bounce.

"...Wait, that's it? It's over?"

He looked around.

Then grinned.

"Damn. That guy's terrifying. Like, I wanna fight him terrifying."

Kaal snorted, still half-asleep.

"That's called 'suicidal instinct.' Keep it."

Scar beamed. “I will!”

In the Arena Above

The glyphs shimmered:

MATCH 3 — ROUND 4: BEGIN PREPARATION

Arox stood at the center of the ring, gaze already shifting toward Team Nyss’s chamber.

Blazetusk rested against his shoulder.

And his lips moved—barely audible.

But Ignis caught it.

He replayed the words in slow-motion flame script for the nobles.

“Send your next. I’ll carry them out too.”

Backstage

Gaurav sat beside the unconscious Aviral.

He looked at his own hands—still trembling from venom, flame, and now fury.

Then whispered, voice low:

"...I'm next."

And this time—

He didn't smile.

He promised.

The ring was still stained with past fights and blood.

Gaurav stepped in anyway.

Bare-chested. Bandaged. Breathing hard. Every movement cracked the gauze taped across his ribs. But the fire...

It still came.

A crimson aura. Not just flame. Something heavier.

It writhed off him in jagged pulses—flame mixed with ether, dragging smoke behind every breath like he was burning from the inside.

His skin steamed. Not from heat. From refusal to cool.

Across the ring, Arox didn't move.

He simply watched.

Blazetusk rested against his shoulder like a silent judgment.

In the Team Krotha Room

Yugetsu stepped back from the viewing glyph.

"...That's not ether fire."

"No," Swayam said, voice sharper than usual. "It's not."

He tapped the glyph feed and zoomed in on Gaurav's aura.

The flames weren't natural. They *looped* in on themselves. Folded.

"He's mixing ether with fire, old move," Swayam murmured. "But this time not with control. He's *forcing* Jeev Shakti to compress Prāṇ Urja. That kind of pressure doesn't shape... it *tears*."

Yugetsu's eyes widened. "That'll kill him."

"If he doesn't kill himself first, the recoil will."

In the Announcer Tower

Ignis leaned forward, eyes flickering with curiosity.

"Look at that, nobles. Look *closely*. You're not just seeing fire. You're seeing a man *forg*e his body into a container it was never meant to be."

Elsa giggled, licking her lower lip.

"He's shivering. Delicious. I hope he screams soon."

Raktabīja scoffed.

"Another loud one. Another waste of ash. Watch closely, lords and leeches—this is how humans *delude* themselves into thinking courage is power."

Back in the Ring

Arox took a step forward.

The ground cracked beneath him.

Not from power. From weight. The **memory** of weight. The way tectonic plates remember pressure.

"You should be on a stretcher," Arox said.

Gaurav cracked his neck.

"Probably."

"You'll break."

"Already broken."

"...Then this is mercy."

"No. This is *mine*."

The bell rang.

The World Snapped.

Gaurav launched forward—ether flames bursting from his calves, launching him low.

Arox didn't dodge.

He *stepped forward*.

BOOM—

First clash.

Gaurav's fist to Arox's ribs—

Met by a *backhand* that crushed the air.

Gaurav skidded ten feet—ribs flaring with red light as the bandages tore.

He didn't stop.

Two more punches.

Each blocked.

Each answered.

CRACK—!

A knee to Gaurav's stomach folded him over.

Arox grabbed his hair. Lifted.

Then **slammed** him face-first into the ring floor.

In the Crowd

The nobles were screaming.

Ignis whispered:

“He's toying with him. That wasn't force. That was... *proof*.”

Elsa moaned, stretching out on her seat.

“Mmm... the blood. The thuds. The way his spine bent. Say it again. Slowly.”

Raktabija sneered.

“Humans were made to be broken. The way that one walks back up? That's not bravery. That's desperation pretending to matter.”

Back in the Ring

Gaurav *stood again*.

Barely.

His lip was split. Blood poured from his eyebrow. His left arm trembled with each movement.

But his aura *spiked* again.

The ether tried to stabilize.

It didn't.

He *screamed*, and *punched* the earth.

BOOM—!

A ring of sequential Prāṇ-blasts exploded around him—earth spikes, fire pulses, wind pressure spikes.

Arox stood still.

He walked through the chaos like it was falling rain.

He ducked under a flame spike.

Swatted aside a wind slice.

Then—

One step.

Low kick.

CRACK.

Gaurav's knee folded *backwards*.

He dropped.

But Arox didn't finish him.

Not yet.

He leaned down, voice flat.

"You've got heart. I won't insult that."

Gaurav coughed blood.

"Then don't pity me. *Hit harder.*"

—

In the Team Kaal Room

Scar was on his feet again. "HOLY—he just *bent* him! Bent him like a damn ribbon!"

He pointed at the glyph replay. "Kaal! Look at that combo. Knee, then collarbone twist—*classic Rift execution-style!* Dude's a war hymn."

Kaal didn't open his eyes. "He's wasting energy."

Scar turned. "Who? Arox?"

“No. The human.”

Scar paused.

“...Damn.”

Inside Gaurav's head

He saw Nikhan's eyes again.

Syra's fall.

The Devouring Path.

The shaking hands he once hid behind his back when no one looked.

Useless. Useless. Useless.

The word echoed.

Then—

He heard another one.

“Believe in yourself.”

Swayam's voice.

Not a hallucination.

A memory.

But sometimes, *memories* scream louder than pain.

In the Ring

Gaurav spat teeth.

And stood again.

Left leg barely working.

Shoulder dislocated.

But standing.

He raised his fists.

Didn't speak.

Didn't need to.

Arox tilted his head.

“...Good.”

And moved again.

He came like a storm clothed in skin.

Blazetusk wasn't swung—it was dragged, like a falling continent.

Gaurav ducked the first arc by sheer reflex.

Didn't dodge the second.

CRACK—

The cleaver caught his side, glancing off his ribs and hurling him sideways. He hit the arena wall and bounced forward—choking on his own breath.

The crowd groaned. Some cheered. Some turned away.

But he stood. Again.

Arox slowed. Not from exhaustion—from something else.

Respect.

“Stay down,” Arox said, voice firm. “I don't want to kill you. You're already cracked. I can see it in your leg. In your breathing. You and the last one... you're injured.”

“Shut up,” Gaurav coughed. “Just fight.”

“We will,” Arox replied, lifting Blazetusk again. “But I want you to live. So that when we meet again... it's real. Because I can see it in your eyes.”

“What?”

“You’re like us. Your reason for fighting... isn’t different than ours.”

Then he came again.

And Gaurav tried.

Tried to fight.

Tried to twist, to use fire, to spark wind, anything—

But everything came in broken half-steps.

His own body betrayed him.

SLAM—

Knee to stomach.

THUD—

Backhand across the face. Spit flew.

WHACK—

Blazetusk to ribs—not full force. Just enough to make the pain unforgettable.

Gaurav collapsed again.

Blood soaked the bandages now. His vision pulsed.

Sound warped.

The crowd blurred.

And then—

The glyphs above dimmed.

—

In the Announcer Tower

Ignis' voice shifted from amused to fascinated. "We're losing him."

Elsa sighed. "Pity. I was hoping for one more scream."

Raktabija grinned. "And yet still, they watch. Because a slow fall is more poetic than a clean death."

In the Team Krotha chamber

Yugetsu slammed a fist on the edge. "He's gonna die in there—"

But Swayam froze.

Not because of fear.

Because of what he saw.

“Wait.”

In the ring

Gaurav twitched.

The flames went out.

The crimson ether aura flickered once.

Then vanished.

And his eyes opened.

No longer black.

But deep blue, laced with brown circular rings, spiraling outward like a storm seen from the sky.

A breath.

Long.

Pulled from somewhere deeper than lungs.

The air shifted.

Dust on the ring lifted without wind.

Stone at his feet vibrated.

And the arena—watched.

Gaurav stood.

And the earth stood with him.

Shards of rock slithered up his shin and thigh, wrapping around his shattered knee like a brace grown from the arena itself.

Air swirled in soft drafts around his shoulders.

Not fire.

Wind.

Earth.

At once.

No transition. No switch.

Just... both.

Flashback – Sector 3

A rooftop. Broken concrete. Wires humming overhead.

Swayam leaned against a rusted pipe. Rachit crouched, picking apart a disassembled weapon. Gaurav stood in the center—frustrated, sweating, hands blazing one moment and then going numb the next.

"I don't get it," Gaurav muttered. "I can't use more than one at once. If I try to ignite wind and earth together, my veins shake. Like something's snapping inside."

"Because it is," Swayam had said. "You weren't born with them. Your Jeev Shakti and pran wasn't grown that way. You're forcing compatibility."

Gaurav dropped to one knee.

"So what do I do?"

Rachit didn't look up.

"You wait until it stops being about 'using' and starts being about being."

Now. In the ring.

He exhaled.

Stone hardened around his forearms.

Wind danced across his back and legs—like hands guiding balance.

The glyphs above shimmered. The system registered it.

ELEMENTAL SYNC DETECTED: GAURAV – EARTH + WIND

Warning: Stability level low. Risk: Extreme.

But Gaurav smiled.

Because he felt no pain.

Only clarity.

Arox blinked.

The change wasn't in strength.

It was in presence.

"So," he said slowly. "You've decided."

Gaurav's voice was quieter now. Centered.

"Not decided. Allowed."

And then he moved.

BOOM—

Gaurav closed the gap in four steps.

Not fast.

Correct.

Each step cracked the stone—not from power—but from the air pressure riding in his motion. The moment he entered range, he ducked under Blazetusk and slammed a stone-armored forearm into Arox's side.

Arox grunted.

Actually grunted.

Gaurav twisted—wind spiraling around his pivoting ankle—and threw a second punch. Air compressed around his fist like a piston.

CRACK—

Arox stumbled back.

Just a step.

But enough for the crowd to lose their minds.

In the Announcer Tower

Ignis stood.

"MIRACLE IN MOTION! A human syncing two core elements not sequentially—but simultaneously."

Elsa arched her back. “I felt that last punch in my thighs.”

Raktabīja spat blood into a gold cup.

“He still loses. He’s just choosing the pace.”

In the Team Krotha chamber

Yugetsu blinked. “What the hell just happened?!”

Swayam’s voice was hushed.

“He stopped forcing Prāṇ and started trusting Jeev Shakti to guide it.”

Yugetsu: “But how? He always needed a beat, a switch—”

Swayam: “That’s a discussion for later.”

Back in the Ring

Arox grinned now.

Wide. White teeth. Not mocking. Alive.

“Alright then.”

He cracked his neck.

"Let's make it count."

Blazetusk rose.

Wind screamed.

Stone cracked.

And they charged.

Clash—

Wind shrieks—

Stone splits—

The entire arena felt smaller.

Two reasons.

Two rhythms.

Colliding.

Not to destroy.

But to see which one held longer.

Gaurav led with a shoulder feint—wind coiling around his body like writhing flags.
He slammed into Arox from the left.

BOOM—!

A shockwave exploded outward. The audience **staggered** back from the ring's pulse barrier.
Rows of glyph-spectators began *glitching* from overload.

Arox countered with a downward swing.

Gaurav ducked. Twisted.

Spun beneath the blade and drove an elbow, now coated in jagged rock, up into Arox's jaw.

CRACK—!

A hint of blood.

Real. Brief.

Arox smiled.

Not out of pain.

But *recognition*.

Then—

They both vanished.

Not invisibly.

Just **fast**.

—

300 meters per second.

Two blurs exploded across the arena.

Rings of dust formed wherever they turned.

Walls cracked.

Pillars fractured.

One of the side-statues shattered from air displacement alone.

The **arena itself screamed** with every collision.

—

In the Announcer Tower

Ignis flickered through three shapes in real-time, barely keeping pace.

“TWO-HUNDRED. TWO-FIFTY. *THREE HUNDRED!* This is speed at which most mortals
die on impact, nobles!”

Elsa was breathless. “I think I just climaxed.”

Raktabija growled.

“And yet even now—look at Arox’s stance. He’s not even flinching. He’s *letting* him swing.”

Ignis narrowed his eyes.

“No. He’s *measuring* him.”

—

In the Ring

Gaurav flipped over a shoulder grab, landing in a slide and launching off the rebound with wind-thrusted feet.

He struck again—twisting his weight mid-flight, throwing a **three-part combo**.

Fist. Elbow. Spinning kick.

Arox parried all three. With one hand.

Not casually.

But with precision.

—

In the Krotha’s Room

Yugetsu had to press his hands to the barrier just to remain upright.

“They’re moving too fast—! I can’t even see half of it.”

Swayam was dead silent.

His mask was off.

Eyes sharp.

“He’s burning *everything*,” Swayam murmured.

“Gaurav’s Jeev Shakti is being funneled raw into kinetic shaping. Every micro-step has a pattern behind it. Wind for momentum. Earth for control.”

Yugetsu: “So he’s—what? Going toe-to-toe with Arox?”

Swayam didn’t answer.

Because in that moment—

Gaurav *stumbled*.

A half-second off.

A single milli second of timing faltered.

And Arox struck.

BLAM—!

A forearm to the sternum.

The *air* around them folded.

Gaurav hit the arena wall **head-first**, a crater blooming around his body.

The crowd gasped.

A healer dropped their tools.

Gaurav *twitched*—and rolled out of the rubble before the smoke cleared.

He was panting now.

Badly.

His left eye was swelling shut.

The wind coiled around him, but less obedient now.

The rocks supporting his knee were cracking at the edges.

He stood again.

Shaky.

But with fists still raised.

And said—

Nothing.

Arox lowered Blazetusk.

He wasn't smiling now.

His voice was low. Real.

"You're strong. But you're forcing it."

He stepped forward.

"This sync? You didn't *build* it. You *bled* it into being. That kind of strength doesn't last."

Gaurav blinked sweat from his eye.

“Then I’ll make it last thirty seconds longer.”

“Why?”

“So I can hit you again.”

—

Arox exhaled.

“... You remind me of someone.”

Gaurav laughed, blood dripping down his chin.

“Don't say your brother.”

“No,” Arox said. “Someone dead.”

Then he moved again.

Clash.

This time Gaurav met him **halfway**.

Not to block.

But to *interrupt*.

He swept upward with a blast of air—redirecting Blazetusk sideways just enough—

And then *headbutted Arox in the nose*.

It didn’t break.

But it echoed.

The crowd **roared**.

Gaurav tried to follow up with a punch—

But Arox’s palm met his chest.

Pushed.

Just pushed.

BOOM—!

Gaurav flew thirty feet backward, bouncing once, twice, then sliding to a stop in a trench of his own making.

He groaned.

He sat up.

And as the blood trickled from his ear—

He smiled.

In the Team Kaal Room

Scar was now fully standing on the bench, shouting.

“DID YOU SEE THAT HEADBUTT?! THAT’S A WAR MOVE! THAT’S WHAT I’D DO!”

He turned to Kaal, who was finally awake.

Kaal just grunted. “He’s still going to lose.”

Scar nodded. “Yeah. But *damn*.”

In the Arena

Gaurav stood once more.

Shaking.

But wind still circled his spine.

Stone still clung to his arms.

And Arox?

Arox rolled his shoulders.

Then gave a rare nod.

“You’re not done yet.”

Gaurav raised his hands.

“Not until I land one that makes you *step back*.”

Arox smirked.

“Then let’s see you try.”

The glyphs above the ring flared again—

The timer shifted.

A new phase was recognized.

FINAL LIMIT APPROACHING. FIGHT INTENSITY INCREASING.

And as they circled each other once more, wind howling, stone trembling—

The crowd leaned forward.

The announcers fell silent.

And the world waited—

To see if a human could shake a mountain.

Gaurav didn't blink.

Neither did Arox.

They moved.

BOOM—

Stone fractured under Gaurav's heel as he launched—low, fast, wind-cradled.

Arox met him head-on—Blazetusk roaring upward in a flaming arc.

Gaurav rolled under, *barely*—

Air sliced over his head. His hair singed at the ends.

He pivoted—

Earth gathered under his fists.

He struck Arox in the chest—

The mountain took it.

Didn't budge.

But *acknowledged it*.

A flicker in his eye.

A shift in his breath.

For two full minutes, they became **rhythm**.

Wind to cleaver.

Stone to shin.

Elbow to jaw.

Knee to guard.

No wasted motion.

No wild swings.

Every move a story.

Every block a memory.

Blood dripped from Gaurav's nose.

Arox's lip was split now.

The crowd had *stopped screaming*.

Now they *watched*.

Quietly.

Almost reverently.

And then—

Gaurav stepped back.

Swayed.

Took in a single deep breath.

And raised both hands to the sky.

Stone cracked at his feet.

Wind spun around his legs like stormrings.

The air began to fold.

Not into fire.

But into **weight**.

His Prāṇ flared *once*—

Then his **Jeev Shakti pulsed** like a scream inside his veins.

He screamed too—

A roar from his *soul*—

“THIS... IS EVERYTHING!!”

He launched forward.

Not flying. Not running.

Colliding.

All of his energy—his remaining Jeev Shakti—pushed into a single punch.

The earth beneath him **shattered**.

The wind behind him *howled* like a hurricane caught in prayer.

He came in like a meteor—

Fist glowing.

Shoulder cracked.

Teeth clenched.

Arox saw him.

Saw the line.

Saw the danger.

Lifted his own fist.

Brought it back.

And—

Then...

He noticed.

Gaurav's eyes rolled back.

Mid-air.

The fist *never landed*.

He **fainted**.

—

Arox's fist was already moving.

Too fast.

Too late.

He *couldn't stop it*.

THWACK—!!

A sound like the world swallowing itself whole.

Gaurav's body **whiplashed** across the ring.

Slammed into the glyph barrier at full force.

BOOOOM—

The containment wall **flared red**, absorbing the blow, then shattered inward in a burst of raw force.

Gaurav collapsed.

Arms limp.

Body twitching once.

Then still.

—

In the Announcer Tower

Ignis whispered.

“...He fainted. *Mid-attack.*”

Elsa sat frozen.

Her hand on her mouth.

“He *almost landed it.*”

Raktabija... didn’t speak.

But his claws curled, hard.

In the Team Krotha Room

Yugetsu had gone pale.

“He... he passed out *before* the punch...”

Swayam stood.

He whispered—

“The body gave up. The will didn’t.”

Then added, softer:

“...It would’ve landed.”

Arox stood over him now.

He looked down at the unconscious boy.

Still breathing.

But barely.

He crouched.

Picked up the hand that *almost* hit him.

Held it gently.

And said, quietly:

“You did.”

Then stood.

Turned to the healers.

“Get him help. Now.”

He walked away.

Didn’t raise a fist.

Didn’t cheer.

Because mountains don’t celebrate earthquakes.

They remember them.

Above the Arena

The glyph matrix shifted.

Lines of molten light trailed across the air as the arena’s scoring system began to update—crowd data, noble reactions, real-time fear pulses all tallied by the Malakour codex.

MATCH COMPLETE

WINNER: AROX — BY KNOCKOUT

—

POINT BREAKDOWN: TEAM MAVIK

+80 Crowd Shockwave: Arox’s Final Blow
+50 Fear Index Surge (After Gaurav Slam)
+40 Precision Control Bonus (Blazetusk Flow)
+30 Respect Spike: Arox’s Mercy Shown
+100 Trial 2 Victory Bonus

Trial 1 Score: 70

Total: 370 Points

—

POINT BREAKDOWN: TEAM NYSS

+60 Audience Pulse: Gaurav’s Elemental Sync (Wind+Earth)
+40 “Will Not Fall” Bonus (Multiple Stand-Ups)
+35 Crowd Roar Peak: Near-Landing Faint Sequence
+35 Aviral Tactical Points (Syra Trap Dome)
+30 Resilience Spike (Fighting Injured)

Trial 1 Score: 30

Total: 200 Points

—

Backstage

Rachit stood at the top of the stairwell.

The light from the scoring glyphs reflected faintly in his eyes.

He didn't blink.

Didn't speak.

Just watched the score burn across the sky.

370.

200.

Then—

He turned.

And walked silently back into the corridor's shadows.

No shift in pace.

No words.

But his footsteps sounded sharper than before.

CHAPTER:3 ENDED

CHAPTER 4: LOSS

The crowd's roar still echoed—phantom thunder chasing silence. But inside the medical corridors beneath the arena, there was no noise. Only urgency.

Team Nyss was being moved on stretchers.

Gaurav's body trembled faintly as he was loaded onto a silver slab layered with a thin healing membrane. Stone fragments still clung to his cracked fists. His knuckles were bloodied, fingers twitching like they hadn't accepted unconsciousness yet.

His head lolled sideways.

A medic adjusted the prāṇ stabilizer collar on his neck. "Muscle spasms are still firing. Pulse's weak but holding."

Next to him, Aviral lay slumped, barely conscious, one arm limply resting across his chest. Burnt streaks lined his shoulder, remnants of Arox's cleaver swing. A medic waved a glyph-scope over his ribs and muttered, "He's got two fractures and a punctured lung seal. We'll need tier-three reinforcement."

Nyss didn't move at all.

She wasn't broken.

She was... absent. Her body was whole, but her soul signature flickered, dimming and reappearing like a dying ember beneath water. Her arms were curled around her chest like she was trying to protect something only she could see. A soft whimper passed her lips—one syllable, fragmented and incoherent.

"Keep the coma field steady," another medic ordered. "Her mind's still trapped somewhere in Trial One's glyph-weave."

Two demon nurses wheeled her away gently, as if touching her too harshly might make her disappear entirely.

Syra from Team Mavik was being pushed alongside them—jaw clenched, one arm hanging over the side of her stretcher. Her glyph-rings were still glowing, but cracked. Her breathing was erratic, teeth grinding as her eyelids fluttered.

Nikhan slithered behind the medic crew—his lower body coiled in focus, face emotionless, voice low. "She doesn't respond to vocal frequency cues."

Arox followed without speaking, the handle of Blazetusk strapped tightly to his back. His steps echoed.

He wasn't limping.

He wasn't slowing.

But his eyes stayed locked on Gaurav's motionless hand as if trying to understand the shape of the punch that almost landed.

In the Team Krotha quarters

The silence wasn't just heavy—it was waiting.

The holo-glyphs still hovered midair, replaying the moment of collapse: Gaurav flying back, the final scream of wind and stone, the split lip on Arox's face.

Yugetsu's jaw clenched hard enough to ache. His black-streaked spider hair twitched faintly at the edges. His fingers hovered over Anshika's forehead, checking the pulse signature.

"She's stable," he said. But his voice wasn't calm. It was sharp. Measured. "Faint oscillations in her mind-thread. Could mean she's close to waking—or about to fall deeper."

Swayam didn't answer. He stood by the holo-display, arms crossed. His frost-thread mask hung from one hand, glinting with the reflection of Gaurav's last charge.

Then he turned to Yugetsu.

"Take her," he said.

Yugetsu's brows furrowed. "What?"

Swayam's tone didn't shift. "You need to carry Anshika to the same ward as Gaurav and Aviral. Make sure they're treated. Properly. No shortcuts. No demon-branded leeches."

Yugetsu's expression darkened. His voice dropped.

"You're not coming?"

Swayam shook his head once.

"I have our match to prepare for."

The words settled like stone dust.

Yugetsu stood up slowly. His limbs were tense—too precise. His mouth opened, but this time no joke came out. No stammer. No awkward pivot.

"You're serious," he said flatly.

Swayam didn't flinch. "Yes."

Yugetsu took a step forward. His voice was quieter now, but not softer.

"You're going to face an entire demon team. Alone. With no healer. No shield. No plan."

"I've got a plan," Swayam said simply.

Yugetsu's hands curled into fists.

“And what that would be .. to die .”

The tension between them felt electric—old, familiar, but on fire now.

Yugetsu’s voice rose. “Did you even see what Arox did to Gaurav? These demons don’t just fight—they erase people. And you think you can take on Team Glazen solo?”

Swayam finally met his eyes. Cold. Unshaking.

“I know I can’t.”

Yugetsu recoiled. “Then why?!”

“Because someone has to do it,” Swayam said. “And I’m the only one left who can.”

There was a silence that cracked something.

Yugetsu took a breath, then snapped: “You think Rachit would approve this? You think Gaurav would be okay waking up to find you gone—ashes on some molten battlefield because you had to play hero?”

Swayam’s eyes didn’t waver. “This isn’t about playing hero.”

Yugetsu’s voice dropped into something lower.

Tighter.

“This is exactly what gets people killed.”

His face twisted—not in anger, but fear wearing the mask of anger.

“I’ve seen this before. Back in the slave pits. When the smart ones... the good ones... stood up thinking they could shield us from everything. They never came back.”

Swayam took a breath. Then placed a hand on his shoulder.

“I will come back.”

Yugetsu’s voice cracked—just barely.

“You can’t promise that.”

“I can,” Swayam said, “because I haven’t finished what I started.”

Then, without waiting for more protest, he stepped toward the exit.

Each step was deliberate.

Quiet.

Final.

Yugetsu stood frozen for half a second—then moved toward Anshika and gently scooped her into his arms, one hand behind her shoulders, the other cradling her knees.

As he turned toward the medical exit, he muttered under his breath—

“...You better come back, bastard. Or I swear I’ll burn this whole arena down looking for your ghost.”

Corridors of the Trial Spire

Swayam’s footsteps echoed down the spiral stairs.

The further he walked, the quieter the arena sounded—until the crowd was just a dull roar above the stone. The glyph torches flickered cold-blue on the walls, casting reflections against the frost-thread weave of his cloak.

His eyes were forward.

Always forward.

Every step was heavier now—not from doubt, but preparation. He passed rooms where other teams huddled, sharpened blades, prayed to gods that no longer answered.

He passed the demon heralds.

The flame-faced scorers.

After some time of walking.

He reached the North Gate.

The North Gate loomed like a vault of forgotten winters.

Swayam stood before it—silent, still—as if carved from the shadows around him. Frostlight spilled across the curved stone, illuminating the blue engravings on his armor. The black metal hugged his form with jagged elegance, the gauntlets ending just before the knuckles—so that his fingers, bare and pale, looked like sharpened icicles.

The Hengdang blades also known as thunder blades crossed on his back gleamed faintly—an unnatural silver threaded with thin veins of lightning that pulsed in silence, like a heartbeat held underwater.

His face was masked.

The frost-thread helm of Krotha—curved, angular, and stitched with runes from a dead dialect—concealed all but his eyes.

And those eyes?

Blue, yes.

But now rimmed with a subtle yellow flare beneath the iris.

Not natural.

Not frost-born.

But no one watching would know that.

Because this was Krotha, after all.

The scourge of the Northern Reaches.

The Sea-Freezer.

The monster who once, when denied passage through a serpent-infested coastline, froze the ocean for seven nautical miles in every direction—turning entire waves to solid glass and spearing leviathans through their own lungs.

Or so the story went.

And now that monster stood alone.

Unmoving.

Waiting.

Inside Swayam's Mind

The voice came again.

Soft.

Serpentine.

Inside his skull like a whisper threading between his thoughts.

“Do you know why you fight?”

Swayam's jaw tensed beneath the mask.

He didn't answer at first.

Then, cold and flat:

“I don't care.”

A faint chuckle echoed in his brain.

Low. Amused. Familiar.

“Still lying to yourself, child. Exhilarating.”

Then silence.

Swayam didn't blink.

Arena Announcers: Above the Ring

Ignis leaned forward, smoke trailing from his shifting dragon-eyes. “And now, the south gate... opens.”

The stadium lights flared to gold.

Three shadowy figures stepped through.

Team Glazen.

First came Lirael.

The Sonorous Edge.

His robes shimmered like spilled oil beneath moonlight. Hair floating upward, unbothered by gravity. He walked without noise, and yet the sound of his steps harmonized with the arena itself—each footfall a silent note.

In his hand, he carried the blade-harp, unfolded in half-form. Its strings pulsed faintly in vibration.

The crowd didn’t cheer.

They listened.

Because Lirael never demanded applause.

He simply made silence feel expensive.

Then Eirixa.

Rose-gold skin glittering with faint glass-petal shimmer. Her martial silks whispered as she walked, but never dragged. Her feet seemed to barely touch the ground. Every motion—shoulder tilt, glance, even a blink—was choreographed like the brushstroke of a painter who hated imperfection.

She didn’t look at the crowd.

She didn’t need to.

She was the kind of woman you noticed after she passed.

And the kind you bled from if you didn’t.

Finally, Caenel.

The Threadwright.

His eyes were half-closed, as if meditating mid-step. The filigree runes on his coat shimmered in slow gradients of gold and red. His hands moved constantly—fingertips weaving invisible threads as if preparing a ritual none but he could see.

He did not smile.

But he radiated serenity.

The kind that unnerved you.

Like standing next to a library built to house forbidden prayers.

—

Elsa exhaled slowly. “...They’re beautiful.”

Raktabīja smirked. “They’re poison made of silk.”

Ignis added, “And they’ve never lost a team fight.”

—

In the Crowd

The nobles leaned forward.

The lower ranks rose from their seats.

Even the bloodthirsty demons went quiet.

All watching the trio walk in perfect sync toward the center of the ring.

The golden glyphs flared—

TEAM GLAZEN: ENTERED.

Then... the North Gate opened.

But only one figure stepped out.

Just one.

Black-armored.

Frost-masked.

And silent.

Confusion rolled through the stands like a wave.

“Where’s the rest of his team?”

“Is he... going solo?”

“Isn’t that suicide?”

The announcers paused.

Even Raktabīja tilted his head.

Ignis leaned forward. “Hold.”

Elsa gasped. “That’s Krotha. That’s Krotha, right?”

The name rippled across the arena—

“Krotha.”

“The Sea-Freezer.”

“The Frost Demon who hunted dragon-worms barehanded.”

But someone in the noble balcony muttered—

“If he’s so powerful... why did his team only score 50 in Trial 1?”

A few others echoed the question.

A ripple of doubt.

A sneer from a fire-blooded general in the crowd.

“He almost died last round. You sure that’s the real Krotha?”

The ring’s central glyph flared. Challenge data uploaded.

Swayam stepped forward into the light.

One hand raised slightly to unhook both Hengdang blades from his back.

They hummed with electric restraint—small crackles dancing across the edge.

He didn’t raise his voice.

Didn’t shout.

But when he spoke, his words carried:

“You ask why we only scored 50?”

He turned his head slightly toward the noble towers.

The frost mask glinting.

“Because this wasn’t worth more.”

“And you ask why I almost died?”

Now his voice grew colder.

Sharper.

“Because for once... I wanted to feel it. The *thrill*.”

He unsheathed both blades at once.

Electric arcs danced in air.

“None of you were worth using my real powers on.”

“And you still aren’t.”

The lightning from his blades flared behind him—casting his silhouette like a storm’s arrival.

“So I’ll give you a handicap.”

“No frost. Just swords.”

Lirael’s expression shifted.

Not surprise.

But interest.

He turned his harp-blade vertical and said, calmly:

“Finally... something unscripted.”

Eirixa gave no visible response—but one petal bloomed off her sleeve and exploded into glass midair.

Caenel exhaled and spoke like a mantra.

“The false frost may melt... but even lies can cut clean.”

—

Elsa whispered. “...Is he bluffing?”

Raktabīja’s grin widened.

“Who cares? It’s about to be beautiful.”

Ignis leaned in. “Let’s see if this storm... sings.”

A soft hum.

A flicker in the arena’s glyph matrix.

And then—

The Rule Flashed Across the Sky:

“CHALLENGE VARIANT: UNBALANCED CONDITIONS DETECTED.”
VICTORY CONDITIONS: KILL. OR CONCEDE.

The crowd exhaled sharply.

Some cheered.

Others went still.

The rule wasn't new. But it was rare. Rare enough to make even demons squint uneasily.

Three-on-one. No timer. Only survival.

And yet...

No one protested.

Because the man standing in the center—the black-armored silhouette under the frost-mask—wasn't just a fighter.

He was **Krotha**.

And in the stories...

You didn't provoke Krotha.

You didn't question him.

Because the last serpent-warlord that did?

They say he was frozen mid-laugh—entire bloodstream turned to glass—and shattered before he hit the sea floor.

So even those who felt doubt...

Swallowed it.

Hard.

Within Swayam's Mind

The voice returned.

Divine.

Commanding.

Dripping with royalty, echoing from a place older than language.

“Let your senses do the thing.”

It wasn't a suggestion.

It was an invocation.

Swayam's jaw clenched. His lips remained sealed.

"You're not ready to command power. But you are ready to obey instinct."

The voice faded like a king walking away mid-sentence.

Swayam didn't answer.

He wouldn't give it the pleasure.

Instead, he adjusted his grip on the twin Hengdang, their handles warm against his skin—warmer than they should be. Lightning kissed the crossguard, coiled around his wrists like it knew what was coming.

He exhaled once.

And said nothing.

Ignis' voice cut through the silence like a ceremonial gong.

"BEGIN."

The Fight: Opening Movement

Lirael moved first.

His robes barely stirred. His feet didn't even stomp. But the sound that followed—

A low harmonic pulse.

Like the breath of a cathedral.

Swayam's spine snapped straight—not from fear, but from resonance.

Lirael spun his harp-blade outward, strings trembling.

One note.

Two.

Three.

Each layered into the next.

The air around him shimmered with invisible lattice lines—vibrational echoes shaping into frameworks like faint glass prisms.

He wasn't launching attacks.

He was tuning the arena.

Caenel stepped right—fluid, silent.

Thread lines flickered from his fingers, trailing in spirals. Some stuck to the air. Others clung to the ground. Each thread shimmered with a faint memory-burn—gold and crimson, like a sunset strung into silk.

He whispered softly:

“Let the loom remember... how flames fall.”

One flick of his hand—

A wave of thread ignited and sliced forward in three perfect arcs.

Swayam didn't move.

He *blinked*.

Then vanished.

Lightning flash—side dash.

The flames sliced past where he stood a breath ago.

One thread grazed his shoulder pauldron—singed the metal.

Swayam reappeared behind Lirael without a word, blades ready to cleave—

But—

Eirixa was already there.

She didn't make a sound. Didn't shout.

She simply raised her hand.

The air behind Swayam *bloomed*.

Dozens of petalglass shards had followed him—mirrors of her last movement, scattered while he wasn't looking.

They burst.

KRSSSH—!!

Swayam flipped sideways, Hengdang sweeping through the explosion—but thin gashes tore down his flank. Sparks flew as he skidded to a halt, dragging one sword across the floor to slow his slide.

The nobles leaned in.

One leaned to another and muttered, “He's fast. But he's not freezing the air. Something's off—”

A general scoffed. “He’s toying with them.”

A young demon near the back of the arena whispered, “He hasn’t even spoken...”

And somewhere, watching from a private box behind shaded crystal, **Lilith** tilted her wine glass.

“Oh... now this is interesting.”

Back in the Arena

Lirael adjusted the pitch of his harp-blade.

“Too quick for tempo one. Switching to staccato.”

He plucked a high note.

The next moment, five thin vibration strikes shot out—barely visible.

Not beams.

Not slashes.

Just air. Accelerated to the point it hummed death.

Swayam ducked low—one grazed his mask.

CLINK.

The outer left cheek shattered.

Just a fracture.

But visible.

Caenel’s eyes narrowed slightly.

Eirixa didn’t even blink.

Swayam stood again, slowly.

The yellow tint in his eyes flared a little brighter.

He said nothing.

But electricity began to hum under his armor now—not loud. Not showy.

Just... waiting.

He stepped forward once.

The ground beneath cracked faintly.

Then he vanished again.

All three members of Team Glazen turned at once—instinctively converging.

But this time, the strike didn't come from behind.

It came from above.

Swayam descended like a bolt of judgment—both blades ignited with lightning, not frost. Arcs of yellow-blue power spiderwebbed across the arena dome as he swung both Hengdang downward.

Lirael barely got his harp up in time.

CLAAAANG—!!

The sound that followed wasn't just metallic.

It was music breaking apart.

One of Lirael's strings snapped.

The impact cratered the floor. Petals, threads, and lattice all fractured under the raw force.

Swayam landed in a crouch.

Eyes glowing.

Mask cracked.

Breathing calm.

His voice finally came—quiet, cold, and carved from thunder.

“You three move like dancers.”

He looked up, one blade still sparking.

“Let's see how you fall.”

A burst of cheers.

Then silence again.

And tension.

Some demons shouted for blood. Others stared, uncertain. A few nobles leaned forward, curious now. Suspicious. The murmurs began to form a wave.

“He's not using frost...”

“That thunder—those are lightning channels...”

“Is this a trick? Or... something new?”

In the betting boxes, nobles scrambled.

“Triple favor on Glazen!”

“Double odds if Krotha takes one down alone!”

Coins and blood chips traded hands. Eyes narrowed.

Lilith, from her private booth, sipped her wine with a new kind of smile.

“So the frost demon burns. Intriguing.”

In the Arena – Lirael’s Memory

The dissonant strike still vibrated in Lirael’s chest.

He blinked once—and in the blink, memory bled through.

A silver chamber.

A sculpture breaking in silence.

His mother whispering:

“If you want applause for chaos, join a circus.”

Lirael tightened his grip on the harp-blade.

No more echoes.

With a sudden shift, he stepped into his own tempo.

He plucked once—

And the air between them shattered.

A harmonic burst compressed into a ripple of force. Swayam darted sideways, lightning chaining across his heel, blades up. But Lirael didn’t stop.

One step forward.

Another note.

This one **resonated** through Swayam’s ribs. The sound didn’t strike—it entered.

He staggered.

Blood surged in his ears. The sound was inside his body.

Lirael’s eyes narrowed.

He began the next chord.

But—

KRZAAAACK—!

A bolt of lightning struck from Swayam’s back, frying the air between them.

Lirael broke his pattern and leapt back, mid-rhythm.

“He’s redirecting internal flow,” he muttered. “Smart.”

Eirixa’s feet barely touched the floor.

She moved like a falling petal.

And from her sleeves, glass-shard blossoms bloomed.

Thirty petals in one breath.

Each spinning, flashing.

She whispered something—

And they began to *orbit* Swayam, tightening like a glittering gyre of razors.

He exhaled.

Let the storm inside him quiet, just for a second.

He didn’t need to fight the petals. He needed them to misfire.

He stepped forward once.

Petals surged in.

Then—

Nothing hit.

The petals crashed into each other—collapsing like shards of mist against pressure-shift.

Swayam had used a faint burst of downward wind from his lightning pulse—reverberating like a magnetic coil—just enough to warp their arc mid-flight.

One shard nicked his cheek.

Just enough to bleed.

But not enough to stop him.

Eirixa frowned.

That... was new.

A Glimpse of Eirixa’s Past

A garden of glass and silence.

Silk carpets that tore under careless steps.

She was five when her grandmother told her:

“Beauty is sharp.”

She was seven when she smiled too wide—and was told to unlearn it.

She was ten when she improvised in the Festival of Blooming Swords—and was never congratulated.

She didn’t seek praise anymore.

Only precision.

Only perfection.

And yet—

This boy, this *man*, was ruining the flow. The fight wasn’t elegant.

It was... messy.

She hated it.

She loved it.

Caenel Moves

He didn’t sprint. He didn’t jump.

He simply *walked* forward.

Threads of silver-orange flame coiled behind his every step.

One in each hand.

They wove like memories.

“This is the part,” he whispered, “where garments begin to tear.”

One thread snapped outward—burning straight toward Swayam’s ankles.

Another twisted behind—targeting his shadow.

Swayam responded not with a strike, but a pulse.

He grounded both blades, sending lightning through the earth. Not upward—but sideways.

It surged along the arena floor—like a mimicry of thread, short-circuiting the thread lines for a blink.

Caenel paused.

Brows slightly furrowed.

Inside Caenel's mind something, a memory flashed.

A loom.

A shawl burning.

A voice saying:

“Too personal. Too warm.”

Flames licking the corners of a memorycloth.

His own breath held in silence.

He was six when they burned the quilt.

Thirteen when he forged a shawl of his own birth.

Seventeen when he left.

Not for rage.

But for *beauty that didn't apologize*.

Now he stood against Krotha—or whoever wore the name.

And for the first time...

His fingers ached to know what this man's threads would reveal.

Back to Swayam

He circled now.

Breath shallow.

Eyes darting.

One cracked mask. Three adversaries. All masters.

I can't beat them all together, he thought.

But I don't need to.

I don't have to kill. I just have to break the rhythm. Make them choose.

A performer doesn't stop playing.

But an artist... can be made to drop the brush.

He moved again—low, fast, this time straight at Caenel.

Lightning danced across his boots.

Not to strike.

To *trip* the thread-loops and force dissonance into the design.

If he could disrupt Caenel's confidence in his pattern...

That would start the fall.

Announcers' Tower

Elsa leaned forward, eyes shining.

"He's not fighting like a demon."

Raktabija growled, one claw drumming the table.

"He's breaking their rhythm."

Ignis grinned.

"A storm doesn't need to be cruel. It just has to make you stop dancing."

All four fighters in motion.

Swayam, crouched low, one sword dragged like a lightning rod, the other pulsing with warning.

Lirael tuning a chaotic chord, petals hovering near Eirixa's crown like a circling crown of knives.

Caenel's fingers spinning fast, faster—uncertain for the first time in years.

Above them—

A glyph flared:

"2 Minutes Elapsed."

Below that:

"Advantage: Undecided."

And somewhere deep in Swayam's mind—

The voice returned.

Softer now.

"You don't have to kill."

"But you may have to break."

Swayam said nothing.

But the next bolt of lightning crackled with a choice.

"You don't have to kill."
"But you may have to break."

The voice faded like it never belonged there.

Swayam said nothing.

But the next bolt of lightning crackled from his fingertips—not wild, not wrathful. Controlled. Composed. Committed.

He dragged the blade along the ground.

A current jumped. Threads trembled. Petals spun backward. And Team Glazen blinked—just once—as the tempo shifted.

Lirael adjusted his stance first.

He didn't retreat. He *leaned* forward, blade-harp parallel to his chest, lips curling into a smirk.

"You think lightning sings? Let's make it weep."

He played again—but this time, *not* as a soloist.

He played as a **conductor**.

The strings vibrated—not just to attack, but to **guide**.

A resonance lattice shimmered behind him—and Eirixa responded instantly. Her petals adjusted. Slower, more deliberate. She slid behind Caenel, whose threads began to dance in rhythm with Lirael's beat.

It wasn't choreography anymore.

It was a **war symphony**.

And for a few seconds...

Swayam was alone in its center.

Inside the Crowd

The nobles rose.

Not out of fear.

But anticipation.

"They're syncing. Full tri-form. I haven't seen it since the Quarter Trials."

"Poor bastard's done now. Even Krotha can't solo this."

On the other side, gamblers doubled down. Chips, jewels, even **favor contracts** were passed around.

Lilith leaned closer to her crystal feed. Her eyes gleamed violet.

“Now the art begins,” she whispered.

Even Ignis sat up straight in the tower.

“Oh ho... It’s no longer a fight.”

Elsa grinned.

“It’s an ensemble performance.”

Raktabīja bared his bloodied teeth.

“Then let’s see who forgets the steps first.”

Back in the Arena

Swayam exhaled once—slow and deliberate.

Then dove straight into the storm.

Lirael's lattice fired a pulse.

Swayam sidestepped.

Caenel's threads snapped forward like whips.

He ducked low, then rolled.

Petals came from all sides—exploding midair, disorienting his vision.

Swayam gritted his teeth. Sparks jumped from his fingertips, shorting the air just enough to flicker his silhouette—and he used the flicker to mislead Caenel’s aim.

Snap—!

One thread carved through his shoulder pauldron.

He winced.

Blood. Shallow.

Still standing.

Still moving.

He wasn’t winning.

But he wasn’t dying.

Inside His Mind

*They're fighting harder now.
Not to kill me. But to prove something—to someone else.
They're not just warriors. They're... prisoners of their legacy.
Good.
Chains can be snapped.*

— *Lirael's past flashes again*

The Vaults of Celareth. A boy alone, playing dissonant notes that cracked the walls. A mother's silence. A thousand echoes judged and remade.

"Let the world hear a requiem it cannot forget."

He didn't fight to kill.

He fought to **compose** a legacy.

— *Eirixa's silence hides a storm*

Daggered smiles. Garden duels. The look of shame when she improvised her own survival. Her robes bled roses. But no one told her she did well. They told her she was *messy*.

"Let me bloom where perfection is not safe."

She didn't fight for victory.

She fought for the right to be *ugly* in bloom.

— *Caenel stands calm, but remembers flames*

A memorycloth. His own heartbeat stitched into silk. Burned. Rejected. Flame-kissed hands now weaving death.

"My family wants me to weave the past. I want to cut the future."

He didn't fight for his name.

He fought to create something **unrepeatable**.

While fighting Swayam mind rushed with observations and calculations.

He absorbed it in flashes.

*Lirael hesitates if the pattern breaks.
Eirixa flinches when she feels elegance slip.
Caenel gets slower when unsure of symmetry.*

*They're dancers who fear falling ugly.
Then I'll give them an audience that doesn't clap.*

He smiled under his cracked mask.

Then blurred again.

This time **on purpose**.

He leapt left—but stumbled. Deliberately.

Let himself roll too far.

Caenel fired a thread straight into the ground—

And missed.

Eirixa's petals closed in—only to strike where he wasn't.

Lirael tuned a chord—

And the echo flared a beat late.

Swayam had **broken the rhythm**.

Not with violence.

But with **uncertainty**.

Somewhere far from the battle

A hallway lit by flickering crystal runes.

The smell of antiseptic and iron.

Rachit stepped out of a darkened chamber, breath steady, tank top torn down one side, a smear of something not-quite-blood across his wrist.

His reddish-brown eyes scanned the corridor.

Rod-blades strapped to his back in an X formation. His skin glistened faintly. Like something had just dried off him.

His expression?

Blank.

But sharp.

The kind of blank that **followed horror**, not preceded it.

He turned left—

A hand landed on his shoulder.

“You said you were going out to take a leak,” Scar’s voice drawled behind him, teeth flashing.
“But this part of the compound is a long damn way from the bathrooms.”

Rachit didn’t flinch.

Didn’t turn.

He just said, flatly:

“And what are you doing here?”

Scar laughed.

“Hunger. Came for food.”

He turned toward the door Rachit had just left.

“Thought this was the kitchen.”

The room was dark.

But something dripped from the frame.

Scar blinked.

Then grinned.

“Wait... is this the kitchen?”

He stepped inside.

One step.

Two.

Then his eyes adjusted.

—

Corpses.

Dismembered.

Boiled.

Hung from hooks.

Some human.

Some demon.

Some *indistinguishable*.

A chef’s apron was folded neatly in the corner.

But the body wearing it had no head.

Flesh turned to **mush** on the floor.

The cages that once held live-stocked meat?

Empty.

The humans?

Dead.

Every. Single. One.

And Rachit—

Had no blood on him.

No visible blade.

But Scar turned and looked at the boy's back.

The way he walked.

Not fast.

Not sneaky.

Just... precise.

Predator-quiet.

Scar chuckled.

Darkly.

"Hah... Are you sure you're human?"

He licked one tooth.

"Not some cast-off Howler-blood kin?"

Rachit didn't answer.

Just kept walking left.

Never looked back.

Scar turned fully to the room. Looked at the mess. Smiled wider.

"If you are what I think..."

He whispered to the hanging flesh.

"I'd *love* to skin you alive."

Then licked his lips.

And laughed.

Cut Back to the Arena

Blood now kissed the arena floor.

Not much.

But more than before.

Petal wounds along Swayam's left leg.

A scorch on his hip.

A thread-burn near the rib.

Lirael's lip was split.

Caenel's sleeve torn.

Eirixa's petals no longer pristine—they bled mist now.

The crowd was silent again.

Because what they were seeing...

Was not a performance.

Not anymore.

It was **exposure**.

All three of Glazen had begun to *breathe harder*.

To miss beats.

Their faces—once masks of calm—now showed hints of *frustration*. Of doubt.

Swayam stood still.

Breathing shallow.

But his eyes gleamed with something strange.

Not fury.

Not glee.

Hope.

They're beginning to question themselves.

He twirled one blade.

Charged the other.

Lightning danced around his shoulders.

“I don’t want to kill you,” he muttered.

“But I will make you stop pretending this was ever a stage.”

A single glyph flared above the ring:

5 Minutes Elapsed.

Blood Threshold: Initiated.

Ignis stood slowly.

“The tempo is shattering...”

Elsa’s lips parted.

“Who will break first?”

Raktabīja leaned in.

Smiled.

“The storm still hasn’t spoken its name.”

“The tempo is shattering...”

Elsa’s lips trembled around the words—more breath than voice.

A sharp glint passed through her eyes. Not fear. Fascination.

“Who will break first?”

Raktabīja leaned in, jaw rigid with joy.

“The storm still hasn’t spoken its name.”

And then—

It did.

Not in words.

Not yet.

But in presence.

Swayam stood in the center of the broken lattice—the ring beneath him cracked, still humming with residual resonance from Glazen’s full-form harmony.

His armor was bruised.

One Hengdang blade glowed white-hot with charge.

The other dripped faint, sizzling trails of his own blood.

His mask was half gone now—jagged edges revealing a tight, joyless smile. His reddish-brown skin was flushed with lightning glow beneath. One eye flickered yellow under stress. The other was pure focus.

Then—

He chuckled.

It was quiet.

And it cut through the air like a glass dagger.

“This... this is all I needed?”

He stepped forward. Just a step.

But each click of his heel on the scorched stone echoed like a nail on crystal.

Lirael tensed. His fingers hovered over his harp, but hesitated.

Eirixa stood poised, petals trembling at her sleeves—yet her eyes darted to her comrades.

Caenel shifted subtly back, one hand near his threads... the other clenched at his side.

Swayam’s voice came again.

Cool.

Amused.

Cruel in its calm.

“You know... I haven’t even used my frost powers yet.”

His smile widened slightly.

“This? This is just warm-up. I’ve only been using my swords.”

He raised one Hengdang.

Lightning arced between the two blades—loud enough that several audience members flinched. The crackling hum built behind his voice like a storm building pressure.

“You should’ve given up when it was elegant.”

“Now it’s going to get... ugly.”

The crowd

Gasped.

Murmured.

Even nobles began to lean back—some whispering.

“He’s bluffing, right?”

“NO way he hasn’t gone all out right?”

A few demons exchanged nervous glances.

Even Lilith paused in her sip.

She tilted her head. Her lip curled.

“Either he’s lying...”

“Or evolution finally got interesting.”

In the Ring

Swayam advanced another step, spinning one blade with relaxed fingers.

He tilted his head toward Team Glazen.

“Let’s try something else.”

“Why do you fight?”

He pointed his blade directly at Lirael.

“Is it for power?”

He turned toward Caenel.

“For legacy?”

Then toward Eirixa.

“Or is it because someone told you... you weren’t enough?”

None of them answered.

Not yet.

So Swayam continued.

His tone became sharper—more needling.

Mocking, without raising his voice.

“Do you want fame? Honor? Recognition?”

“Or are you just dancing for the dead?”

“Tell me, golden children of Celareth... what are you proving?”

Lirael’s teeth clenched.

He stepped forward.

“We fight to leave behind something better. To make sure our names echo in more than bloodlines.”

Swayam’s eyes lit up.

He laughed.

Not mocking now.

But—deeply entertained.

“Echo, huh?”

He twirled a blade and flicked a spark across the floor.

“Funny.”

“Because when I strike, I don’t echo.”

“I erase.”

He stepped forward again.

Now only ten feet from them.

Caenel’s hands twitched.

Eirixa’s petals began to orbit again—but slower. Hesitant.

Swayam’s eyes narrowed.

“Let me guess. You each trained for years. Your families gave you power, legacy, expectation... and not once did you ever ask yourself if you *wanted* it.”

He flared lightning in both hands.

“Do you know what I wanted?”

A pause.

Then a smile—painful, honest.

“Nothing.”

“I didn’t want to be a hero. Or a villain. Or a legend. I didn’t want to ‘carry’ anything.”

“But life doesn’t give a damn what you want.”

“It just puts weight in your hands.”

“So the only thing left to do...”

He raised both swords.

The ground beneath him cracked—electric fissures exploding outward.

“...is *cut back*.”

Swayam Charges

Lightning exploded behind his legs as he dashed.

This time—

Not silent.

Not subtle.

He *roared*.

A low growl that built with every step, until it turned into a rising scream of storm.

He leapt toward Caenel first—blades spinning.

Caenel threw three thread-shields.

Swayam crashed through all of them in one spinning arc.

The final shield shattered on impact—flame exploding around them.

Swayam used the fire to vanish into smoke—

And reappeared behind Eirixa.

She gasped—barely flicking a blossom shield in place. The petals blocked the strike—

But Swayam didn’t retreat.

He *stepped through* the explosion.

His mask cracked further.

Now fully exposed.

Sweat trickled down his cheek. Blood streaked the corner of his jaw.

But his eyes—those strange yellow-tinted eyes—were locked onto Lirael now.

“You’re next.”

Lirael played a harmony—

But it came half a beat late.

Swayam struck his blade into the arena floor and redirected his lightning upward—into the strings.

CRAAAAK—!!

The harp screamed.

Lirael winced, stepping back.

All three of them now bled.

Barely standing.

Still breathing.

But the rhythm?

Gone.

Swayam Stands Still

He looked at them—one by one.

His breath heavy.

But not heaving.

His posture unshaken.

His words, now softer.

“Tell me.”

“Is this what greatness feels like?”

He didn’t mock now.

He **meant it**.

He wanted them to ask themselves.

To hurt.

To doubt.

To crack.

Lirael looked down at his broken harp.

His fingers trembled.

He whispered, as if to himself:

“I thought... I was past this.”

Eirixa clutched her shoulder, petals half-bloomed, blinking into the heat.

She whispered:

“It wasn’t supposed to look like this...”

Caenel’s threads hovered in front of him—but he didn’t command them.

He stared at Swayam.

Quiet.

Expression unreadable.

Then softly:

“Did we ever want this? Or just... never want to fail?”

Inside Swayam’s Mind the voice whispered

“You really aren’t a hero.”

Swayam didn’t flinch.

He blinked once.

“I know that.”

“Better than anyone else.”

Team Glazen remained on their feet.

But their eyes weren’t on Swayam anymore.

They were on the ground.

Or the past.

Or the question that had been buried for years and now screamed for air.

They weren’t beaten.

But they’d stopped fighting.

Swayam didn’t lift his sword.

He didn’t need to.

The silence was louder than any blow.

And when he finally turned—

Lightning still humming through his blades—

He whispered,

“Fight me again... when you're no longer pretending.”

And walked past them.

As the arena lights dimmed.

And the world watched—

A storm that didn't kill.

Just shattered.

The lightning faded.

Slowly.

Like a theatre's final light dimming after the actors had forgotten their lines.

Swayam stood there—alone, untouched in presence but blood-scraped across the ribs and calves. His hair clung to his forehead in wet, black strands. The remnants of the frost mask clung to one side of his face like broken porcelain.

Team Glazen hadn't moved.

Lirael stared at his shattered harp, chest rising and falling with uneven breath.

Eirixa's petals floated in midair like orphaned butterflies. Her hands trembled, not from pain—but from something else.

From doubt.

Caenel's threads hovered like ghosts. They flickered at his fingertips, but he never gave them an order.

Three noble-blooded champions, raised above the clouds—

Now held hostage by a single man's words.

And still—

Swayam didn't raise a blade.

He didn't press forward.

Instead, he turned around.

Walked five steps.

Then stopped.

Right in the center of the ring.

He glanced toward the audience—his eyes narrow, the faint yellow in them almost glowing now.

The silence stretched taut.

And then...

He said, loudly and clearly:

“I give up.”

The entire arena flinched as if struck.

A half-second of disbelieving silence followed—

Before the explosion of noise.

Elsa stood so suddenly her chair fell behind her.

“Wait—what?! He... he what?!”

Ignis sat frozen, the heat aura around him pulsing irregularly.

“Did he just... surrender?”

Raktabīja’s expression didn’t move. He merely tilted his head, one talon flexing.

“No...”

“He played them.”

The nobles roared in outrage.

“He could’ve won!”

“He dominated them!”

“Is this a trick?!”

“What kind of frost demon surrenders!?”

Demons in the eastern stands spat toward the ring.

One warlord howled with fury, slamming his goblet to the floor.

Another slammed a bet-slip down and shouted,

“Fifty platinum on that coward! He SCAMMED us!”

And then—

Swayam turned his head again.

Faced the stands directly.

He smiled.

Not warmly.

Not cruelly.

Mockingly.

His voice rose again—just loud enough to carry.

“Why would I waste my time finishing off three broken kids from floating ivory towers?”

His words weren’t venom.

They were dismissal.

Casual.

Cold.

His tone was the sound of a lion ignoring insects.

“I’ve got a thousand better things to do than entertain doubters with delusions.”

He raised one hand and *brushed it sideways*, as if brushing the entire arena away.

“You all wanted Krotha?”

“You got Krotha.”

“And Krotha doesn’t need to *win* when no one here is worth the full extent of his frost.”

He chuckled.

“Be grateful I even drew my swords.”

And then—

He turned his back on all of them.

On Team Glazen.

On the announcers.

On the arena.

And walked toward the North Gate.

At first the crowd showed: confusion.

But then—

Hesitation.

“He didn’t *lose*...”

“He let them go.”

“He mocked us.”

“He... held back?”

The lie was sinking in.

Swayam’s deception wasn’t just in words.

It was in posture.

In silence.

In the way he *walked away* without fear.

The nobles, one by one, began to stop shouting.

Some nodded.

One whispered:

“That was Krotha.”

“Had to be.”

“No one else would dare insult *us* and get away with it.”

Above the Arena – Glyph Matrix Update

The golden glyphs in the sky shimmered.

The match data poured in—laced with coded judgment from the Malakour codex, audience reaction data, combat velocity, resonance breakage, psychological damage, and fear pulses.

And then—

It all froze.

Final glyphs formed in the air, glowing with finality.

MATCH COMPLETE

WINNER: **TEAM GLAZEN** – BY FORFEIT

TEAM GLAZEN

- ▶ Trial 1 Points: 100
- ▶ Trial 2 Points Earned: 0
- ▶ **Total: 100**

TEAM KROTHA

- ▶ Trial 1 Points: 50
 - ▶ Trial 2 Points Earned: 200
 - ▶ **Total: 250**
-

Backstage – Swayam Smiling Alone

Swayam passed through the corridor's threshold.

The glyph wall closed behind him with a hydraulic hiss.

He exhaled.

Finally.

The frost demon mask shattered fully in his hands.

He placed the Hengdang blades in their back slots and leaned briefly against the wall.

He didn't smile like a winner.

He didn't grin like a liar.

He closed his eyes.

And for just a second—

He let the exhaustion show.

Then he whispered:

"Two hundred."

"Seven-fifty more..."

Within a sealed stone chamber behind the arena's nerve center, the scoring attendants—Malakour scribes with chain-bound limbs—whispered to one another, reviewing the encoded pulse impressions of the match.

One stared at Swayam's fear signature reading.

It was flat.

Emotionless.

Like the entire match didn't register on his nerves.

He turned to the others.

"That's not frost control."

"That's something else entirely."

The others didn't respond.

The glyphs had already been sealed.

The ruling entered the archive.

It was official.

Team Krotha: 250 points.

The path to a wildcard entry was open.

Only 750 more needed.

Cut to the Medical Ward – Anshika Stirring

A distant hum echoed through the room.

Yugetsu sat beside Anshika's pod, chewing his nails silently, eyes darting between the glowing scorefeed and her healing pulse.

Her hand twitched.

Once.

Then stilled again.

Yugetsu whispered under his breath:

"He did it..."

Then louder, but still trembling:

"Just hold on, Anshika."

"He's making a path... one lie at a time."

Meanwhile – Team Glazen

Lirael sat on a medical cot, harp shattered across his lap.

Eirixa stared at the blood-stained petals in her hands.

Caenel hadn't moved in fifteen minutes.

No one spoke.

Finally, Lirael whispered:

“Did we lose?”

Eirixa shook her head slowly.

“No.”

“But I’m not sure we won either.”

Caenel’s voice finally came, low and hollow.

“He broke our tempo.”

“Not with strength...”

“With... questions.”

And they sat there—still champions.

But haunted.

By a storm that didn’t need to finish them.

Only **remind them** of what they feared becoming.

Swayam stood beneath the glowing banners of the tournament’s rotating scoreboard.

His name was not listed.

Only **Krotha**.

Next match: unknown.

Time until next trial: 48 hours.

He leaned on the wall, exhaled.

Then smiled.

Sincerely.

Softly.

“I’ll get there.”

“For us.”

He opened his eyes

And walked away.

The storm had passed.

But its shadow was just beginning to bloom.

CHAPTER 4 ENDED

CHAPTER 5 – THINK

The corridor felt colder than it should have.

Swayam walked in silence, his boots clicking against the obsidian-tiled floor of the arena's upper hallway. Demons—hulking, sharp-eyed, infernal beings who'd tear flesh without hesitation—stepped out of his path without a word. They didn't sneer. They didn't whisper. They gave way.

Not to him.

But to Krotha.

He slid a smaller frost mask from his side pouch—sleek, matte, silver-lined at the edges with an open lower half for breath. Not the one he'd worn into battle, but one more... medical. Mysterious. A mask a demon hunter might wear when examining a corpse or visiting plague-ridden battlefields. He tightened its clasp behind his ears as he walked, a low static hum buzzing from his armor's blue-etched surface. Sparks danced briefly at his shoulder—residue lightning leaking through the Hengdang blades mounted across his back.

Swayam didn't stop.

Didn't blink.

Only walked.

Each step was deliberate. Each breath measured. Behind the eye slots of his mask, his yellow-tinted blue eyes burned like suppressed thunder.

He reached the medical wing.

The doors hissed open.

The scent hit first. **Medicinal herbs**—clovegrass, numbing nectar, and vaporized vaxa leaves—curled through the air. Beneath it, faint antiseptic. Sterile, clinical. Clean.

The white marble flooring shimmered under the magelight panels above. The walls were pale ivory, lined with vines trapped in crystalline vases, glowing with soft, bioluminescent petals. Medical scrolls floated midair, unraveling and rewriting themselves with prāṇ diagnostics in flowing glyphs.

Six beds lined the room. Three occupied. One couch.

Swayam paused at the threshold, then stepped inside.

Yugetsu was the first to speak.

He sat cross-legged on a low stool near Anshika's couch, his multi-layered coat draped like silk armor. His grey eyes, barely covered the mental exhaustion.

“They’ll survive,” Yugetsu said, without looking up. “Medics said the Gomukh glacial ice water is stabilizing Gaurav’s internal burn levels. Aviral should wake tomorrow. Gaurav... three days minimum. Maybe more.”

Swayam said nothing.

He stepped forward, gaze scanning.

Aviral lay slumped in bed, chest wrapped in translucent healing silk, prāṇ-sutures pulsing over his exposed shoulder. Tubes snaked from his wrist and neck—blood, glucose, and a third with a faint icy glow that pulsed with soft blue light. He twitched once, his mouth murmuring something in sleep.

Gaurav... was worse.

The entire upper half of his body was encased in reinforced bandage wrap, his ribs compressed under a pale yellow shield of rune-stabilized bone adhesive. His right arm was twisted into a resting cast, half-eaten by a prāṇ-infusion scaffold that hummed like a low heartbeat.

The tube feeding him glacial fluid—Gomukh ice water—gleamed like liquid diamonds. Each drop sizzled as it met the red-orange flames beneath his skin, cooling him inch by inch.

The boy looked more like a burned out torch than a fighter.

And then there was Nyss.

Unmoving.

Lying in the bed furthest from the door, her face serene—too serene. Like she wasn’t sleeping, but dreaming. Swayam’s jaw tightened beneath the mask. The glyphs floating above her chest were still running in loops.

Devouring Path: Trial One Residual Illusion - Heaven Locked Sequence - Termination Not Achieved

The system hadn’t freed her yet.

She was still lost in that realm.

Still eating illusions.

Still surviving.

Swayam’s fingers brushed past the chart at the table’s edge. He picked it up, sat beside Anshika on the couch, and scanned it.

INTERNAL REPORT: MEDICAL DIAGNOSTICS – NYSS, AVIRAL, GAURAV

- *Nyss*: Trapped in Devouring Path – Heaven Variant (non-lethal, but energy-intensive). Heart rate stable. No external injuries. Drain on prāṇ: 0.3% per hour.

- *Aviral*: 17 bone fractures. 12 muscular ruptures. Internal bruising. No permanent damage. Projected Recovery: 30 hours.
- *Gaurav*: 44 fractures. Skull micro-fracture (left temple). Cardiac trauma. Over 50 torn muscle groups. Internal bleeding contained. Heart stabilized using Gomukh Prāṇ Mesh. Projected Recovery: 72–96 hours.

Swayam read it all in silence.

Yugetsu leaned forward. “You’re thinking something.”

“No,” Swayam said. He set the report down, eyes still lingering on Gaurav. “I’m remembering.”

“Remembering what?”

“How many bones we had... the last time we left for this hell.”

Yugetsu snorted. “Guess Gaurav wanted to set a record.”

Anshika stirred slightly beside him, groaning.

Swayam turned. Her head shifted, cheek brushing against the couch cushion. Her face was pale, and her lips were cracked, but there was breath in her chest. Her fingers twitched.

He didn’t speak. Just let her rest.

From the hallway, the sound of laughter echoed. Drunken demons. Swayam’s eyes flicked once to the door.

Yugetsu followed his gaze.

“You saw the betting zone?”

“Yeah.”

“They put down twenty-two million silver coins on Gaurav surviving. Twelve million on Aviral. Almost thirty on Nyss waking up.”

Swayam nodded slowly. “So they’ll live.”

Yugetsu shrugged. “You know how it works. When money gets involved... even nobles become healers.”

Swayam stood, the couch creaking beneath him. He walked toward Gaurav’s bedside and paused. The boy’s face—so often cocky and full of fire—was still.

His bandaged arm twitched once.

And Swayam spoke—not loudly, but enough.

“Next time,” he whispered, “try not to shatter your heart for a point.”

He gave him a last glance—not of pity, but a silent promise—and made his way toward the adjoining bathroom.

“Yugetsu,” he said, his voice calm but distant, “Call the medics. Tell them I’m ready.”

Yugetsu gave a nod without words, understanding the weight behind them.

The bathroom door shut with a soft click. No locking sound. Just a pause in reality.

White tiles. Warm lights. A silver basin.

Swayam stood before the mirror, both palms pressing onto the cold metal. His frost mask stared back at him. The mask he wore not for hiding... but for surviving.

He lifted it slowly—first from the chin, then over the bridge of his nose—revealing the face of a boy barely older than those lying unconscious outside.

Bruised ribs ached beneath his armor. His thigh throbbed where the petal shards had cut through his movement. The burns along his shoulder still pulsed from Caenel’s flame-threads. Blood had dried in places the medics hadn’t yet touched.

But the pain wasn’t what brought his breath short.

It was the guilt.

The mirror caught everything: the flicker in his pupils, the stiff line of his jaw, the twitch in his cheek as he recalled Devouring Path. The screams. Gaurav’s broken body. Aviral’s limp hand reaching in that final blow. Anshika—trapped in illusions, wounds visible and invisible.

Then, there was Rachit.

Somewhere in another pocket of hell. Alone. Unreachable.

Swayam exhaled, slowly. Fog spread across the glass.

“This tournament,” he whispered to his reflection, “isn’t just about victory.”

His voice cracked, once.

“I was supposed to lead. I was supposed to... protect them.”

His hands trembled—just slightly. Then steadied.

He looked deeper into the mirror. Into the man behind the pain. Into the boy who refused to die in the dark.

Then, softly but firmly, he murmured:

“Rise up.”

The mirror stayed silent.

He repeated it, jaw tightening. “Don’t give in.”

His palm slammed the edge of the basin.

“Rise the fuck up.”

His eyes locked in. Bloodshot, hollow—but unwavering.

“Over this hell... we’ll build something better.”

He stayed like that for several seconds. Eyes narrowed. The last tremble leaving his fingers.

Then came the knock.

“Swayam,” Yugetsu’s voice was low. “They’re here.”

Swayam stepped out slowly, mask in hand but not yet on.

Two demon medics followed Yugetsu, one carrying a gleaming white briefcase of potions, the other levitating a diagnostic orb. Both halted the moment they saw him.

He didn’t speak. Just sat where Yugetsu had been earlier, rolling up the sleeve on his injured arm.

The cracked forearm was revealed—darkened with impact, threads of discoloration spidering down to his wrist. A threadmark from Caenel’s construct.

“Leave the mask,” the older medic suggested gently.

Swayam’s eyes narrowed.

“Fix the bones. Leave the rest.”

He pulled the mask over his face. Snapped it in place with a quiet, deliberate sound.

The medics exchanged a brief glance. Professional. Wordless. Then began.

The healing salve hissed as it touched his burns. The glowing gel stitched the torn skin at his thigh. One whispered chant re-aligned the cracks in his forearm. The bandages layered themselves into place like silk snakes wrapping a warrior’s wounds.

He winced once when they dabbed a glyph-activator to reset his rib alignment.

“You took these hits and walked?” one of them muttered. “What sort of frost demon are you—”

“I’m the kind that doesn’t explain,” Swayam cut in. Not hostile, just final.

The room fell quiet.

Yugetsu watched from the wall, arms folded. He saw the slight shake in Swayam’s shoulder when the medic pressed against his ribs—but didn’t say a word.

When they finished, one medic handed him a flask.

“For energy retention,” he said.

Swayam took it, nodded once, but didn’t drink.

Instead, he looked around at the beds again—his team still lost in their own storms.

His thoughts drifted briefly.

Gaurav, Aviral, Anshika, Nyss, Rachit.

Then back to himself.

The frost mask remained. The face beneath it didn't matter right now.

What mattered... was the war ahead.

And the monsters who would never see him fall.

Two days passed.

The white of the medical room remained untouched. Not a scuff on the marble. Not a wilt in the vases. But the air—tension-thick, held the unspoken weight of recovery, of waiting, of watching.

Aviral was the first to stir. He had woken up just under twelve hours after Swayam's silent vigil ended, groaning into consciousness with a snark that sounded half-choked and half-heroic.

"Has anyone seen my staff I think I'll need it to walk?" he had rasped.

Now, Gaurav was up too. Forty hours after the match, his eyes fluttered open slowly. Vision blurred, head pounding. But alive. Awake.

His first words?

"...I'm not dead, right? 'Cause if I am, this heaven smells a lot like Yugetsu's hair oil."

Yugetsu—cross-legged on his usual stool, face unreadable—blinked slowly. "...You're not dead. Yet."

Gaurav smirked and tried to sit up—grimacing as every tendon in his body screamed in protest. "Good. Then give me five minutes and a bowl of dried roots. I'll kill the scoreboard myself."

Across the room, the hologlyph shimmered into life again.

This time, not a match replay.

News.

The projection flared with the stamped glyph of authority: **Malakour Enforcement – Arrest Notice.**

A deep-voiced announcer read over dramatic tones:

"Under Rule 93, Section C of Arena Sanctity Law—Scar, registered participant of Trial 2, is hereby taken into custody under suspicion of violating sacred non-combat zones by... executing the cooking staff."

The hologlyph flickered to footage—low resolution, but undeniable. Scar, arms chained, walking out of the culinary zone with a grin that sent ice into every watching vein.

And beside him—silent as dusk—stood Rachit.

Expression unreadable. Lips pressed thin. Eyes far, but unblinking.

A group of Malakour enforcers escorted them both

Yugetsu narrowed his eyes. "...Scar got arrested?"

Aviral frowned. "Wait—why the hell would he kill kitchen staff? I mean, I get his whole murder-aesthetic, but chefs?"

"Even they took Rachit with them," Gaurav muttered. "That's... not adding up."

Yugetsu shifted on his stool, arms folded, voice tightening.

"...Do you guys think maybe... it wasn't Scar?"

Silence.

A moment later, Yugetsu added in a quieter tone, his strange slit-pupiled eyes narrowing, "...What if it was Rachit? What if he's trying to get rid of Scar cause he might be the reason he is away?"

A sudden breath broke the air.

From behind them, on the couch, Anshika sat up.

She hadn't moved in over a week. Her body had been as still as a statue, her eyes shut, trapped in an illusion.

But now—

She sat. Slowly. Eyes open.

Her voice was flat. Measured. Like cracked porcelain.

"...It wasn't me."

Yugetsu fell off his stool with a small yelp. Aviral spilled the cup of water in his hand. Gaurav jerked in bed, wincing from the sudden movement.

They stared at her.

Something about her expression—blank yet focused, composed yet off—struck deep into them.

She wasn't blinking. Her hands rested in her lap like she'd never been unconscious at all.

But her posture... the silence behind her eyes...

Aviral whispered, "Wait a second..."

Yugetsu scrambled back up, pointing with trembling fingers. "Something's not right. That—That isn't her. That's not *how* she wakes up."

Then—

The door opened.

Soft footsteps.

And in stepped the one they thought had been awake all this time.

Rachit.

Torn blue tank top, now even more ripped than before. His grey harem pants were dust-streaked. The crossed rods on his back glinted faintly under the sterile light.

He was smiling.

Not a smirk.

A smile.

And that alone shook them.

He never smiled.

Genuine joy flickered across his bruised but sharp face as he looked at the girl on the couch.

“Sorry,” he said softly. “Took longer than I expected.”

He walked over—his movements smooth, familiar—and removed the rods from his back.

He placed them gently into the seated girl’s lap.

As her fingers touched the rods, a ripple passed through her. Her face shifted, twitched, cracked, her eyes started changing its colour to reddish brown...

And just like that—

The illusion broke.

A spiral of light peeled back from the girl’s body like mist revealing dawn.

Her form shimmered. expanded. Hardened.

The girl now sitting on the couch wasn’t Anshika.

It was Rachit.

And the one who had been standing for days, walking, eating, watching—the one they thought had *been* Rachit—was Anshika.

Gaurav’s lips parted. “Wha...”

Yugetsu’s mouth dropped open. “That’s— What the—?!”

Aviral’s cup dropped again.

The hologlyph above them didn’t flicker. But the reality in the room shattered like glass.

Rachit—now the real one—stood. Calm.

Anshika's face looked tired from using her body illusion. She rubbed her wrists. Her neck. Her face.

"...We switched," she said simply.

No apology. No explanation.

Just truth.

Yugetsu stood frozen for a moment.

Then his body jolted forward with a burst of emotion.

"What the *hell* were you two thinking?! You lied to us! We thought *you* were Rachit! And you—" he pointed to Rachit, his voice cracking, "—you just *let* us believe it?!"

His voice trembled. "I—I trusted you."

Rachit turned.

Without a word, he walked to the bin in the corner. Gripped the torn blue tank top. Ripped it the rest of the way, and dropped it in.

He faced them shirtless now—his chest bearing scars old and new, lean muscle tensed, skin streaked with dried blood.

His voice was calm. Quiet. Firm.

"I know you're angry."

His eyes locked onto each of theirs, one at a time.

"But listen to me."

His tone didn't plead. It didn't command. It simply *was*.

"Just hear me and Anshika out."

Gaurav, still clutching his bandaged chest, grunted. "Then you better start from the damn beginning."

The tension hung like a blade between them all.

And Rachit nodded once.

The tension hung like a blade above their heads—sharp, thin, waiting to fall.

Rachit didn't speak at once.

He turned instead, walking with quiet, deliberate steps toward the bedside table beside Nyss's bed. The weight of unspoken things pressed into the floor with each step. The white jug sat still beside a silver goblet, untouched.

He poured nothing.

Instead, he lifted the jug to his lips and drank—every last drop. His throat moved with long, slow gulps, the curve of his jaw tense as if swallowing down more than just water.

Then, lowering it, he finally spoke—gaze locked to the shimmering glyph above Nyss's bed.

"The footage you saw... it's probably twenty hours old."

His voice was low, calm, but it silenced the room instantly. The hologlyph crackled faintly above him.

He glanced sideways—at the girl now seated where he once sat.

"Am I right?"

Anshika nodded. "Yes. Roughly twenty-two."

Yugetsu, still upright but visibly trembling, clutched the edge of his stool like it might vanish beneath him again.

Rachit turned from the glyphs and began walking slowly—his eyes tracing their faces, his bare chest carrying both tension and presence. He stopped before Yugetsu, crouching slightly so they were eye-level.

His palm reached up and gently rested on the childlike hybrid's head.

"You've been maturing well," Rachit said, the corners of his mouth twitching into something halfway between a smirk and something softer. "Fast."

Yugetsu blinked—mouth opening, then closing. His cheeks flushed slightly, confused by the warmth and weight of the gesture. He tried to speak, but all that escaped was a quiet, "...Oh."

Aviral cleared his throat roughly from across the room, adjusting the sling around his shoulder. "Alright then—fine. So tell us. *When* did you two switch places?"

Gaurav leaned forward slightly despite the pain in his body, echoing the question with his eyes.

"You never came to our tent. Not once. Not even to check in. You never came to the damn rooms either."

The tension returned. Sharper this time.

Rachit straightened slowly, eyes narrowing with that familiar weight—like he was stepping onto the edge of a blade and daring it to cut.

"...Are you *sure* about that?"

His voice dropped just slightly. And that drop sent a flicker through all of them.

They looked at each other. Uneasy. Faces shifting.

Then—

Rachit tilted his head, slightly mocking, slightly grave.

“Have you already forgotten? That night, when you all left Anshika and that hybrid girl—Lyss or Lysara or whatever her name was—for clothing and armor prep?”

The words hit like a needle through skin. Sharp. Specific.

Yugetsu’s face went pale. His lips parted, forming a slow, careful sound.

“...Wait.”

His mind raced—unwinding memories, moments, glances.

“That... robed female demon who came in for armor pickup. That wasn’t a demon, was it?”

He looked up slowly, his strange slit-pupiled eyes widening.

Rachit’s own reddish-brown irises darkened just a shade—like embers under ash. The corners of his mouth twitched downward, and he didn’t blink when he answered:

“Yes.”

Yugetsu recoiled a little—eyes wide, breath hitching.

“So... so you changed them? *Both* of them? You mean—cleaned... *them*?” he stammered. The words tumbled out like misfired marbles.

Aviral’s mouth opened.

Gaurav coughed, choking on his own spit.

“*WHAT?!*”

Even Anshika looked mildly amused, though she remained composed.

Yugetsu’s skin had turned red to white in rapid succession. “Y-you mean you... saw... I mean—”

Rachit didn’t even blink.

"Hardest choices," he said, quietly, "require the strongest will."

Yugetsu nearly fainted. Gaurav fell back against the pillow, palm over his forehead. “This guy’s unreal.”

But before the humor could truly stretch its wings, Anshika spoke—calm and clear.

“It didn’t happen like that,” she said. “He broke the illusion first.”

She glanced down at her palms. Then raised her gaze again.

“He found me. Explained everything. Told me he couldn’t be seen with the team—at least not yet. Not till the illusion was broken fully. Then he asked me to take care of things... like gear, armor, clothing.”

She nodded toward Nyss, unconscious and wrapped in glowing glyphs.

“Mine and hers.”

She paused, her tone softening. “While he just lay there. Staring up. Motionless. Like he wasn’t even breathing, but... thinking.”

Everyone quieted again.

The room fell heavy.

Swayam—who hadn’t said a word since the reveal—finally stepped forward. His eyes bore into Rachit with the sharpness of someone who’d *seen* death more than once and lived to argue with it.

“So tell me, Rachit,” he said, voice low. “How’d you break the illusion?”

His gaze flicked to the glyphs still rotating slowly above Nyss’s form.

“And more importantly—can you do it again?”

Rachit inhaled. Slow. Not dramatic. Just necessary.

He stepped away from Yugetsu, walking to the edge of Nyss’s bed.

He stared at her for a long time. The way her body twitched in small flinches. The way the glyphs spun faster whenever someone got too close—as if defending a paradise not meant to be touched.

“You all felt it,” he said finally. “Devouring Path’s illusion... doesn’t trap with chains. It seduces. Gives you what you want. What you *need*. It gives you the *perfect life*—a heaven so convincing you don’t *want* to leave.”

The room listened in complete silence now.

Even the hologlyphs paused their flickering.

“But it’s not real. And deep inside, you *know* that. That’s why—if someone offers just the right word... just the right hope...”

He looked at Anshika again.

“The illusion shatters.”

Swayam exhaled—quietly, but with weight.

“That’s why they gave us twenty-four hours with our new shuffled teams before Trial 1 began...”

“A seed,” Rachit confirmed. “A seed of memory strong enough to conflict with the false paradise.”

“But what about Nyss?” Gaurav asked, still trying to make sense of it. “You can do it again, right?”

Rachit didn’t answer right away.

His eyes stayed locked on Nyss.

“I knew Anshika,” he said finally. “I knew what made her smile. What she *regretted*. What she needed to hear.”

“But Nyss... We never even talked. I don’t know what her heaven looks like.”

He turned to Gaurav and Aviral.

“But you two do.”

They both froze.

Gaurav opened his mouth. Then shut it.

Aviral’s brow tightened.

Swayam’s voice was grim.

“Then it’s on us.”

The room had finally begun to breathe again.

Anshika sat quietly on the couch, fingers curled lightly around the rods now resting beside her. The revelation still hung in the air like the scent of scorched air after a lightning strike.

And yet, Rachit was calm.

Always calm.

Yugetsu stared at him. Eyes narrowed—not with anger, but with a kind of raw, childlike confusion. His legs swung idly off the side of the chair, but his words came slow and careful.

“But still... all this stuff, the switch, the illusion, the armor... It doesn’t explain one thing.”

He leaned forward.

“Why didn’t you *ever* come to check on us? Not once since Trial 1 ended. Not a single time. Even after you switched places with Anshika you didn’t tell us.”

Rachit didn’t turn toward him.

Swayam answered instead.

His voice was low, almost surgical in its clarity.

“No. It explains *everything*.”

He crossed his arms, eyes fixed on the flickering glyph in the center of the room.

“He didn’t come because he was busy getting Scar arrested.”

Yugetsu blinked.

Then frowned. “But... why?”

He looked between Rachit and Swayam, like a child trying to untangle the threads of a riddle woven by gods.

Rachit finally turned.

There was something unreadable in his eyes now—less cold, more distant.

“Because Scar’s insane,” he said simply. “And if he realized my original team was still alive...”

He let the weight of that sentence hang.

Then added,

“He’d come for you.”

Gaurav snorted. His ribs still ached, but his pride refused to.

“I’ve seen him fight. That psycho’s strong, sure. But I could handle him. I’ve faced worse.”

Rachit’s head slowly tilted toward him.

“You sure?”

Gaurav stared back, annoyed. “Yeah.”

Rachit didn’t blink. Didn’t smile. Just walked forward—each step like a silent verdict.

“I read the logs. All of them. Every trial’s small to big test. Every fight. Every death.”

His gaze pierced.

“You all remember the *Devouring Path*? Of course you do. It nearly killed every one of you.”

Aviral’s jaw tightened.

Anshika looked down.

“You remember the predator that attacked you before the gate?” Rachit said.

He gestured at them with two fingers. “One. That was it. A single apex.”

Then his voice dropped.

“Team Kaal got *twelve*.”

Everyone froze.

Yugetsu stopped fidgeting.

Gaurav lowered his water bottle, forgetting to even sip.

“Twelve apex predators. Each one meant to stop a team in their tracks. A full set. And guess how many Kaal fought?”

Silence.

“Zero,” Rachit said. “Scar killed all twelve. Alone. Ate their hearts.”

“Kaal didn’t need to lift a finger. I didn’t either. I was just there.”

No one said anything for a long time.

Even the med units in the corners had gone eerily still, as if the machines themselves were listening.

“If Scar knew you survived,” Rachit continued, “you’d already be dead.”

Gaurav looked away. He grabbed the water jug again, jaw clenched.

He drank with both hands, even as his bandaged ribs visibly twitched in pain. But he didn’t stop. He wouldn’t stop.

And still, Rachit moved.

He stepped toward the center of the room, where the floating glyph panel shimmered faintly in the air.

One tap—and the light flared.

A new projection emerged.

TRIAL 2: ROUND 2 STARTS IN 3 DAYS

He swiped left.

The image morphed—now a table of names, ranks, and blood points filled the air in glowing columns.

Rachit didn’t speak at first. He just pointed.

The top row gleamed with stark gold text:

- **Team Abhishaap – 400 Blood Points**
- **Team Kaal – 370**
- **Team Mavik – 370**
- **Team Atheron – 350**
- **Team Slade – 350**
- **Team Syris – 300**

Then the names continued downward—until a thin, pulsing red bracket marked the danger zone.

- **Team Nyss – 200 (7th Position)**
- **Team Krotha – 250 (6th Position)**

“Recognize that third-place team?” Rachit asked, voice razor-flat.

Gaurav glanced up.

And winced.

“Team Atheron,” Rachit said.

“The same demon warriors we met before the Room of Revelation.”

Gaurav scoffed. “*Warriors*? They were more like bunch of arrogant crap.”

Rachit gave a slight tilt of the head,

his tone sharper now.

“Gaurav—your team’s at 200. *Seventh*. If that doesn’t go up in Round 2...”

He let it hang.

“We’re all doomed.”

He didn’t raise his voice. He didn’t need to.

The weight in his words made them feel heavier than metal.

Aviral leaned forward, slowly. His eyes were still bruised, but alert.

“So what do we do?”

Rachit turned to him.

“You and Gaurav. Get your heads together. Think. Dig through *anything* you remember about Nyss—words, moments, regrets, memories. Anything that can be used to pull her out of that illusion.”

Yugetsu sat up straighter.

His voice was soft again.

“What about the rest of us?”

Rachit swiped left again.

Dozens of glowing panels flared across the room—each showing slow-motion clips, stats, frame-by-frame breakdowns of battles fought across Trial 2’s first round.

“We analyze,” Rachit said.

Then Swayam stepped forward.

Mask still on. Arms folded. Shadowed.

“We adapt.”

Rachit looked at him.

“We rise. Or we die.”

The glow of the holoscreens faded behind them. The murmuring lights dimmed to a hush.

And somewhere, as if across a world stitched together by silence and cold steel—

A light flickered to life in a room of darkness.

It wasn't the kind of darkness born of night or shadow. This was a darkness cultivated—deliberate. Like a cage grown inward instead of built. The walls breathed faintly with surveillance glyphs. The only furniture in the void was a simple table, smoothed by time, and two chairs on either side—facing each other like dueling blades about to draw.

One of them was already occupied.

Scar sat there. Still. Massive.

His hulking frame overflowed the chair like a god forced into furniture too small for worship. His arms were locked together atop the table, muscles coiled like waiting serpents. The other two—those vicious, veined arms were crossed behind his back, a silent reminder that restraint was a choice.

And it was wearing thin.

Across from him, a figure in white stood. Then sat.

The investigator.

His robes were perfect, pressed and ceremonial, as if ceremony could help contain what sat before him. His skin was pale—so pale it bordered on translucent. His face, unnervingly symmetrical, looked like a cross between a triangle and a circle, giving him the expression of someone half-calculating, half-false. His green eyes glowed, but there was no warmth in them.

Only authority.

Only need.

“You killed six kitchen staff, three handlers, and all the preserved beasts,” the investigator said, voice taut with control. “Even the human slaves assigned to the kitchens. Why?”

Scar didn't blink.

He leaned back slowly into the chair. It creaked under the weight of him. And then he smiled—slow, wide, and far too pleased for someone in chains.

“Can't say,” he said, lips parting like jaws. “White wash.”

The investigator's eyes narrowed, his jaw tensing. His voice sharpened.

“You *will* tell me. Now.”

Scar tilted his head.

His eyes gleamed with something ancient and wild. Not rage. Not pride. Something deeper.

“Even if I *wanted* to explain,” he said, his tone half-sing-song, half menace, “you wouldn’t understand. Not with that little marble brain you polish every morning in front of your doctrine mirror.”

He leaned forward again—so close that the investigator could hear the faint growl in his throat.

“And if you *were* capable of understanding... you’d already be running.”

The silence that followed wasn’t empty.

It pressed in.

Like breath held too long.

The investigator held his ground, but there was a flicker—just a flicker—of something tightening in his jaw. His fingers trembled as they reached for the edge of the file on the table. He didn’t open it.

He simply stood up.

Scar watched him the entire time, eyes never blinking.

As the investigator moved to leave, he hesitated by the door.

“You’ll be questioned again,” he said.

“You’ll break eventually.”

Scar’s smile never faded.

“I’m not here to break.”

He bared his teeth.

“I’m here to remind the world that monsters don’t belong behind bars. They belong outside... where the screaming happens.”

The door opened.

The investigator left.

And Scar sat alone again. Smiling.

As if prison was just another waiting room.

The light above him flickered once—then steadied.

Somewhere, beyond the sealed doors and layered spells of containment, time moved on. Cold corridors whispered with routine. Glyphs tracked footsteps, and reports buried themselves in bureaucratic folders no one would ever read in full. And in the way of all tightly wound places—everything waited for the next explosion.

Two days passed.

Outside the sterile walls of Scar's confinement, the Arena's tempo quickened. Teams moved like predators preparing for another cull. Weapons were inspected. Stratagems whispered. Wounds licked. And the air was ripe again with the tension of blood to be spilled.

It was in this returning tension that Rachit entered Team Kaal's room.

The doors slid open with a soft exhale of breath, glyphs recognizing his presence, though none dared speak it aloud.

The chamber was larger than most—utilitarian but reinforced like a bunker. Its walls weren't decorated; they were scarred with old blows and sealed fractures from training gone too far. The lighting was dim. Controlled.

Kaal sat in the center, unmoving.

He wasn't on a throne. He didn't need one.

A simple sofa, wide enough to seat three men, bowed beneath his weight. His massive form leaned back, arms relaxed, as if carved into the room itself. Burnt-bronze skin shimmered faintly under the ambient light, the demonbone plates on his shoulders bearing deep etchings—lines of command, marks of battles not shared in words.

On his chest: the symbol of his house. A sun wrapped in chains.

His ember-orange eyes didn't meet Rachit's.

They didn't need to.

"So," Kaal said, voice like gravel dragged over steel, "how was your meeting with your original team?"

He didn't ask if it happened. He already knew.

Rachit stepped forward, barefoot barely making a sound against the reinforced flooring. His expression was unreadable, lips set in a neutral line, eyes calm.

"I don't know what you're talking about."

Kaal didn't move. Still staring straight ahead.

"Don't insult me," he replied, voice heavier now—closer to the ground, like something anchored in stone. "Why get Scar arrested?"

A beat passed.

Then another.

"Was it necessary?"

Rachit's fingers twitched, barely. Just a shift in posture.

"He's unstable," he said. "If he knew my original team survived this long—he'd go after them. So I bought them time."

Kaal's ember-eyes blinked once. Slowly.

Still not looking at Rachit.

"You could've told me."

Rachit let out a soft breath through his nose, not quite a scoff.

"And you think he would've listened to you?"

That got Kaal's attention.

His head turned. Just enough.

A sliver of that burning gaze fell on Rachit, not like a threat—but like a judge finally acknowledging a plea.

"I wouldn't have asked," Kaal said. "I would have made him listen."

His voice didn't rise. It didn't need to.

Because when Kaal said *made*, he didn't mean through force alone. He meant through system. Through structure. Through command. Scar was chaos—but Kaal was gravity. Unyielding. All-consuming in the long game.

Rachit met that gaze. Still calm.

"Even gravity can't hold the wind forever."

A pause.

Then a faint shimmer in the far wall—just above the reinforced battle display unit.

A glowing glyph shimmered to life. Its message clear.

[12 HOURS REMAINING UNTIL TRIAL 2 — ROUND 2 BEGINS]

Neither of them reacted to it.

Because that clock had already started ticking in both their minds.

Kaal leaned slightly forward, one massive hand resting on his knee. The glyph-light cast harsh shadows over his demonbone plates. He didn't ask for details. He didn't demand strategy. He simply stated:

"Don't let your human attachments make you predictable."

Rachit tilted his head.

"And don't mistake my humanity for weakness."

Kaal's lips curved. Not a smile. Just a motion. As if registering something... mildly interesting.

He leaned back again.

The matter, for now, was closed.

And time marched on.

—

Two nights bled into their dawns.

The Arena quieted only in moments, and even then, the silence trembled like a breath held too long.

Inside the dimmed medical chamber, the air smelled faintly of antiseptics and healing salves, touched by the warm notes of earth from the potted plants by the corners. The ceiling glyphs had dimmed to resting hues—soft blues and silvers, casting long sleepy shadows across the white-marble floor.

Yugetsu had finally curled up on the long couch, arms wrapped around a pillow too large for him, breathing slow and steady. His body curled in such a way that his features looked younger, almost normal—if not for the faint glow around his slit-pupiled eyes that flickered even in sleep.

Aviral's chest rose and fell in rhythm, his bandaged arm loosely resting over his stomach. The cracks in his bones had started closing, enough that his fingers twitched now and then with dreams he wouldn't remember.

Gaurav, the hardest hit, remained wrapped in reinforced healing silks. The tubes remained, still feeding glacial fluids into his blood to calm the violent Pran surge. His face was calm, though his jaw occasionally clenched—as if somewhere in his dreams, he was still trying to protect someone.

Two times in these two days, Anshika had placed her glowing palms over their forms—her healing technique not one of miracle, but of painful acceleration. Muscle stitching, nerve aligning, fracture-splicing. A gift that didn't restore—but hurried what was broken toward repair. Even Gaurav's ribs, once described as shattered beyond contest, had begun to knit like the roots of a stubborn tree.

And in that room now, only one remained standing.

Swayam.

His back was straight, arms behind him, eyes fixed on the hovering glyph-screen that flickered before him like a shrine of moving war.

Match Lineups – Trial 2, Round 2:

- **Team Kaal vs Team Slade**
- **Team Abhishaap vs Team Krask**
- **Team Krotha vs Team Nakaros**
- **Team Nyss vs Team Juro**
- **Team Atheron vs Team Ashed**

- **Team Syris vs Team Viren**

The list goes on half of it hidden on second slide.

He studied the list with quiet focus.

His mask still covered half his face, but his eyes revealed thought after thought firing in sequence. He wasn't just reading names—he was building mental maps, movements, probabilities.

Beside him, a soft voice rose.

“So... what do you think?” Anshika asked.

She stood tall now—closer to how she'd been before the Devouring Path. Her voice held strength again. Her posture had changed too, but there was something deeper in her eyes now. Stillness. Understanding. As if illusion had burned away some fragile layer of who she used to be.

She tilted her head slightly.

“How do you think these matches will go?”

Swayam didn't blink.

“We'll win.”

His voice didn't rise. It wasn't bravado. It was structure. Will hardened into a shape.

Anshika's lips parted—but said nothing.

—

Elsewhere—quiet, isolated—

Rachit sat alone beneath a hanging lamp that flickered slightly in the corner of his assigned quarters. The walls were dull stone, bare, but in front of him was a single thing: a silver locket.

He held it between his thumb and forefinger. Gently. As if anything more would shatter what was already cracked.

His thumb pressed the hinge, and the locket clicked open.

Inside was a photograph—burned at the edges, faded with time, stained in places like a memory slowly drowning. Four figures.

A woman: warm eyes, elegant features, a subtle strength beneath softness.

A toddler girl: cheeks full, mid-laugh, caught mid-turn toward the camera.

A man: older, wise, eyes sharp like he knew too much too early, a quiet pride.

And at the edge—a boy. His face scorched beyond clarity. Only the outline of a shoulder, chest, and half a collar remained.

Rachit stared at it for a long time.

Then closed it with a gentle *click*.

—

Back near the armory—two figures emerged from the shadowed corridor, boots clicking against the polished stone floor.

Swayam still wore his Krotha attire—the black metal armor with blue engravings, the frost mask firmly strapped over his face, fingers gloved but free to move. Two Hengdang rested once again on his back—silent, waiting.

Beside him, Anshika now moved with strange grace. Her new attire shimmered beneath the arena’s overhead light: midnight violet bodysuit layered with iridescent charcoal and violet sheer fabrics that fluttered as she walked. Her corset belt bore subtle glyphs, old language for misdirection. Her boots struck clean, yet quiet. On her thighs—poisoned daggers, curved like smile lines in a liar’s mouth.

Her sleeves floated behind her wrists, embroidered in hypnotic runes that coiled with movement.

She looked sideways at him as they turned a corner. Her hand tapped her dagger once.

“Don’t think I missed that pause earlier.”

Swayam tilted his head slightly.

“What pause?”

“When you said ‘*we’ll win.*’” Her voice dropped a notch. “You weren’t just talking about our teams, were you?”

Swayam didn’t answer.

He didn’t need to.

They turned down another corridor—returning now to regroup, to plan, to finish preparations for a trial that would chew through the rest of them like a blade through silk.

But the frost in his step—and the venom in hers—suggested something else entirely.

That some teams were entering Trial 2’s second round to *survive*.

And they were going in to *rewrite the game*.

Swayam and Anshika reached the medical room in silence. Yugetsu was still curled on the couch, arms around his long pillow, fast asleep like he hadn’t moved in hours. Gaurav and Aviral lay in their beds, breathing evenly under the healing wraps, their chests rising with a steadier rhythm than before.

Neither of them said a word as they sat down—Swayam beside Gaurav, Anshika near Aviral.

For once, they allowed themselves to rest.

Five hours passed.

Quiet, deep, undisturbed sleep.

Aviral stirred first, wincing as he shifted under the sheets. Gaurav groaned a moment later, turning his neck slowly, testing his body like it still might betray him.

Swayam and Anshika were already awake, sitting upright in their chairs, silent and watching.

Gaurav's voice broke the calm.

"Nice daggers," he said, nodding toward Anshika's hips. "You two get me anything while you were out playing warrior dress-up?"

Swayam didn't even look at him.

"Yeah. We did."

"But you're not touching them until your ribs stop cracking every time you laugh."

Gaurav smirked, but then winced hard as if his own laugh just proved Swayam's point.

Yugetsu was still snoring lightly, one arm flopped off the couch, fingers twitching.

Then—

It hit.

A sudden, undeniable surge of Pran.

Everyone felt it.

Like the air was sucked out and slammed back in. A hum deep in the bones—followed by a *crack* of sound so violent it shook the beds.

The floor trembled. Glass vials clinked against trays. Yugetsu yelped, falling off the couch with a blanket tangled around his legs. The glyph-screens blinked erratically overhead.

"What the hell was that?!" Aviral sat up fast, regretting it immediately as pain flared across his ribs.

Swayam was already standing.

Anshika, too.

They didn't speak—they just moved, out the door, through the hallway.

"Stay with them," Swayam said over his shoulder to Yugetsu.

"Yeah—yep—sure," Yugetsu stammered, wide-eyed, blanket still draped over one arm.

Gaurav tried to get up, but his leg gave out. He cursed, gripping the edge of the bed.

Swayam and Anshika reached the spectator's viewpoint in less than a minute. Demons were scattered in panic. Shouts echoed from the upper balconies. Even veteran staff were shaken, retreating into the shadows of stone corridors.

And then they saw it.

The arena.

Or what was left of it.

One entire section had been split—clean through.

The rupture was surgical. Not just cracked or cratered—but *cut*. A deep, yawning scar across the stone and glyph-forged metal, stretching from the eastern viewing pit to the central ring.

On the far edge, standing just one inch from where the ground had been *disintegrated*, was Kaal.

He hadn't moved.

Didn't even flinch.

The section of arena next to him was gone—annihilated. Yet he stood there, shoulders square, gaze locked forward.

Across the expanse of destruction...

Abhishaap.

His hair moved in phantom motion, static tracing across his body like living thread. Sparks danced around his shoulders. The sleeves of his coat hung torn and loose, but his posture was relaxed.

Too relaxed.

But the thunder in the air spoke his presence louder than any roar.

A young demon official lay behind a fractured wall, hands over his head.

"I—I don't even know what he did. He just—he just walked in and the arena *broke!*"

Abhishaap looked around.

His eyes locked briefly with Kaal.

Two apex monsters.

Neither blinked.

Kaal's body shifted—barely. Then he turned. Walked away. No words. No posturing. As if the display hadn't impressed him in the slightest.

Abhishaap watched him leave, lips twitching into a faint smirk. Not joy. Not mockery. Just recognition.

Then he turned—his coat fluttering in the shockwind—and saw Swayam.

Even at this distance, their eyes met.

And Abhishaap *smiled*. Just a little. The way predators do when they see something interesting.

But there was a hitch in his step. Barely visible—but there. A sideways sway. A stumble too subtle for untrained eyes.

He disappeared into the dust clouds that drifted through the southern gates.

Only after he vanished did the arena's restoration glyphs activate.

Glowing sigils sparked to life across walls and ground, pulsing in sequence. One by one, the shattered stone and burnt glyphsteel began to repair themselves. It would take hours—but it would be whole again.

The air still crackled. Not with power—but with unease.

Swayam said nothing.

Anshika didn't need to.

They turned and walked back—silent, both thinking the same thing.

That wasn't just a display.

That was a message.

—

Elsewhere, down a different corridor—dark and soundless—Abhishaap walked alone.

The hallway was empty, lights dimmed. Repair glyphs flickered overhead, adjusting the structure after the destruction he'd left behind.

He moved in silence, boots echoing faintly against the marble.

Ahead, a massive figure stood waiting. Still as a statue.

Seven feet tall, broad shoulders wrapped in fur and armor. The low blue light caught the shimmer of his crystalline pelt—each hair a shard of frost and ice. His back was straight. His head bowed.

Krurog Frosthowl didn't speak. He didn't need to.

The moment Abhishaap drew close, Krurog knelt—one knee down, clawed hands together. No ceremony. Just raw, disciplined obedience.

Then he spoke, voice deep and vibrating the air like a low snarl caged in frost.

"Lord Abhishaap... I spoke with the medics. They confirmed—ten nights ago... the liquor we shared... it carried a 20% concentration of Zeta Prime blood."

Abhishaap's eyes narrowed slightly. His pace slowed but didn't stop.

"Zeta Prime," he muttered.

He stopped just beside Krurog, gaze now focused ahead.

That blood type wasn't just rare—it was nearly myth. One in ten million zeta blood type might carry it. Its properties were volatile, extremely potent. A natural amplifier for Prāṇ energy—but dangerously unstable when mixed with foreign compounds.

And they had drunk it with liquor.

Abhishaap's hand twitched slightly.

It hadn't tasted unusual—stronger, yes, but no alarms had rung.

"The alcohol," he murmured, mostly to himself, "would've stripped the benefits... left only the stimulant effect. No healing. No boost. Just... imbalance."

His fingers curled and uncurled. He remembered the sway in his walk. The tremor in his left leg. The slight delay in his reflex after casting Raijin's Spear.

The aftershock he had dismissed now echoed in memory.

He turned to Krurog, eyes sharper now.

"How much did it weaken me?"

Krurog raised his head slightly—not enough to challenge, just to meet his gaze.

"...Pardon me, my lord."

"But judging by the effect of your last strike—Raijin's Spear—"

He paused. Chose his words.

"It wasn't even one percent of what you've shown in simulations. A tenth of a tenth, at most."

A beat of silence.

Then—

Abhishaap let out a slow breath. Not frustration. Not panic.

Just recalibration.

He stepped past Krurog, walking again. Smooth. Precise.

"One percent," he said, quiet.

"Still enough for most."

Behind him, Krurog stood, falling into step.

No more words exchanged.

Their footsteps echoed through the corridor.

The glyph lights overhead flickered again—adjusting brightness to follow Abhishaap's movement, reacting to his Prāṇ signature.

But even that signature pulsed unevenly now. It stuttered in rhythm, like a heartbeat caught in a hiccup. Where once it blazed like voltage now it flickered like old wiring—powerful, yes, but *wrong*.

Krurog noticed. He said nothing.

His loyalty didn't come from ignorance.

It came from reverence.

And what he saw—even in weakness—still terrified him.

They walked deeper into the compound. Past locked doors. Past rooms sealed by glyphs that only answered to bloodline authority.

Two soldiers bowed as they passed—low and tight, eyes down. Abhishaap didn't acknowledge them.

Inside one room, Shyvana lay unconscious in a Prāṇ containment chamber.

Her armor cracked.

Her body twitched occasionally from voltage echoes.

Krurog paused by the door.

A glyph reader at the entrance flared with her status.

Prāṇ Reserve: 40%. Recovery Incomplete.

Status: Stable. Burnout Mode Activated.

Abhishaap glanced at it briefly.

Then walked on.

He knew the cost of the drink now. Of whatever "celebration" they had taken part in ten nights ago.

And if this was what 1% looked like...

Then the ones in his way should consider themselves lucky.

Because anything more—

Would've ended the arena entirely.

—

Seven hours passed.

The arena, shattered and fractured earlier, now stood reborn.

Repaired glyphwork had done its job. Not a single crack remained on the stone or walls. Not a trace of the destruction lingered in the marble corridors, the floating ring platforms, or even the

glyph-bathed viewing towers. The structure itself looked cleaner than before—like the arena had taken its scars and grown stronger for it.

But for those who had seen it...

The silence of that lightning still lingered somewhere deep in their nerves.

Now, however, the crowd returned—unaware. Thousands of demons, nobles, and hybrids poured back into their seats, excited for the second round to begin. They brought noise, hunger, and wild anticipation, completely ignorant of the ghost that had hovered over the arena hours ago.

But not everyone had forgotten.

Up in the central commentator tower, the trio of announcers sat side-by-side in their crimson throne-chairs.

Their mics were muted.

Elsa's fingernail tapped the wood armrest, rhythmic and sharp. Her lips curled—not with amusement this time, but thought. Raktabīja stared ahead, arms crossed, mouth unmoving. Ignis, in his humanoid form, leaned back with one boot on the ledge, eyes flickering faintly in their dragon-pupil glaze.

“So,” Ignis muttered under his breath. “That’s the prodigy of the Volghora line.”

Raktabīja didn’t blink. “He didn’t even scream the name of his attack.”

Elsa’s smile faded.

“He didn’t need to.”

Ignis exhaled smoke through his nostrils. It coiled like incense.

“I’ve read his file,” he said, tone shifting. “Volghora family had given a birth to a being whose strength and intellect has no match in whole of lighting demons. They kept his birth secret for 15 years. Not because he was dangerous—but because they were afraid of *who he’d surpass*.”

Raktabīja tilted his head. “The King of Storms?”

Ignis nodded once.

“If Abhishaap ever reaches full control of that bloodline...”

The three fell silent.

But then—glyphs shimmered across the arena ceiling.

Bright red spirals. Then circular rings of light, forming the giant projection wheel that always marked the start of a new match.

ROUND 2 – MATCH ONE

TEAM KAAL vs TEAM SLADE

Raktabija leaned forward. The red mic light blinked on.

“Well, well, well. Looks like we’ve got ourselves a thunderous opening.”

Ignis grinned. “Round Two begins with blood—Team Kaal takes the stage.”

Elsa’s voice joined, elegant and chilling.

“But without Scar... who's under investigation for the suspicious slaughter of the cooking staff... this match may run differently.”

Raktabija added, “For now, Team Kaal enters with only two active fighters. Scar is currently detained under Rule 117—awaiting Tribunal interrogation.”

A fresh glyph pulsed in the center ring.

Two sigils formed on opposite ends of the battlefield.

On one side: a burning sun wrapped in chains—**Team Kaal.**

And on the other: a twin ripple of flame and mist—**Team Slade.**

The crowd erupted.

From the southern gate, they emerged.

Slade Vaarmire walked first—his twin-veined arms glowing faintly, shimmering in a balance of water and fire. Every step he took echoed a different element—his boots leaving behind fading trails of vapor and warm steam. His coat billowed as if reacting to battlefield winds that hadn’t yet arrived.

Behind him, Neer Anbu flipped his whip-spear twice in his hand as he walked, his silver hair braided tightly, moonlight eyes scanning everything with the bored intensity of someone searching for something worth killing. His robes shimmered—illusion-threaded, bending subtly at the hems.

Last came Rezen. Silent. Immense. Each step he took felt like a low quake. Crystals shimmered across his shoulders, light embedding itself into his muscle. His gaze never left the enemy gate.

Team Slade stood at the edge of the ring now.

They didn’t speak.

Didn’t pose.

They simply *stood*—balanced, harmonized, as if the battlefield were their temple and they had just begun their prayer.

The northern gate creaked open.

The shimmering sun-in-chains insignia burned into the center ring, the symbol of discipline, of command, of destruction given structure.

In the observation room—

Yugetsu stirred first, arms still wrapped around his pillow.
His eyes flickered open as the glyph light stung the edges of the room.

Anshika leaned closer to the transparent screen embedded in the wall. Her lips moved faintly—no words, just a hum of anticipation.

Aviral, still bandaged across his midsection, shifted his pillow higher behind his back. “Looks like it’s starting.”

Beside him, Gaurav exhaled, his breath tight from his healing ribs but held steady. “Let’s see if our ghost shows up.”

Anshika said nothing.

She didn’t need to.

Down in the arena, silence fell like a veil.

And then...

They entered.

Two shadows, opposite in size, yet equal in weight.

Kaal walked first.

Each of his steps struck the floor with absolute balance.

No dust rose. No emotion showed.

His massive frame, a sculpture of burnt-bronze flesh and demonbone discipline, carried the quiet command of extinction.

Behind him came **Rachit**.

Leaner, shorter, but no less magnetic.

He didn’t walk like a demon or a soldier—he moved like a whisper of violence.

Barefoot. Anklets faintly rattling. The two rods crisscrossed on his back like an unfinished thought.

That vest—open, matte black, sleeveless—flowed with every breath like it wanted to ask a question it already knew the answer to.

As he stepped into the center ring, the glyphs adjusted to follow him alone.

High above, Swayam sat quietly on the couch. Mask on.

Eyes narrowed beneath the frost.

Yugetsu, now fully awake, blinked as the cameras zoomed in.

Rachit’s head tilted.

And then he looked up.

Right at the camera.

No smirk. No nod.

Just those **burning reddish-brown eyes**. Quietly waiting.
Like he was staring right through the lens. Through every floor. Through the steel.

As if to say:

"I'm still here."

Swayam leaned forward.
"He's confirming," he whispered.

Gaurav scoffed. "Look at him... getting all the credit."

Anshika didn't respond, but her lip curled. Just slightly.

"That's *your* round-one performance they're praising," Gaurav grunted. "You manipulate audience and fracture skulls and this guy just walks in and *collects applause*."

Yugetsu snorted, "To be fair, he wears it better."

The announcers crackled to life.

Elsa: "Welcome back, blood-soaked beauties. It's time for Round Two—and the storm of stakes has only just begun!"

Raktabīja: "my little organ grinders... it's *Team Kaal!* The ones who don't blink!"

Ignis (calmer, smoother): "The sun-chained house walks with intention today. I read the report—Kaal's gravity domain shattered three teams last cycle. But look who's beside him... our quiet collector, Rachit. Returning after staying low last round."

Elsa (mock gasp): "But wait, where's their chaotic charm? Where's Scar?"

Raktabīja: "Ah, yes. Tragic! Arrested for, uh... excessive seasoning in the kitchens."

Ignis (grim): "Scar was implicated in the murder of all staff in the culinary wing. He's not participating this match—or the next few."

Elsa: "Pity. I liked him. He made excellent chaos. But let's focus... because the balance-breakers are already in position."

While the crowd cheered, the **northern gate** remained still.

Then, **Rachit walked in. Alone.**

Kaal was already seated in the waiting zone, resting like a sleeping god—shoulders still, arms folded across his chest, eyes half-lidded but absorbing everything.

Barefoot. Rods crossed on his back.

Hair falling slightly over one eye, tension coiled in the way he walked—not tight, but **contained**.

Focused.

The anklets at his feet rattled once. Then stilled.

His vest, a matte black tailcoat-like sleeveless hybrid, moved with subtle shifts in weight—too quiet for flair, too exact for chance.

He stopped in the middle of the ring and looked forward.

Neer Anbu smirked. Of course it was him.

Behind Neer, Slade and Rezen had already taken their seats in the resting area for their team, crossing arms, watching with neutral confidence.

Above, another glyph shimmered.

"TRIAL 2 – ARENA OF JUDGMENT – ROUND 2"

And beneath it, four words burned into the air:

❖ Kill or Knockout ❖

The rules were clear.

The stakes were primal.

One fighter each. No substitutions.

Ignis: “And here we go. Rachit—former teammate of Krotha's group, now standing alone under the command of Kaal. He’s been quiet this tournament. Too quiet.”

Elsa: “Quiet’s sexy. Especially when he’s hiding things. Did you see him move last round?”

Raktabīja: “Did he move? Or was that someone else in disguise?”

Ignis (smiling faintly): “We’ll see now.”

Up in the medical bay, Yugetsu leaned forward, his breath fogging the glass slightly.

“That’s our guy,” he muttered.

“Technically not but practically yes,” said Gaurav, pushing himself upright. His bandaged arms twitched as he tried to sit straighter.

“He’s still ours,” Anshika corrected, eyes locked on the ring. “He never left.”

Aviral, his side still sore, looked over at her. “They’re already calling him the solo wildcard of the trial. The credit’s flowing his way.”

Gaurav chuckled, even through the wince. “Anshika, look—he’s getting famous off *your* fight. You sure you’re not mad?”

Anshika blinked slowly. “Let him have it. Let them all think it was him.”

Then, lower: “After all it was all his plan to begin with.”

Back in the arena—

Rachit didn’t flinch.

He rolled his shoulder once.

And **Neer Anbu** stepped forward.

The whip-spear slid out from his hand like silk, unfolding mid-motion.

The scent of **burned herbs and sweet smoke** drifted behind him, a strange perfume that clung to blood and illusion alike.

He tilted his head at Rachit.

“Hmm,” Neer whispered across the space between them, loud enough only for Rachit to hear.

“You’ve got the look of a killer.”

He spun his weapon once—slow, fluid, hypnotic.

“But are you sharp... or just *pretty*?”

Rachit’s head tilted in return.

No smile. No twitch.

Just one hand raised to his chest—tapping lightly at the **utility wrap** tied around his waist.
A code gesture.

One that didn’t say “fight.”

It said “**measure.**”

The glyphs flared gold.

The bell rang once.

Neer Anbu vanished.

No chant. No prep. Just motion—a **blur of smoke-laced silk and pale lavender skin** streaking straight toward Rachit with his whip-spear already mid-spin.

Rachit didn’t blink.

His body dipped low—not back, but **forward**, sliding past the initial arc of the weapon. A thin trail of smoke coiled behind the whip as it cracked the air just above him.

Crack—swipe—twist.

The blade-wrapped lash recoiled and snapped toward Rachit's spine from behind, but he was already on the move again—**two steps sideways, right shoulder dipping**, chain-anklets rattling softly.

Neer's grin flashed.

"Fast..." he whispered, barely audible beneath the clash of breath and motion.

"But still tasting me out?"

Another strike. This time a **high sweep**, followed by a sharp heel kick from Neer's left leg—one meant to connect with Rachit's ribs while the whip distracted his vision.

Rachit spun into the kick—not away from it. **His left shoulder absorbed the motion**, sliding just past the arc, letting Neer's shin graze across the leather flap of his vest without ever touching skin.

He didn't counter.

Not once.

Just dodged. Turned. Reset.

Elsa (commentating, almost seductively):

"Oooh... see that? Rachit isn't fighting. He's... *dancing*."

Ignis:

"No—he's **measuring tempo**. Every move is to learn something. He's reading Neer like a manual."

Raktabīja (snarling):

"He'll run out of ring before he reads that freak."

Up in the medical suite, the mood split.

Yugetsu was glued to the screen.

"He's not even trying to hit. He used to hit me way harder during training."

"He's trying to know the moves," Anshika said, eyes narrowing. "He's *understanding*. Every twitch, every pause. He's mapping Neer's range."

Gaurav grunted, shifting painfully in his bed. "Well haven't seen him fight since we left Reinhard place."

Aviral winced as he adjusted his pillow. "How long is he planning to dodge before, Neer stops playing?"

Back in the arena—

Neer's expression had begun to shift.

The playful grin? Still there. But **his eyes sharpened**.

His whip snapped again—this time **coiled low toward Rachit's legs**, while his body feinted to the right and his left hand flicked something small—a **smoke shard**—toward Rachit's shoulder.

Rachit moved before it even reached.

A vertical leap—knees tucked, body rotating—**clean over the sweeping coil**. The smoke shard detonated harmlessly mid-air, a cloud blooming behind him.

As he landed, he planted his left foot, skidded low on his right heel, and rolled out of the fog, emerging near the edge of the ring.

Still no strikes.

No aggression.

Neer flicked his weapon back into coil-form and began circling slowly now.

“Seriously?” he called out, amused. “Still not even one hit?”

Rachit didn't answer.

His right hand tapped the metal rod on his back once, but didn't draw it.

Neer's eyes narrowed. His smile returned, but it was thinner now—**less playful, more focused**.

“You're not here to win the round,” he said softly, spinning the spear once more. “You're here to *understand* me.”

Rachit's eyes, deep reddish-brown, finally locked onto his opponent with weight.

Still expressionless. Still calm.

But this time, he nodded—just once.

Then whispered:

“Exactly.”

Ignis:

“Confirmation received. That wasn't a taunt. That was an agreement.”

Elsa:

“They're not fighting... they're *communicating*. Through motion.”

Raktabīja:

“They better start killing, or I'm gonna get bored.”

From his seat in the resting zone, **Kaal** didn't move. But his gaze never left the ring. His eyes—those constant orange embers—watched Rachit's foot placement, his exits, his timing. Silent approval. Silent calculation.

On the opposite bench, **Slade watched too**, fingers lightly pressed against his chin. Neer was holding his own, but something about his subtle hand twitch suggested annoyance.

And **Rezen**, massive arms crossed, gave the faintest grunt.

In the ring—

Neer stopped spinning his weapon.

He lifted it. Let the smoke coil drop away.

And said, quieter now:

“Alright, phantom. Let's *test* what you've learned.”

Neer's voice had softened—but his movements didn't.

With a flick of his wrist, the whip-spear **uncoiled in a blur**, ribbons of smoke trailing from its bladed edges like perfume in wind. His body followed with it—one shoulder rolling, spine pivoting like liquid combat.

First strike—horizontal slash at waist height. Fast. Aimed not to kill, but to make Rachit *flinch*.

Rachit didn't flinch.

He stepped *through* it. A pivot on his heel, letting the lash pass a fraction of an inch from his ribs. **The tail of it grazed the edge of his open vest, catching air—not skin.**

Neer's grin sharpened.

“Cute.”

He didn't stop moving. The whip spun upward—**snap twist into a crescent arc**, reversing direction and aiming straight for Rachit's throat now.

Rachit ducked—not backward, but sideways.

His body angled sharply to the left, one hand grazing the ring floor as he **slid beneath the arc**, ankles bending with dancer's fluidity, chain-links at his feet rattling gently.

Neer followed, his legs already in motion.

He dashed in, planting his heel and swinging the whip-spear **overhand like a scythe**, bringing down a spiraling cut that hissed in the air.

This time, Rachit spun under it—a **narrow spiral, cloak flaring out, one hand grazing his rod at his back** but not drawing it yet.

The blade missed.

Again.

Ignis:

“He’s not just dodging—he’s *ghosting* Neer’s rhythm. Every attack, he shifts half a beat before it’s fully formed.”

Elsa (intrigued):

“It’s like Neer’s fighting a shadow that doesn’t want to become real. He’s getting no reads off this kid.”

Raktabīja (snarling):

“Why’s he running? Five minutes in and not a single goddamn strike? Boring.”

Ignis:

“No. That’s the move. He’s *teaching Neer to get frustrated.*”

In the medical suite, Gaurav sat up a little, chuckling.

“I understand Neer’s pain that guy once did same to me.”

Anshika didn’t laugh. Her eyes were locked on the screen.

Yugetsu leaned forward. “He’s building pressure. Not letting Neer breathe.”

Neer wasn’t smiling now.

His eyes tracked Rachit—**half-circling him now**, switching tempo. His steps were looser. More erratic. One leg stepped hard, then soft. The whip’s tail flicked near Rachit’s feet, low strikes meant to **disrupt balance**.

Rachit adjusted easily.

A short hop. Pivot. Slide.

He let one of the strikes curl beneath his arm, *barely missing the edge of his ribcage*—then pirouetted around the crackling smoke line it left behind.

Still no counter.

And that? That was getting under Neer’s skin.

Inside Neer’s head:

He's not attacking.

He's not reacting.

**He's watching.*

Neer narrowed his eyes. *You think I'm your test dummy? Your experiment?*

He dropped into a lower stance.

The whip compacted.

Then it lashed **upward like a rising fang**, point-first this time.

Rachit didn't dodge.

He stepped **toward it**.

A quick-footed blur—**his chest twisting to let the blade pass just beside him**, while one chain-wrapped foot **hooked around Neer's back ankle and redirected pressure**, causing the attack to *overextend slightly*.

Neer stumbled half a step.

A mistake. Small—but real.

And Rachit?

He still didn't capitalize.

He just *watched*.

Elsa (a sharp breath):

"Oh, *now* he's in Neer's head. He *let* him make that mistake and didn't punish it."

Ignis (impressed):

"Psychological warfare. Every dodge is saying: 'You're not worth the strike yet.'"

Raktabīja (growling):

"If he doesn't start drawing blood, I will."

Neer grit his teeth.

"This isn't a fucking exam," he spat.

"You're not testing me. You're running."

He lashed again.

Whip left—mist bloom right—fake low sweep to bait a duck—follow-up pulse to the upper thigh—

Classic misdirection combo.

Rachit *spun backward*, arms tight, body corkscrewing in a minimalist motion that looked almost lazy. The **mist puff missed his eyes** by a whisper.

The pulse? *He slid under it.*

Still untouched.

Now Neer's expression had darkened.

His pace quickened—his strikes weren't testing anymore.

They were **snapping**.

One. Two. Three. A volley of five precise lashes—**each one aimed at different vectors**: hip, collar, knee, temple, chest.

Rachit **moved like silk under pressure**.

- Turn.
- Elbow dip.
- Shoulder lean.
- Cross-step backward with weight distribution on the heel.

The whip never touched him.

Ignis:

"Five minutes. Not a scratch."

Elsa (softly):

"He's making the world forget he was ever part of another team. Rachit's *owning* this moment."

Kaal, from the resting zone, blinked once.

Just once.

And finally, Neer hissed.

"Still dodging? What the hell are you waiting for?!"

Rachit's eyes flicked up.

Neer *lunged*—whip shifting into spear form mid-motion.

The tip blurred as he stabbed forward, trying to feint high and go for the side-rib puncture.

Rachit leaned into the incoming blade— letting it pass just half an inch from his chest. So close the pressure of the spearhead brushed air against his compression wrap.

He moved past it, around Neer's arm—**shoulder gliding past elbow**—and stepped *behind him*.

Still. No. Hit.

Just a breath at his back.

Then vanished backward into mist.

The crowd had gone quiet.

Because what they were watching...

Wasn't a brawl.

It was **a lesson**.

Back in the medical room, tension hung like mist over steel.

Yugetsu leaned forward, eyes sharp. Anshika said nothing—but her lips were pressed tight.

Aviral shifted slightly in his bed, wincing. "Still no hits...?"

Gaurav, half-sitting upright now, frowned and muttered, "How long does he plan on just dodging?"

Swayam, standing near the glyph screen, crossed his arms.

His voice was calm. But absolute.

"Two days."

Everyone turned.

"...What?" Aviral blinked.

"Two days?" Anshika echoed, almost disbelieving.

Swayam didn't look away from the screen. "That's what he told me."

And—

The memory rose.

Three days earlier, just outside the medical bay.

Rachit had stepped out quietly, barefoot as always, anklets rattling faintly against the smooth blackstone floor. He found Swayam waiting near the glyph archway.

Rachit's eyes, still shadowed by sleep deprivation, locked onto him.

"They'll need more time, won't they?" he asked. Voice low.

Swayam nodded once. "Gaurav has internal fractures. Aviral's blood vessels still won't stabilize under stress. They're strong, but they won't be ready."

Rachit looked back toward the room, where the others slept.

Then back at Swayam. No hesitation in his voice.

"...I can buy us two days."

Swayam blinked. "You sure?"

Rachit smirked—only slightly.

"Just don't ask me how."

The memory cracked.

We returned to the present.

And everything made sense.

Swayam stood now, arms crossed, facing the others in the medical bay.

"I didn't say anything," he said. "Because none of you would've let him do it."

Gaurav stared at the screen again.

Rachit was *still* dodging.

Each movement now made sense.

Each sidestep, each duck, each perfectly timed evasion—**they weren't just tactics.**

They were a *sacrifice*.

Elsa:

"Wait, wait—new glyph update coming through!"

Glyphs shimmered above the arena in burning yellow light. The audience began murmuring.

Then the text formed, glowing sharp across the ring:

NEW RULE: RINGOUT ONLY – Knockouts and kills now disallowed by vote. Pushing the opponent out of bounds is the only path to victory.

Ignis:

“Oho. That changes *everything*. Looks like the crowd wants to watch a war of movement!”

Raktabīja (grumbling):

“This isn’t a dance competition. Who voted for this garbage?”

Elsa (reading stats):

“84% approval rate. Majority of audience is loving the tension—and they want to *see how far Rachit can go*.”

Back in the ring, Neer’s brows twitched.

A fresh sweat drop slid down his temple.

“Still running?” he asked, his breath now heavier. “Or are you actually trying to bore me to death?”

Rachit didn’t answer.

Didn’t speak.

Didn’t smile.

He just shifted back onto the balls of his feet—**ready to dodge again**.

But inside, he was watching everything:

- Neer’s **foot pressure**.
- The **coil tension** in the whip-spear.
- The **slight favoring of Neer’s left leg** after the fifth-minute sequence.

He was *measuring* the storm.

And he had time.

Because now?

So long as he stayed in the ring...

He couldn’t lose.

Three hours later.

The arena felt... quieter now.

Not because the crowd was silent—far from it. They were screaming, cheering, some even chanting Rachit’s name like he was a myth refusing to break.

But *inside* the ring?

It was just footsteps.
Mist.
Whip lashes cracking into air.
And breathing—heavy, uneven breathing.

Rachit's bare feet skidded across the tiled arena again, narrowly dodging a smoke-laced spear thrust. His breath was sharp, calculated. Chest rising in a steady, strained rhythm. His clothes clung tighter now, sweat soaking the dark cloth across his back and chest wraps.

He didn't look worn out.

But his legs? His ribs?
They were singing with tension.

Even a panther has limits.

Still—he moved.
Slid under a sweeping arc.
Tilted sideways mid-sprint to avoid the spear's return path.
A flip over mist terrain.
No counter. Just another dodge.

He wasn't *fighting*.
He was **lasting**.

And the clock ticked on.

—

Neer's eyes twitched.

His braid had begun to come undone at the ends. His robes, now sliced in places by his own chaotic spear flurries, flared as he stomped forward.

"Okay," he muttered. "Three. Damn. Hours."

He cracked his neck. "You planning to speak today, shadow-boy? Or just run 'til one of us dies from boredom?"

Still nothing.

Rachit ducked under another spin-lash, this one wrapped in enough Prāṇ to dislocate a normal fighter's spine.

The whip struck the ring floor instead—leaving a spiral-shaped scorch that hissed with residual steam.

"Oh come on, Rachit," Neer barked. "Even Rezen talks more than you, and he doesn't even talk."

He phased backward mid-lash, emerging a few feet behind Rachit—trying to get ahead of his rhythm.

But Rachit didn't even flinch. His body shifted *mid-turn*, pivoting on one heel, letting momentum roll him past Neer's lunge like mist slipping between broken walls.

A chorus of gasps erupted from the audience.

Up in the announcer box—

Ignis:

"Three hours and *zero hits*. Not one! Are we sure Rachit isn't just an illusion himself?"

Elsa:

"That kind of focus is *inhuman*. His heartbeat must be in complete sync with Neer's tempo by now."

Raktabīja (growling):

"No. This isn't strategy. Either that human loves to humiliate demons or that human's stalling for something."

Back in the medical room—

Aviral sat up, shifting slowly to the edge of his bed.

Gaurav was leaning forward in his bed, fists clenched.

"Does he even know what he's doing anymore?" Aviral muttered.

Swayam didn't answer.

But Anshika whispered, almost reverently, "He's still counting."

Yugetsu added under his breath, "Every lash, every mist-phase, every time Neer holds his breath—he's logging it all."

"The biggest advantage he has in this fight is his inability to sleep," Gaurav spoke.

"His one of the biggest problem is his strength here," Swayam finished.

Inside the ring, Neer was smiling now. But not out of joy—out of disbelief.

He slashed again—feint low, spin right, flip his grip and strike high. Rachit *barely* bent out of the whip's range. His hair sliced by the mist-edge, strands floating free.

Still no retaliation.

"Still dodging, huh?" Neer whispered, breathless now.

He grinned bitterly. "Are you even *alive* in there?"

No answer.

Only the faint sound of anklets rattling, barely audible under the storm of footsteps.

Rachit's eyes didn't burn with rage.

They **burned with a timer.**

A silent, flickering countdown—

In the continuous dodges time flowed and reach a point where six hours had been passed since the fight had begun.

Six hours.

Six hours of mist lashing through the air.

Six hours of perfect footwork, evasive movement, and *not a single word* exchanged between them.

Until now.

The arena felt different.

Not electric. Not intense.

Heavy.

Like everyone was holding their breath, hoping someone—*anyone*—would break the loop.

Neer stood in the center, chest rising and falling with each controlled breath. His whip-spear spun once in his hand, not to strike—but out of habit.

Then he... stopped.

The weapon folded in on itself with a whisper of smoke. He placed it back against his back holster.

He stared at Rachit, arms spread slightly as if to say *what now?*

And finally—he broke the silence.

“You know,” he began, pacing slowly now, **“I thought I’d enjoy this. The quiet guy. The mysterious silent act.”**

He tilted his head.

“But this isn’t silence, is it? It’s just... *boring.*”

Rachit said nothing.

The crowd, unsure how to react, murmured. Some booed. Some laughed nervously. One demon in the stands had *literally* fallen asleep, head on a snack tray.

 **Ignis:**

“Six hours in. And we’re witnessing history, folks. This fight has officially become the **fifth-longest** match in the known records of Kaali Bhoomi’s Trial Arena!”

🗣️ **Elsa** (laughing softly):

“The longest, of course, being the infamous three-year duel between demon-lords Vyx and Akurokai. No winners—just two corpses holding swords when they fell.”

🗣️ **Raktabīja** (growling):

“I was there. They died standing. Respect.”

Back in the arena, Neer pointed a finger at Rachit with mock offense.

“Don’t tell me,” he said, voice now dripping sarcasm, **“you’re trying to beat the three-year record. Is *that* the plan?”**

Silence again.

Neer rolled his eyes, turned—

And then—

“No.”

A single word. Low. Calm.

Rachit’s voice—raspy from disuse—cut through the arena like a blade through fog.

Neer paused. His smile froze, caught mid-smirk.

He turned back slowly, blinking. **“...So you *can* talk.”**

The crowd exploded.

Finally.

Even **Slade**, who had been watching with arms folded, cracked a grin. **“About time,”** he muttered under his breath.

Rezen just hummed, unmoved. Eyes locked on Rachit’s stance.

At that moment, the glyphs above the ring shimmered again.

A new **audience-voted rule** appeared in golden fire:

“NEW RULE: Dodging three attacks in a row = disqualification. Ring-out remains valid.”

A shocked ripple tore through the arena.

Neer whistled. “Ohohoho... they really *hate* you now.”

But Rachit stepped forward. Calm. Controlled.

Neer darted in again.

First strike—a sweeping whip spin aimed at Rachit’s right side.
He pivoted, narrowly avoiding it.

Second strike—a mist-flick lunge aimed at his legs.
He rolled low, the mist sizzled past him.

Third strike—

Rachit didn’t dodge.

He caught the spear shaft mid-air.

Twisted his wrist.

And *blocked* with a single spiked black rod—one that had appeared in his hand like it had always been there.

It rang with the sound of forged metal and surged mist pressure.

His eyes flicked up to Neer.

“Two dodges,” he said.

“Unlimited blocks.”

Up in the resting zone—Team Slade was watching closely now.

Slade tilted his head with new interest.

“That human is playing his cards well.”

“Meaning?” Rezen asked quietly.

Slade leaned forward, elbows on his knees.

“Meaning that was his first move on purpose. He wanted the rule to change.”

Rezen didn’t blink. “Why?”

“The audience vote and rule is what decides new rule and getting them to change rule in a given situation provides that human security of some kind.”

Back in the ring—

Neer’s eyes flared in disbelief.

He *lunged* in frustration. His spear cracked into the rod again—once, twice, in a flurry.

Rachit stayed calm, deflecting each hit with minimal movement, like the rod was part of his nervous system.

Each block sparked friction.

The anklets on his feet rattled softly with every pivot.

Neer shouted, “**You’ve been waiting this whole time for me to burn out, huh?**”

Rachit’s response was just a smirk

Neer’s whip recoiled—but his grin returned. Exhausted. Furious.

“**After I am done with you, you won’t be smirking be anymore.**”

The arena roared to life again.

Neer came in fast—too fast for most eyes to follow. His form blurred, split briefly in illusion, then reformed as he **twisted mid-air**, the whip-spear spinning like a spiral of moonlight smoke.

The first strike was a **downward arc**, meant to cleave shoulder to hip.

Rachit **slipped sideways**, the blade grazing only air—**first dodge**.

But Neer didn’t stop. Mid-spin, he reversed his grip and **slammed the butt of the spear toward Rachit’s ribs**, a tight redirect most wouldn’t have expected so soon.

Rachit raised his left rod, **angled the shaft**, and let it absorb the full brunt of the blow.

The crowd heard the impact—a *clang* like an iron bell.

A ripple of smoke-laced wind whipped outward.

Block one.

Ignis:

“He’s dancing that fine line now. Two dodges max. One misstep—and he’s out.”

Raktabīja (grunting):

“Doesn’t look scared. I’ve seen statues with more tension than that kid.”

Elsa (with intrigue):

“Is he not sweating? After nearly *seven hours*, he hasn’t even bled yet...”

Back in the ring—Neer’s teeth clenched.

He pressed harder.

A feint right. An overhead flip. A phantom attack from behind—

—Rachit turned into it. **Second dodge**. Inches from his spine.

And now?

No more dodges.

Neer’s whip slashed sideways again.

But Rachit moved **with** it. He didn't run from the force—he flowed into its arc, **spinning low and bracing one rod upward**, letting the smoke-lined whip wrap around the obsidian-metal rod.

He **yanked**, pulling Neer slightly off-balance.

Neer clicked his tongue. “Ohhh. You’ve got rhythm now, huh?”

The spear retracted.

Neer attacked again—this time a direct thrust.

Rachit caught the midshaft between both rods—**block three**, pressure sliding across his palms.

Then—**twist**.

The rods crossed into an “X” shape, locking the spear just enough to redirect it.

Rachit stepped *in*—chest to chest range.

A bold move.

Slade’s eyes narrowed from the resting zone.

“He’s baiting Neer. Limiting his range. If Neer can't use the full arc of his whip... he’s half his usual threat.”

Rezen, still sitting like a stone sentinel, simply nodded.

Neer grit his teeth.

“Fine! Let’s make it ugly!”

He phased—his entire body **dissolving into mist**. The spear dropped. For one brief second, he was nothing but a swirl of vapor behind Rachit’s back.

But—

Clang.

The rod met mist—*preemptively*.

Rachit had *turned* before the body even reformed. The rod didn’t strike Neer—but it **interrupted the phase**, forcing him back to solidity prematurely.

Neer staggered.

Eyes wide.

“**You predicted my mist timing...?**”

Rachit didn’t speak.

But in his mind?

Neural pattern: 3 seconds from aggression to phase.

Mist compression: denser when he's frustrated.

Minimum visibility: 0.4 seconds. Phase trajectory—spirals counterclockwise.

Every move wasn't instinct.

It was **measured**.

In the medical room, even **Gaurav** sat upright now, eyebrows raised.

“He’s reading Neer’s entire fight flow,” he muttered. “He definitely has gotten stronger in past months.”

Yugetsu, arms crossed, with a fear in his eyes as if remembering some bad memory added with a shivered voice, “During training he was not much fast but he still dodged all my moves and threw me around the basement like a rag doll and called it a training.”

Anshika smiled a little and spoke: “Currently he is using exactly enough energy to maintain his conditions.”

Aviral: “Two dodges. Unlimited blocks. No blood.”

Swayam, flatly: “Not just a model. A cage.”

Back in the ring—

Neer snarled.

His whip was **flames** now. Coated in condensed heat mist, glowing white-blue at the seams.

“This is where the talking stops,” he growled.

He **charged again**. Five strikes—one after the other.

First arc—**block**.

Twist—**block**.

Fake-out sweep—**barely deflected**.

Reverse-grip jab—**caught in both rods**.

Fifth strike—

Neer faked high, then **slid under**, sweeping his leg to trip Rachit.

The first **close call**.

Rachit bent his knee, dropped his weight—

And flipped backward. A cartwheel, ankles clinking softly, just past the edge of contact.

His foot grazed the glyph line at the edge of the arena—then returned.

Not a ring-out.

Not a dodge.

He *never stepped out*.

Neer was panting now.

Hair unbraided slightly, sweat sticking to his neck.

Rachit?

Still breathing calmly.

Still watching him.

And still—**untouched**.

Ignis:

“Seven hours in. Zero wounds. Two dodges at a time. No violations.”

Elsa:

“And now the longest no-contact solo defense in modern arena history. The man is *rewriting strategy itself*.”

Raktabīja (grudgingly):

“Would’ve ripped his face off five hours ago. But fine. This is... impressive.”

Neer finally broke into a laugh—half-breathless, half-delirious.

“You don’t bleed, you don’t talk, and you *still* haven’t hit me.”

Then he pointed the spear at Rachit’s chest.

“So what *are* you?”

Rachit’s eyes flared—faintly.

Only his lips moved.

“A delay.”

The wind shifted.

Somewhere, time ticked closer to day two.

And **Rachit's real fight**—

—was still *waiting* to begin and Time didn't just pass—it **sank** into the ring like lead.

The glyphs dimmed and re-glowed with each passing hour, marking the relentless cycle. The sun had long disappeared behind Kaali Bhoomi's blood-colored horizon and risen again. Now, the arena bathed in dull gold, the heat of midday soaking into skin, breath, and sweat.

And Rachit was still standing.

His hair clung to his neck. His chest rose in steady, minimal intervals. His body was soaked—**not trembling, not faltering**, but clearly strained.

Not a single drop of blood lost.

But now—he was *dripping*.

The audience murmured not in awe, but in disbelief. Some had slept, eaten, **come back**, and found the same two men on the battlefield. Still fighting.

Or at least... one of them was.

Neer Anbu stumbled to a stop near the center glyph.

His hair was loose now, braid half-undone, white strands sticking to his cheek.

His whip-spear hung limp at his side.

His robes were torn. Chest rising and falling in ragged sighs. He blinked hard.

Then, **threw his hands up**.

“Man. Either kill me or get killed!”

His voice cracked. But it echoed.

“This is the **WORST** battle of my life. Not because it's long—I **don't care about that**. But because you—YOU—” he pointed the spear like an accusation, “are so damn boring!”

No response.

“You give no reaction! No talking! No pain. No expression. Nothing! It's like fighting a... a **sleepwalking calculator!**”

Rachit said nothing.

Still breathing. Still watching.

Neer dropped the spear to the ground with a *clang*.

“Fine. I give up.” He turned toward the edge of the arena glyph. “Let the record show—I *walked off this battlefield with my mind still intact.*”

He stepped forward.

The glyph shimmered slightly as his foot crossed over the boundary.

The crowd murmured.

Some chuckled. Some hissed. But most?

They just **watched**, hypnotized.

Neer trudged forward, dragging his heel along the arena edge glyph, preparing to forfeit.

He paused—half in, half out.

Then his expression flickered.

He **snapped around**, weapon lashing forward in a *final, desperate whip-strike*, launching a cloud of shimmering mist and razor-wind toward where Rachit stood just a few meters behind—

But the strike hit **nothing**.

A pause.

A breath.

And then—

A calm voice **next to his ear**:

"You suck at lying."

Neer's eyes went wide.

He turned—too late.

Rachit stood **beside** him, not behind.

His skin glistened in sweat. His eyes burned low, not with anger—but with a kind of iron stillness.

His right leg rose smoothly—then *slammed* against Neer's chest with a sharp, controlled side-kick.

Neer went flying backward, landing squarely back in the center of the ring.

The glyph shimmered again—confirming the fight still hadn't ended.

Rachit knelt slowly, adjusting the strap of his utility belt. From a hidden side-pouch, he pulled out a small matte-gray bottle—barely a quarter-liter. He popped it open and tilted his head back.

The **sound of gulping** felt louder than the crowd.

Every drop mattered.

His throat was dry. His breath faintly ragged. His body? Tense, pulsing, soaked with layers of sweat. Anklets clinked slightly as he rose again.

Only 250 ml.

But right now?

It was more than enough.

He fastened the cap and slid the bottle back in place.

Another **24 hours** remained.

And he still hadn't struck once.

Ignis (chuckling dryly):

"He even drinks like a ghost. Where the hell did he stash that bottle?"

Elsa (half-whispering, half-awed):

"No blood. No flash. No collapse. Just pure... restraint."

Raktabīja (snorting):

"This fight's like pulling teeth with a whisper. But gods help me—he's still standing."

Audience reactions varied:

Some stood, mesmerized.

Some booed. Others clapped slowly, confused whether to cheer or curse.

A few near the back were **snoring**.

One demon child whispered to their father, "Is this still the same fight from yesterday?"

"Yes," he replied. "And he still hasn't punched anyone."

In the Team Slade resting area:

Slade leaned forward slightly, elbows on his knees, face unreadable.

"...That boy's trying to win without winning," he murmured.

Rezen, seated cross-legged like a statue, spoke for the first time in hours:

"No. He's trying to *wait* without *breaking*."

Slade didn't reply. But his gaze lingered on the two fighters—eyes calculating, reading every breath, every twitch.

Team Kaal's resting side:

Kaal was asleep.

Legs folded. Hands resting on his knees. His head tilted slightly downward, like a giant statue meditating.

Even now, **nothing** stirred him.

Even this was strategy.

Inside the medical room:

Anshika stood over **Gaurav**, hand pressed to his chest, glowing faintly with her healing touch.

His eyes had been fluttering open now and then—but she kept pressing.

“Longer you sleep,” she muttered, “faster you heal.”

A half-conscious grunt escaped him.

“I wanna... see how long he keeps this up...”

Anshika narrowed her eyes. “And I want you *alive*.”

She pressed a pressure point—**his body slumped again**. Out cold.

Yugetsu, leaning by the doorway, folded his arms.

“Two more hours, maybe. Then he’ll hit exhaustion curve.”

Swayam, seated by the wall, nodded once.

“...Then he’ll improvise. Or collapse.”

But there was a glint in his eye.

He knew Rachit wouldn’t collapse.

Not before the **48 hours were done**.

In the ring, Neer pulled himself up again, coughing, wiping his mouth with the back of his wrist.

He stared across the field—at the barefoot, sweat-glazed figure standing there silently.

Rachit’s shoulders rose... fell.

He didn’t reach for a weapon.

He didn’t move forward.

He simply *watched*.

And as the glyph timer shimmered high above—marking **hour 24** complete...

No fanfare. No lightning crack. Just a soft shift in the wind, as if the world itself had inhaled in anticipation.

Rachit's eyes didn't narrow.

They sank.

Deeper into the stillness he had carved out for himself over the last day—an illusion of control built on fatigue, discipline, and silence. But deep inside, he knew...

He was running on glass.

Eight days.

Eight nights.

Not a blink of true sleep.

Only slivers of rest carved into stolen seconds during meditation or breathless walks.

The trembling in his legs wasn't visible.

Not yet.

But he felt it. Every breath now required effort—measured, controlled, rationed like food in a siege.

One mistake... and it would all fall apart.

Across from him, Neer rolled his shoulders. His body was drenched in sweat, breathing ragged—but his fire was not gone. If anything, it was burning sharper now.

"Still standing..." he muttered, flicking his whip-spear outward and drawing a lazy arc in the air.

"Let's see what happens when the ghost has to bleed."

He surged forward again, fast this time—deliberately chaotic. Not with elegance now, but with rage. Strikes came in short flurries, desperate flinches disguised as patterns. A twist of the wrist, a lunge, a spinning drag of the whip meant to pull Rachit closer—and always circling, always driving him further back.

Rachit kept moving. One dodge. One block. Anklets rattled. Feet shifted. The rod hummed with deflections.

But he could feel it.

The edge.

Not metaphorical. Literal.

The glyph-ring under his heels pulsed with a faint crimson as he took one last step back—his heel brushing the warning line that separated arena from void.

He had no more space.

His body wasn't fast enough to sidestep now. Neer was mid-swing, his whip cracking toward Rachit's exposed torso.

And so—

He moved.

For the first time in the entire battle—

Rachit *struck*.

It wasn't flashy. It wasn't cinematic. It was **survival**.

A pivot, inward. One hand pushing the whip aside, the other drawing his rod in a tight arc—blunt-end rising just enough to clip Neer's left ribcage with a **thud**.

Neer's eyes widened—not from pain, but shock.

Because he was still in motion.

And he was now tilting off balance.

There was nothing to grab.

He fell.

Backward.

Over the glyph line.

And just like that—

He was out.

The arena lit up with a crack of blue lightning and golden seal markings:

❖ ROUND RESULT: TEAM SLADE - LOSS

❖ RINGOUT CONFIRMED - NEER ANBU ELIMINATED

The silence hit before the cheers.

A breath.

Then—chaos.

Half the crowd **erupted in noise**, disbelief and awe blending into a roar that rattled the viewing columns. Some stood, eyes wide in shock. Others blinked like they'd just missed it.

In the announcer booth—

Elsa gasped. "He did it. Oh my gods, *he actually did it!* Twenty-four hours of nothing and he wins in one swing—*are you joking?!*"

Ignis exhaled through his nose. "I... I think I need to lie down."

Raktabīja, grinning, added, "And not a *single drop of blood* shed. That's one way to rewrite the meaning of 'killing time.'"

Inside the **medical wing**, the glowing screens flashed the result.

Yugetsu sat up from where he had been dozing in the chair. "...He pulled it off."

Anshika, wiping her brow, shook her head in disbelief. "He wasn't supposed to attack... I thought—"

Swayam, still seated, didn't move. But his jaw clenched.

He knew.

Rachit didn't celebrate because it wasn't a win.

It was a **break**.

A compromise.

And one he'd told Swayam—he **couldn't afford**.

Far above, in the **team resting zones**, **Kaal** opened one eye.

He hadn't moved in hours. Still seated like stone, chin resting on his fist.

He stared at Rachit—who now stood in the middle of the ring, breathing heavily, sweat dripping down the nape of his neck.

Rachit wasn't smiling.

He wasn't proud.

He was just... standing.

Like someone who had bought victory—

at too high a price.

On Team Slade's platform, **Slade** watched with his chin resting on his knuckles.

Rezen, beside him, folded his arms.

"...That wasn't strategy," Rezen muttered.

Slade's lips tightened. "No. That was necessity."

Neer, meanwhile, had landed on his back outside the glyph zone. His limbs sprawled out, chest heaving.

He laughed bitterly.

"Figures," he mumbled to himself. "All that noise... and I still fell for a step-back counter."

In the ring, **Rachit opened the water bottle again**. Only a few drops remained.

He drank.

Not because he was thirsty.

But because the body, when breaking, needs **routine**.

Then he turned his head slowly—just slightly—to the nearest camera orb floating above the arena.

His lips didn't move.

But his eyes **spoke**.

Someone saw that.

Someone knew what that meant.

And now...

he had to survive
one more day.

The new glyph shimmered above the arena, burning itself into visibility with cruel clarity:

RULE: Victory by Heart Extraction Only.

Everything else—points, ringouts, knockouts—was irrelevant now. The arena knew only one truth: kill, or be killed.

A breath passed.

Then Rezen stepped into the ring.

His crystalline forearms glinted beneath the pale arena light. Towering, calm, brutal—he didn't posture or flare power. His gauntlets clicked softly as they locked into place, absorbing memory-stone pulses that pulsed like heartbeats.

Across from him, Rachit barely stood straight.

His bare chest gleamed with sweat, his breath slowed deliberately to conserve what little remained in his body. Twenty-four hours of constant movement, eight days without sleep—and now a titan stood before him.

And still, he stepped forward.

ROUND TWO BEGINS.

Rezen didn't test the waters.

He charged—fast.

The ground cracked under his momentum, stone plates shattering as his bulk propelled like a missile. Rachit barely moved in time, sliding under Rezen's swing as those massive gauntlets crashed where his head had been.

BOOM—!

A blast of wind and dust threw outward.

Rachit spun low and to the left, ankle chains rattling faintly. Rezen turned mid-motion and slammed a punch to the ground, and *crystalline spikes* erupted outward like jagged thunder.

Rachit *jumped*—both feet landing on one shard midair, flipping over. The crowd gasped.

Ignis (announcer): “That’s *pure impact crystal*! Touching that can rupture a heart!”

Raktabija: “And he’s dancing on it like it’s a dinner table!”

From above, Rachit dropped into a dive-kick, but Rezen *blocked* with a raised arm. The collision echoed—metal rod against crystal gauntlet—and the *shockwave* cracked the ring floor in a spiderweb beneath them.

Rachit spun, grabbing one rod from his back, swung it horizontally—aimed at Rezen’s ribs.

CLANG!

Rezen didn’t dodge. He *absorbed*. The kinetic energy traveled through his body into his gauntlets—the crystals glowing faint orange.

Rezen grunted.

Then—

BOOM—he released the stored impact back through his palm.

Rachit raised his second rod just in time, and the blast deflected sideways—but the *force* still launched him off his feet, skidding across the arena floor in a controlled slide.

Slade’s voice (from resting area): “Don’t let him stabilize. He’s on a timer.”

Rezen nodded once—and charged again.

Rachit stood just in time to duck under a hammer-fist. He pivoted around Rezen’s elbow, used both rods like a scissor to *trap* one of Rezen’s arms briefly.

But Rezen twisted, dragging Rachit with him, and slammed his knee toward Rachit’s chest.

CRACK!

Rachit’s forearms caught the knee, bracing with both rods, but his body was *launched back* again. He flipped midair, landing—barefoot—into a reverse crouch.

His arms *shook*. Not from fear. From damage *absorbed without bleeding*.

Still no blood. No cut.

Yugetsu (in medical room): “That’s bad he can’t even quit the fight.?”

Anshika: “He’s nearing collapse.”

Swayam: “He will find a way, as always.”

Gaurav stirred but didn’t wake—his body still under healing enchantments.

This time, Rezen *feinted left* and appeared behind Rachit faster than expected—crystals in his shoulder forming rapid layers.

He punched straight.

Rachit *sidestepped*—but it brushed his ribs.

A *blastwave* shot sideways, knocking both fighters apart.

Rachit rolled to a stop, breathing harder now. He reached to his side, feeling the compression wrap tighten automatically around his ribs. Bruised—but still *no blood*.

Rezen blinked.

Rezen (quietly): “You should be broken by now.”

Rachit stood again, nodding slightly.

Rachit: “I am.”

Audience Reaction:

Many stood now. Some were shouting. Others were silent—watching a man who hadn’t slept in eight days fight a juggernaut who could kill with a slap.

One woman in the stands wept softly.

A child whispered to his father, “He’s fighting like he can’t stop.”

Announcers:

Ignis: “This isn’t just stubbornness. This is a message. He’s *not* trying to win. He’s trying to *endure*.”

Elsa: “And enduring against Rezen is like hugging a mountain during an avalanche.”

Rezen jumped forward with his full bodyweight—gauntlets pulled back, kinetic blasts charging. He was trying to *flatten* Rachit once and for all.

Rachit sprinted forward too.

They *collided* mid-ring—

—but Rachit slid under again, grabbed Rezen’s thigh with one rod for leverage, twisted mid-momentum—

—and *used* the kinetic recoil to *backflip* away, landing in a low crouch.

His breath was ragged now. Muscles *shaking*. Anklets rattling with every step.

But still—no blood.

In resting area, Slade folded his arms, watching intently. He didn’t speak, but his glowing amber eyes narrowed.

Neer, sitting now, sipped water.

Neer: “Told you he was boring. But now he’s turning terrifying.”

Back in ring, Rachit tightened his grip on the rods again. His skin was flushed red from heat and bruises. His eyes half-lidded from exhaustion, but his gaze still locked on.

Above the ring, the rule still shone bright:

TAKE THE HEART.

But he hadn’t even drawn blood.

Not yet.

Rezen came at Rachit again, this time with **double-fisted blows** that cracked the tiles.

Rachit parried the first hit with a rod—*clang*—then **flipped backward**, skidding across the arena with his feet dragging small furrows.

His anklets rattled faintly.

Rezen closed the gap with surprising speed for someone his size and threw a **low kick** toward Rachit’s ribs.

Rachit twisted at the last second, turning mid-air and **catching the blow with his shin**, absorbing the kinetic force with a full roll as he crashed sideways onto the ground—but **immediately kicked up**, back on his feet.

His lips were pale. Sweat dripped down his jaw, tracing old scars. The water flask at his belt was long gone—emptied an hour ago.

Rezen spoke finally, voice like cracked stone.
“You’re running out of time, runner.”

Rachit didn’t answer.

He just stepped forward.

Rezen clenched his fists. The kinetic charge built in his forearms—**crystals glowing brighter**, veins swelling with embedded earth-force.

He stomped and **released a kinetic burst**, a concussive wave aiming to **blow Rachit off his feet**.

Rachit **angled his rod**, spinning into a crouch as the blast swept past, **using its momentum** to swing around Rezen and land a **quick elbow to his back**, followed by a **reverse knee toward the ribs**.

Rezen grunted.

But he was barely fazed.

He **twisted**, backhanding with his crystalline gauntlet—

—**Rachit ducked**, but the shockwave hit his shoulder and **sent him skidding back** ten feet.

The crowd stirred. Finally—visible impact.

In Announcers’ Booth

Ignis, grinning wide now:

“He felt that one. His shoulder dropped an inch.”

Elsa licked her lips.

“And it only took *one* full strike. Rezen’s playing his part. The *anchor*, unmoved.”

In medical room the ones who trusted Rachit there trust was turning into a worry.

Yugetsu: “He’s slowing down.”

Anshika: “He needs to rest—he hasn’t—”

Swayam, cutting in:

“He knows what happens if he stops. That rule. He has to win... or buy time.”

Back in arena

Rezen rushed.

This time faster.

Left jab—Rachit parried.

Right hook—Rachit rolled under.

But Rezen was relentless. A **grapple move** came in.

He caught Rachit by the vest and **lifted him** halfway before **slamming him down**.

The ground cracked beneath.

But as the dust rose...

Rachit was already rolling free.

One rod **jabbed upward**—

—not toward Rezen's chest—

—but to **his left gauntlet's joint**, where memory-stone met skin.

It **clicked** sharply—stunning Rezen's arm for half a second.

Long enough for Rachit to **flip back to his feet**, breathing heavy.

Still not bleeding.

Still not speaking.

But now?

Rachit's fingers twitched.

The vibration hum was starting to gather.

And in the med-room, **Swayam's eyes narrowed.**

"He's about to use it."

Back in arena, the tiles split from beneath Rezen's boots as he launched himself forward—no delay, no feint, just pure forward force.

A single punch.

But it was enough.

It landed.

Right in the center of Rachit's chest.

The sound wasn't of impact—it was *collapse*. A dull, horrifying *thud*, like stone caving in under pressure.

Rachit's body **whipped back**, lifted off the ground like a rag caught in a hurricane.

His mouth opened mid-flight—

—and a thick spurt of **blood burst upward**, splashing against his lips, his chin, spraying in a brief arc toward the clouds above.

His eyes didn't close.

They stayed locked on Rezen.

His arms hung limp in mid-air, body twisting in slow motion—

—and yet, **he swallowed**.

The blood in his mouth—**he drank it down** with a dry, rattling gasp, as though his body wouldn't allow him the weakness of coughing it up.

In the whole audience Gasps rippled.

One half of the audience stood.

The other sat in stunned silence.

Ignis whispered in awe, "That was... clean."

Elsa, her smile fading:

"He felt that one in his spine."

Raktabīja, leaning forward with eyes wild:

"He's going to die if this keeps up."

Back in the ring

The Attack Doesn't End

As Rachit's body flew across the ring toward the edge—

Rezen's boot stomped into the ground with seismic command.

The earth groaned.

A **massive crystal pillar** erupted from the arena tiles beneath Rachit, sharp as a spear, **racing to meet his falling form like death rising to greet him**.

The shard glinted in sunlight.

Rachit's body spun—

—**head downward, feet upward**, a mess of angles and blood—

And in that frozen instant, as the crystal soared—

his left hand shifted.

Just barely.

The fingertips outstretched—**just a breath of skin brushed the surface of the upcoming crystal.**

And then...

"Shatter."

A whisper. No louder than breath.

The instant the word left him, **the arena changed.**

A sound like **glass screaming under pressure** echoed.

The entire shard froze mid-rise—**then ruptured.**

Crack

CRACK

SHHHK-TCHHHHHHHHH!

Like a building of mirrors collapsing inward, **the crystal exploded into powdered dust**, the force of the vibration shooting back down into the earth like thunder seeking refuge.

A **wave of silent force rippled** across the battlefield—

And every audience member felt it in their teeth.

In medical room, Yugetsu shot up.

"Finally he is using it."

Swayam answered without blinking.

"Yeah. Vibration."

Anshika, whispering:

"He shattered *crystal*. That wasn't resonance... that was refined harmonic vibration."

Rachit's body continued falling—but the shattering wave had bought him a split second.

A second he didn't waste.

His **right foot landed** atop one of the still-floating shards mid-air—

He **pushed off** it with barely enough strength, twisting his torso, and flipping upright **just inches before hitting the ground.**

He landed on his knees.

Blood trickled from the corner of his mouth, but his eyes were steady.

Chest heaving.

Ankle rattling.

The rod on his back gleamed under broken light.

Rezen, still standing, looked down at him with renewed respect.

And spoke, for the first time in minutes.

“You shattered my crystal... with a whisper.”

Rachit stood slowly, limbs trembling.

Rezen charged with thunder in his steps.

Each stride shook the ground beneath him as kinetic force built up around his body—**his crystal plates growing sharper**, denser with every second.

But Rachit was already moving.

Faster than breath.

Faster than fear.

He **threw both black metal rods** with a twisting spin—one high, one low, diagonally crossing in air.

Rezen dodged the first—a quick sway of his upper body.

The second he **batted away with his gauntlet**, the clang of metal against crystal ringing like a dull chime.

“Projectile feint?” Rezen muttered under his breath, just before—

Rachit was in front of him.

No weapon.

No windup.

Just a **sudden punch**—clean, sharp, unexpected—**right to Rezen’s jaw.**

CRACK!

It wasn’t a heavy blow.

But it was precise.

And it made Rezen’s head snap to the side with a grimace.

Before Rezen could retaliate—

Rachit vanished.

He didn't teleport.

He **ran**.

Barefoot, his soles skimming the floor like a phantom, kicking up dust and leftover crystal grit from their earlier clash.

In the stands audience's Gasps spread again, confused.

Why was he **running** after finally landing a clean hit?

The camera zoomed in, chasing behind Rezen's head, capturing the sweat rolling down his cheek.

And then—**he felt it**.

A **tingling heat** blooming across his chin.

His fingers brushed his jaw—

—**and found something tied there**.

A small black anklet.

Loose.

Elegant.

Charred slightly at the edges.

His pupils narrowed.

“What the—?”

And then it detonated.

BOOM.

A low, short-range pulse—**not an explosion**, but a *focused directional blast* of **compressed vibration**—

—right into his face.

Rezen staggered back, eyes reeling.

The force didn't pierce his skull—but **it rattled the crystals inside** his own flesh, momentarily knocking his sensory balance offline.

It was as if every echo he'd stored in his body **fought back at once**.

He **dropped to a knee**, clutching his face.

A cracked sliver of crystal **fell from his right cheek** and shattered.

Glyphs shimmered overhead

"Direct impact successful. Target momentarily destabilized."

Elsa gasped:

"Did he just plant an explosive anklet on someone mid-fight—in *the middle of a punch*?"

Ignis, eyes wide with a crooked smile:

"No... that wasn't an explosive. That was *a pressure trap*. He threw the rods to draw focus, landed a hit, and planted a vibration capsule inside a disguised anklet. That was precision. That was restraint."

Raktabīja, chuckling:

"A silent scream in the form of a string. Delicious."

Slade Vaarmire narrowed his glowing amber eyes.

He leaned forward slightly, speaking almost to himself:

"So... he sets mines with his fists."

Neer, still seated, his lip swollen, muttered bitterly:

"Told you he's annoying."

Rezen stood slowly, cracking his neck as he rose.

The damage wasn't permanent.

But his pride?

It had taken the first hit.

Yugetsu, stunned:

"He... he planted an explosive on Rezen while punching him. I didn't even see it."

Anshika, clutching her dagger:

"He's getting reckless. That kind of move could have backfired."

Swayam, calm, watching:

“No. That wasn’t reckless. That was desperation.”

He glanced down at the sleeping **Gaurav**, then said quietly—

“And he’s just getting started.”

Rachit didn’t stop running.

He circled the arena like a shadow chasing its tail—**each breath slower**, each step heavier.

His body was draining—but his focus?

Laser-sharp.

He reached the far edge of the ring again, then turned.

Rezen now stood tall, his nose slightly bleeding, eyes narrowing, lips forming his first real smile of the fight.

“Alright,” Rezen said calmly. “Your move.”

And Rachit?

He walked.

Not ran.

Walked forward.

Like the storm had found its feet again.

The glyph shimmered overhead.

32 hours.

That number pulsed in gold flame—floating like a silent monument above the ring.

The audience—once thunderous—was quiet now. Not bored. Not excited.

But caught in the same breathless stasis as the fight itself.

One man. Two battles. Thirty-two hours.

Rezen's boots struck the ground like hammers to the bones of the world.

With a thunderclap, he stomped his right heel down, hard.

KRRRAKKK—!!

The arena floor ruptured.

Crystalline veins spidered out from the impact point—then **erupted upward**, a storm of jagged **earth-demon crystal lances** growing like sharpened trees from hell.

The ring was no longer flat.

It became a **spiked hellscape**, the once-smooth terrain now a **jagged nightmare of slicing geometry**.

Rachit didn't have time to run.

He landed one step wrong—

—and that was enough.

A sharp crystal shard gashed his sole.

He didn't scream.

But he **winc**ed.

The first real reaction in hours.

Blood pooled beneath his heel, trailing as he leapt to the next crystal edge.

Another shard sliced his foot as he landed.

And another.

And another.

In the stands, **Elsa gasped**, her eyes wide:

“Rachit's bleeding. For the first time in this fight... he's bleeding.”

Ignis's draconic form stirred, golden eyes narrow with curiosity.

“He's still not falling. But this terrain... it was built to make you choose: run, and be cut; stay, and be crushed.”

Raktabija, chuckling, added:

“The ring itself is now a blade. And Rachit's the only one walking barefoot.”

Anshika stood up, panic in her voice.

“He's losing grip—his legs were already shaky and if his blood touches the floor than it's over!”

Yugetsu's voice was cold.

“He hasn't had sleep in over eight days... he's fighting dehydration, blood loss, nerve fatigue.”

Swayam didn't flinch.

He watched, arms crossed, lips tight.

“No... he's still in control. His blood won't be detected as it's mixed in crystals and its dust”

He looked over at the monitor.

But then muttered:

“Run.”

Back in the ring:

Rezen advanced.

Not fast.

Just relentless.

Every step he took **brought up more crystal**, reshaping the field.

Each step was a declaration.

“Your feet bleed on my ground,” Rezen said quietly, voice like echo in stone.

“Now you know what anchoring feels like.”

Rachit’s breathing was deeper now.

Each inhale visible.

Sweat streaked down his ribs. His clothes clung to his skin.

His **bare feet slipped slightly** on the slick red sheen coating the glassy terrain.

But he kept moving.

Sometimes slow. Sometimes sudden.

The **metal anklets around his ankles** clinked faintly, their rhythm now stuttering—**off-tempo**.

He slipped again.

Another gash.

His right ankle now had a **deep horizontal cut**, small **trails of red seeping over black metal**.

Neer, sitting in the rest area, shook his head:

“I danced with him for a day. This guy... is a goddamn ghost. But that’s not ghost blood.”

Slade stood now, arms crossed, jaw tightened.

“He can’t keep this up.”

Rezen, in the ring, watched him bleed and tilted his head.

“This isn’t bravery,” he said as he walked.

“This is self-destruction.”

But Rachit moved again.

He **slid under a vertical pillar** of crystal as it erupted, slicing the sleeve off his left arm.

Another landed just a breath behind him—*too close*.

He turned mid-air, used the bounce to launch himself onto another jagged shard, then—
—**ran along its side**, one foot slicing open again, blood leaving tiny streaks on the tilted surface.

Rezen lunged, fist cocked back.

WHAM!

It crashed where Rachit *had* been.

Instead, **he was behind him**, arm coiled.

A **palm strike** to Rezen's back. The vibration hum was there—but faint.

Too faint to rupture crystal.

Still, it was enough to make Rezen **lose balance** on a loose, growing shard.

He turned, eyes sharp.

"Still holding back," Rezen growled.

Rachit didn't answer.

Just adjusted his footing—wincing slightly—and raised both fists again.

The glyph pulsed again.

"Combat Intensity: Critical."

"Rachit Vital Signs: Unstable but Combat-Ready."

And the announcers' voices returned, sharper now.

Ignis, nearly growling with excitement:

"He's been cut. He's been cornered. He's bleeding... but he's still standing."

Elsa **whispered** almost reverently:

"Thirty-two hours... of no rest... no food... no break... and now barefoot on razors."

Raktabija **laughed, voice like splintered bones:**

"If he doesn't die from blood loss, he'll die from legend."

Rachit's lips moved.

The mic barely caught it.

But one word escaped:

“...Not yet.”

He coughed.

Spat some blood to the side.

Then crouched low—

—and charged.

Not away.

But toward Rezen.

The arena floor gleamed under the overhead glyph, now shimmering a deeper orange—like a dying sun refusing to set.

The crystals that once stood like a maze of blades were now flattened, cracked, or cratered from the sheer pressure of two forces locked in a silent war.

And now... it was no longer a one-sided dance.

It was a fight.

Flesh met crystal. Fist met bone. Step met strike.

Rachit and Rezen were exchanging blow for blow, momentum for momentum.

No tricks.

No delays.

Just rhythm.

Rezen lunged—shoulders squared, crystalline gauntlets glowing with stored kinetic energy.

Rachit *weaved*, letting the first strike graze past his cheek—just enough to feel the force cut air like a bullet.

He ducked under the second, twisted sideways, and **struck the back of Rezen's ribs** with a sharp elbow.

It made a dull crack—vibration rippling through Rezen's back like sound across steel.

Rezen spun on impact and answered with a **knee into Rachit's side**.

Rachit blocked with a forearm, but the impact alone pushed him **backward five meters**, feet sliding over blood-slicked crystal.

Their faces told the truth.

Rachit's eyes were sunken now, dark circles shadowed under the reddish-brown irises.

His chest rose and fell like a man drowning slowly in open air.

But his posture...

Still strong.

Still ready.

Rezen's calm was cracking.

His breathing had grown louder—**not from pain**, but from the **surprise of resistance**.

For the first time, the crystal anchor was not immovable.

His blows landed... and they weren't enough.

Then something shifted.

A low hum began building.

First, like a **whisper beneath the crowd's murmur**...

Then rising... becoming **tangible**... like the feeling of sitting too close to a speaker as bass hits.

The **vibrations** around Rachit's arms began to **intensify**.

His very breath now made tiny fragments around him rattle.

Every time he moved, the black rods on his back shuddered slightly—like tuning forks against the storm.

Yugetsu, still watching from the medical room, suddenly sat up straighter.

His voice rose slightly:

"Wait... that frequency... it's increasing."

Anshika blinked.

"I've never seen him go this far before..."

Swayam just nodded slowly.

"He's finally letting go... but only a little."

He added, colder now:

“You all know why he waits. His Pran is unstable. And the only thing he has full control over—is Jeev Shakti.”

He glanced at **sleeping Gaurav**, face still wrapped in healing bindings.

“And you saw what that did to someone who lost control.”

Back in the ring—

Rezen went in for a punch.

A clean, downward slam.

And for a moment, Rachit didn't dodge.

He took it.

Right to the **shoulder**.

CRACK.

The impact shook him.

His feet bent on the crystal—he nearly dropped.

But his right arm **coiled back**...

His knuckles trembled.

The vibrations sang louder now.

The hum of built-up kinetic resonance pulsed across his body.

Then—

He whispered:

“Resonance.”

And punched.

It wasn't fast.

It wasn't flashy.

It was **precise**.

His fist landed **centered on Rezen's chest plate**, just below the sternum.

A ripple of vibration **pulsed out from the point of impact**—visible, like heat waves across stone.

BOOOOOOOOM.

Both bodies flew **backward in opposite arcs**.

Rezen skidded, arms scraping through the broken crystal terrain—shattering several on impact, crystalline shards spraying outward.

Rachit's hand jerked back from the blow—**his knuckles cracked, skin split**, but **not cut**, just bruised from recoil.

He landed in a crouch, but his body almost buckled.

He caught himself at the last second, **one knee down, both palms trembling**.

Blood welled in his mouth.

He swallowed it before it could fall.

Rezen clutched his chest, breathing heavy.

Not cracked, not broken...

But that punch—he'd *felt* it through every crystal nerve.

His body still functioned.

But he couldn't ignore it.

That was no normal blow, he thought.

That... that reached my marrow.

And in the crowd—

Elsa finally broke the silence with a hushed breath.

"That... was Resonance."

Ignis hissed softly, his massive serpentine form shifting.

"That's not vibration anymore. That's... that's harmonic warfare."

Raktabīja grinned like a child handed a cleaver.

"He's done playing monk. He's becoming weapon."

Slade, still watching from his team's rest corner, leaned forward.

"Finally," he whispered.

"Let's see what he *really* becomes when he bleeds."

And above them all—

The glyph shimmered.

33 hours complete.

The audience didn't scream.

They didn't cheer.

They waited—entranced, afraid to blink.

Because something in the air had changed.

Not just the tempo.

Not just the power.

But the **intention**.

Rachit rose slowly, uncoiling from the earth like a shadow returning to its shape.

His expression unreadable. His stance unhurried.

No blood spilled, but the damage inside him was clear to any who looked close enough.

And then—without warning—

He turned.

And **ran**.

Gasps erupted through the stands like waves breaking a dam.

Rachit— the man who had endured thirty-three hours of relentless battle, who had calculated every move like a monk at war with fate—

Was now **sprinting** toward the **northern gate** of the arena.

No flourish. No exit gesture.

Just **deliberate retreat**.

“Is he... running away?” Ignis muttered, the coils of his draconic body tensing.

Elsa's lips parted in disbelief, a thousand conflicting emotions swimming behind her eyes.

“He can't—he wouldn't...”

Even **Raktabīja**, blood-slicked and grinning, hesitated.

“Wait... is this... cowardice?”

The gate door slammed behind Rachit with a loud clang of old iron.
He locked it from inside, twisting the ancient bolt into place with trembling fingers.

No audience.

No lights.

Just the **cold silence** of the corridor that led behind the northern wall.

He dropped to the ground like a falling thread, back against stone, and pulled off the utility wrap from his waist.

Blood oozed from the soles of his feet, fresh and dark.

He opened a cloth pouch—small, old, frayed at the corners. Inside: **strips of bandage**, stained from use but clean enough.

With practiced precision, he wiped the floor first—**no traces** could remain.

Then he began to wrap his ankles and arches tightly, stopping the bleeding.
Every knot pulled made his arms tremble more.

His mouth was dry.

Breath shallow.

But he moved with the precision of a man who had done this **hundreds of times before**.

Back in the arena—

The crowd was in chaos.

Some **booed**. Some **shouted**. Some stood still, **trying to understand**.

In the announcer's box, the glyph shone brighter now, rewriting itself—reminding all:

❖ VICTORY CONDITION: TAKE THE OPPONENT'S HEART.

❖ LOCATION: NOT SPECIFIED.

The realisation hit like thunder in slow motion.

Elsa blinked, then whispered:

“Wait... there's no rule that says the extraction has to happen *in* the arena.”

Ignis's slit eyes widened.

“He's not running...”

Raktabīja howled with delight.

“He's **luring**.”

Slade stood slowly, his arms crossed.

A slow smile curved across his lips—proud, bitter, admiring.

“He weaponized the rules...”

Inside the darkened halls of Kaali Bhoomi’s northern wing, the sound of footsteps echoed—calm but growing faster.

Rachit had moved deeper now.

His breathing steadied with every step.

Not recovered.

But **composed**.

He didn’t look back.

Because he didn’t have to.

He *knew* what would come next.

Back on the field, **Rezen finally understood**.

The confusion in his calm gaze evaporated.

He looked toward the gate Rachit had vanished into... and clenched his gauntleted fists.

No hesitation. No roar. No demand for answers.

Just **motion**.

He strode forward, quiet and full of purpose.

Each step heavier than the last.

At the gate—three punches.

Each one struck with controlled fury, each hit causing the barrier to shatter inch by inch—cracks forming like spiderwebs of light through crystal.

Then—

BOOM.

The northern gate **crumbled**.

He stepped through.

And entered **Rachit’s terrain**.

The arena watched in silence.

The announcers held their breath.

And deep inside the northern hallways, beneath the ghost-lit torches and ancient glyph-scorched walls—

The **hunt** had begun.

The dust still hadn't settled from the broken gate, but Rezen didn't wait for silence.

He surged forward—**boots pounding** through ancient stone.

The corridors of Kaali Bhoomi's northern interior were carved from black rock and memory, twisted with age, layered with secrets. Glyphs flickered and died on the walls as he passed, reacting to the foreign crystal energy vibrating through his blood.

He **didn't stop**.

He **didn't slow down**.

He didn't even **breathe through his mouth**—he just **ran**, arms tensed, ready to snap forward at any second.

Each step shattered something: cracked tile, splintered a wooden barrier, collapsed a prayer wall meant for quiet offerings.

He was smashing through not just architecture—but **history**.

And still...

No sign of Rachit.

—

Far away, deep inside one of Kaali Bhoomi's sky-chambers, where the windows curved like thorned ribs and the ceiling bled slow-dripping fire—

Lilith reclined sideways on her velvet throne, one thigh hung lazily over the armrest, her silver-black hair coiled around her fingers like a whisper of smoke.

A dark mirror hovered in front of her, its surface rippling softly with the live feed from the arena.

She licked her lower lip as Rezen burst through another wall in pursuit of his prey.

Her laugh was slow. Soft. Predatory.

"Rachit," she murmured to herself, eyes glinting like poisoned garnets. "Every time he breathes, the world tightens."

A pale-skinned demoness stepped beside her—maid uniform crisp, a decanter of bloodwine balanced perfectly in her hand.

She hesitated. "Mistress... forgive me, but... why are you watching this one so closely? He's... just human."

Lilith tilted her head toward her, still smiling, as if tasting something beautiful the maid couldn't see.

"My pretty fool," she said. "This world, is an elaborate tapestry of lies and... if you look closely you will understand, that he is the lie eater."

She leaned in close, whispering like it was a confession only meant for ghosts.

"He's not special because of what he does.
He's special because he can't help what's coming."

Then she turned her gaze back to the mirror.

And smiled wider.

—

Back underground, in the bowels of the old arena—

Rachit didn't run blindly.

Every twist of his path was measured.

Every corridor he chose, every sharp turn, every moment of stillness—**intentional**.

He didn't panic.

His breathing was steady, but dry—his throat burning. The blood-soaked bandages around his feet were wet again. He moved like a wraith on fire, silent even as pain radiated from every limb.

And still—**he did not stop**.

He was leading Rezen.

Guiding him, like a hunter luring prey not into a trap—

—but into **truth**.

Rachit passed through a wide, open arch.

The walls widened suddenly.

He stepped through a **room of silence**.

Inside—an old demon shaman, ancient and robed in soot-black linen, knelt in front of a massive black idol. Its body twisted with **ten arms**, each one holding a weapon or relic—one held a severed head, another a bowl of black fire, another a fetus of stone.

A halo of **dripping ash** hung above the idol's head.

It was a place of worship.

A room built to venerate the **Kāli Purush**—the Great Hunger beneath all creation, the silent force that fed on endings.

Rachit didn't bow.

He simply passed through.

But the shaman's chanting wavered, eyes flickering open. He turned, just in time to see the human vanish into the shadows beyond the altar.

—

A moment later—

Rezen entered.

But he **did not** crash this time.

He stopped at the edge of the threshold.

His chest rose and fell once—slow and deep. He didn't look at the shaman, or the room. But his eyes fell upon the black idol.

He took a knee.

He bowed.

Not as a worshipper.

But as a warrior acknowledging a throne **older than kings**.

The announcers gasped.

From above, where the magical vision floated to every corner of the audience, **Ignis** whispered with a reverence that hadn't touched his voice in centuries:

"He's taken the battle to the temple of Kāli Purush..."

Elsa, barely able to speak, clutched her quill against her lips. "No one's ever dared fight in that room. Not during a Trial. Not like this."

Raktabīja exhaled through his teeth, amused and horrified.

"Either they'll die in there..."

Or they'll wake him."

—

Somewhere deep in the old temple, Rachit's steps echoed once more.

He knew Rezen was behind him now.

He could feel it—not as a threat. But as a **constant**.

A weight closing in.

The old stories said the demon gods hated noise.

And Rachit's silence now, in these black halls—

Was louder than a war cry and,

There, shadows bent like prayer beads on fire.

Rachit stood at the far edge of the temple hall, the glow of ceremonial torches casting long slashes of gold and bloodlight across his skin. The floor beneath him was a patchwork of black stone slabs—each carved with forgotten demon verses, sigils so old they pulsed faintly in the presence of warriors.

And from the archway of broken pillars—

Rezen stepped in.

His breath steamed in the temple air.

He scanned the room.

And found him.

Rachit.

Waiting—barefoot, bruised, barely holding upright.

But still waiting.

No words were spoken.

There was no crowd here.

No roaring announcers, no audience screams.

Only the idol watched.

Ten arms of stone loomed behind Rachit, each casting a silent shadow like a judge unwilling to intervene.

The two charged—clashing in a feral blur of blows.

Rezen, despite exhaustion, was still fast. Each step he took left behind tiny cracks of crystal, forming momentary runes beneath his boots before fading. His gauntlets glowed faintly with stored kinetic energy—each punch like a memory of thunder. His body curved, leaned, struck like stone guided by rhythm.

Rachit, now past thirty-five hours without sleep, fought like fire encased in ice. Every movement was conserved, coiled, minimal—but his instincts burned loud. He sidestepped, ducked low under a wide swing, parried a fist with his forearm. His bare feet slid against the etched stone floor—blood smearing across divine verses, leaving a trail behind him.

They broke apart for a breath.

Rachit turned and **ran toward the idol**.

Rezen, knowing it was no retreat, followed—his massive boots cracking the floor with every step. They collided again, this time beneath the shadow of the **Kāli Purush**.

The statue towered above—its black eyes empty but watchful.

Candles flickered from bowls held by its hands.

The twin-faced skulls carved into its base almost seemed to grin wider as the fight dragged on.

Rachit's hands trembled.

Rezen's gauntlet smashed into his side.

He staggered.

Rezen didn't let him recover.

A blur of motion—

And Rachit was **grabbed by the throat**, lifted high above the temple floor. His legs kicked once in midair before going still—eyes fixed calmly on Rezen.

"You're not weak," Rezen said, breathing hard. "You're relentless. But this—"

He squeezed tighter.

"—this ends here."

Rachit's lips curved into a broken smile.

"No," he whispered.

Then—**he raised his right hand**.

Far above them, suspended by a thick, rusted chain, the **temple bell** hovered in place.

Monstrous in size, wide enough to cover a dozen corpses. Its edges were etched in old prayer glyphs, each letter glimmering faintly under sacred moss.

From inside the hollow curve of the bell—**two black rods fell**.

Rachit's rods.

They dropped past the chain.

And **sliced through it** as they fell.

The chain snapped.

The bell dropped.

A soundless moment held time hostage.

Then—**CRASH**.

The bell **slammed** over both of them.

At the last instant, Rachit threw himself backward, hitting the ground and rolling as the monstrous bell came down like a war god's fist.

Rezen wasn't so lucky.

The impact thundered through the temple—dust exploded in a ring around the fallen bell. Cracks webbed outward like starbursts. **Rezen's arm**—his left, thick and plated—**jutted out from under the rim**, crushed and twitching.

Inside—he was silent.

Outside—Rachit didn't move at first.

Then he slowly sat up, **his body shaking**. He crawled toward the bell, dragging himself with elbows and knees. One of his eyes was nearly swollen shut now. His mouth bled again, but he didn't spit.

He simply leaned against the bell.

And **placed both his palms flat on its metal**.

The metal was cold. Ancient. It pulsed with the trapped breath of centuries.

And then—

He spoke.

One word.

A word that didn't echo—it **resonated**.

"Resonance."

And the bell **sang**.

A note rang out—not music, but **violence distilled into sound**.

The kind of tone that pierced bone marrow and rattled teeth loose.

It echoed through every hallway, every glyph wall, every demon shrine of the Kaali Bhoomi.

In the **arena**, the audience fell silent again.

Some **fell to their knees**, blood leaking from their ears.

In the **commentator's tower**, even the monstrous Raktabīja flinched.

"That sound... it was made by a human?"

Elsa wiped blood from her ear and shook her head.

"No. Not human. Not fully."

Ignis curled tighter in his seat, scales rippling.

“He’s tuning into something primal now. Using something like a bell used to worship god to win, what a mad he had to be to do it.”

—

In the **medical room**, Yugetsu was already up, pacing.

“Damn it,” he muttered. “He’s gonna kill himself doing this.”

Swayam leaned forward, fists clenched.

“He’s not trying to win anymore,” he said.

Anshika whispered, “Then what is he doing?”

Swayam answered, eyes sharp:

“He’s trying to keep a promise.”

And beside him, **Gaurav**, still sedated, stirred briefly before falling unconscious again.

—

Back inside the temple—**silence fell again**.

Rachit sat beside the bell, too weak to stand.

Inside, Rezen had passed out cold.

The vibrations had shattered his crystal network, fried the kinetic memory in his gauntlets, and sent every shard inside his body into disarray.

But the rules were cruel.

Victory required one thing:

To gouge out the heart.

And Rachit—

—he didn’t have the strength to lift the bell again.

He simply slumped against it, eyes half-shut, blood drying at the corners of his mouth.

A single breath escaped him.

Not tired.

Not satisfied.

Just **surviving** and he fainted.

Body slumped over the bell, like a stack of grains against a wall trying to get support.

And after what felt like an eternity,
The temple's silence was broken not by battle—
—but by pain.

A scream tore through the stillness.

“Noooo... not again!”

Rachit's eyes flew open, bloodshot and wild.

His body convulsed for a moment, limbs spasming as if waking from drowning. His forehead pressed to the cold stone floor as if grounding himself in reality, in the now, in anything other than what he had just seen in his sleep.

Memories?

Hallucinations?

Whatever they were, they hurt more than any blade.

His breath caught—stuttering, desperate.

And then—

He remembered.

Rezen.

The bell.

The fight.

The time.

Rachit slowly rolled over, the bones in his arms creaking like rusted hinges. His knees scraped against the prayer-scarred stone floor as he tried to rise.

He got one foot beneath him.

Then the other.

And—

Collapsed.

His cheek struck the floor hard, a sharp crack that echoed against the stone idol of Kāli Purush looming above.

From the crushed entry to the temple, wind filtered in—soft and low, carrying echoes of the **glyphs outside** shimmering alive again:

 **47 hours complete.**

 **1 hour remains.**

And across the arena, in the open stadium where audience and earth met—

Chaos had turned to awe.

The Audience

At first, it was murmurs. Small, hesitant.

Then the murmurs grew.

“Is he still... alive?”

“He’s still inside?”

“That human’s lasted forty-seven hours?”

A fire demon in the back of the upper terrace shook his head, his third eye wide open in disbelief.

Below, a group of younger spectators stared at the northern temple entrance as if it were the mouth of a living myth.

“Do humans really have that much stamina?” one whispered.

Another replied, “No. They shouldn’t.”

In announcer tower,

Ignis, for once, wasn’t moving.

His massive serpentine body was coiled tightly, expression unreadable.

Even Raktabīja had stopped grinning, his cleaver resting idle on the desk.

It was Elsa who broke the silence. Her voice, for once, didn’t carry its usual intoxicated lilt.

“Forty-seven hours... He’s been fighting for forty-seven hours straight. First Neer. Then Rezen. And he’s still—alive.”

She leaned forward, lips parting just slightly.

“And he’s still trying.”

Raktabīja finally spoke, low and grim:

“This isn’t just willpower anymore.”

“This is war against his own body.”

In southern team resting zone

Slade Vaarmire stood now, arms crossed, watching the entrance to the temple like a commander waiting for an omen.

Neer Anbu sat cross-legged nearby, his injuries bandaged, chin resting on his palm. His silver eyes weren't laughing anymore.

He let out a tired exhale.

"That guy's not a fighter," he muttered.

"He's a ghost with bones."

Even Rezen's name—etched into the arena records—had started to **glow faintly**, signaling signs of vital recovery.

He was waking up.

Team Kaal

Back at the medical suite, Gaurav was still sedated—his brow twitching in discomfort from fevered dreams. Yugetsu, now fully conscious, paced like a caged predator.

Aviral sat beside Anshika, bandaged but quiet.

Swayam stared at the arena screen with narrowed eyes, arms crossed.

No emotion.

Just calculation.

"One hour left," he said.

Anshika looked over, hopeful.

"Will he make it?"

Swayam didn't answer right away.

But eventually, he said:

"He'll move. No matter what."

"He's Rachit."

Inside the Temple

The first sound to break the silence was **stone grinding against metal**.

A slow movement.

Rezen's fingers.

They curled.

Then his arm twitched.

His body shifted beneath the weight of the shattered bell. The edges groaned against his armor. His crushed arm—still bleeding—twitched as if shaking off the pain.

His eyes opened beneath the shadowed dome.

The bell still echoed—faint tremors humming across the stone like memory refusing to fade. Rachit's body trembled against the cold temple floor, joints locking and unlocking as if his bones no longer trusted him to stand.

He crawled toward the arched doorway, dragging himself inch by inch, broken fingernails scraping against rune-marked stone. His breaths were shallow, each one carrying the weight of near-collapse, yet he moved—because time demanded it.

As he reached the frame of the doorway and clutched its edge to pull himself upright, a deep voice echoed from the dark behind him. Calm. Disciplined. Measured like ritual, yet powerful enough to pierce through fatigue and blood-loss.

“You shouldn’t leave without bowing and offering to your god or he might take something he likes.”

The voice belonged to the **shaman**—an old demon, robed in dark silks embroidered with obsidian thread. His horns were wrapped in prayer cloth, his eyes glowing faintly like dying coals behind the incense smoke. He had not moved from his kneeling position in nearly twelve hours, observing everything. Watching.

Rachit paused. His chest rose, fell. A breath caught.

He turned his head slightly, just enough that his face was visible through sweat-matted hair.

Then he whispered—dryly, truthfully:

“I’m an atheist.”

And he stepped out.

One hand dragged against the wall, the other cradling his abdomen. He limped forward, each step a negotiation with agony.

The temple corridors spiraled like a maze of ruin and memory, torches flickering with whispering flames.

As he passed through the long corridors, he muttered to himself, the words nearly drowned by his own labored breath.

“With this rule...”

“...I can stretch the fight as long as I want...”

He paused, glancing down at his **right hand**—split across the knuckles, raw beneath dried blood. He flexed the fingers slowly. Pain flared like lightning up his forearm.

“...but this body...”

He exhaled through clenched teeth, his back leaning against the wall for support.

“...guess even will has a limit.”

The glyph-rule etched in the sky was clear—

"To win: Take the opponent's heart."

He looked at his palms.

At his trembling, battered arms.

“Can I even do that now?”

He pushed onward.

Medical Wing – Team Kaal Rest Chamber

Monitors pulsed. Hologlyphs displayed biometric vitals. The room, though distant from the temple, was alive with tension.

Swayam stood by the edge of Gaurav's bed, arms crossed. His eyes, unreadable.

Anshika sat near Aviral, who was half-upright now, feverish and wide-eyed.

Yugetsu, pacing back and forth like a thread about to snap, finally growled, “This is madness. He needs to pull out. He needs to stop—”

Anshika shook her head slowly.

“He's not the kind who stops.”

Yugetsu looked toward Swayam, searching for a rational voice.

But Swayam's answer came without turning around.

“He always finds a third way.”

His fingers tightened slightly at his sides.

Back in the Temple Corridors

Rachit's footsteps faded.

He was gone.

Swallowed into the deep veins of Kaali Bhoomi's temple.

And far behind—

The **shaman** turned his head slightly toward the idol of Kali Purush, his voice so faint it could've been a whisper to the stone itself.

“He denied the god.”

“But even atheists bleed in temples.”

Moments Later – Back inside the shattered prayer hall

Rezen’s fingers twitched.

Then his elbow.

Then—**CRACK**—his shoulder shifted beneath the collapsed bell. With a roar that split the silence, Rezen’s crystalline muscle surged and the shattered bell rolled aside, leaving him kneeling in dust.

His breath came hard, his arm mangled from the bell’s edge. But his eyes were open—focused.

He looked at the idol once more.

And bowed his head.

“Thank you... for everything.”

Then he stood.

Every motion left tiny cracks in the stone beneath his boots.

And he **ran**.

Stone walls blurred past him, old prayers carved into each one.

He smashed through arches and stepped over collapsed columns—each step thunderous.

Outside – The Arena Audience

The view from the screens was chaos. The audience leaned forward, straining to keep up. The fight had broken into the temple’s inner sanctums—uncharted zones, sacred spaces where no match had ever reached.

And still... no victor.

A thunder demon in the front row exhaled, palms sweaty. “He’s still running. Both of them.”

A child beside him whispered, “What’s he even trying to do?”

Elsa leaned toward her mic, barely able to process.

“Ladies and gentlemen...”

“...this is not a match anymore. This is penance. Ritual. Endurance carved into muscle.”

Ignis stirred behind her, tail twitching.

“Let them go.”

“Let them bleed until the glyphs decide who still has purpose.”

The northern temple swallowed both names now—**Rachit** and **Rezen**.

But only one would leave with the other’s heart.

And Rachit—

Was still walking.

Still thinking.

Still looking... for that third way and Rezen,

He was running.

His boots cracked over fossilized petals scattered across the stone floor—remnants of offerings never cleaned, wilted centuries ago. The ceiling above him wept condensation, and every breath he took steamed into the cold. The corridor twisted, an artery of old gods and deeper glyphs, curving left—then abruptly right—then opening into a chamber at the end.

There—just ahead.

Rachit’s back.

Walking. Limping. Disappearing into a room lit faintly from within.

Rezen’s speed surged. His crystal-laced arm raised, ready to—

CRACK!

He didn’t knock.

The heavy wooden door burst apart in a thunderous fracture of hinges and splinters. Dust and light spilled into the corridor as he stepped inside.

A quiet room.

And in its center—**Johan**.

Sitting.

A single knee bent, arms resting loosely over it. A projection glyph hovered midair above his lap, showing the fight’s glyph-timeline: both Rachit and Rezen’s vitals, scores, paths. The display flickered like a lazy firefly in a bottle, distorting now and then as if reacting to the temple’s tremors.

Johan didn’t look startled. Didn’t rise.

Just glanced over his shoulder, a flick of eyes—not even a full turn.

“I saw that human walk in here,” Rezen said, voice like gravel hitting water. “Where is he?”

Johan’s voice came soft, unaffected. “I don’t know.”

His hand reached into the glyph’s interface, casually swiping it to rewind their match feed.

He studied it.

Then asked without blinking, “Why haven’t you won yet?”

Rezen’s jaw locked. His breathing was slow, but hot.

Johan kept watching the display. “He’s weaker than you.”

No answer.

No movement.

Rezen turned to leave.

He was halfway through the doorframe when Johan’s voice returned, mild—almost curious.

“Maybe because he’s just smarter than you.”

The words struck—not loud, not sharp—but deliberate, like a scalpel tracing where it would cut.

Rezen stopped.

The stone groaned faintly beneath his feet as he stood still. Then—a **spike of crystal** surged from the ground behind the doorway, clean and sharp.

It missed Rachit’s head **by an inch**.

Rachit exploded out from behind the wall, **kicking Rezen full in the chest**.

The impact wasn’t powerful—but sudden.

Rezen stumbled back a half-step. Rachit, bleeding and breathless, didn’t stay. He bolted through the opposite corridor like a shadow in retreat.

But in the chaos, the crystal had struck a side-table.

On it, a simple sculpture—a **glass bird**, handblown and delicate—**toppled and shattered**.

The sound was small. Barely audible.

But Johan’s head turned.

His gray eyes found the fragments.

His voice came, this time quieter. Almost personal.

“Fix it.”

Rezen didn’t even look back. “It’s broken.”

He stepped toward the corridor, resuming pursuit.

“Buy a new one.”

He took one more step.

And then—**WHIP-CRACK**—

Rezen’s body twisted as **Johan’s boot collided with the left side of his jaw.**

The strike wasn’t wide.

It wasn’t dramatic.

It was surgical.

And it **launched Rezen sideways, shattering through three stone pillars, two sacred walls,** and finally crashing hard through a **seventh partition**—collapsing in a rain of rubble.

The silence that followed was deafening.

Johan didn’t chase. Didn’t even move.

He stood there, hands still at his sides, his breath steady.

His voice rose like an afterthought.

“Why don’t you try to buy a new win?”

Then—he turned. Walked away from the broken sculpture without looking at it again.

As he passed Rachit, he didn’t stop. Just glanced once—briefly.

Muttered:

“Weakling.”

And vanished down a shadowed corridor, becoming one more ghost of the temple.

Rachit stood alone.

Still bleeding.

Still breathing.

But no longer hunted.

He looked through the shattered path, walls broken in a perfect trajectory. At the far end, slumped and gasping—

Rezen.

Coughing dust. Crystals fractured across his back. Jaw bloodied. Hands gripping cracked stone.

Rachit walked forward. Not fast. —just deliberate.

Each footfall sounded loud now, as if the temple itself was listening.

One step over fallen prayer scrolls.

Another over shattered offerings.

Then—

BZZZZZT

A sudden glyph lit in the temple sky. All around the inner sanctum—above every arch and brazier.

A sound pulsed through the arena network—a low bass hum followed by a chime.

Announcer Booth

Elsa's breath caught.

Ignis sat up fully, alert.

Raktabija's expression was unreadable.

“Announcement from the Kaali Bhoomi Tournament Council,” Elsa read, voice tight. “Match status: **cancelled** due to unauthorized interference.”

The audience gasped.

“Teams involved: Kaal and Slade.”

“Verdict: Both teams will receive equal points. **200 points each.**”

The entire arena erupted in noise—shock, outrage, laughter, and disbelief mixing together.

In Lilith's Private Chamber

The screen dimmed.

Lilith sat on a velvet-draped lounge, wineglass swirling in her hand.

A slow smile curled at the edge of her lips.

“Interesting,” she whispered.

Her long nails tapped twice against the crystal stem.

“Wolf in sheep skin seeing Sheep in wolf skin.”

Contestants everywhere froze mid-training, mid-recovery, mid-fight.

Kiel blinked at the match-feed.

Syra spat her drink.

Even Atheron—cold and calculating—leaned forward just a touch.

Temple – Inner Sanctum

The wind had returned.

It carried incense and old prayers and ash.

Rachit stood near Rezen's broken form.

Not in triumph.

Not in anger.

Just... studying him. Silent.

The third way had found him.

And it hadn't required a kill.

In medical suite,

The glow of healing glyphs dimmed into blue pulses across the walls. Curtains of mist-veined cloth hung between beds, fluttering slightly from the temple's occasional tremors. An antiseptic scent mixed with incense drifted in quiet waves. Monitors whispered vitals like lullabies meant to soothe warriors too used to screaming.

Gaurav stirred.

The pale light caught the bandages wrapped around his thigh. He flexed his jaw slowly, the crackling of neck vertebrae audible as he shifted upright against the headrest.

Everyone else was watching the suspended glyph screen near the far wall—**the match had just ended.**

Or rather, **been ended.**

Yugetsu was curled on the long couch in the corner, legs folded beneath him, biting into a fruit-stuffed rice ball. His eyes, though sleepy-looking, hadn't moved from the replay once.

Swayam stood near the window in his **Krotha attire**, arms folded behind him like a shadow still mid-performance. His swords were crossed behind his back, untouched but watching.

Aviral sat up straight on his bed, back no longer slouched. He was fully healed—only the thin white line near his ribs remained as a whisper of yesterday's wounds. Anshika stood beside him, her hands behind her back, watching the replay without blinking.

Rachit had walked away limping.

Rezen had been left broken.

Johan had broken the match, the rules, and seven walls.

The room held that silence—the kind that knew no one wanted to be the first to speak.

So of course... Gaurav did.

“Reminds me of that time I volunteered to distract those jail guards,” he muttered, his voice dry, croaky. “Got halfway down the corridor, started a fire, screamed like an idiot... but slipped and fell straight into sewage.”

He glanced around.

Not a single chuckle.

Only blinking, stunned faces.

Gaurav rolled his eyes. “You all missed the funny part. I still managed to get away. Just... covered in human regrets.”

Yugetsu blinked twice, then slowly snorted.

Swayam looked like he was going to argue the punchline, but instead said, “You almost died that day.”

“Yeah,” Gaurav smiled faintly. “So did he today. That's why it's funny.”

The screen dimmed. The match glyphs disappeared. Official result: **200 points to Team Kaal. 200 to Team Slade. Match: Cancelled.**

Swayam turned from the window. The veil of detachment dropped from his voice.

“I’ll go bring him here.”

“No,” Yugetsu spoke up, rolling sideways on the couch. “You’re Krotha. You can’t just show up as yourself anymore. You go meet him like that ruin the disguise and before he takes your help he will be lecturing you.”

“I’ll handle it—” Swayam started again, his voice low.

“I’ll go,” Yugetsu offered, standing now, brushing crumbs from his jacket.

“No,” Anshika interjected, walking toward the door. “I’ll go.”

Yugetsu tilted his head, eyes wide. “Why can’t I?”

Aviral, Swayam, and Gaurav answered in perfect sync:

“Because you’re too dumb.”

Yugetsu stared at each of them, betrayed. “You guys rehearse that or...?”

“No,” Anshika said as the door closed behind her.

Southern Corridors – Team Slade’s Resting Wing

Steam curled from the floor tiles.

Slade stood.

So did Neer, his hands tucked into his flowing sleeves, his silver tattoos dim in the light.

They said nothing.

They walked into the deeper south wings—where no screens played, no glyphs floated, only statues of nameless warriors stood in silent rebuke.

Neer sighed, finally.

“He won’t speak of it.”

“Then we don’t ask,” Slade answered, eyes closed briefly. “He held his own. That's enough.”

Northern Corridor – Kaal’s Private Route

Far from the healing wards and viewing chambers, a weight moved through the stone hallway like a tide too old to explain itself.

Kaal walked.

Not quickly.

Not with concern.

He had seen the match. All of it.

And now, he walked not toward Rachit—but away.

Because in his mind, **if Rachit couldn’t handle this**, then he was **never meant to stand beside them in what came next**.

Rachit walked alone—past collapsed offerings and broken tiles.

The limp in his step had worsened. His shirt clung to him, stiff with dried blood.

His fingers still trembled, echoing the last feedback of Rezen’s prana.

And though his voice was hoarse, it cut clean through the silence.

He glanced back once, at the rubble-strewn path behind him.

Muttered to no one:

“Buy a new win.”

A faint smirk ghosted across his face. Just once.

Then, he turned right—into the corridor ahead.
Each step forward dragged like a promise made under oath.
His breath slowed. Vision wavered.

Then it struck.

A flash. A hallucination—or a vision born from his own unstable prana.
It wasn't new. His prana had never obeyed him—never stayed calm.
And in that flicker of a moment, he felt it.

Déjà vu.

He had walked like this before. Broken. Battered. Alone.

He blinked—
And it vanished.
Gone as if it had never been.

He stood there a second longer, caught between past and present,
Uncertain of what he had seen,
And even more unsure of what it meant.

Yet he moved.

One foot forward. A stagger. Another. His limp had deepened—now more drag than step. Blood
crusted like dried lacquer across the seams of his vest. The sound of his own heartbeat echoed
louder than his footsteps.

Then, behind him—
A voice.

Familiar. Calm. Warm like a flame refusing to die out in a frozen world.

“There you are.”

Rachit didn't turn. He didn't need to.

Anshika's soft footsteps approached, her silhouette emerging from the lingering mist of spent
spells and scorched air. The hem of her violet skirt stirred as she walked—shifting from charcoal
to iridescent blue under the flickering temple lights. Her detached sleeves whispered against her
skin, runes softly glowing in pale lilac as she extended a hand toward him.

“If you weren't oozing with this ridiculous *jeev-shakti* of yours,” she said, tone equal parts
chastising and amused, “I'd never have found you down here.”

She moved to his side without hesitation and hooked his arm over her shoulder. Rachit didn't
protest—just let his weight settle into hers, his gaze still fixed forward, jaw locked and silent. His
face was unreadable—stone carved from exhaustion and pride. But his arm? It trembled against
her collarbone.

They walked. Slowly. The corridor ahead stretched like a tunnel to nowhere, lit by the dim pulse of fading barrier lights and flickers of distant crystal-lanterns.

After a long silence, Anshika broke it.

“You know,” she said gently, eyes forward, “you’re pretty mature for a 16-year-old.”

Rachit said nothing.

She side-eyed him with the ghost of a grin. “Swayam wanted to come drag you to the medical suite, you know. Said he’d carry you himself if he had to.”

Rachit let out a breath. It wasn’t a laugh. Not quite.

“...Idiot,” he muttered.

“*You’re* no better,” she fired back without missing a beat. “Two-day non-stop battle in the name of ‘strategy’? You might be smarter than the rest of us, Rachit, but you’re also a goddamn lunatic.”

Rachit’s lips twitched—just for a second. A half-chuckle broke through, sharp with pain. “I’ll take that as admiration.”

Anshika rolled her eyes. “You would.”

They walked a few more paces, their steps uneven—his limp against her steadiness forming a kind of rhythm, like a broken metronome still trying to keep time.

“So,” Rachit said eventually, voice dry. “How are they? Aviral and Gaurav.”

Anshika’s expression softened. “Aviral’s fine. He’ll be able to fight at full strength by tonight. As for Gaurav—he still needs another full healing cycle. I’ll give it to him before dawn so he’s ready for tomorrow’s match.”

Rachit nodded slightly, his eyes flicking downward. “How many cycles do you have left?”

“One. Well, half of one,” she admitted.

“And your replenishment?”

“By midnight. Maybe a little earlier if I meditate properly.”

Rachit stopped walking for a breath, then said, “Use the half-cycle on me. Now.”

She hesitated. “You sure? It’s not—”

“I’m sure.”

Wordlessly, she shifted, turning to face him more fully. One hand pressed to his chest, just over the sternum. Her palm hovered there for a second, as if reading his heartbeat.

Then she activated it.

A soft *hum* escaped her lips—almost imperceptible, like the start of a lullaby. From her fingertips, light bloomed. Green at first. Healing. Warm.

Then—

It turned crimson.

Flickered to deep blue.

And then—

Black.

The corridor darkened as if swallowed whole. Shadows rippled from Rachit's chest, writhing against her palm. The healing light cracked—warped. His unstable *prana* had surged up and around her fingers, swallowing her aura whole.

Then—

Silence. Emptiness.

No healing took root. No wounds mended.

Anshika pulled her hand back sharply, her brow furrowed, voice tight with the answer they both already knew.

“...It's what we feared,” she said. “Your prana—it's too unstable. No magic, no technique... nothing's going to take root in that mess.”

Rachit didn't look surprised.

He just exhaled—slow, steady. Then managed a dry smirk.

“Perks of being a Zeta Prime.”

Anshika shook her head, lips twitching in that way that said she didn't know whether to slap him or laugh. “You treat this like a badge.”

He shrugged. “It is. Just... one that stabs me every time I wear it.”

They walked on.

No more words.

Only footsteps.

And a trail of flickering lights left behind them, dying out one by one.

The corridor narrowed as they walked, its stone walls rising like weary titans on either side—etched with fractured murals of battles long since forgotten. Light pooled from cracked magelamps, flickering like dying stars above their heads. Every few steps, loose dust stirred from beneath Rachit's dragging bandaged foot, breaking the otherwise stifling silence.

Then, through the dense layers of ancient stone and spell-charred halls—
A voice floated in.

Distant. Echoing. Warped by the sheer number of walls between them.
It was the announcer, barely audible, calling out the beginning of the second round.

“—Match two of the second round... now underway in the central arena...”

Anshika tilted her head slightly, listening. “They’ve started already,” she muttered. “Well, sound barely makes it through these vaults.”

Rachit’s face didn’t change. A subtle flick of the eyebrow was the only sign he’d registered it at all.

She smiled at that—still calm, still holding his weight, like she had done it before.
“I guess we missed your dramatic exit fanfare,” she teased, glancing sideways. “No flowers, no banner. Disappointing.”

“...Not a fan of flowers,” Rachit replied flatly.

Anshika exhaled through a smile, then nudged his side—lightly enough not to hurt, but firm enough to test if he could still be annoyed.
“So what’s been going on in that quiet little genius mind of yours?” she asked casually. “Since you last fought me—and lectured me for, what, an hour about my prāṇ distribution?”

“Fifty-eight minutes,” Rachit corrected.

She groaned, mock-frustrated. “Right. Because that’s the part I was most worried about being inaccurate.”

“I remember,” he said, voice quieter now. “Your prana distribution was shallow and sometimes localised. Energy bled through the seams. No anchoring on illusions.”

She lifted a brow, feigning indignation. “And now?”

He finally turned his head just enough to glance at her. “Better. People can’t tell them apart.”

Anshika grinned at that, proud despite herself.

Then Rachit added, deadpan:
“You still have a long way to go.”

She laughed—genuine and warm. The sound softened the tension in the corridor. “You’re impossible.”

He gave no reply, but the faint smirk that curled at the corner of his mouth said enough.

As they continued, the corridor opened slowly into the outer ring of the healer's ward. By the time they neared the arch leading to the medical suite, the announcer's muffled voice called out again—just as a rush of cheers followed.

“...And with that, Team Abhishaap secures victory! A stunning, dominant finish—”

Anshika glanced up at the ceiling. “Guess the next match is done,” she said. “We’ll have to catch the replay.”

Rachit didn't respond. His head dipped slightly. The weight on her shoulder grew heavier.

The doors slid open as they entered.

A sudden wave of scent hit them first—cool, sharp antiseptic layered beneath earthy tones of clovegrass, vaxa vapors, and fresh bioluminescent flora. The contrast from the crumbling stone halls outside was striking.

Light pooled like liquid moonlight from shimmering magelight panels overhead, casting a gentle glow across pristine white marble floors. Along the ivory walls, crystalline vases cradled vines tipped in glowing petals—lending the space a surreal, almost sacred feel.

Floating scrolls hovered midair, scribbling glyphs in shimmering script—each one pulsing with real-time diagnostic data. The quiet rustle of parchment and the occasional *ping* of spell updates were the only sounds.

Six beds were arranged neatly, three already occupied.

Aviral sat propped up, absently adjusting the bandage at his waist.

Gaurav leaned against the wall beside his bed, legs swinging, eyes flicking up as soon as the doors opened.

Nyss was unconscious, breathing steady under the faint glow of stabilizing runes.

When Anshika and Rachit entered, all eyes turned.

Aviral's brows lifted in concern. Swayam, seated nearby, immediately stood—face tightening. Yugetsu, kneeling beside Nyss, straightened and stepped forward. Even Gaurav—usually irreverent—froze mid-smirk.

Anshika guided Rachit gently to the empty bed nearest the diagnostic node.

“Well,” she announced, voice steady despite the exhaustion creeping into her bones. “Once I patch him up, we all can tell him that he's the biggest idiot, she looked at yugetsu and added maybe second biggest.”

Swayam nodded grimly. He moved to the storage alcove, pulling open drawers. “What do you need?”

Anshika listed off quickly, voice sharp and clinical now:

“Grade 3 anaesthetic. Plaster of Paris. Disinfectant. Antibiotics. Stitches. Tweezers. Gloves. Salve. Prāṇ seal tape, Medical grade 2 box And water.”

Swayam grabbed each item in rapid succession.

She sighed, brushing a loose strand of hair behind her ear. “Can’t have anyone knowing the rare specimen we’ve got here.”

Meanwhile, Rachit turned his head slightly—his gaze locking on Gaurav, who was trying to keep his expression casual but failing.

Rachit smirked faintly.

“You saw the guy who hit Rezen, right? Johan?”

He coughed once. “That’s your opponent tomorrow. Enjoy.”

Gaurav grinned, but his knuckles had turned white from how hard he was gripping the bedpost. “I was hoping for an easier round. Guess not.”

“Our luck is worse than Rachit’s sleep schedule,” Aviral muttered.

“I don’t care about luck,” Gaurav fired back—trying to keep the banter alive. But his eyes kept flicking back to Rachit’s face.

Then Rachit’s eyes fluttered. His body slumped.

Swayam froze.

Yugetsu’s eyes widened. “Wait—”

Anshika was already moving. Her fingers pressed to Rachit’s neck, checking for a pulse. Everyone crowded in, the moment strung tight with held breath.

Then—

Rachit’s eyes opened again. Just barely.

His voice was a whisper, cracked and calm.

“Give me twelve hours...”

A pause.

“After this little operation... I’ll be fine.”

And then his eyes closed again—this time slipping into unconsciousness for real.

For a second, no one moved.

Then Anshika exhaled—long and controlled. “He’s stable,” she said. “Pulse is clean. No internal rupture... just pain. Too much of it.”

Swayam, clearly rattled, pulled a chair close and sat down fast, hands shaking.

Yugetsu muttered “So much pain yet he finds a way to mock you Gaurav” trying to ease tension but it didn’t work.

Aviral, eyes tight, just leaned back on his bed, fists clenched in his lap.

And Gaurav?

He leaned in close to Rachit's unconscious face and whispered, "You better not be bluffing, asshole."

Then stood, cracked his neck, and turned to the others.

"Let the bastard rest. He earned it."

Chapter 5 ended

CHAPTER 6 –THE RING OF SOLITUDE

The arena roared with the chaos of anticipation. A hundred thousand voices pressed together in waves, their cheers bouncing off stone walls and climbing into the ash-choked skies above. Glyphs shined along the upper rim, filling the very ashen into spectacle to witness.

At the very center, under the merciless lights, stood one man alone.

Gaurav.

His boots scuffed against the dust-slicked ring floor as he shifted his weight. Sleeveless vest clinging to his frame, crimson stitching faintly pulsing each time his prāṇ stirred. Scars kissed his forearms. He rolled one shoulder once, twice, as though reminding his body it still worked — despite the truth written in every stiff angle of his posture.

His eyes, dark brown but alive with that reckless fire, swept the crowd. He didn't grin, not this time. His jaw was tight, lips pressed in a line. But his presence carried the same charge as always — raw, messy, impossible to ignore.

A spotlight flashed on him.

From above, three voices filled the air. The announcers.

Elsa's was first — sharp, polished, carrying a hint of theatrical mockery.

“Ladies and demons, look who stands before us once more! The boy who spat in physics' face and snapped it over his knee — the human slave who dared to *break the sound barrier* with his fists. Gaurav from Team Nyss!”

The crowd screamed, but it wasn't unanimous. Some cheered. Some jeered. Many leaned forward, waiting to see if the legend was rumor or truth.

Ignis's voice followed — deep, booming, dripping with disbelief.

“Rumor or not, the record stands. Air and earth — *together*. The lunatic actually blended them mid-combat. Boosting speed with wind, bracing his shattered limbs with stone. And in that final charge, he moved faster than a demon blade strike. He was *this* close to shattering Arox into paste!”

“And then fainted mid-swing,” Elsa cut back in, smirking through her tone. “Ah, such poetry. Our little hero fell to the very thing he tried to conquer: his own body.”

“Don't mock him yet,” Ignis shot back. “The boy broke over forty bones in that match. Forty! And lived. He shouldn't even be standing right now.”

“Which makes me question,” Elsa purred, “where are his teammates? Not a trace of Aviral, no shadow of Nyss. He walks into the ring *alone*. What does that say, dear Raktabīja?”

The third voice entered then. Raktabīja's tone was low, gravel-thick, weighted with quiet menace. Unlike Elsa and Ignis, he didn't fill silences with flair. He cut them.

“It says they abandoned him. Or...” A pause, deliberate. “...he volunteered.”

The crowd murmured. Some eyes narrowed. Some fists pumped. Humans in the audience cheered wildly, proud of one of their own standing among demons. Others hissed, laughing at the absurdity.

Down in the ring, Gaurav cracked his neck slowly, then spat to the side. He finally smirked, though it looked carved rather than natural. He raised one hand, flexed it, showing the calluses. “Alone’s fine,” he muttered under his breath, voice almost lost in the roar. His shoulders rolled back. His spine straightened. “Means I don’t have to hold back.”

The eastern gates groaned.

Iron slid against stone. Chains rattled. Then — silence.

Every eye in the arena turned.

Through the widening gap stepped Johan Agryas.

He didn’t storm. He didn’t strut. He walked. Straight-backed. Unhurried. Every line of his body precise, as if the air itself moved aside to let him pass. The slate-gray jacket brushed lightly at his waist. Sleeves rolled to the forearms revealed faint scars, pale lines crossing olive skin. His eyes — still, calm, gray as stormless skies — swept the arena not for applause, but for measurement.

A hush followed him like a cloak.

The crowd’s roar dimmed into murmurs, then whispers. Some leaned back, uncomfortable. Others leaned forward, unable to look away. A demon boy in the third row gripped his father’s sleeve and whispered, trembling, “That’s the one who walked out of Vyra alone.”

Elsa’s voice cracked into the silence like a whip.

“And here he is! Johan Agryas — ‘The Solitary Cut!’ The sole survivor of Vyra’s fall in the Devouring Path! The demon who shattered in his previous shattered whole team without breaking a sweat! The one who—”

Ignis interrupted, his voice rougher now. “The one who kicked Rezen through *seven walls*. And called Rachit of Team Kaal weak... to his face.”

Raktabija didn’t embellish. His words came slow, heavy.

“He is not strength. He is control. And control... kills.”

The arena swallowed a breath.

Johan’s boots touched the ring floor without a sound. He didn’t look at the announcers. He didn’t look at the crowd. His gaze went straight to Gaurav. Held him. Dissected him.

Gaurav grinned wider, fire cracking at the edges of his aura, faint threads of crimson glowing at his vest’s seams. His heart hammered in his chest, but his fists clenched steady. He bared his teeth, called out across the silence:

“You like looking, demon? Keep staring. ‘Cause this human’s about to make you blink.”

The crowd erupted.

Some laughed at his arrogance. Some screamed in mad hope. Some cursed, betting coin on Johan. But all of them leaned forward, because Gaurav — reckless, broken, still burning — was the only human stupid enough to stand alone in front of Johan Agryas and dare him to blink.

And Johan?

He didn't smile. Didn't frown. Just spoke, voice calm, carrying clear even without amplification. "Three."

The word cut through the arena like a blade.

"Three moves. That's all you get before I stop pretending you matter."

The glyphs burned into existence above the ring, their golden light shimmering against the storm of dust. Each symbol etched itself into the crowd's memory with deliberate cruelty:

"Rule: Last man standing.

Victory: Break the other until they surrender."

No countdown. No bell. Just inevitability.

Gaurav's boots echoed on stone as he walked forward, shoulders loose, head high. His crimson-stitched vest glowed faintly with his steps, like embers breathing under ash. Johan didn't move. The demon stood five inches taller, arms folded over his chest, chin slightly lowered—as though Gaurav hadn't earned the courtesy of his full attention.

The human tilted his head, eyes burning with that half-mad defiance only Gaurav could carry. "Johan Agryas," he said, loud enough for the arena to swallow it. "Let's play a game, shall we?"

Johan's gaze shifted—slow, precise, dissecting him like prey. When he answered, his voice didn't rise above the hum of the glyphs, but it cut through everything.

"A game... with a human slave?" His lips barely curved. "I'll pass."

The arena hissed. Half the crowd jeered, half fell silent, waiting for Gaurav's fire.

And he gave it. He spat on the stone between them, wiped his nose with the back of his bruised hand, and grinned wide enough to show the crack in his lip.

"Even if I offer you something you can't ignore? A vial. Stronger than anything your medic's hoard. Heals what even time can't touch. Permanent diseases, gone."

Johan blinked once. No change in expression. But he spoke, and his words weighed like iron.

"...And what would you want in return?"

Gaurav leaned forward, fist resting on his knee, grin sharpening like a blade.

"Information. About Nyss. What you know of her." His voice grew lower, edged. "After all—you're her cousin."

A ripple tore through the crowd—gasps, whispers, disbelief. All eyes cut to Johan.

The demon's face, until now carved from stone, shifted. Not anger—something quieter. Contempt. His eyes narrowed with surgical calm.

“Don’t call me her cousin.” His tone was flat, dismissive, a guillotine’s drop. “She is worthless. Like you.”

The grin slid off Gaurav’s face. His fists clenched until his knuckles turned white. His chest rose faster, his neck veins taut. The simmering anger in him glowed crimson at his vest’s seams.

“...If I win,” Gaurav said, each word sharp, “I get that information.”
“And if you win—” he lifted his chin, eyes locked, “—you get the vial.”

Johan tilted his head slightly.

“What vial?” he asked, disinterest dripping like venom. “I don’t need anything.”

But Gaurav didn’t miss the tiny twitch—the kind Rachit would have catalogued, the kind only brothers notice. A spark of hunger flickered in Johan’s calm.

So Gaurav pushed.

“Oh, come on. Don’t play blank with me. I saw you asking Lilith for one. Saw her ignore you. She told you that even she has no access to its source.” Gaurav’s grin came back, wolfish, taunting. “I’ve got more.”

The demon’s eyes stilled. Not a flicker, not a twitch. But silence weighed heavy enough to confirm.

Gaurav didn’t wait for his response. With a roar that cut through the coliseum, he closed the distance and slammed his fist into Johan’s jaw. The crack of bone meeting bone was a gunshot that shook the stands. Dust burst from the stone under his feet.

The crowd erupted into chaos.

Johan’s head tilted with the blow, but his body didn’t move an inch. Slowly—mechanically—he turned back, face unchanged. No bruise. No mark. His eyes were surgical steel.

He exhaled through his nose. Calm.

“One.” His voice was low, precise. “You’ve got two more. Enjoy them.”

Gaurav shook his knuckles, grinning through the sting. His jaw trembled with the thrill.
“Two more’s a gift, Johan. Don’t blink.”

The arena roared louder, half in fear, half in awe, as the human brawler squared his shoulders against the demon predator.

And somewhere in the silence between heartbeats, the audience understood—
this wasn’t just a fight.

This was a collision.

Fire against scalpel.

Emotion against precision.

A human heartbeat against a demon’s stillness.

The air trembled. The dust rose.

The second strike was already on its way.

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Fire against scalpel.
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A human heartbeat against a demon's stillness.

Gaurav fist driving like a hammer into Johan's chest. The sound was dull, like knuckles against stone. Johan didn't even blink.

The second strike cracked louder, a ripple of force running through the air, but Johan's body absorbed it like water taking in a stone.

By the third blow, the crowd was already leaning forward, breath tangled between disbelief and anticipation. Gaurav's eyes narrowed, his muscles coiling, the ground trembling beneath his charge—

—and then, instead of driving in the expected blow, he snapped his fingers across Johan's forehead with a mocking flick.

"Johan," Gaurav grinned, voice carrying in the sudden hush. "The game's on."

The predator's eyes sharpened. One instant he was still, the next he blurred, closing distance with an inhuman snap. His fist came down like judgment—

—but Gaurav twisted away at the last moment. Johan's punch met the earth instead.

The ring *screamed*. Stone burst in a spiderweb of cracks, the force rolling outward in a quake that rattled teeth and sent dust spiraling into the stands. Audience members clutched the railings, some screaming, others howling with thrill.

Elsa's voice broke in, sharp with glee.
"Did you SEE that? That's not a strike—that's annihilation wrapped in muscle!"

Raktabija hissed, voice thick with hunger.
"And yet the human dodged... oh, how he dances on the edge of a blade."

Ignis' low chuckle rumbled.
"Not a dance. A challenge. One flame daring the storm."

Down in the ring, Gaurav straightened, his chest rising and falling. The calm blue shimmer of his aura rippled—then deepened. Sparks burst from his skin, crawling like veins of fire. In the space of a breath, blue gave way to a blazing, furious orange, the glow licking the cracked stone beneath his feet.

The audience erupted again—fear, awe, and something primal stirred by the sight of a man whose will alone bent the battlefield into fire.

The air in the arena didn't just hum—it *screamed*. Every punch Johan threw was a localized earthquake, a concussive blast of force that cracked the very foundation of the ring. Dust and debris hung in the air like a perpetual fog, illuminated by the frantic, shifting glow of Gaurav's aura.

He was a phantom in the storm, a flicker of crimson and orange against Johan's relentless gray. He wasn't just dodging; he was *evaporating*. One moment he was there, the next he was five feet to the left, the stone where he'd stood exploding into powder under Johan's fist.

CRACK—BOOM—SHATTER.

The sounds were a brutal symphony. Gaurav's breath came in ragged, fire-hot gasps. He wasn't faster than Johan—no one was. But he was unpredictable. A desperate, beautiful chaos against Johan's perfect, murderous order.

He landed a glancing blow on Johan's ribs—a punch fueled by a sudden surge of earthen Prāṇ that hardened his fist to granite. The hit landed with a sound like a mallet striking a monolith.

Johan didn't grunt. He didn't stagger. He simply turned his head, those storm-gray eyes locking onto Gaurav with a fresh, clinical interest. A faint, almost invisible smile touched his lips. It wasn't kind. It was the smile of a scientist finding a new, fascinatingly volatile specimen.

"Earth," Johan stated, his voice cutting through the din like a scalpel. "Predictable."

He moved. Not a blur, but a *repositioning*. He was simply in front of Gaurav, his hand snapping out to grip Gaurav's throat. But before his fingers could close, Gaurav exhaled—a sharp, whistling breath.

Wind.

A torrent of compressed air erupted from his lungs, not to attack, but to propel. He shot backward, skidding across the torn stone, his boots leaving molten, fire-licked trails.

"Wind too?" Johan mused, tilting his head. He began walking forward again, each step measured. "A slave with two affinities. A rarity. A waste."

Gaurav spat a glob of blood onto the ground, where it sizzled and evaporated. His vest glowed a dangerous, unstable red. "You talk too much for a guy who's supposed to be finishing me in three moves!" he roared back, his voice hoarse.

"I am enjoying the presentation," Johan replied calmly. "The way a body breaks... it tells a story. Yours is particularly... dramatic."

He lunged again. This time, Gaurav didn't retreat. He met him head-on.

CLANG!

The sound was metallic, shocking. Gaurav's forearms, sheathed in a last-second shell of jagged rock, intercepted Johan's strike. The rock shattered instantly, but it absorbed the force. Gaurav's bones screamed in protest, but they held.

For a single, breathtaking second, they were locked together, faces inches apart. Gaurav could see the absolute, terrifying stillness in Johan's eyes. No anger. No effort. Just execution.

"Why her?" Gaurav gritted out, the strain making his voice a raw scrape. "She's your blood! What did you do to her?!"

Johan's gaze didn't waver. "Blood is a biological accident. Not a bond. She was weak. She was discarded. It is the natural order."

The coldness of it, the utter lack of remorse, sent a new kind of fire through Gaurav—one that had nothing to do with Prāṇ.

He pushed back with a surge of pure, adrenalized strength, breaking the lock. He didn't create distance. He stayed close, his style shifting from evasive to brutally direct, trading blow for blow.

A fist wreathed in fire met Johan's palm, the flame snuffing out with a hiss.

A kick guided by wind was deflected with a minimal turn of Johan's hip.

An elbow hardened with earth was caught and pushed aside.

It was a masterclass in futility. But Gaurav was learning. Adapting. For every move Johan used, Gaurav's body, honed in a thousand street fights, filed it away.

And then he mixed them.

It wasn't the deep, stable sync he'd achieved against Arox. That had been a fleeting moment of perfect harmony. This was something else—desperate, violent, and unsustainable.

He stomped his foot. **Earth** Prāṇ shot through the ground, not to attack, but to anchor him, to brace his skeleton against the titanic forces he was about to unleash. In the same instant, he drew a sharp breath, pulling **Wind** Prāṇ into his lungs, supercharging his blood with oxygen, accelerating his nerves.

He threw a punch. A simple, straight right.

But his fist wasn't sheathed in rock or flame. It was sheathed in **crackling white lightning**.

The air screamed as it ionized. The punch was faster than anything he'd thrown before—a blur of raw kinetic energy and elemental fury.

Johan's eyes widened a fraction. For the first time, he didn't block or deflect. He *moved*. He leaned back, the lightning-charged fist grazing the front of his gray jacket, leaving a smoldering black streak across the fabric.

The crowd fell utterly, deathly silent.

Johan looked down at the scorch mark. Then back at Gaurav. The faint smile returned, wider this time. A genuine spark of amusement in the depths of his gray eyes.

"Lightning," he said, a note of real surprise in his voice. "Three elements. You are full of contradictions, human."

Gaurav stood panting, the lightning flickering and dying around his arm. The backlash was immediate—a searing pain lanced up his meridians, and a trickle of blood escaped his nose. He wiped it away with a trembling, grinning hand.

“Yeah, well,” he coughed. “Stick around. The show’s just getting started.”

In the Medical Suite

The room was so quiet they could hear the hum of the healing glyphs over the distant roar of the arena feed.

Rachit slept fitfully on the central bed, his chest rising and falling in a shallow rhythm. The others were clustered around the floating hologlyph, their faces painted in the shifting blues and oranges of the battle below.

Yugetsu was chewing on his thumbnail, his spider-hair twitching nervously. “He’s mixing them again... he’s gonna tear himself apart.”

Aviral, now fully healed and standing, had one hand pressed against the cool wall, his knuckles white. “He’s buying time. And information.” His eyes were sharp, analyzing every feint and counter. “Look at Johan’s footwork. He always resets with his weight on the left. Gaurav’s starting to see it.”

Swayam stood apart, his Krotha mask off for once, revealing a face etched with grim focus. His arms were crossed, his blue eyes narrowed at the screen.

“It’s working,” Swayam said, his voice low and certain. “Just as we predicted.”

Anshika glanced at him from where she was monitoring Rachit’s vitals. “Predicted? You predicted he’d get the living hell beaten out of him to piss off a demon so he’d talk about his cousin?”

“We predicted Johan’s arrogance,” Swayam corrected, not taking his eyes off the fight. “He sees combat as a puzzle. Gaurav is presenting him with a fascinating, volatile one. He won’t crush it immediately. He’ll poke and prod. This will give them points and Johan he’ll enjoy the process. And in that process...” Swayam’s jaw tightened. “...he might just let something slip.”

On the bed, Rachit stirred in his sleep, a faint grimace crossing his face as a particularly loud impact echoed from the speaker. He murmured something incoherent, three words “FUCK YOU NIGHTMARES,” before settling back into his forced slumber.

The room fell silent again, the weight of their friend’s sacrifice hanging heavy in the antiseptic air.

In the Team Mavik Chambers

The atmosphere was different. Less tension, more... professional appraisal.

Team Mavik lounged in their opulent viewing room, the arena feed projected on a massive crystal screen. Syra was sharpening her daggers against a whetstone, her expression bored but her eyes tracking every movement.

Nikhan slithered slowly behind the couches, his forked tongue flicking out as he tasted the tension in the air. “The human is more resilient than projected.”

Arox was standing, arms folded over his massive chest. He wasn’t watching the fight; he was watching *Gaurav*. A faint, rumbling sound echoed in his chest—not a growl, but a sound of deep, resonant approval.

“He stands,” Arox said, his voice like grinding stones. “Again.”

Arox eyes stayed on Gaurav, on the way he pushed himself back up after every shattering blow, on the wild, desperate fire in his eyes.

“It is not about pieces,” Arox said finally. “It is about will. His... is unbroken.”

Syra stopped sharpening her daggers. “Johan is playing with him. You know that, right? The moment he gets bored...”

“I know,” Arox interrupted, his voice firm. “But until that moment... it is a good fight.”

In Lilith’s Private Observatory

Lilith took a slow, languid sip from a goblet of wine so dark it was almost black. She reclined on a divan of living shadow, the arena playing out on a screen of solidified moonlight before her.

A genuine, delighted smile played on her lips.

“Oh, little ember,” she purred to herself, watching Gaurav weave another desperate combination of earth and wind to evade a crippling strike. “You burn so brightly it hurts to look at you.”

Her garnet eyes flicked to Johan, to the calculated precision of his movements, the cold curiosity on his face.

“And you, Johan... so controlled, so perfect. So sure you are above it all.” She took another sip, her smile turning wicked. “But he’s getting under your skin, isn’t he? Not with strength. With... *heart*. A thing you so desperately pretend you do not have.”

She leaned forward, her interest sharpening into a razor point.

“Show me, Johan Agryas. Show me what happens when perfection is challenged by a beautiful, broken mess.”

Back in the Ring

Gaurav was running on fumes and fury. Every mixed-element strike was a gamble, a searing jolt of agony that bought him a half-second of parity. He was a symphony of malfunctioning power, cracking apart in real-time.

He slid under a sweep of Johan's leg that would have decapitated a lesser fighter, coming up on the demon's blind side.

"She's stronger than you!" Gaurav yelled, the words tearing from his raw throat. He didn't throw a punch. He thrust his palm forward, and a concentrated blast of air—like a cannonball of pure force—shot out, aiming to unbalance Johan.

Johan shifted his weight, dissipating the force with an almost lazy rotation of his body. But he was listening.

"She survived!" Gaurav pressed, breathing hard. "She survived whatever hell you came from! What does that make her?!"

Johan's response was a flick of his wrist. A shard of stone, shattered from the arena floor, shot toward Gaurav's head like a bullet. Gaurav ducked, feeling it shear off a few strands of his hair.

"It makes her lucky," Johan said, his voice still calm, but a new edge had entered it—a subtle sharpness. "A stray insect that avoided the boot. It does not make her significant."

"Lucky?!" Gaurav laughed, a broken, bloody sound. He surged forward again, this time layering fire over his fists, turning them into living meteors. "She's got a crystal in her chest that hums like a damn god! You call that LUCKY?!"

He unleashed a barrage of fiery punches. Johan weaved through them, each dodge a masterpiece of minimal motion. One of the blows grazed his shoulder, singing the fabric again.

Johan's hand snapped out, faster than thought, and caught Gaurav's wrist mid-punch. The grip was like iron, crushing. Gaurav cried out as he felt the bones grind.

Johan pulled him close, their faces inches apart once more. The clinical curiosity was gone from his eyes, replaced by something colder, darker.

"You speak of things you cannot possibly understand, slave," Johan whispered, the words meant for Gaurav alone. "That 'hum' is not a blessing. It is a chain. A cage of her own making. She clings to her rituals, her mantras, her discipline... because without it, she is nothing. A hollow, screaming thing. Just like you."

He twisted Gaurav's arm, forcing him to his knees. The pain was blinding.

"I didn't *do* anything to her," Johan said, his voice dropping to a venomous, almost intimate low. "I simply refused to stand beside a creature who defines its worth by the chains it chooses to wear."

He released Gaurav with a shove that sent him sprawling onto the cracked stone.

Gaurav pushed himself up on trembling arms, his vision swimming. He'd gotten his answer. It was uglier than he'd imagined.

Johan stood over him, looking down. The small smile was gone. His expression was now one of final, bored dismissal. The experiment was over. The puzzle was solved.

“You have your information,” Johan stated. “Now, lie down.”

The air around Johan *shifted*. It wasn’t a glow or an aura. It was a *pressure*. The calm before an execution.

Gaurav looked up from the ground, blood dripping from his lip onto the hot stone. His body was a tapestry of pain. But his eyes... his eyes still burned.

He pushed himself to his feet, every movement a symphony of agony.

“Yeah... I got it,” Gaurav spat, swaying slightly. He raised his fists again, the Prāṇ around them sputtering weakly—a faint flicker of orange, a wisp of air, a shudder of earth. He was trying to mix them again, to draw one last, impossible burst of power from his breaking body.

“But see... I’m not done asking questions.”

The final, desperate round was about to begin.

Gaurav’s body screamed in protest, a chorus of shattered bones and torn muscles. But beneath the pain, a deeper hum began—a dissonant, terrifying harmony. The air around him warped, shimmering with four distinct energies fighting for dominance before violently, unwillingly, merging.

His right fist glowed with a chaotic, prismatic light. Flames licked around knuckles sheathed in jagged rock. Crackling white lightning webbed between his fingers, and a screaming vortex of wind compressed it all into a single, unstable point. The air itself groaned, the pressure dropping as if the arena was holding its breath.

“Alright, you cold-hearted bastard,” Gaurav rasped, his voice barely audible over the elemental storm gathering in his hand. Blood streamed from his nose, his ears, the corners of his eyes. “Let’s collide our punches. That’s my last move. After that... I’m a goner. Just like your goddamn empathy.”

He took a staggering step forward, the stone cracking under his weight. “And if you found this whole experiment so cool... why don’t you tell me about Nyss’s childhood?”

Johan watched, his head tilted. The clinical curiosity was back, overriding the brief flash of annoyance. He saw a biological system pushing itself into catastrophic failure for a single data point. It was... fascinating. He said nothing, merely raising his own right hand, fingers curling into a clean, perfect fist. No glow. No aura. Just impossible, condensed strength.

They moved at the same time.

Gaurav lunged, a comet of self-destructive fury.
Johan stepped forward, the picture of efficient motion.

Their fists met.

The impact did not produce a sound. It produced a **void** of sound—a split second of absolute silence that swallowed the world—before reality rushed back in to fill the emptiness.

BOOOOOOOM.

A shockwave of pure force, mixed with shards of rock, tongues of fire, and forks of wild lightning, exploded outward. The glyph-barrier around the ring flared a brilliant, desperate red before fracturing like glass, sending the front rows of the audience scrambling back with screams.

Gaurav's arm went numb. Then came the pain—a white-hot agony that told him every bone from his knuckles to his shoulder had splintered. He was airborne, hurled backward like a ragdoll by the recoil of his own power and Johan's immovable force. He sailed across the width of the arena, a broken arc of a man, before crashing into the reinforced southern gate with a sickening, metallic **CRUNCH**.

He slid to the ground, a heap of smoldering cloth and bleeding flesh. Consciousness flickered.

Johan, meanwhile, skidded back exactly three feet. His boots carved twin grooves into the stone. His fist was unmarked. He lowered his arm, straightened his jacket with his other hand, and began walking. Each step was measured, calm, echoing in the new, ringing silence of the stunned coliseum.

He stopped before the crumpled form of Gaurav. He looked down, not with malice, but with the detached air of a researcher concluding notes on a terminated specimen.

"You asked about her childhood," Johan began, his voice carrying easily in the quiet. "It is not a story. It is a case study in efficiency."

He spoke plainly, his words as cold and sharp as a scalpel.

"Her childhood," Johan began, his voice flat, devoid of any emotion, as if reciting a clinical report on a failed subject. "Was a lesson in utility. Our family believed strength was the only currency. Weakness was a sin to be purged."

Gaurav coughed, a wet, painful sound.

"Her mother was weak," Johan continued, his gray eyes looking past Gaurav, into the memory. "Sentimental. A liability. The family decided her energy, her very essence, would be better served strengthening the bloodline. They cooked her. Alive."

He paused, letting the horrific image hang in the air. The crowd, for once, was too stunned to even gasp.

"And then they served her heart to Nyss. On a lacquer plate. They believed consuming it would either break her completely and make her pliable, or force a monstrous transformation. She vomited blood for hours. She did not break. She did not transform. She simply... emptied."

He finally looked down at Gaurav. "I was the one who trained her after that. I taught her the discipline, the control, the cold pragmatism required to survive in a world that devours the warm-hearted. I made her strong. And then she came here, to this vulgar spectacle, without my permission. She traded that strength for... this." He gestured dismissively at the arena, at Gaurav. "It is worthless. Now you have your information. Give up."

Gaurav, through swollen eyes, looked up at him. A strange, bloody smile spread across his face.

"Hell nah," he rasped. "*You* give up. And I'll give you the vial tomorrow morning."

Johan's expression didn't change, but a faint line appeared between his brows. "Then why do all of this? Why take these beatings?"

"Krotha's plans," Gaurav choked out, the name a talisman. "And his motives... he knows. And come on, man... you're strong. Now tell me... was there ever a moment? Even a second? Where you saw your little sister, and not just an experiment?"

Johan was silent for a long moment. The arena waited.

"...No," he said, and the word was final. Absolute.

Gaurav's smile didn't fade. It just turned sad. "Johan... could you help me stand?"

A beat. Then, with the detached efficiency of a medic attending to a piece of equipment, Johan bent down, hooked his hands under Gaurav's arms, and hauled him upright, holding him there as Gaurav's legs wobbled uselessly.

For a second, they stood there, the demon supporting the broken human.

Then Gaurav moved. With the very last dregs of his strength, he twisted in Johan's grip and slammed a palm into the demon's chest. It wasn't a punch of earth or fire. It was a blast of pure, concentrated **Wind**, fueled by nothing but his rage and his heart.

THUMP.

It was enough to surprise Johan, to make him release his grip and take a single, involuntary step back. Gaurav collapsed back against the gate, his hand falling limp.

Johan wasn't hurt. Not even slightly. He looked down at his chest, then back at Gaurav, his head tilted in genuine, utter bewilderment.

"The FUCK kind of brother are you?!" Gaurav screamed, the words tearing from his throat, raw and bloody and filled with a pain that had nothing to do with broken bones.

Johan stared at him. The clinical curiosity was gone. The annoyance was gone. All that was left was a blank, uncomprehending slate. He had given the data. The subject had reacted illogically. The experiment was concluded.

Without another word, Johan Agryas turned. And he walked away announcing "I give up". He strode past the center of the ring, past the stunned silence, and exited through the eastern gate without a backward glance.

Gaurav slid down the gate to the ground, his head lolling forward. He was done.

The glyph board flickered overhead, untouched, unlooked-at. The result was irrelevant.

Announcer's Booth

The silence stretched for a full ten seconds before Elsa found her voice, though it was uncharacteristically small.

"Well... I... I don't even know what to classify that as."

Ignis's rumble was subdued, thoughtful. "That was not a match. That was an autopsy. And the corpse... got up and asked the coroner about his feelings."

Raktabija was uncharacteristically quiet. When he spoke, it was a low, serious growl. "The human lost. He is broken. But the demon... he walked away from a victory. I have never seen that. Ever."

Elsa tried to regain her composure. "The, uh, the scoreboard confirms! Victory by last man standing... to Gaurav of Team Nyss! Team Nyss's point total rises to 400!"

Her announcement fell flat, swallowed by the heavy, bewildered silence that had settled over the Kaali Bhoomi. The story of the fight wasn't in the points. It was in the broken boy at the southern gate, and the perfect, untouchable demon who had won everything, and somehow, inexplicably, lost.

It was the medics who broke the spell. A team of four, their white and silver robes stark against the scorched earth, moved with practiced efficiency. They did not run; their movement was a somber procession. They gently loaded Gaurav's limp form onto a floating stretcher, the prāṇ-field around it glowing a soft, sterile blue. As they carried him away, a single, hesitant clap started from the human section of the stands. It was quickly joined by another, then a dozen, then a hundred—not a roar of victory, but a slow, respectful percussion of acknowledgement for the sheer, insane will they had witnessed. It was cut through by the louder, more numerous jeers and dismissive hisses of the demons, creating a dissonant symphony that followed the medics out of the arena.

The journey through the sterile, gleaming corridors of the medical wing was a blur of passing lights and hushed, professional murmurs. Gaurav drifted in and out of consciousness, each jolt of pain a mooring line to reality. The world was a smear of white ceilings and the concerned faces of healers whose words sounded like they were coming from underwater.

Then, the familiar scent of clovegrass and vaxa leaves. The door to the suite hissed open.

He was wheeled in. The others were already on their feet. Yugetsu's gaze was wide with anxiety. Aviral, now fully mobile, had his arms crossed, his usual snark replaced by a deep frown. Anshika was at Rachit's bedside, her head snapping up, her hands already glowing with a readiness to heal. Swayam stood by the window, having just removed the frost-mask of Krotha. His face was an unreadable mask, but the tension in his shoulders was palpable.

The medics transferred Gaurav to a vacant bed with a soft, hydraulic sigh. As they began hooking up diagnostic glyphs to his chest, his eyes fluttered open. They landed on Swayam. Through cracked lips, swollen face, and with a voice that was little more than a dry, rasping whisper, Gaurav managed a weak, triumphant smirk.

"Told ya all," he breathed, each word a monumental effort, "that I'll win."

A beat of stunned silence filled the room. Then, Swayam let out a soft, incredulous breath that was almost a laugh. He walked over to the bedside, looking down at the human wreckage that was somehow claiming victory.

“Yeah,” Swayam said, his voice low and laced with a mixture of awe and exasperation. He placed a hand on Gaurav’s less-injured shoulder. “Yeah, you won. Now don’t you dare pull a move like that again.” His grip tightened almost imperceptibly. “Taking care of you is getting tiresome.” The unspoken affection in the gruff words was clearer than any declaration. “So. With that, we are one more move ahead.”

From the adjacent bed, a voice, thin and raspy yet razor-sharp with clarity, cut through the room. Rachit’s eyes were open, just slits, but they were focused. He had fought his way through the sedatives, drawn back to consciousness by the familiar energy of Gaurav’s return.

“So,” Rachit murmured, his gaze fixed on the ceiling, processing the emotional data in the room. “Gaurav won.” A slow, deliberate blink. “That is... adequate.”

And then, as if his body had received the confirmation it needed to finally surrender, the light in his eyes dimmed. His head lolled to the side, and he fell back into a deep, unnatural sleep, the shallow rhythm of his breathing the only sign of life.

Anshika was at his side in an instant, her fingers on his neck, checking his pulse. She let out a small, frustrated sigh, a faint blush of embarrassment coloring her cheeks. “Perhaps,” she admitted, glancing at the empty vial of sedative on the side table, “to get him to actually rest, I might have given a little bit... too much.”

The tension in the room shattered.

Aviral snorted, shaking his head with a wry grin. “Only you could overdose the one guy who fights sleep harder than he fights demons.”

Yugetsu’s nervous energy finally found an outlet in a giggle that was half-relief, half-hysteria. “He’s gonna be so mad when he wakes up and realizes he missed the matches.”

Even Swayam’s stern expression softened into a faint smile. The absurdity of it—Gaurav’s defiant claim, Rachit’s clinical approval followed by immediate unconsciousness—was a moment of much-needed levity in the grim atmosphere.

The moment passed, and Anshika’s healer instincts took over. She turned her attention to Gaurav, her expression turning serious. “Your turn, hero,” she said, her voice all business.

For the next hour, the medical suite was filled with the soft hum of Anshika’s Jeev Shakti. She worked with meticulous precision, her hands moving over Gaurav’s broken body. The deep, angry bruises faded to a sickly yellow. The cuts sealed into thin, pink lines. Dislocated joints were coaxed back into their sockets with soft clicks and whispered chants. The internal bleeding was stemmed, the fractured bones nudged into alignment and wrapped in glowing bands of stabilizing energy.

Gaurav gritted his teeth through the process, his knuckles white as he gripped the sheets. It wasn’t a gentle healing; it was a rapid, aggressive reconstruction that prioritized function over comfort.

When she was done, Anshika stepped back, wiping a sheen of sweat from her brow. Gaurav looked whole again, though pale and utterly drained. The fire in his eyes was banked, replaced by the deep exhaustion of a spent furnace.

“There,” Anshika said, her own energy visibly depleted. “You are... functional. But your core is still a mess.” She picked up a transparent IV bag filled with a liquid that swirled with tiny, diamond-like particles, shimmering with an inner cold light. “You still need a full IV cycle of Gomukh glacial ice water. Can’t have your Jeev Shakti burning you up from the inside after that little light show.”

She hooked the bag to a stand and inserted the line into his arm. A blissful, cooling sensation immediately began to spread through Gaurav’s veins, quelling the last embers of painful, unstable energy. His eyes fluttered shut in relief.

With the two most critically injured members stabilized, a new tension entered the room. Swayam looked from the unconscious Rachit to the sedated Gaurav, then to Aviral.

“Right,” Swayam said, his voice taking on the tone of a commander. “Yugetsu, Anshika. We move. Our match is next.”

Aviral uncrossed his arms and gave a sharp, confident nod. “Go. Win. Don’t worry,” he said, jerking a thumb towards the two occupied beds. “I’ll take care of these self-harming pricks.”

Swayam raised an eyebrow, a dry chuckle escaping him. “Says the man who literally burns himself alive with his own fire in the middle of a fight to win.”

Aviral’s grin was unrepentant. “I’m a specialist. They’re just amateurs.”

The brief exchange was a familiar ritual, a passing of the torch. Swayam gave a final, lingering look at his team—his family—then turned. His posture shifted, straightening, the casualness of Swayam sloughing away like a discarded skin. He picked up the frost-threaded helm from the table.

As he fastened the Krotha mask back into place, the air around him seemed to grow colder. The blue etchings on his black armor glinted with a sharper light. When he turned back to them, it was no longer Swayam who stood there, but the Scourge of the Northern Reaches. The transformation was terrifyingly complete.

Yugetsu took a deep, steadying breath, he adjusted his layered coat, his fingers nervously tracing the hidden weapons within. Anshika squared her shoulders, the iridescent charcoal and violet of her attire seeming to drink the light in the room, her expression settling into one of cold, deadly focus.

They were ready. Team Krotha was ready.

They moved towards the door, a unit of focused intent, the air crackling with their combined resolve. Swayam reached for the door handle.

And then it happened.

A sudden, piercing chime echoed through the entire medical suite, followed by the voice of Elsa, the announcer. But it wasn't her usual theatrical, arena-filling boom. It was flat, official, and broadcast through every glyph-speaker in the Kaali Bhoomi complex.

“ATTENTION ALL PARTICIPANTS. ATTENTION ALL GUESTS.”

They froze.

“BY ORDER OF THE MALAKOUR TOURNAMENT COUNCIL, ALL REMAINING MATCHES FOR TODAY’S ROUND AND UPCOMING, ARE HEREBY SUSPENDED. EFFECTIVE IMMEDIATELY.”

A wave of stunned silence washed over them.

“THIS SUSPENSION WILL REMAIN IN EFFECT UNTIL NEW ORDERS ARE ISSUED. ALL PARTICIPANTS ARE REQUIRED TO REMAIN WITHIN THEIR DESIGNATED QUARTERS OR MEDICAL SUITES. ANYONE FOUND IN UNAUTHORIZED SECTIONS WILL BE DETAINED. PLEASE AWAIT FURTHER INSTRUCTIONS. THAT IS ALL.”

The announcement cut off, leaving a ringing silence more profound than any noise.

The three of them stood at the threshold, their momentum utterly broken. The fierce energy that had been coiling for a fight dissipated into the sterile air, replaced by a heavy, bewildering uncertainty.

Swayam’s hand, still on the door handle, slowly fell to his side. He didn’t turn around, but the others could see the rigid set of his shoulders beneath the Krotha armor. Yugetsu’s nervous fidgeting returned full force, his eyes darting around as if looking for the source of this new, invisible threat. Anshika’s cool composure remained, but her eyes had narrowed, calculating the countless implications of such an unprecedented interruption.

Behind them, in the quiet of the suite, the only sounds were the gentle hum of the medical glyphs, the soft drip of the Gomukh ice water into Gaurav’s veins, and the deep, sedated breathing of Rachit.

Swayam, still encased in the Krotha persona, remained at the door for a long moment, his hand hovering where the handle had been. Slowly, the tension bled from his shoulders, replaced by a rigid, frustrated stillness. He didn't turn with a quiet, deliberate motion, he reached up and unclasped the frost-mask. He didn't remove it fully, but let it hang at his throat, a stark white contrast against the black armor. His face, when he finally turned, was a carefully neutral mask, but his blue eyes burned with cold, unasked questions.

Yugetsu deflated like a pierced balloon, all his nervous energy dissipating into a slump. He shuffled back to the long couch and collapsed onto it, pulling his knees to his chest. "Suspended?" he whispered to no one in particular, his multi-layered coat seeming too large for him suddenly. "They never suspend matches. Not unless... something's really wrong."

Anshika was the picture of calm, but her stillness was that of a drawn blade, not a resting one. She walked to the transparent wall screen and waved a hand, pulling up public arena feeds. The screens showed empty rings, confused crowds being ushered out by stone-faced Malakour

enforcers, and scrolling glyphs repeating the suspension notice. "No reason given," she stated, her voice clinical. "No speculation on the feeds. Just a complete and total shutdown."

Aviral let out a low whistle from his bed. "Well, this is new. What do you think? Did someone finally assassinate a noble in the stands? Did the kitchen staff unionize after Scar's... incident?"

"No," Swayam said, his voice low. He finally moved away from the door, his boots making no sound on the marble. "This is bigger than that. This feels... structural." His gaze swept over Rachit and Gaurav, both lost to their respective forced slumbers. "It's a containment order. They're locking everything down."

The air grew heavier. They were fighters, strategists. Inaction was a poison.

In Johan Agryas's Quarters

The room was spartan. A single bed, a reinforced training dummy in the corner, a small desk. There were no personal effects. No trophies, no mementos. It was a space for a weapon to rest, not a person to live.

Johan stood by the only window, which offered a view of the now-empty arena far below. His hands were clasped behind his back, his posture perfectly straight. The faint scorch mark from Gaurav's lightning strike was still visible on his slate-gray jacket. He had not changed.

The announcement had not stirred him. His expression remained one of detached analysis. His gray eyes scanned the organized chaos of the evacuation below, processing data.

Why cancel the matches?

The question was a logical puzzle, devoid of emotional investment.

Hypothesis 1: An external threat. Unlikely. The Kaali Bhoomi's defenses were legendary. A breach would have been audible, visible.

Hypothesis 2: An internal power play. Probable. The tournament was a nexus of political maneuvering. A move by one noble house to disadvantage another.

Hypothesis 3: A reaction to an anomaly. His eyes flicked down to the scorch mark on his chest. The human. The unstable, multi-elemental display. The Krotha impostor's performance. Rachit's prolonged, calculating defense. The... emotional outbursts or is it Athereon or Volghora

His gaze grew slightly more focused. The variables were accumulating outside acceptable parameters. The tournament was an experiment, and the specimens were behaving erratically. Cancellation was the logical choice for a controller reasserting dominance, recalibrating the environment.

A faint, almost imperceptible frown touched his lips. It was... inefficient. It disrupted the data collection.

He turned from the window. The waiting was irrelevant. It was merely a change in conditions. He began a series of slow, precise kata forms, his movements silent and exact in the center of the bare room. The only sound was the whisper of his clothing and the controlled rhythm of his

breath. He would wait. He would observe. And when the parameters were reset, he would continue.

In the Team Mavik Chambers

The contrast to Johan's cell-like room was absolute. Team Mavik's quarters were a lavishly appointed den of shadow and opulence. Plush, dark carpets, low couches heaped with silken cushions, and the low, perpetual glow of demon-forged braziers.

The announcement had hit them differently.

Nikhan was coiled around a central pillar, his serpentine lower body tense, his forked tongue flicking out rapidly as he tasted the air. "A suspension," he hissed, his voice a sibilant whisper. "The scent on the command glyph... it was laced with fear. Not caution. *Fear*."

Syra was lounging on a divan, but her languid posture was gone. She was upright, meticulously polishing one of her blade-like nails with a sharpening stone. The repetitive *scritch-scratch-scratch* was a sharp counterpoint to the silence. "Boring," she drawled, but her eyes were sharp, darting towards the sealed door. "Just when things were getting interesting. That human was a beautiful, bloody mess. I wanted to see how many pieces Agryas would leave him in."

She looked over at Arox. "What's the play, Mountain? Do we sit here and preen?"

Arox was standing before a massive, reinforced window, his arms crossed over his chest, Blazetusk still strapped to his back. He had not moved since the announcement. His immense frame blocked the light, casting a deep shadow across the room. The demonbone plates on his shoulders seemed to absorb the ambient noise.

He was not thinking about politics or anomalies. His mind was back in the ring, watching a boy with shattered legs stand up again. And again. And again.

"The play," Arox rumbled, his voice so deep it vibrated in the chests of the others, "is to wait."

He finally turned. His ember-orange eyes glowed in the dim light.

"The strong are not troubled by delay. They are sharpened by it." His gaze swept over Syra's impatience and Nikhan's anxiety. "The human understood that. He used time as a weapon. This suspension... it is just another form of waiting. Another whetstone."

He walked to the center of the room and sat down on the floor with a sound like settling stone. He closed his eyes, entering a state of absolute, immovable calm.

"Be sharp," he commanded, and said no more.

Syra rolled her eyes but stopped polishing her nail. Nikhan forced his coils to relax, though his tongue still flicked out nervously. Meanwhile, somewhere further from all of this commotion,

the chamber of bone was no longer a theater for critique; it was a war room humming with alarm. The flesh-glass screen at its center, once replaying kills and techniques, now showed

chaotic, shaking images of Rakhtphul's streets. Smoke plumed from districts that had been serene just hours before.

"The prisons are broken!" hissed Judge Erix'thel, his twelve eyes blinking in agitated sequence. His long claw tapped a frantic rhythm on his armrest. "Every containment glyph, shattered from the *inside*. It's not a breach. It's an... awakening."

A demoness with wings of molten ore leaned forward, her voice a grating rumble. "The criminals inside... their Pran signatures are spiking. Multiplied. By a factor of ten. A low-level thug now hits with the force of a war-born champion. How is this possible?"

Arch-Duke Mur'Rok, the Skulldrinker, rumbled, "A pathogen? A curse? A coordinated ritual?"

"It is a blessing," purred Lady Vurnessa, though her usual laziness was edged with sharp interest. She licked a drop of nectar-sap from her wrist. "A sudden evolution. The weak have become deliciously strong. The hunt in the streets will be... exquisite."

"This is no hunt, Vurnessa," snarled a judge with a jawless face, lips bleeding with the force of his words. "This is anarchy! My own compound is under siege by a pack of gutter-rats who should barely be able to lift a shiv!"

The central scorer, his head a bowl of green flame, spoke in a flat, grim tone that silenced the bickering. "The Malakour Knights are engaged. They are containing what they can. But the multiplier effect is... unpredictable. Techniques are evolving mid-fight. Low-level thugs are manifesting advanced, often unstable, combat arts. The city is being looted, district by district."

The screen flickered, showing a flash of crimson and disciplined fury. Reinhard Volcari moved like a streak of fire through a mob of enhanced criminals. He was a blur of efficiency—a twist, a disarming strike, a precise impact that crumpled a berserker twice his size without killing him. He paused for a fraction of a second to pull a terrified demoness from a collapsing doorway, shielding her with his body from a hail of shattered stone, before plunging back into the fray.

"He fights well," murmured the antlered judge, his pale blue eyes tracking Reinhard's movements. "But he is one man. The chaos is everywhere."

[THE STREETS OF RAKHTPHUL]

Renzo, his fine blue coat now smudged with soot, fought with controlled fury at the head of his knight unit. "Hold the line! Compression formation! Don't let them flank the plaza!" His water whips lashed out, entangling enhanced criminals, but he grunted with effort. "They're stronger... faster. It's like fighting reflections in a funhouse mirror!"

His knights, disciplined and brave, were being tested as never before. A blow that should have staggered an opponent now sent a knight flying. A technique that should have contained a rogue now shattered against a sudden, inexplicable surge of power and back in medical suite. The feed on Anshika's screen flickered again, this time catching a glimpse of the horde amassing just beyond the grand arches of the central plaza. A sea of frenzied, empowered demons, their eyes glowing with unnatural power, pressing against the shimmering barrier that protected the arena's sanctum.

Swayam followed her gaze, his own eyes widening slightly behind the mask's slits. He saw it. The suspension wasn't about the games. It was about *this*.

"The arena..." he said, his voice a low, grim realization. "It's not suspended. It's being turned into a fortress. And we're all locked inside."

And through it all, the heart of the city, the Kaali Bhoomi central plaza, remained a bizarre island of oblivious spectacle. The powerful glyph barriers that separated the arena from the city now served a dual purpose: keeping the fighters in, and the chaos out. The roar of the crowd inside was a stark, dissonant contrast to the screams and clashes outside. The participants, from the noble Athereon to the brutal Abhishaap, remained focused on their games, utterly unaware that the city hosting their tournament was crumbling around them.

CHAPTER 7: ASH AND ARROGANCE

THE BLAZEBORN OF SOUTH DISTRICT

The scent of burning spicewood and panic hung thick over the South District market. It was a choking perfume, a far cry from the usual aromas of sizzling street meat and fragrant oils. A stall selling shimmering silks was now a bonfire, the expensive fabrics curling into blackened petals of ash. Another, filled with enchanted crystals, popped and crackled, releasing minor, uncontrolled magic into the hazy air.

Chaos was a living entity here, and it fed on fear.

Screams, not of spectators but of victims, formed a dissonant choir. A hulking brute, his skin now bubbling with unstable, jagged spikes of bone—a symptom of the mysterious "Awakening"—backhanded a cart, sending fruit and splintered wood flying. The vendor, a portly demon with horns like a ram, scrambled backward, his eyes wide with terror.

"Please! I have nothing! Nothing!" he begged.

The brute grinned, a line of drool mixed with blood dripping from his jaw. He raised a mallet-like fist, ready to pulp the vendor's skull.

A shadow fell over him.

It wasn't a large shadow. It was lean and swift, dropping from the rooftop above like a bird of prey. But it carried a weight—a pressure of imminent annihilation.

The brute had a half-second to look up.

Ryuu Varkal landed on his shoulders.

The ash-blond hair, tipped with fiery orange, didn't even rustle. His crimson eyes, glowing with faint, pulsating rings of molten orange, didn't glance at the brute. They were fixed on the terrified vendor.

"You're in the way, extra," Ryuu said, his voice a sharp, biting blade of sound. "Scram."

He didn't wait for a reply. His left hand, clad in scorched, fingerless dragon-hide gloves, snapped down and planted itself flat on the brute's forehead. All five digits made contact.

A low hum filled the air, a sound like a forge-heart igniting.

The brute's eyes bulged. A network of crimson light, like cracks in heated stone, spread from Ryuu's palm across his entire skull. There was no fire, not yet. Just pure, concentrated thermal energy being forced into a confined space.

"Detonation Touch."

FWUMP.

The sound was sickeningly contained. It wasn't a grand explosion, but an *implosion* of force. The brute's head snapped back with a wet crunch, his body seizing violently before collapsing like a sack of rocks onto the cobblestones. He wasn't dead. But the neural pathways controlling his

motor functions were permanently, violently rearranged. He would be a drooling vegetable, if he ever woke up.

Ryuu landed lightly beside the twitching body, not even bothering to watch it fall. He flicked his wrist once, as if shaking off something distasteful. A few ember-sparks drifted from his gloves.

The vendor stared, paralyzed, a half-scream caught in his throat.

"I said *scram*," Ryuu repeated, his tone dripping with impatience. "Or do you want me to clear a path for you too?"

The vendor finally found his legs, scrambling away into a nearby alley without a backward glance.

Ryuu paid him no more mind. His gaze swept the chaotic thoroughfare. His targets were everywhere—lowlives and thugs, now empowered into raging, unpredictable monsters. Their numbers were the problem. Not their skill.

He saw a pair of them, one with arms elongated into bladed whips, the other with skin hardened to stone, trying to pry open a vault door with their bare hands.

"Amateurs," Ryuu muttered.

He didn't run. He *moved*. A burst of compressed air—not wind, but the concussive aftershock of a tiny, controlled explosion at his heels—propelled him forward in a blur. He landed between the two criminals.

They turned, snarling.

Ryuu's hands shot out, simultaneously. Left palm on the stone-skinned one's chest. Right palm on the bladed-whip wielder's shoulder.

"Chainburst."

FWUMP-FWUMP!

Two precise, sequential detonations. The stone-skinned demon flew backward, a web of fractures appearing across his torso as he smashed through the vault door he was trying to open. The other screamed as the joint of his shoulder disintegrated in a puff of pulverized bone and muscle, his bladed arm falling limp and useless.

Ten seconds. Three criminals neutralized.

He was a whirlwind of calculated, brutal efficiency. He didn't kill, but his "neutralization" was a lifetime sentence of broken bodies. A kick to a knee was followed by a touch that detonated the cartilage within. A grapple was an opportunity to plant a hand on a spine and deliver a shockwave that scrambled the nervous system.

He moved through the market like a sculptor, and the medium was pain. Ember-sparks trailed in his wake, the only beauty in the devastation he wrought.

His count was internal, relentless. *Twenty-seven. Twenty-eight.*

A group of five, emboldened by their new strength, surrounded him. One breathed a cloud of acidic mist. Ryuu didn't retreat. He clapped his hands together in front of him.

"Blaze Core."

A sphere of compressed concussive force erupted from his palms, not outward, but *inward*, swallowing the acid cloud and condensing it into a harmless, sizzling droplet before the reverse shockwave hit the five like an invisible battering ram, throwing them in different directions into walls and stalls, bones snapping audibly.

Thirty-three.

He was a storm, and the storm had a purpose. He cleared a plaza, his movements a deadly dance, each step a prelude to a crash of thunder. The public, the "extras," either fled from him or cowered in his wake, unsure if he was their savior or a second, more focused disaster.

Then, the ground shook.

Not from his explosions. From a footfall.

Lumbering out from a side street was a giant. It was a minor demon breed, usually employed for heavy lifting, now swollen to monstrous proportions by the Awakening. It stood fifteen feet tall, its grey hide like granite, and in its hands, it wielded the entire axle of a merchant's wagon as a club.

It saw Ryuu, the epicenter of the chaos in its territory, and roared, spittle flying.

Ryuu didn't flinch. He sighed, a sound of profound annoyance.

"Finally, something that isn't a complete waste of my time."

The giant charged, each step cracking the cobblestones. It swung the wagon axle in a devastating, horizontal arc meant to turn Ryuu into paste.

Ryuu didn't dodge. He exploded *upward*. A controlled detonation at his feet launched him into a high, graceful arc over the swing. He sailed through the air, embers streaming from his body, and came down directly on the giant's broad, muscular back.

The giant stumbled, confused, swatting at its own back like at a fly.

Ryuu dug his boots in, finding purchase on the corded muscle. He leaned forward, his lips almost brushing the beast's ear. His voice was a low, conversational purr, laced with imminent violence.

"Hey, dumbass."

The giant froze, its small brain processing the voice coming from behind its head.

"You better give up now," Ryuu said, his right hand hovering just an inch above the small of the giant's back. All five fingers were splayed, ready. "Or I will blow your ass up so bad that the medics will be piecing it back together for weeks."

The giant, enraged, tried to buck him off.

"Wrong answer," Ryuu said.

His hand slammed down.

This was no *FWUMP*. This was a **KRA-KOOM!**

A massive, localized explosion erupted from the point of contact. There was no fireball, only pure, concussive fury. The giant's roar was cut short as its body arched violently, the force lifting it clean off its feet. It flew forward, crashing through the remains of a stone fountain and landing in a heap, its lower spine and pelvis utterly shattered. It would never walk again.

Ryuu landed amidst the settling dust and debris, his boots making a soft *crunch* on the broken stone. He didn't even look back at his handiwork.

He glanced around. The immediate area was quiet. The remaining awakened criminals who had witnessed the giant's fate were now scrambling over each other to get away from him.

A slow, grim smile touched his lips. He cracked his neck, the faint, fiery undertone of his skin glowing a little brighter.

Ninety-one.

In under ten minutes, he had turned a chaotic warzone into a scene of brutal, silent order. The market was a wreck, but the threat was gone. All that was left was the moaning of the crippled and the scent of ozone, ash, and fear..

At that exact moment, a voice, cool and devoid of physicality, threaded itself directly into his consciousness. It was the Malakour Command Frequency, a telepathic weave reserved for high-priority operatives.

«Status update. Blazeborn Varkal. Report your position and progress.»

Ryu didn't flinch. His mental reply was as sharp and biting as his spoken words. *«Southern market sector is pacified. Ninety-one hostiles neutralized. No further significant resistance. The area is... quiet.»* He glanced at a twitching body nearby. *«Mostly.»

«Acknowledged. Your efficiency is noted.» The voice paused, then broadened its channel, including other key minds across the city. *«All units. Blazeborn Varkal has secured the Southern Districts. Converge and contain.»*

A new voice, familiar and steady as iron, resonated in the shared mental space. It was Reinhard Volcari. *«Northern Districts are also clear. The Awakened were disorganized, but numerous. The Knights have formed a perimeter. We have everything in control. Moving to reinforce the West District.»* There was no boast in his tone, only a commander's factual assessment. The image he projected was one of methodical, unstoppable progress.

A third voice chimed in, laced with a familiar, strained pride. Renzo. *«East District here. We've taken control over roughly sixty percent of the area. Resistance is... spirited. But we are pushing forward. They're learning to fear water again.»* In the mind's eye, one could almost see him flicking a speck of soot from his fine blue coat, even amidst the chaos.

Ryu cut the connection with a mental scoff. Extras, all of them, needing to coordinate and announce their every move. He didn't need a team. He was a one-demon army. He turned from the ruined market, his boots kicking up a small cloud of ash as he began moving west, following the sound of distant conflict. The real fight, it seemed, was elsewhere.

Far from the open-air chaos of the districts, deep within the fortified bowels of the Kaali Bhoomi arena's administrative wing, a different kind of cleansing was underway.

The hallways here were pristine, lit by softly glowing glyphs set into polished obsidian walls. The air was cool, recycled, and smelled of ozone and authority. It was a place of order, of rules, of controlled power.

A new sound echoed in this sterile environment.

Whistling.

It was a cheerful, tuneless melody, bouncing off the hard surfaces with a jaunty, off-kilter rhythm.

Scar walked down the center of the hallway, his four arms clasped neatly behind his back as if he were on a leisurely stroll through a garden. His dust-white skin was clean, his blood-seal tattoos a vibrant, pulsing crimson against the monotone backdrop. The permanent carved grin on his face was, for once, matched by a genuine light in his eyes.

A Malakour Enforcer, clad in heavy, rune-etched armor, rounded the corner. His helmeted head snapped up, weapon rising. "Halt! This sector is under lockd—"

Scar didn't break stride. One of his upper arms, previously hidden behind his back, flicked forward. There was no weapon. Just his index finger, extended. It touched the center of the enforcer's chest plate with a soft *tap*.

The enforcer froze. A single, perfect crimson dot bloomed over his heart on the white ceramic armor. For a second, nothing happened. Then, a spiderweb of red lines erupted from the dot, crawling across the entire breastplate with a sound like cracking ice. The enforcer made a wet, gurgling sound and collapsed, the armor shattering into a thousand bloody pieces as he hit the floor, his internal organs turned to slurry.

Scar didn't even look down. He brought his finger to his lips, licked the tip clean with a forked tongue, and continued whistling.

Another enforcer appeared from a doorway, this one faster, firing a bolt of null-energy from a prismatic rod.

Scar's lower left arm snapped up, palm open. He caught the bolt. It sizzled and writhed in his grasp like a living thing. He looked at it, head tilted with curiosity, then closed his fist. The energy vanished with a pathetic *pop*. The enforcer stared in disbelief.

"Now, now," Scar chided gently, his voice a singsong whisper. "That wasn't very friendly."

He was in front of the enforcer in a blink. Two hands gently cupped the man's helmeted head, like a lover's caress. The other two hands patted his shoulders.

"Shhh," Scar whispered.

A sickening *crunch* echoed in the hall, the sound of a walnut being obliterated inside a steel vise. The enforcer went limp. Scar released him, letting the body drop, and wiped his bloody palms on the man's uniform as he stepped over him.

He moved with a dancer's grace, a whirlwind of serene violence. He didn't rage. He didn't roar. He *administered* death. A guard lunging from the left found his neck neatly snapped by a casual backhand. One trying to flank from the right was disemboweled by a swift, downward claw of fingers he never saw coming. Each death was instantaneous, precise, and delivered with that same, unwavering smile.

The whistling never stopped. It was the only warning they ever got. A cheerful prelude to a silent, smiling end.

He reached a reinforced security door, its surface humming with protective glyphs. A final enforcer stood before it, braver than the rest, his sword held in a trembling two-handed grip.

"Y-you... monster!" the enforcer stammered.

Scar stopped whistling. He looked genuinely puzzled.

"Monster?" he asked, his voice soft. He took a step forward, his four arms spreading wide in a gesture of innocent inquiry. "I'm just tidying up. This place was so... messy."

He took another step. The enforcer shuffled back, his sword tip shaking.

"All these rules. All these chains." Scar's smile widened, showing too many teeth. "It's so... stifling. Don't you think?"

He was within arm's reach. The enforcer, driven by terror, screamed and thrust his sword forward.

Scar's lower right hand moved, too fast to follow. He didn't deflect the blade. He plucked it from the enforcer's grasp by the hilt, reversed it, and in the same motion, drove it up through the man's jaw with a brutal, upward thrust. The scream was cut off with a metallic grate.

Scar held the enforcer there, impaled on his own weapon, for a moment longer. He leaned in close, his grin a hair's breadth from the dying man's face.

"I'm not a monster," he whispered conspiratorially. "I'm an artist. And you... you were all just so much noise in my composition."

He let go. The body slid off the blade and crumpled to the floor.

The whistling resumed, brighter than before, as he turned to the sealed door. He placed all four of his palms flat against the humming metal, his head cocked as if listening to a symphony only he could hear.

Scar's four palms remained pressed against the cold, humming metal of the security door. The glyphs under his hands flared, resisting, then sputtered and died as his own chaotic energy—a force that defied structured magic—overwhelmed them. With a final, deafening *click*, the massive door slid open with a sigh of defeated machinery.

The whistling stopped.

His carved smile remained, but the light in his eyes shifted from anticipatory glee to vacant curiosity. He stepped inside.

The chamber was empty.

Not just unoccupied—*emptied*. The obsidian thrones, grown from bone and nightmare, stood vacant. The hollowed skull-basins beneath them were dry. The central flesh-glass screen was dark and inert. The air, once thick with the scent of nectar-sap, blood, and ancient power, was now stale and cold. They were gone. Vurnessa, Mur'Rok, Erix'thel, the antlered judge, the flame-faced scorer... all of them. Vanished like ghosts before the dawn.

Scar's head tilted. He walked slowly to the center of the room, his boots silent on the rune-inscribed floor. He ran a finger along the armrest of Vurnessa's throne, the one woven from stitched-together torsos. It was cold. A low, guttural sound, not quite a growl, rumbled in his chest. It was the sound of a child finding their favorite toy broken and discarded.

His disappointment was a physical presence, a drop in pressure that made the very air feel heavy.

Then, the flesh-glass screen flickered to life.

But it did not show the Demon Council. Instead, the faces of the announcers filled the screen, projected now to every corner of the Kaali Bhoomi complex—to the medical suites, the training chambers, the noble boxes, and the cells.

Elsa, Ignis, and Raktabīja looked... different. The theatrical glee was gone from Elsa's face, replaced by a strained, official calm. Ignis's fiery form was coiled tight, his serpentine eyes narrowed. Raktabīja's blood-flecked tongue darted out nervously.

"ATTENTION. ALL PARTICIPANTS." Elsa's voice was sharp, amplified, and devoid of its usual purring mockery. It was the voice of a system enforcing a new, brutal reality.

In the Medical Suite, Swayam, who had been staring at the city-wide chaos on the other screen, spun around. Anshika's hands, which had been checking Gaurav's IV, stilled. Aviral and Yugetsu looked up from their posts.

"BY EMERGENCY DECREE OF THE COUNCIL OF FLESH AND SCORE," Ignis boomed, the crackle in his voice sounding more like a warning than showmanship, **"THE FORMAT OF THE KALI BHOOMI TOURNAMENT HAS BEEN AMENDED. EFFECTIVE IMMEDIATELY."**

On the screen, a new, stark set of glyphs burned into existence, visible to all:

**PHASE 1 - CONCLUDED.
NEW RULES: FREE-FOR-ALL.
OBJECTIVE: SURVIVAL.**

**VICTORY CONDITION: BE ONE OF THE LAST THREE TEAMS STANDING.
ALL RESTRICTIONS LIFTED.
THE ARENA IS NOW THE ENTIRE KAALI BHOOMI PRECINCT.**

"LET THE FINAL CULLING... BEGIN," Raktabīja finished, his voice a deathly whisper that seemed to slither through the walls.

The announcement ended. The screen went dark.

The silence it left behind was absolute, and more terrifying than any roar.

In the Medical Suite:

Swayam's hand went instinctively to the frost-mask at his throat. His knuckles were white. He didn't look at the others; his gaze was fixed on the door, already calculating sightlines, choke points, and threats. Anshika's face had drained of color. Her clinical composure cracked, revealing the raw survivalist underneath as her eyes darted to the unconscious forms of Rachit and Gaurav. They were liabilities now. Prey. Aviral, ever pragmatic, was already moving, his hands igniting with a low, controlled flame as he began reinforcing the door glyphs with searing heat, his jaw set in a hard line. Yugetsu simply stared, his multi-eyed gaze wide and unblinking, his body trembling so slightly it was almost invisible. The concept of a fair fight had just been devoured.

In Team Kaal's Chambers:

Kaal, who had been seated in meditative silence, opened his ember-orange eyes. He didn't startle. He didn't speak. He simply stood. The burnt-bronze plates on his shoulders seemed to grow denser, the air around him warping with intensified gravity. This was a language he understood perfectly: reduction until only the strongest remained.

In the Team Mavik Chambers:

Syra stopped polishing her nails. A slow, predatory smile spread across her face. "Now *this* is a party," she murmured, her blades extending from her forearms with a soft *shink*. Nikhan hissed in excitement, his coils tightening. "The strong will feast, and the weak will be the feast!" Arox, still seated on the floor, finally opened his eyes. He didn't smile. He didn't frown. He simply nodded once, a deep, acknowledging rumble in his chest. Blazetusk on his back seemed to hum in anticipation.

In the Hall of the Empty Council:

Scar stood in the silence, listening to the fading echo of the announcement. His initial disappointment melted away, replaced by a new, dawning understanding. The smile on his face didn't just return; it transformed. It was no longer just carved into his skin; it was alive, ecstatic, and utterly unhinged.

He began to laugh.

It wasn't a loud laugh. It was a soft, wheezing sound that shook his shoulders. He lifted his head to the vaulted ceiling, his four arms spreading wide as if to embrace the entire, terrifying complex.

"They changed the game," he whispered to the empty thrones, his voice filled with a reverent joy. "They made it... simple."

He looked at his hands, flexing all ten fingers.

"No more committees. No more points. No more *judgment*." His laughter grew louder, echoing madly in the cavernous room. "Just survival. Just... art!"

He spun in a slow, graceful circle, his laughter peeling through the chamber like a cracked bell. The upper management was gone. It didn't matter. A bigger, better, bloodier canvas had just been unveiled and multiple floors away and beyond this madness in the sterile silence in the medical suite was now a fragile shell, ready to be shattered by the first team desperate for an easy kill. Swayam stood motionless, his blue eyes scanning the room as if seeing it for the first time—not as a sanctuary, but as a trap.

His mind was a cold, racing engine.

Teams still active. Abhishaap. Kaal. Athereon. Mavik. Slade. Possibly Viren, Syris. The wounded teams—Reeva, Nakaros, Drexil. They're weak, desperate. Desperate teams look for leverage. For prey.

His gaze landed on the two occupied beds. Rachit, breathing shallowly, face pale. Gaurav, hooked to the IV, out cold.

Two unconscious humans. Bait. A meal ticket for any team looking to thin the herd without a fight. Who would come? Mavik? Too proud. They'd see it as scavenging. Syra would sneer. Arox would ignore it. Slade? Maybe. Pragmatic. Viren? Definitely. They're vultures. But there are at least two full-strength teams here in the wing... maybe they'll fight each other first. Maybe they'll ignore us.

The *maybe* hung in the air like a guillotine blade. He couldn't gamble on *maybe*.

Beside Gaurav's bed, Anshika's face was a mask of controlled tension. Her fingers, which had been checking the IV drip, now rested on the hilt of a hidden bone-scalpel tucked in her belt. Her amethyst eyes were not panicked; they were calculating triage in a battlefield. *Two critical patients. One strategist near awake but weakened. One fire-user at near capacity. One... unknown.* Her glance flicked to Yugetsu, who was frantically but silently shoving gauze, pain-numbing salves, and water vials from the supply cabinet into a makeshift bag, his movements jerky with suppressed terror. He wasn't preparing to fight; he was preparing to run and hide.

Aviral finished searing the door's locking mechanism with a final, precise jet of flame. The metal glowed red, then cooled to a hardened, warped seal. It would hold, but not forever. He turned to Swayam, his expression grim, soot smudging his cheek.

"We can't fortify this place. It's a box," Aviral said, his voice low and urgent. "They'll come through the walls, the vents, or just wait us out. We need to move. Stay, what do you think?"

Swayam's eyes met his. The decision had already been made minutes ago, the map unfolding in his mind's eye. He gave a single, sharp nod.

"We move. All of us."

He strode to Rachit's bed, grabbing a spare medical tarp. "We take them with us. We are not leaving bait, and we are not leaving brothers."

"Move *where*?" Anshika asked, her voice clipped. "The halls will be a slaughterhouse."

Swayam didn't pause as he began efficiently rolling Rachit onto the tarp, creating a makeshift sled. "The service corridors. West wing, past the armory and devotion place. Where Rachit had fought Rezen."

Aviral's brow furrowed. "That area's a dead end. Leads to the old underground maze."

"Exactly," Swayam said, securing the tarp with swift knots. "It's the least populated area now. Most teams will cluster near the main arenas or the supply caches. The maze is a forgotten relic." He glanced up, his gaze piercing. "Johan's temporary quarters are in that wing. We take the left fork in the main corridor, avoid his sector completely. Engaging him at full strength is a gamble. In this state..." He didn't finish. They all heard the unspoken end: *It's suicide*.

"So our plan is to hide in a monster-infested maze?" Anshika raised a skeptical eyebrow, but her hands were already moving to help Gaurav, carefully detaching his IV and sealing the port with a pulse of Jeev Shakti.

"It was used for 'Run and Burn,'" Swayam confirmed, his voice devoid of emotion as he recited the horrific past. "Human slaves, hungry beasts, demon spectators. Now it's mostly empty. Most demons would get lost in there. Our bet is simple: we get in, we stay hidden. These two wake up." He nodded at Rachit and Gaurav. "The other teams take each other out in the main complex. Then, *rejuvenated*, we go hunting for the last spots."

Anshika finished securing Gaurav to another tarp-sled. She looked at Swayam, her skepticism now laced with a more practical fear. "And how are we so sure *we* won't be lost forever in a pitch-black maze designed to devour people?"

For the first time, a flicker of something other than grim determination crossed Swayam's face. A sliver of foresight.

"When you were all unconscious after the first trial," he said, his voice dropping, "after I visited the armory for the sword... I also took a map from the quartermaster's log. At first, the glyphs were confusing—old architectural plans. But after Rachit's fight in that sector, I saw the environmental glyphs on the walls. They matched the map's indicators. The maze is charted. Either Rachit already knows the layout, or he doesn't. But we have the map. We won't be lost."

The room held its breath. Yugetsu stopped packing, a vial of antiseptic clutched in his white-knuckled hand, a fragile hope dawning in his wide eyes. Aviral let out a slow, impressed breath, the tension in his shoulders easing a fraction. Anshika simply stared at Swayam, her earlier skepticism dissolving into a look of stark reassessment. The quiet one, the leader who wore a mask, had been planning escape routes while they slept.

Swayam hefted the end of Rachit's tarp. "Aviral, take point. Burn anything that moves that isn't us. Yugetsu, middle guard. Watch our flanks. Anshika, you're rear guard with Gaurav. I'll pull Rachit. Move fast, move quiet. We don't fight unless cornered. Our only objective is the left fork, then the maze entrance."

They moved as one unit, a desperate convoy. Aviral's hands glowed at his sides, ready to unleash hell. Yugetsu held a jagged piece of surgical steel like a dagger, his eyes darting to every shadow. Anshika's free hand shimmered with a faint, disorienting haze—a ready illusion. Swayam pulled the tarp, his muscles corded with strain, his every sense screaming into the silent, deadly hallways ahead.

High above, in the shattered commentators' booth, a different kind of calculation was concluding.

Johan Agryas sat in Elsa's vacated chair, its plush crimson upholstery now stained with dust and a single, perfect drop of blood that wasn't his. He held a crystal glass of pure, clear water, sipping it with mechanical precision. The booth was a wreck—shattered monitors, torn sound-dampening foam, the metallic tang of fear still clinging to the air.

At his feet lay a large, blood-soaked cloth. It was lumpy, covering something. Around its edges, a fine, glittering dust of pulverized crystal—remnants of something which had marked it with purple liquid—was scattered, mixed with darker flecks. Johan had his boots propped casually on the cloth-covered mound, as if it were an ottoman.

His storm-gray eyes were distant, staring at the blank, broken main screen.

Hypothesis confirmed, his mind recited. The suspension was a reaction to accumulating anomalies. The new rule set is the logical extreme: force a convergence. Eliminate statistical noise.

Survival probability matrix:

Team Abhishaap: 97.3%. Unstable variable: Shyvana's emotional volatility. Mitigated by Abhishaap's control.

Team Kaal: 94.8%. Unstable variable: The human, Rachit. Anomalous strategic depth. Mitigated by Kaal's gravitational absolute. Weakness: Rachit is currently is unconscious and missing.

Self: 99.1%. Variables: None significant.

Conclusion: The final three will be Abhishaap, Kaal, and myself. The rest are variables in the process of being eliminated.

He took a final sip, the water tasteless. The chaos below was not chaos to him; it was a predictable chemical reaction, reaching its equilibrium.

He placed the empty glass down on the console with a soft *click*. He swung his legs off the blood-soaked cloth, standing up. He adjusted his slate-gray jacket, brushing a stray fleck of crystal dust from the scorch mark Gaurav had left.

He looked down at the cloth-covered shape one last time, his expression one of mild, academic disdain.

"Well," he said to the empty room, his voice flat and clear. "You all were adequate opponents. For gnats."

He turned to leave, pausing at the shattered doorway—the one Scar had not come through, but through which violence had clearly visited. He glanced back, a final, dry epitaph offered to the unseen remains beneath the cloth.

"I believe we have transacted for my... decorative piece. Your member broke it." A pause. "Panic in the afterlife."

And without another look, Johan Agryas stepped through the ruined doorframe and into the echoing chaos of the culling, a walking embodiment of the very principle that now ruled the Kaali Bhoomi: cold, efficient, and utterly without mercy.

VOLUME 2 ENDS